

A W O R L D B O O K

# The Turning

*Kind, Condition, and the reach of the Tree*

Living world book · Cut-year 387

Spine locked · reserved chapters marked *to write*

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# Using This Book

This is the world book of **the Turning**, written for people who will play here. It explains the place in ordinary language. A line in quotation marks is something a person in the world might say, and the text says who says it. A habit people will not explain is described as what they do. There is no build-order here, and no note about why a choice was made. Open questions the world itself has not settled stay open in the text.

The **spine is locked**. Chapters keep their numbers and titles. When more of the world is built, it is written *into* the chapter that already exists. Grey boxes marked **Not yet written** are reserved holes. They are intentional, not missing pages. Filling one means replacing the box, not adding a new chapter. The hole that remains in Other Places is two claimants on one green: a type, not a seated square. Deep forage ecology in Climate stays thin on purpose.

**Books I–IX** are the setting as a player can meet it.

**Book X** is GM canon. The table does not start knowing it. Read the world first if you want to audit it the way a player would. It also holds the sound-system behind the names, the keystone, when the fire is caught, hidden Phoenix agency, and the Isolated Fall opening at Harrow's Green. How to name a person, make a new name, and glue a hall stays in **Language and Naming**. Continent names are unpacked in **The Four Continents**.

**Rules** for Daggerheart sit inside the Condition and Kind entries: Transformation cards and ancestry features, using the game's own terms (Hope, Stress, Hit Points, Fear, range bands). Folklore and in-world papers are quoted as they are told.

The vault remains the working source of truth. This book is the reading copy, for audit now, and for filling as the world grows.

Print the PDF with a wide right margin, or annotate it in any PDF reader. The HTML is the same book: searchable, with a clickable contents. Open the HTML in a word processor if you want comments in the margin.

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BOOK I

## What This World Is

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# The World in Brief

Vampires, werewolves, and their kin exist in the Turning. They are part of society: accepted, employed, and needed. They are not a persecuted underclass and they are not a secret. Each is a becoming, not a species, and each is a neighbour with a job and a cost.

Every person carries two layers, and they stack.

**Kind** is what you are born: Human, Elf, Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, Yumboe, and the rest. Kind is mundane. Nobody blinks at a fox-tail in a market or wings on a ridge. You are raised by a place, not by your ears. There are no Kind-nations.

**Condition** is what you become. Roughly three in four people acquire one over a lifetime. A Condition is a managed state with law, guild, medicine, and work attached to it. Society is built around what the Conditioned can do, and around helping them live with the cost.

Two paths lead to a becoming. At a child's tenth-year solstice, families gather at a **Turning Tree**. A coloured leaf falls, and a Condition is **Given**. If the leaves hug with no colour, the child is one of **the Kept**: kept whole, wanted in their own right, not a failure. Later, some people cross a threshold alone (a drowning, an oath, a death) and are **Struck**, with no leaf and no ceremony. Over a lifetime the split runs about sixty Given, fifteen Struck, twenty-five Kept for life.

Every Condition carries a **Tithe**: not a church tax, but an upkeep that must be met to live well with the becoming. Meet it, and you are a valued citizen. Fall behind, and a small, real edge shows. The will stays one's own. No Condition can compel another person.

Some hold that the **Leaf-Mother** blessed the world with these gifts, and that the Trees are her hands. Skeptics say it is simply what the Trees do. Right practice binds; right belief is argued about. The Motherfaith is one faith among several.

There is one origin Tree, the **Awakening Tree**, called Thaeloren, on Maiethorn. Every town Tree is a living graft of it: a cutting of that same wood, planted in new ground. The map of the world is a gradient of that wood's **reach**, meaning how far the grafts have spread: sacred-dense origin, mercantile middle, thin frontier, and a storm-walled isle beyond the Trees entirely.

The surface of life is late-medieval: chartered towns, guild halls, markets, letters of credit, mills, universities. No printing press. No gunpowder. The one advancement beyond that surface comes from Condition-labor, paid for by Tithes, concentrated where those Conditions live.

It is the **Years of Hands, Cut-year 387**. Town Trees stand in most squares. The walk to the origin is no longer required, except where the wood is still travelling, or has failed. On Heskoren the Grafting is not finished. Kumbaan has never Turned.

This book is the world as it stands.

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# Kind and Condition

Every person in the Turning carries two layers, and they stack.

**Kind** is what you are born: the shape of a body and a bloodline. Human, Elf, Drakona, Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, and the rest. Kind is mundane. Nobody blinks at it. It is simply the ancestry you arrived in.

**Condition** is what you become. Vampire, werewolf, and their kin are not species in this world. They are becomings: something happens, and a person is changed. Roughly three in four people acquire a Condition over a lifetime. One in four never do. A Condition is a managed state with law, guild, medicine, and work attached to it. Society is built around what the Conditioned can do, and around helping them live with the cost.

## How a becoming arrives

There are two paths, and the split is the central social fault line of the world.

**Given**, at Leaf-Fall. In their tenth year, on the solstice, children gather with their families around a Turning Tree. A scion (a living cutting of the origin Tree) stands in every town. Leaves fall and wrap around each ten-year-old. A colour falls, and a Condition is Given; the leaf-colour names which one. It is ceremonial, expected, proper. A Given child grows up already knowing what they will become, and is trained and guilded for it. No colour, but the leaves hug the child: they are one of **the Kept**. The Tree keeps them as they are. That hug is a blessing in its own right. The Kept are wanted and special, not a failure and not a lack.

**Struck**, later. Some Conditions cannot be Given to a child. A ten-year-old cannot die and walk back. A child cannot consent to a contract. These arrive only when a person crosses a threshold later in life: the door you go through decides what you become. No leaf, no ceremony. Onlookers call it tragic, miraculous, or a little suspect. The Kept are not a closed club. A slice of them still turn.

The sorting is simple. Innate fates are Given only: the Long-Lived, the Two-Bodied, the Answered, the Phoenix. Things a child physically cannot have done are Struck only: the Returned (death), the Bound (a sworn pact). Survivable near-death doors can be foreseen by the Tree or walked through by accident, and those Conditions come both ways: the Far-Voiced, the Stilled, the Taken-In. A Given Far-Voiced (blue leaf at ten, guild-trained) and a Struck Far-Voiced (drowned at thirty) are the same becoming and very different people.

Of the whole population, over a lifetime: about **60 percent Given** at the Tree, about **15 percent Struck** later, about **25 percent Kept for life**. The Given and the Struck together are the three-quarters who carry a Condition. At the ceremony itself, about 40 percent of children receive no colour; about a third of those will still be Struck someday.

## The Tithe

Every Condition carries a **Tithe**: an upkeep that must be met to live well with the becoming. This is not a tax paid to a temple. It is the cost of staying whole. Meet it, and you are a valued citizen: neighbour, colleague, family. Fall behind, and a small, real edge shows: hunger, restlessness, a Cry, a limb locking stone-still, an element that lets go in a crowded room. The infrastructure that helps people pay their Tithes is part of why society organizes around the Conditioned.

A Tithe is satisfied by ordinary work and rest. The dangerous edge is something a person can walk toward, or something a story can press. It does not seize the will. A Conditioned person remains themselves. The cost is paid in body, memory, Stress, standing, and time, never in stolen control.

Standing is not one thing. Some Conditions are common and ordinary. Some are rare and looked up to. Some are rare and looked down on. Some are feared. One is legendary.

## Nine to choose, ten in the world

Nine Conditions can be Given or Struck. A tenth, **the Unbound**, called the Hollow in the common tongue, is not a starting becoming. It is the downstream state a Bound enters when a term-limited contract ends without another being signed. You become Unbound only through Bound.

**The Given-Over** is a title, not a Condition. It is the world's name for a Bound who signs contract after contract until the being on the other side effectively holds them. Among the contract-guilds the term of art is **the Forfeit**. It is an NPC-tier fate.

### RULES

Conditions are Daggerheart **Transformation cards**: a flavor line and features, at minimum a boon and a labeled Tithe, hooked to Hope, Stress, Hit Points, Fear, and Experiences. One transformation per player character. It sits in the loadout like a heritage card and does not count against domain-card limits. Feature count varies; spotlight and complex Conditions carry more than the workhorse cards. What is constant is a clean boon and a labeled Tithe on every card.

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## Roster

| Condition                            | Folk still know         | Path                          | Share of the people              | Standing                             |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------|-------------------------------|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Long-Lived                           | vampire                 | Given                         | ~2.5%                            | rare / revered                       |
| Two-Bodied                           | werewolf                | Given                         | ~18%                             | common                               |
| Returned                             | zombie                  | Struck                        | ~7%                              | normal / quietly respected           |
| Bound                                | demon (by contract)     | Struck                        | ~5% (includes the Unbound)       | feared                               |
| The Unbound<br>( <i>the Hollow</i> ) | the price of a contract | Struck, chains off Bound only | ~1.5%, <i>inside</i> Bound's ~5% | pitied / uneasy                      |
| Far-Voiced                           | siren                   | Both                          | ~12%                             | revered                              |
| The Stilled                          | gorgon                  | Both                          | ~7%                              | feared / guild-regulated             |
| The Answered                         | djinn                   | Given                         | ~10%                             | wildcard                             |
| The Taken-In                         | leshy                   | Both                          | ~13%                             | respected-but-looked-down / frontier |
| Phoenix                              | phoenix                 | Given                         | <0.1% (one at a time)            | legendary                            |

The Kept, the ordinary ~25 percent who receive no Condition, are not on this table. The Tree hugged them. They are wanted in their own right.

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BOOK II

## Peoples

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# The Conditions

Condition cards do not advance with character level. A becoming is not a class. The card you hold at level 1 is the card you hold at level 10. Class features, domain cards, Experiences, weapon tier, and Hope scars are what change around it.

What can still deepen: a Two-Bodied may attach an animal-form Experience when they would gain an Experience, and a second signature capability only as a once-ever story milestone. Returned and Phoenix spend Hope slots — a countdown, not a power-up. Bound Terms and Pledge move by story. Attacks that use Proficiency (Kindle, Reach, the Green Word, the Two-Bodied natural weapon) rise because Proficiency rises, not because the Condition card levels.

Tithe clocks drain or fill on a **long rest** unless the card names another trigger. A day with two short rests does not tick these clocks twice. At each long rest, run this list once. Each line is yes-or-no.

| Condition    | At this long rest                                                                                                                             | Not a rest clock                                                             |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Long-Lived   | Spent Hope on Unfading Mind, used Blood-Read, or spent a downtime move in study or witness? <b>Refill.</b> Else <b>remove a Memory token.</b> | —                                                                            |
| The Answered | Spent Hope on Reach since last long rest? <b>Refill.</b> Else <b>remove a token.</b>                                                          | Asking the element a question                                                |
| The Taken-In | Can you touch a living plant where you rest? <b>Refill.</b> Else <b>remove a Green token.</b>                                                 | —                                                                            |
| The Stilled  | This long rest included a physical downtime move, a spar, a drill, or a fight? If not, <b>add a Grey token.</b>                               | Gaze still adds Grey when used                                               |
| The Unbound  | Rested with someone who knows your name and shares the meal or the watch? <b>Refill Quiet.</b> Else tokens stay.                              | Spending Quiet in play                                                       |
| Returned     | Did anything toward your Purpose since last long rest? If not, settle (Stress, cold touch).                                                   | —                                                                            |
| Far-Voiced   | —                                                                                                                                             | Scene: mark Stress from feeling, or the GM names grief, terror, rage, or joy |
| Two-Bodied   | —                                                                                                                                             | A day without the other self; next Fear roll shifts you                      |
| Bound        | —                                                                                                                                             | Terms and the Whisper                                                        |
| Phoenix      | —                                                                                                                                             | Death and the Dwindling                                                      |

## Long-Lived

**Folk recognition.** The old tales called them vampires. **Path.** Given only: a rare leaf-colour at Leaf-Fall. **Share.** About 2.5 percent. **Standing.** Rare and revered.

Aging simply stops, and nothing witnessed is ever forgotten. A Long-Lived is not a blood-drinking predator. They are an ageless keeper of memory who lives on what they learn. Where the folklore vampire fed on the living, the Long-Lived feed on knowledge. When starved they do not hunt: they

fade, forget, and finally empty out. The old blood-hunger survives only as an echo. A Long-Lived can read a memory in a single drop of blood. By ancient courtesy they will not cross a threshold uninvited.

They are the world's archivists, judges, notaries, and living libraries. Courts, guilds, and archives are built around them. Too many deathless people and institutions would go rigid, so their scarcity is part of the world's shape. They are consulted, and a little apart.

**The old courtesy.** A Long-Lived waits to be asked in, always. It is held as the deepest good manners, a mark of trustworthiness (a keeper of records does not intrude), and no one quite remembers it as anything else. It is old, and it is universal among them. A Long-Lived who is refused the door feels the refusal more than they will say. It is simply how the Long-Lived have always been.

The pleasant face of the Tithe (the upkeep of the becoming, not a church tax) is why they hold the jobs they do. A Long-Lived wants to keep learning, so scholarship, judging, and record-keeping are self-medicating careers. Deprivation is the danger: imprisonment, a dull siege, exile somewhere with nothing new. Isolating a Long-Lived is a recognized cruelty.

They can have children and families, but none are guaranteed to inherit the Condition; most don't. They watch spouses and children grow old and die, then either stop and live on alone with the memory, or begin again and outlive that family too. Beneath the hunger for knowledge, this is the deeper Tithe: the cost of the Long-Lived is measured in funerals. They are deathless, not unkillable. Violence, accident, or a failed Tithe still ends them, which keeps their numbers stable across centuries.

## RULES

*Ageless keepers of memory, law, and record: they live on what they learn.*

- **Unfading Mind:** Your aging has stopped and you forget nothing you take in. You have **advantage** on rolls to recognize, appraise, or recall what you have personally witnessed. **Spend a Hope** to recall a witnessed detail *complete* — the vow as spoken, the face, the exact count. The Hope is for the perfect record, not for the ordinary librarian's job.
- **Blood-Read:** Memory rides in blood. Taste a **single drop** of a creature's blood (freely given, or from a wound) and you read a **true memory** carried in it, a fragment of what that person has lived, chosen by the GM to fit what the blood remembers. It is never predation and never harms the donor: one drop, one glimpse. The older or more guarded the memory you reach for, the less you may get.
- **The Hunger to Know (Tithe):** Place **3 Memory tokens** on this card. **At a long rest, refill all tokens** if since your last long rest you **spent Hope on Unfading Mind, used Blood-Read, or spent a downtime move** in study or first-hand witness. Otherwise **remove a token**. Always-on advantage does not refill the clock; using the keeper-tools does. Each time you lose a token:
  - **2 tokens:** no effect.
  - **1 token:** the **fade** begins: **disadvantage** on rolls to recall, recognize, appraise, or use Presence, and you start losing older memories (describe what slips). Other action and reaction rolls are untouched.
  - **0 tokens:** you are **starving** — you are **Vulnerable**, and at the start of each **long rest** still at 0 tokens you **mark a Stress**. If you would mark your last Stress this way, mark a **Hit Point** instead. If you would mark your last Hit Point this way, you do **not** make a death move: you simply **go still**, mind emptied, the true death of the Long-Lived. You may clear Hit Points and Stress as usual. Getting a token back (a Hope spent on recall, a Blood-Read, a downtime study) stops the starve before the next long rest.

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## Two-Bodied

**Folk recognition.** The old tales called them werewolves. **Path.** Given only. **Share.** About 18 percent. **Standing.** Common.

A Two-Bodied is not a beast that overtakes a person under the moon. They are a person who carries a second, animal self that is always theirs to command. No rage, no loss of control. The second body is a useful animal partner you carry inside you. This is the common workhorse Condition, and the most versatile labor force: rescue, herding, wild-work, war, courier and scout work. A second body suited to a job.

Shifting is voluntary and clean. The animal shape is not an empty suit. It carries its own personality, temperament, and inner voice, distinct from the born self, and the Two-Bodied converse with it: not aloud as a person (the animal mouth cannot form human speech), but in the head, a running second opinion. The wolf that wants to run the scent *now*. The hawk that trusts height over talk. The otter that finds the whole meeting tedious. It is named. It is known (“that’s Bramble, her otter”). Townsfolk come to recognize its moods. It never takes the wheel. The change and every action stay the person’s to command. What it does is nag, want, and color: a live companion you happen to be.

The Condition runs in families. Children of a Two-Bodied parent are far more likely to be Given it at their Awakening, and usually as the same animal. Whole bloodlines are wolf-folk, hawk-folk, otter-folk. A first-in-the-line, or one who breaks type, is notable.

The other self is a real, natural animal, roughly between a housecat and a large wolf, bear, boar, or horse in size: no bigger, nothing mythic. A real animal does exactly what that animal really does. A hawk flies. An otter swims and holds its breath. A bear is strong. The hard limits are size (housecat-to-bear, never a giant hawk or a dire wolf) and no myth (no roc, no kelpie). In the animal form there are no hands, no person’s mind at work, no speech-as-a-person, no tools. A flying Two-Bodied is a superb scout and courier but is not a Tengu. A Tengu is a person aloft, with hands to carry and fight and a human mind and voice in the air. An aquatic Two-Bodied swims brilliantly but works the water as a beast, not a tool-using Answered or a true amphibious person. The body is a magnificent animal. It is not a person wearing fur.

Because the upkeep is simply being the animal sometimes, most Two-Bodied satisfy it without thinking. Their jobs demand the animal form anyway. The restless forced-shift is the edge: it strikes at the worst moment (mid-negotiation, mid-stealth), costs a Stress, and never takes the wheel.

## RULES

*A person who carries a second, animal self, not a beast that overtakes them.*

- **The Other Self** (*boon*): You have a second body: a specific real animal, chosen when you become Two-Bodied. You may **shift between your two selves at will**, as an action. The change is **always yours to command**, no Stress and no roll (your gear melds with you and returns when you change back). In animal form you gain:
- **Natural build.** Your animal's real gifts are yours: a **natural weapon** (teeth, claws, antler, hoof): **Primary** · **Instinct**, or **Strength** if the animal's signature is brute force (bear, boar) · **Melee** · **d8 phy** (housecat-sized: **d6 phy**; bear or boar: **d10 phy**) · **One-Handed** · **Natural** — cannot be disarmed; usable only in animal form; you cannot equip another Primary while in this form. Roll damage dice equal to your **Proficiency**, as with any other weapon. You do not add a second weapon's dice on top. Plus the beast's movement: a wolf's run, an otter's swim, a hawk's flight. You are one or the other.
- **A signature capability**, chosen with the GM to fit the animal: e.g. a hawk's *see a mouse from the sky*, a wolf's *run a scent for miles*, a bear's *shrug off a blow* (**advantage** on the fitting rolls, or a small once-per-scene effect the GM sets). One signature to start.
- **An animal Experience.** Choose one **Experience** reflecting your animal's nature (e.g. "Wolf's Nose," "Cat's Balance," "Bear's Strength"), usable only in animal form.
- **A voice, not a driver.** Your other self has its own name, temperament, and inner voice you can converse with. It is pure roleplay: it flavors and nags, grants no mechanical bonus on its own, and **can never take an action you don't choose**.
- **Both Must Be Lived** (*Tithe*): If a full day passes without time spent as your other self, it grows restless. The next time you roll with **Fear**, you **shift into it whether you meant to or not, and mark a Stress**. You stay fully in control. Only the *timing* isn't yours. Shift back normally.

**Growth.** You start with **one** animal-form Experience and **one** signature capability. Whenever you would gain an Experience, you may attach a new **animal-form Experience** to your other self (usable only in animal form). Your **signature capability stays one**, with a single exception: **a second signature is a once-ever milestone**, never a routine pick. It is granted by the GM as the payoff of a genuine story arc (a season lived almost entirely in your other self, a defining trial passed in that shape), and it is the only way the capability count ever grows. The natural weapon's die does not rise with character level; only Proficiency does. The Tithe is not a rest clock. It rides the duality dice on purpose.

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## Returned

**Folk recognition.** The old tales called them zombies. **Path.** Struck only: it requires death. **Share.** About 7 percent. **Standing.** Normal and quietly respected.

The Returned are not rotting, mindless corpses. A Returned is a person who died with something unfinished, and whose purpose keeps them walking: calm, deliberate, unafraid of death because they have already met it. Where the folklore zombie decays, the Returned persist.

You cannot be Given this at age ten. Someone dies with a thing left undone strong enough to hold them, and they get back up. Society hands them the jobs that kill the living: plague wards, mine collapses, battlefield recovery, tending and speaking for the dead. They are solemn, dependable, the people you send where the living cannot safely go. They are unshaken by gore and death, and death itself struggles to keep them.

The Tithe is a feeling as much as an upkeep. A Returned is only steady while they have a reason. Neglect it and they cool, literally and socially. The living can tell a settling Returned at a touch. The Returned build their lives around their purpose with almost religious care. Their returns are counted: each Refuse to Fall burns a Hope slot, so a long-walking Returned is a person you can see running out of comebacks. **Blaze of Glory** remains the death they can choose: after a life of refusing rest, going out spectacularly on their own terms rather than on the last scar.

When the unfinished thing is finally done, they have a choice death denied them. They may **Settle** (lie down and take the rest they skipped, at last) or **become one of the Kept**, laying the Condition aside and living out the rest of their days as a mortal again. Taking up a new Purpose instead keeps them Returned and walking. That is a major character beat, coordinated with the GM.



## RULES

*You died with something unfinished. It keeps you walking.*

- **Unfinished Business** (*boon*): You have already died once, and death does not hold you the way it holds other people. When you make a **death move**, you **cannot choose Avoid Death**. Your options are **Blaze of Glory**, **Risk It All**, and a fourth option this card gives you: **Refuse to Fall**. Avoid Death is the safe road — unconscious, a chance of a scar, back when an ally clears a Hit Point or the party finishes a long rest. A Returned already died; that road is spent. **Refuse to Fall**: you go down (taken out of the current scene) and pull yourself back together by the next **long rest** (describe how). Coming back leaves a mark: **cross out a Hope slot as a scar**. **If you would cross out your last Hope slot this way, you cannot Refuse to Fall** — the unfinished thing finally lets go, and that death is true and final. You may still choose **Blaze of Glory**, or gamble on **Risk It All** and die if it fails. Refuse to Fall is the *steady* road back, and it is **finite**, counted in scars. You are also **unshaken by the dead and dying**: automatically pass rolls to resist fear, horror, or despair from corpses, gore, and deathly places.
- **The Tether** (*Tithe*): Name your **Purpose**, the unfinished thing that holds you here (write it on the card). While you can still act toward it, you are steady. If a **long rest** passes in which you did nothing in service of your Purpose, you begin to **settle**: mark a **Stress** that can't be cleared until you next act toward it, and your **touch runs cold**. Living creatures you touch (or that touch you) feel a bone-deep wrongness and mark a Stress, and you have **disadvantage** on rolls to comfort, persuade, or charm the living until you act toward your Purpose again.

**When the Purpose is fulfilled.** Settle, become Kept, or name a new Purpose and keep walking.

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## Bound

**Folk recognition.** The old tales called them demons, but in this world the demon is a contract, not a bloodline. **Path.** Struck only: a child cannot consent to a contract. **Share.** About 5 percent. **Standing.** Feared.

The Bound are the only Conditioned who chose it. In some extremity they swore a contract with something on the other side, and got power in exchange for Terms (the standing obligations written into the contract). The horror is contractual, not infernal: a debt and a counterparty (the other party to

the contract) that always watches the ledger. This is distinct from Infernis, Daggerheart's demon-blooded *ancestry*. Bound is acquired, never born.

Society fears them. The power is real, the terms are binding, and a Bound who falls behind is collateral. Society also needs them. A Bound's sworn word is literally binding, and they know a lie when they hear one, so they are the world's enforcers, oath-keepers, witnesses, and debt-arbiters. When a treaty absolutely must hold, a Bound swears to it.

The counterparty may be chosen at creation, or left unknown as a thread to discover: a demon or lesser power (a named, bargaining entity); a cosmic-horror intelligence (vast, indifferent, *wrong*); or unknown even to the Bound. They do not know what holds their note.

The only sure release is to kill the thing that holds the contract, but a patron that can grant power can often sense the intent forming, so plotting it is its own peril. Term-limited contracts instead simply end, releasing the Bound and collecting the Pledge (the piece of themselves named at signing as the price). What walks away is Unbound.

True flight may be contracted, but the sky is spoken for. It is the province of the Tengu and, in legend, the Phoenix. A contract for flight is uncommon and never clean: it grants literal, visible wings (or a stranger tell: a shadow that lifts, feet that will not touch ground) that a Bound cannot furl or hide, marking them plainly as something that made a bargain, the way a Phoenix's fire marks them. Most who want the sky are better served by gliding or a saving slow-fall. True sustained flight is a GM's call, priced with heavier Terms and a Pledge to match. It is not one of the ordinary, hide-in-a-crowd boons.

**The Given-Over** is the world's name for a Bound who keeps signing, power after power, pledge after pledge: first out of fear of paying what they already owe (sign another contract to defer the debt), then because it becomes too much to stop. Bit by bit they give themselves over until the being effectively holds them. This is a narrative title, not a playable Condition. A person who has signed away nearly all of themselves is no longer really playable. The plain name is the Given-Over. Among the contract-guilds, the Forfeit.

## RULES

*You swore something to something, and it answered. Now you both keep the terms.*

- **The Granted Power:** When you became Bound, you named what you wanted, and the contract granted it. With the GM, choose one small, defined boon your class doesn't give you. Examples: **you can never become lost** (always know true north and the way back), **you don't need to breathe, you need no food or water, you can speak and understand any tongue, you always know when someone lies to you.** Active boons cost a **Stress** to use. Passive ones simply work. Flight, if granted at all, follows the marked-bargain terms above.
- **The Terms (Tithe):** Your contract carries **Terms** written on the card, a standing obligation the counterparty exacts (for example, "never refuse a sincere plea," "collect what is owed," "tell no lie on a holy day"). Keep the Terms and the power is clean. **Break a Term, or miss a payment, and the contract collects.** The GM gains **Fear**. Until you make restitution (a defined act the GM sets), your Granted Power costs a **Hit Point** instead of Stress, and **The Whisper** begins. While you owe a debt, when you roll with **Fear** the GM may voice an intrusive thought or a plausible lie the counterparty wants you to believe. You may act against it freely, but **shutting it out costs a Stress**. The debt compounds each time you fall further behind. The Whisper suggests. It never commands. The counterparty cannot take control of you.
- **The Pledge:** At signing you also named **what you would give when the contract ends**, a part of yourself (an eye, a leg, your capacity for fear, your memory of home). Written on the card. You keep it while the contract runs. When a term-limited contract comes due, the counterparty releases you and **collects the Pledge**, and you become one of **the Unbound** (colloquially, the Hollow).

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## The Unbound

**Folk recognition.** Not a monster from the old tales: the price of a contract. Colloquially, **the Hollow**. **Path.** Struck only; chains off Bound. **Share.** About 1.5 percent: only the subset of Bound whose contracts were term-limited rather than open-ended. **Standing.** Pitied / uneasy.

When the term ends, the counterparty releases the person and collects the Pledge, the part of themselves they named at signing, and they walk away unbound: free of the contract at last, but left with a hole where a piece of them used to be, exactly as agreed. The Condition is titled Unbound for

the release. The common tongue calls them the Hollow, after the hole. Both are true: a freedom, and an absence.

The Pledge was chosen up front, at the signing. You knew what you would owe. So the loss is both grief and gift: the hole is also an immunity. People are not afraid of the Unbound. They are unsettled by the absence in them. Where the Long-Lived must keep learning to stay whole, the Unbound must keep connecting to stay quiet: opposite fuels.

A player cannot simply choose the Unbound at character creation. It is a downstream state: you become Unbound only after playing through (or arranging at session zero, with the GM) an actual Bound contract, establishing what the contract was, what you Pledged, and the moment the term came due and it was collected. The Absence must be a specific, agreed loss with real weight, not a free immunity.

## RULES

*You paid what you promised. Something is missing now, and the missing place is quiet, and strong.*

- **The Absence:** Name what the contract took (the Bound Pledge). You permanently lose it, in the fiction and, where it matters, on the sheet. The hole is also a **narrow immunity**: you are immune to effects that would **mark Stress** (or grant the GM **Fear**) *by working through that capacity*. You are not immune to every roll in the lane. Agree the details with the GM at the moment you become Hollow. Three lanes:
- **A capacity of the mind** (fear, grief, love, the ability to lie, memory of a person or place) → immunity only to **Stress-marking** (or Fear-granting) effects that use that capacity. Gave up fear: a terror that would mark Stress does not; you still have to treat a scared crowd as a crowd. Gave up deceit: you *cannot* lie, and a lie that would mark Stress if it landed does not mark Stress on you. You do not automatically know every lie.
- **A sense of the body** (an eye, hearing, taste) → immunity to **Stress-marking** effects that require that sense (the Stilling Gaze aimed at you, a blinding light that would mark Stress). Illusions you must see still work unless they would mark Stress through that sense.
- **A part of the body** (a leg, a hand) → immunity to **Stress-marking** pain or effects through that part (and often a prosthetic or Condition-crafted replacement in the fiction).
- **The Quiet (Tithe):** Place **3 Quiet tokens** on this card; begin play with them filled. **Spend a Quiet token** to act through the hole: take an action the missing thing would have stopped, or gain **advantage** on a roll where the empty place makes the hard thing easy. You still mark Stress from effects outside your Absence immunity. Quiet is not a second no-sell of the same lane. **At a long rest, refill all tokens** if you rest with at least one other person who **knows your name** and shares the meal or the watch. Alone, or among strangers who do not know you, the tokens stay where they are. **At 0 tokens the pull turns loud:** while empty, whenever a bargain, favor, or offer of power is on the table, the GM may present it as unusually reasonable, and **refusing to reach for it costs a Stress**. Suggestion, never compulsion. You can always say no; it just aches. This is the road back to Bound, and from there toward the Given-Over spiral.

# Far-Voiced

**Folk recognition.** The old tales called them sirens. **Path.** Both. **Share.** About 12 percent (~11% Given, ~1% Struck). **Standing.** Revered.

A Far-Voiced is not an irresistible song that lures the unwilling to their death. Their voice has total emotional fidelity: it carries exactly as far, and exactly as true, as the Far-Voiced means it to. The old trope's horror (a song that overrides your will) is not how this works. The danger runs the other direction, into the Far-Voiced themselves.

A Far-Voiced's voice is never drowned out by distance, storm, battle-noise, or water, and it never says less than it means. That is why the signal network runs on them: relay-singers post along coasts, roads, and border-towns to carry warnings, alarms, and orders faster and farther than any horn or drum. Courts and treaties want them as witnesses, because a Far-Voiced's own voice betrays real feeling the moment they are under pressure, so their sworn word is trusted precisely because they are bad at lying under strain. They fill concert halls because emotion, delivered audibly and exactly, is the whole art form. They are revered rather than feared, but a Far-Voiced who cannot master the channel is a genuine hazard to everyone in earshot, which is exactly why guild training exists.

The two paths read differently. A **Given** Far-Voiced drew the colour at the Awakening and spent childhood guild-trained (breath control, projection, the discipline of venting on purpose), controlled, professional, poised. A **Struck** Far-Voiced nearly drowned. The door is surviving drowning. They came up with the voice raw and untrained, the undertow already pulling before anyone taught them to swim it. Same Condition, very different person. No leaf, no ceremony: it reads to onlookers as a miracle, or as faintly uncanny. A Struck Far-Voiced usually needs a guild's help fast, before they learn the hard way what happens at zero tokens in public.

The pleasant face of the Tithe is why the jobs exist. Deliberate, controlled venting (performance, ritual song, relay-calls) is how a working Far-Voiced manages the channel, so the careers that need a big voice are also the careers that keep one healthy. The guild drilling (breath work, scheduled performance, the discipline of singing it out before a shift ends) exists because an un-vented Far-Voiced is unpleasant to be near, and a Cry (an un-vented outburst of feeling) in a crowded hall or a command tent is a real, documented hazard.

A Bound detects others' lies. A Far-Voiced betrays their own feeling.

## RULES

*Your voice carries exactly as far, and exactly as true, as you mean it to.*

- **The Carrying Voice:** Your voice is never lost to distance, weather, noise, or water, and it lands with the emotional weight you intend. Spend a **Hope** to be heard clearly and understood by everyone you intend, across any distance or chaos in the scene, **or** to land a rally, warning, plea, or calming word with exact emotional force: gain **advantage** on that roll.
- **The Undertow (*Tithe*):** Place 3 **Breath tokens** on this card. This clock is **scene-triggered**, not a rest drain. When you **mark Stress from feeling**, or the GM names grief, terror, rage, or joy as what's in you this scene, you must **vent it**: sing, cry out, laugh, weep, something audible, before the scene ends. If you don't, **remove a token**:
  - **2 tokens:** no effect.
  - **1 token:** the **undertow pulls**. Your voice starts leaking whatever you're actually feeling underneath your words. You have **disadvantage** on rolls to persuade, deceive, or perform a feeling you don't hold.
  - **0 tokens:** the next strong emotion you feel escapes as an involuntary **Cry**. Everyone within earshot marks a **Stress** as your raw feeling crashes into them (the GM may instead gain a **Fear** for a crowd or hostile scene). The Cry empties you: mark a **Stress** yourself, then refill to **2 tokens**. It's out now, one way or another.

The Cry costs listeners Stress and costs the Far-Voiced a Stress. It never compels an action, a belief, or a roll. Nobody's will bends. It is an emotional gut-punch, not a command.

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## The Stilled

**Folk recognition.** The old tales called them gorgons. **Path.** Both. **Share.** About 7 percent. **Standing.** Feared and guild-regulated.

One of the Stilled is not a monster whose gaze is a weapon. They are a person who can still things: arrest a wound, freeze a fight before it turns lethal, hold a struggling patient steady under the knife. The old trope's horror (turn-to-stone as a curse you inflict on others) is not how this works. The danger is that the stillness has to come from somewhere, and if one of the Stilled doesn't keep moving, it starts settling into them.

The Gaze, their stilling look, can hold a moment still: a bleeding wound stops bleeding, a spreading poison stops spreading, a blade already swinging hangs a beat too long. Peacekeepers want them on a riot line. A stilled brawl is a brawl that didn't turn into a massacre. Surgeons and medics want them in the theatre: a patient held perfectly still is a patient who survives the knife. They are feared and licensed rather than revered, because the same Gaze that stops a wound bleeding can, misused or lost to anger, hold a person still forever. Licenses, oversight, and a strict code govern who may still and why.

Old folklore's snake-hair survives as flavor, not mechanics: hair stirs faintly when something nearby has gone dangerously still (a held breath, a knocked arrow, a predator about to spring). A tell their trade has learned to read.

The two paths read differently. A **Given** Stilled drew the colour at the Awakening and trained young under guild discipline: knows exactly how much stillness they can spend and how to keep moving to shed it, composed and professional. A **Struck** Stilled actually survived being turned to stone, held rigid, unbreathing, for however long it took someone to reverse it, and came back with the stillness now living inside them, unpracticed and closer to the surface. The door is surviving being turned to stone: petrified by another of the Stilled's Gaze, a trap, a curse, an accident, and returning to flesh. No leaf, no ceremony. Onlookers call it a miracle, a mercy, or a little unnerving, depending on who did the reversing. A Struck member of the Stilled usually needs a guild's help fast, before an unmanaged Grey (the stillness collecting in them, a clock toward stone) teaches them the hard way what a seizing feels like in public.

The Stilled drill hard, spar often, and stay physically busy almost as a matter of professional identity. Every use of the Gaze banks a little Grey, so the guilds build constant motion into the job itself (patrols, practice bouts, dance as therapy) to work it back out before it settles. An unlicensed or careless one of the Stilled who lets the Grey fill and seize is a real, documented hazard, first to themselves. A stilled doorknob is one thing; a stilled hand on a weapon is another. The guild's oversight is strict rather than ceremonial.



## RULES

*You can hold a moment still. The stillness has to come from somewhere, and if you don't move it along, it settles into you.*

- **The Stilling Gaze:** You may still a wound, a spreading harm, or a struggle you can see. **A harm** (bleeding, poison, disease) you can see: no roll. The harm pauses until you look away, use the Gaze again, or the scene ends. **A willing or downed creature:** no roll. They gain **Stilled** (below). **An unwilling creature:** make an **attack roll** (Instinct or Presence). On a success, they gain **Stilled**. A miss still adds Grey. You can keep **one** stilling at a time; a new use releases the last. Nothing you still this way is harmed by the stilling itself. The stillness has to come from somewhere: **each time you use the Gaze, add a Grey token.**
- **Stilled** (*special condition, not Restrained*) — A Stilled creature cannot take **actions or reactions**. They can speak, perceive, and be targeted. They are not Restrained: they can be moved by others. They may **mark a Stress** to clear Stilled when they would act. It also clears if you look away, use the Gaze on another target, or the scene ends.
- **The Grey** (*Tithe*): The stillness you spend collects in you, and if you don't work it back out, it settles. Place **Grey tokens** on this card, starting at **0**. This is a *filling* clock, not a draining one. **Add a Grey token** each time you use the Stilling Gaze, and **add one** when you take a **long rest** that did not include vigorous exertion (a downtime move spent on labor, a spar, a drill, or a fight). **Clear one token** at the end of a scene in which you marked Stress from physical effort, or dealt or took damage. The stillness rises:
  - **1 token:** no effect.
  - **2 tokens:** the **grey creeps in**. Your joints stiffen; you have **disadvantage** on Agility rolls and on rolls to evade.
  - **3 tokens (full):** the stillness **seizes**. The next time you use the Stilling Gaze, or the next time you take damage, one of your own limbs **locks stone-still**, useless until it's tended and rested off (describe it: an arm, a leg, your jaw). The GM may instead gain a **Fear**: something small and nearby (a doorknob, a cup, a patch of ground) turns permanently to stone, collateral of the seizing. Afterward, clear back to **1 token**.

The seizing only ever locks the Stilled's own body, or harmless scenery. It never petrifies another creature and never takes a PC's turn away from its player. Nobody's will bends; nobody else pays the debt.

# The Answered

**Folk recognition.** The old tales called them djinn: jinni, wish-granting spirits in lamps. **Path.** Given only. **Share.** About 10 percent. **Standing.** Wildcard.

An Answered is not a wish-granting spirit trapped in a vessel, bound to serve whoever holds it. They are a person one of the four elements answered at the Awakening, and will now go on answering for the rest of their life. No wishes, no master, no bottle: an element that talks back to the Answered's hands the way a native tongue talks back to a native speaker.

At Leaf-Fall, an Answered child's leaf marks them Given, and its **shade** names which element answered: **Ember** (fire), **Tide** (water), **Root** (earth and stone), or **Gale** (air). From that day the element is theirs to speak to, not summon or command, coaxed like clay, never conjured like a spirit.

That is why the Answered run the craft guilds built around their element. Ember-Answered glasswrights and smiths who don't need a furnace at full heat. Tide-Answered shipwrights and dyers who can bend a hull's planks or set a colour without steam or mordant. Root-Answered masons and potters who coax stone and clay without chisel or wheel. Gale-Answered sailmakers and instrument-makers who cut and voice their work with the wind's own help. Watch rotations, escort work, and firefighting crews give them a steady outlet as well.

Which element answers, and what temperament came with it, is different every time. An even-tempered Root-Answered potter and a short-fused Ember-Answered smith have nothing in common but the name. Some guilds prize them above any other artisan. Some households are wary of hosting one whose element runs hot. The leaf-shade names the element; it does not tell you which kind of person you are getting until you meet them. That is why "wildcard" sticks as a label.

Real, purposeful use of the element keeps an Answered steady, so apprenticeships run long and workshops exist to give them work. One of the Answered kept idle, grieving, or benched too long is a genuine hazard to be near, and every guild hall has a story about the time someone's untended element finally let go in a crowded room.

There is no Struck door. An element answers at the Awakening, or it does not. This is not a bargain, the way the Bound swore a contract with a counterparty.

## RULES

*An element answered you at the Awakening. It still does, and it still expects to be spoken to.*

Choose your **element** at creation: **Ember, Tide, Root, or Gale**. It sets both features below.

- **The Answering Hand** (*boon*): Your element obeys your hands without tool, forge, or force (glass blown with no furnace, a hull bent with no steam, stone coaxed with no chisel), granting **advantage** on any action roll to shape, repair, wield, or read something made of your element. In the moment, it answers too: **spend a Hope** to use your element's **Reach** (see the table). The Reach is always available. The Tithe below is what wears down if you don't use it.
- **Spoken, not commanded** — Once per **long rest**, you may **ask** your element one question it can feel through its medium. Ember: heat, fuel, and what would burn. Tide: flow, depth, and what the water has touched. Root: weight, fault, and what the stone holds. Gale: pressure, scent, and what the air carries. The GM gives a clear impression, not a map. Your element does not obey another creature's order or bargain. If someone tries to treat it as theirs, it does not answer them. You may **spend a Hope** to turn that refusal into a Reach effect aimed at the interruption.
- **The Untended Element** (*Tithe*): Place **3 tokens** on this card. **At a long rest, refill all tokens** if since your last long rest you **spent Hope on Reach**. Otherwise **remove a token**. Asking the element a question does not refill the clock; spending Hope on Reach does. At **2 tokens**: no effect. At **1** and **0**, the element starts speaking for itself. See the table.

| Element                            | Reach ( <i>spend a Hope</i> )                                                                                                                                                                                                                | 1 token (restless)                                                                                                      | 0 tokens (it lets go)                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Ember</b> ( <i>fire</i> )       | Send a burst of fire at a target within <b>Very Close</b> range. Make an attack roll (Instinct or Strength). On a success, deal <b>magic damage in d6s equal to your Proficiency</b> and the target is temporarily <b>On Fire</b> .          | You run <b>hot</b> : disadvantage on action rolls needing a steady hand or a cool head (stealth, precision, composure). | You <b>flare</b> : mark a <b>Stress</b> ; searing heat rolls off you and anyone within <b>Very Close</b> must give ground or work through it (scorched cloth, singed hair; no direct damage). Refill to 2.   |
| <b>Tide</b> ( <i>water</i> )       | Move like water: breathe and swim freely as though water were air, flow out of a fall or a grapple unharmed, <b>or</b> slick the ground within <b>Very Close</b> . Creatures there must succeed on an <b>Agility Roll</b> to move out of it. | You run <b>thin</b> : disadvantage on action rolls needing brute force or holding your ground.                          | You <b>flood</b> : mark a <b>Stress</b> ; water and mud spread under you ( <b>Very Close</b> ), and you <i>and</i> everyone in it must make an <b>Agility Roll</b> to move out until it drains. Refill to 2. |
| <b>Root</b> ( <i>earth/stone</i> ) | Turn skin to bark and stone until the spotlight leaves you: <b>reduce the severity of the next damage you take by one threshold</b> , and gain <b>advantage</b> on rolls to resist being moved, knocked down, or Restrained.                 | You run <b>slow</b> : disadvantage on Agility rolls.                                                                    | You <b>calcify</b> : mark a <b>Stress</b> ; you become <b>Restrained</b> by your own stiffening body until you or an ally clears it with a successful action roll. Refill to 2.                              |
| <b>Gale</b> ( <i>air</i> )         | Move like wind: on a move, reach anywhere within <b>Close</b> range with no roll even under pressure; <b>or</b> a sudden gust slams a door, knocks something loose, or carries your voice clearly across a storm.                            | You run <b>wild</b> : disadvantage on action rolls needing careful aim or a steady stance.                              | You <b>gust</b> : mark a <b>Stress</b> ; uncontrolled wind scatters every loose or unsecured thing within <b>Very Close</b> (dropped weapons, papers, smoke, dust; GM adjudicates). Refill to 2.             |

Every 0-token consequence lands on the Answered's own body or the air, water, and ground immediately around them. It never targets or harms another creature directly, and never bends

anyone's will. Nobody is compelled; nobody else pays the debt.

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## The Taken-In

**Folk recognition.** The old tales called them leshy: trickster forest-spirits that led travelers in circles until they died. **Path.** Both. **Share.** About 13 percent (~12% Given, ~1% Struck). **Standing.** Respected but looked-down; frontier.

One of the Taken-In is not a haunting and not a lure. They are a person the wild took partway into itself and gave back changed: bark at the knuckles, moss in the hair, a spread of antler or a knot of root somewhere on the body, and green things that lean toward them. The wild lives in them now, and answers them, which is exactly why the hard land gets worked at all.

They can coax growth, read the wild, and move through it unseen and unlost. The frontier runs on them. A Taken-In steward makes thin soil yield, keeps a herd through a bad winter, walks a forest without ever losing north, and knows a day out which way the weather turns. They are society's farmers, foresters, herders, and frontier-wardens.

The cities and their guilds need the grain, timber, and wardens the Taken-In provide, and eat well because of them. But one of the Taken-In is dirt-handed, backcountry, and no longer quite human to look at. The bark and antler unsettle people who have never left the paved districts. Prosperous farm-country reveres them. Polite city society finds them a little coarse, a little uncanny, and keeps them at arm's length.

The two paths read differently. A **Given** Taken-In drew the green at the Awakening and grew up in it: a farm or forest child comfortable in their half-wild skin, the change coming on gentle and known. A **Struck** Taken-In got lost and dying in the deep wild, days without a path, ready to lie down, and the wild took them in rather than let them die, remaking them partway to keep them. They come back more uncanny, more overgrown, and quietly unsure whether they walked out a person or something the forest sent.

Their work is their upkeep. A life spent on soil, among growing things, under open sky keeps the green in them fed without a thought. The Tithe only bites when one of the Taken-In is pulled off the land: a long sea voyage, a stretch in a stone gaol, a season stuck in a walled city on a lord's business. Old frontier custom is to send them home before they wilt. City hosts who must keep one indoors learn to fill the room with potted green and open windows, courtesy that also keeps their guest from going to seed on the parlour floor.

## RULES

*The wild took you in and gave you back green. It still lives in you, and it needs living things around it.*

- **The Green Word** (*boon*): Growing things heed you. You have **advantage** on action rolls to forage, track, navigate wild land, calm or read an animal, or find your way, and you never become lost in a natural place. In the moment, the green answers:
- **Spend a Hope** to make roots, vines, and brush erupt from any natural ground within **Close** range. Make an **attack roll** (Instinct or Strength) against a target there. On a success, deal **physical damage in d6s equal to your Proficiency** and the target is temporarily **Restrained**; or
- **Spend a Hope**, while in any natural cover (brush, trees, tall grass, roots, soil), to draw it around you and become **Hidden**; or
- **Spend a Hope** to force sudden, useful growth. A branch bridging a gap, a screen of thicket, a root ladder, a burst of ripe forage. The GM sets the scale.
- **The Rooting** (*Tithe*): Place **3 Green tokens** on this card. **At a long rest, refill all tokens** if you can **touch a living plant** where you rest (soil, a tree, a field, a potted green). Otherwise **remove a token**. The test is yes or no. Open sky without a plant does not count. A window-box does.
- **2 tokens**: no effect.
- **1 token**: you **wilt**. Your green browns and sheds, and you have **disadvantage** on action rolls to resist fear, despair, or exhaustion (the wild in you is starving and it drags at you).
- **0 tokens**: you **go to seed**. Mark a **Stress**; you are **Vulnerable** until you next touch living land, and the wild reaches for any it can find (weeds crack the flagstones, a beam sprouts leaves, roots buckle the floor: the room around you goes riotously overgrown). The GM may instead gain a **Fear** in a tense scene. Reach living land and refill to **2**.

The go-to-seed growth erupts from the ground and structures around the Taken-In. It never entangles, targets, or harms another creature directly, and never bends anyone's will. Nobody is compelled; nobody else pays the debt.

# Phoenix

**Folk recognition.** They are called what the stories call them: **the Phoenix**. Every other Condition wears a plain, euphemistic title (the Long-Lived, the Returned, the Far-Voiced) because those becomings pass unremarked in the crowd, and the quiet name is their camouflage. The Phoenix cannot pass, cannot hide, and the whole world already knows the story. The naming itself marks them as singular. **Path.** Given only. No threshold can Strike one into being. **Share.** Less than 0.1 percent, and there is only ever **one at a time in the entire world**. **Standing.** Legendary.

A Phoenix is not a bird of eternal, cost-free rebirth. They are a person who burns down to ash and rises again, but not unchanged and not forever. Each death takes a piece of who they were; each life is a little further from the first. Where the Long-Lived never die and the Returned refuse to stay dead, a Phoenix *does* die, completely, and comes back a new turn of the same soul, carrying fewer and fewer of the old one's memories.

When the current Phoenix finally ends (spends their last life), the Tree gives the leaf to a single child, somewhere, and the next one begins. So a Phoenix is not rare the way a good harvest is rare. They are singular: the one living person the whole world's phoenix-stories are currently about. The Tree names them once a generation or once an age, and then not again until they're gone. Almost nobody has ever met them. They are known through stories.

This makes a Phoenix a fault-line a whole city forms around. In a single town they may be, all at once:

- **Revered:** proof the Leaf-Mother is real, a living miracle paraded on holy days;
- **Worshipped:** followers who believe touching them, or their ashes, blesses or heals;
- **Hunted:** those who want their ashes, their blood, their feathers, or their death (some believe a Phoenix's ash grants a life; some just want the one irreplaceable thing gone);
- **Hated and feared:** skeptics who call them a fraud, faiths who call them heresy, rulers who can't stand a symbol they don't control.

They cannot hide in a crowd. A Phoenix is *the* Phoenix, and everyone has heard the stories. This is the true weight of the Condition, heavier than any Tithe: you are the most known person alive, and the world has already decided what you mean.

A Phoenix is a spotlight Condition. The **whole table** agrees — the Phoenix player and the **other players** commit together, the way you'd agree to a campaign about a chosen one. If anyone at the table does not want that weight, pick another Condition or run the Phoenix as an NPC legend. The player commits to roleplaying the legend: the constant recognition, the followers and hunters, the impossibility of an ordinary life. It plays as a slow-burning, finite-lives arc, not a casual pick. It also works as a recurring legendary NPC whose rebirths a party witnesses across an age.

Day to day, a Phoenix pays nothing: no hunger, no rooting, no venting. The whole cost is spent at death, in *self*: a little less memory, one fewer life. The real upkeep is social and unrelenting: being the only one. A Phoenix cannot walk a market unrecognized, cannot refuse the meaning others pour into them, cannot stop the worshippers or the hunters from finding them, and cannot grieve a rebirth in private. The stories are heavy with loss for a reason: Phoenixes who rose so many times they forgot their own children, and Phoenixes who ended not by a hunter's hand but by simply choosing to stay dead rather than come back as still less of themselves. A Phoenix late in their cycle is a person made mostly of legend, with almost none of their first life left inside.

They can furl the wings of fire and pass, for a moment, as ordinary. The moment they fly, everyone watching knows what they are.



## RULES

*You are the only one. You will die, as you have died before, and rise, a few more times, and no more.*

**The living-fire boons** (a Phoenix simply *is* these, no cost unless noted):

- **Deathless to Flame:** You cannot be harmed by fire or heat of any kind: you take **no damage from fire** and can walk through, stand in, and breathe within flame unharmed. Ash and cinder are home.
- **Wings of Fire:** You have wings of living flame and **you can fly**. **Once per rest**, while flying, you may **mark a Stress** after an adversary attacks you to gain a **+2 bonus to your Evasion** against that attack. (You can furl the wings to pass for ordinary, but the moment you fly, everyone watching *knows what you are*.)
- **Kindle:** **Spend a Hope** to send a burst of fire at a target within **Close** range. Make an attack roll (Instinct or Strength). On a success, deal **magic damage in d6s equal to your Proficiency** and the target is temporarily **On Fire**.

**The rebirth:**

- **Rise From Ash:** When you make a **death move**, you gain a fourth option: **Rise From Ash**. Your body burns to nothing and reforms whole by the end of the next scene. You return with **Hit Points cleared. Stress is not cleared**. You are **Vulnerable** until your next rest, standing in your own ashes. Rebirth burns part of who you were. With the GM, name a piece of the old life that did *not* come back: a memory, a face, a skill, a fear, a name you used to answer to. You come back *you*, but lighter, and a little more like something that has done this before.
- **The Dwindling (Tithe):** Rebirth is finite, and paid in self. **Each Rise From Ash permanently crosses out a Hope slot**, as a scar does; your lives are counted in Hope. **When you would cross out your last Hope slot to Rise, you cannot**. That death is your true and final one, and this turn of the soul ends for good (per the SRD scar rule: crossing out your last Hope slot ends the character's journey). *Then, somewhere, a leaf falls for the next Phoenix*. There is never a second living Phoenix while this one can still Rise. What looks like two is something else. The dread is the **count**: everyone at the table can see how many risings are left, and so, quietly, can the Phoenix.

Rise From Ash acts only on the Phoenix's own body and Hope. Kindle is an ordinary attack, no different from a torch or a blade in what it may target. Nothing here compels another creature's will.



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# The Kinds

## Kinds

You are raised by a place, not by your ears.

A **Kind** is the ancestry you are born with: a birth-shape. Nobody blinks at a fox-tail in a Maiethorn market or wings on a Heskoren ridge. Conditions are the becoming the world organizes around. Kinds are the body you brought to the Turning Tree. There are no Kitsune kingdoms, no Selkie thalassocracies (sea-empires), no Tengu mountain-empires.

What the custom Kinds have are **hearths**: the place-people of a Kind, terrain they were born to, where they are densest and not theirs alone. A hearth is a forest, a coast, a ridge, a dry country, an isle. More than a fireplace, and not a flag.

Yumboes look like an exception. They are rare off Kumbaen because of distance (the storm-wall), not because Kind is a nationality. On the isle they are ordinary. On the mainland they are a sailor's tale. Same people. The map did that, not a racial law.

## Kind, Condition, place

| Layer            | What it tells you                                                                  | What it does not                              |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <b>Kind</b>      | Birth-shape; sometimes a hearth (coast, ridge, wood, isle)                         | Loyalty, faith, legal standing, which country |
| <b>Condition</b> | What they became (~75%); Tithe; guild/licence                                      | Ancestry                                      |
| <b>Place</b>     | The drift they speak, the institution-names they use, the polity that vouched them | What ears they have                           |

A Kitsune clerk on the Lestrand docks, a Tengu pilgrim in Threnmaieth, a Selkie vouching-witness in Vaethorn: none of those is a mistake. The interesting collision is always Kind × Condition × place.

Kinds do not carry a Tithe. A Tithe belongs to a Condition.

## The four custom hearths

**Kitsune: three hearths, one Kind.** The fox-born already come in three Foxes: Wilds, Snows, and Sands. That is the distribution, written into the body. Three grounds, and no fox-country. They marry and mingle; a child takes after one parent's line. You meet Kitsune in every port and every court. You meet more of a given Fox where that ground is.

| Fox                              | Hearth                               | Where on the map                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Wilds</b> (red / forest)      | tangled wood, hedgerow, Motherwood   | densest in Maiethorn's Motherwood and Heskoren's deep forests                                                          |
| <b>Snows</b> (white / high cold) | high snow, pale open country         | densest on Maiethorn's central range and Heskoren's highland spines                                                    |
| <b>Sands</b> (pale / dry)        | dry hills, rain-shadow, sand-country | densest in Maiethorn's Rain-Shadow: the leeward east of the central range, the one true dry country in the known world |

A Fox of the Sands in a wet Strandoren harbour is unremarkable (people move). A town in the Rain-Shadow with no fox-born at all would be the thing worth asking about.

Old Kitsune hearths still have a word for a fourth fox no one is born as anymore. The word is kept; the Fox is not. A grandmother will say it and not explain.

**Selkie: the coasts.** Selkies belong to two homes at once, so their hearth is the line between: strand, estuary, cold harbour, the towns that face water. Densest on Strandoren's indented coasts (the continent is almost all shoreline). Common in Maiethorn's western ports on the inner sea. Present on Heskoren's wild coast, thinner inland. Not native to Kumbaan. A Selkie who makes that crossing is a story, not a population.

Inland Selkies exist (the skin Anchors; they can always find their way back to water). They are simply fewer, and they miss the place they aren't, which they consider normal.

**Tengu: the ridges.** Tengu hearths are peaks, cliff-shelves, and the wind that lives there. Densest on Maiethorn's central range and Heskoren's highland spines, the two continents that actually have killing height. Rare as a settled people on low Strandoren. The ones you meet there are usually sky-couriers (a family, a perch on a clock-tower, a run over the inner sea), not a ridge-town transplanted to a quay.

Tengu settlements cling to crags and are reached by wing or by rope. A lowlander arriving on foot is a guest who climbed. That is the courtesy.

They keep a running, half-teasing rivalry with the Selkies. Sky-folk and sea-folk each remain convinced their element is the one worth belonging to. The rivalry is colour, not a border.

**Yumboe: the isle.** Kumbaen, and almost nowhere else. Mythic-rare off the isle; on it, ordinary. No Leaf-Fall, no Given Conditions; Struck possible but rare. Their Kind and their table are their own. A Yumboe on the mainland is usually the only one anyone in that town has ever seen. They have no mainland hearth. The storm-wall is the distribution.

## Stock ancestries

Daggerheart's stock set (Clank, Drakona, Dwarf, Elf, Faerie, Faun, Firbolg, Fungril, Galapa, Giant, Goblin, Halfling, Human, Infernis, Katari, Orc, Ribbet, Simiah) lives everywhere the Trees do. They are not assigned continents. A few leans keep the map from reading as grey slurry:

- Water-born stock (Ribbet, Galapa, some Seaborne communities) cluster on the same coasts as Selkies, and are not Selkies: Ribbet breathe the deep; Selkies hold their breath and cannot be kept.
- Height-and-wild stock (Giant, some Ridgeborne / Wildborne) show thicker on Heskoren's uplands, beside Tengu ridges, not instead of them.
- Old-wood stock (Elf, Faerie, Fungril, Firbolg) show thicker in Maiethorn's Motherwood, beside Wilds-fox hearths.
- Infernis are born demon-blooded. They are not Bound. They are not a Bound-underclass and they have no Bound-homeland.
- Halfling and Faerie are not Yumboe. Small-and-flight and small-and-lucky stay their own lanes; the good people are isle, moon, and unseen hands.

Leans are not rules. A Ribbet judge in inland Threnmaieth is ordinary. A Giant on a Lestrاند dock is ordinary. A thicker pocket of one stock in a town is a fact about the town. It is not a nation, a guild, or a seat.

The kitchens are the place's larder. An ancestry does not grow its own staple.

- **Ribbet and Galapa** cook on the quay, close enough to hear the tide: bread softened in fish broth, with seaweed or a cockle when the tide was good. They do not own the coast, and they are not Selkies.
- **Giants** eat the usual upland meal, oat mash and dried peas, and they do not eat it on a Tengu perch. They do not own the ridge.
- **Elves, Faeries, Fungril, and Firbolg** are thicker in the Motherwood, beside Wilds-fox hearths. The clearing is still mixed. Oat pottage, dried peas, mushrooms when the week was wet. A Fungril household sets one spoonful aside. They will not say who it is for. They do not own the wood, and a Faerie is not a Yumboe.

- **Fauns and Halflings** are thicker on farmland. They cook cabbage in the morning's milk and eat it in the yard. That is how that house eats. It is not a guest-meal. They do not own the field.
- **Katari and Simiah** eat a handful where they were working, a loft or a mast or a branch, and still come to the town's supper. They do not own the canopy.
- **Clanks, Dwarves, Goblins, and Drakona** are thicker where a town already mends things. Bread and beans at the bench, still warm from the work. Ember is a lean some Drakona share with the Answered. It is not a Drakona chapter. They do not own the mill or the forge.
- **Orcs** are thicker where the day's work is lifting. A pot of peas in the yard, the cart still hitched. They do not own the road or the watch.
- **Humans** are common on every continent that has Trees, and no more common on one than on another. They cook what the town cooks. They are not the body everyone else is measured against.
- **Infernīs** are born with demon blood. They are not Bound. They have no homeland. They eat from the same pot as the rest of the house. They do not set a separate bowl because of the blood.

Humans are common. They are not a default the others deviate from. There is no human baseline to marry away from.

Factions recruit by Condition, guild, and faith, not by Kind. A settlement may have a hearth-neighbourhood (a Selkie quay, a Tengu perch, a Rain-Shadow fox-market) without the town being that Kind. Ornsael is the worked example: fox-market by the well, mixed Kinds, no gate. A person gets a Kind, a Condition or Kept, and a place. The place names them.

## Hearth-Mark

Stock Daggerheart ancestries grant two features. Each custom Kind grants three. The customs were balanced against each other. Stock is not a trap.

A character whose two ancestry features are **both from stock ancestries** — a single stock Kind, or a stock-and-stock mix — takes a **Hearth-Mark** at character creation. A character who takes **any custom-Kind feature** does not. The third feature is the hearth written into the body.

Name the **place that raised you**: a town, a quay, a ridge-road, a walk-hold, a roll-street. Write it as a place-phrase, not a Kind-phrase. *Hallowquay salvage-child* is a Hearth-Mark. *Seal-blood* is not.

**Once per session**, when you make an action or reaction roll that leans on how that place taught you to live, add +2. You do not spend Hope for this. You may still spend Hope to add a relevant Experience on the same roll.

This is not an immunity, not a Stress power, and not a shopping list. If a phrase starts granting swim-breath, flight, or “cannot be caught off guard,” it has become a feature; throw it back and write the place again.

Everyone still takes a **Community** as the SRD requires. A Hearth-Mark is not a second Community and not a third ancestry feature. You still take the two Experiences the SRD gives every character.

## Mixed Ancestry

The table allows what Daggerheart allows. Mixed Ancestry is a legal heritage, not a rare exception and not a toy you ask permission for. Two mainland Kinds — stock, custom, or one of each — mix by the SRD rule: the **top** (first-listed) feature of one ancestry and the **bottom** (second-listed) feature of another.

Custom Kinds have a third feature. That third feature is the **hearth feature**. It is not available in a mix.

| Kind    | Top            | Bottom        | Hearth (not mixed)               |
|---------|----------------|---------------|----------------------------------|
| Kitsune | Slip the Frame | Fox's Glamour | Your Fox (Wilds / Snows / Sands) |
| Selkie  | Second Skin    | Slip the Hold | Seal-Kin                         |
| Tengu   | Wind-Winged    | Wind-Caller   | The Mountain's Mood              |

Yumboe is **not on this table**.

How to build one:

1. Take **one Top** from one parent Kind and **one Bottom** from the other.
2. Take **no** hearth feature from either custom Kind.
3. Take **no** Hearth-Mark if either feature is custom. Take a Hearth-Mark if both features are stock.
4. If both chosen features grant the same verb (fly and fly, swim and swim), keep one and take the unused listed Top or Bottom from either parent instead. Do not stack the same verb.
5. Write both sides on the body — ears and webbing, wings and a fox-brush, whatever the pairing is. That is the mix, not a hidden tell waiting to be a third feature.

Do not take three features from one custom Kind and then add a stock feature. Do not take two hearth features. Community is unchanged. Kind still stacks with a Condition. A mixed-heritage character Turns, or is Kept, or is Struck, like anyone else.

A mixed Kitsune is fox-touched (Slip or Glamour). They are not a Fox of the Wilds, Snows, or Sands unless they take the full Kind.

## Yumboe at the table

A Yumboe character needs **GM leave**. They are mythic-rare off Kumbaan; a mainland campaign that seats one has decided the storm-wall let someone through.

If the table says yes, they are the **full Kind**: Hollow-Hill, Moon-Waked, and The Unseen Hands. No Hearth-Mark. No Top/Bottom split. No Yumboe feature paired with a stock or mainland-custom feature.

A child of a Yumboe and anyone else is either a full Yumboe (same GM leave) or the other parent's Kind, with at most a story-tell. They are never a mechanical mix. The good people do not come in halves. That is not a blood-purity doctrine. Distance and the storm-wall are enough.

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## Kitsune

Kitsune are the fox-born: slight, quick-eyed people with a fox's ears and a brush of tail, and the cold pale light of **foxfire** (*kitsunebi*, fox-flame) always a thought away at their fingertips. In folklore the fox is a shapeshifter and a liar. The truth is gentler, and still real. A Kitsune can throw a **glamour**: foxfire drawn into the shape of another face, a borrowed voice, a trick of the eye. Glamour is an illusion of seeming, not flesh. It never touches what a person decides, only what they perceive. Kitsune are no more dishonest than their neighbours. They simply cannot quite be pinned down. They redirect. They step out of the frame of a situation and leave you looking at where they were, or at a face that isn't theirs. The tail is real and worn openly, and often the surest way to catch a glamourous fox: the one thing the fire will not hide.

Foxfire is common to every Kitsune: the ghost-light that leads travelers off the mountain path, the pale fire that hides the sacred white fox, the flame the old nine-tails were said to carry. Each kind of fox bends the same fire a different way.

Just as the world holds arctic, desert, and forest foxes, the fox-born come in kinds shaped by the country they were born to. The **Fox of the Wilds** (red-and-russet, the forest and hedgerow fox), the **Fox of the Snows** (white-coated, born to the cold north and the high snows), and the **Fox of the Sands** (pale and huge-eared, born to the deserts and dry country). All are Kitsune. All share the same slipperiness and the same foxfire, and marry and mingle freely; a child takes after one parent's line or the other. Each carries a gift bred into it by its home ground, and turns its foxfire to a different old fox-story: the will-o'-wisp that leads a hunter astray, the pale flame that swallows the white fox from sight, the ward-fire of the fox that always knows what's coming.



Three of every four people acquire a Condition. Kitsune are a Kind who never quite stay where you left them. Their reputation is misdirection-without-deceit. The fox slips the trap and leaves the trap in plain view.

## Values

Kitsune prize the graceful exit and the unfought fight: the deal that dissolves before it comes to blows, the door found before the room fills with smoke. They tend to distrust cornered situations (their instinct in a corner is to make a new corner) and to admire cleverness over force. A common fox-born saying: *“Never the last one holding it.”* They keep their word carefully, because a people so slippery would be trusted by no one if they were also untrustworthy. A Kitsune’s given word tends to be very solid, and they know it is their most valuable possession.

## Customs

Because they defuse rather than escalate, and can never quite be cornered, Kitsune work as mediators, brokers, and night-couriers. They carry delicate news between rival houses, hold the neutral ground in a negotiation, walk the dark roads by their own cold foxfire, and are trusted to be somewhere unnoticed and gone again without a scene. Foxfire is a small everyday grace, too. Children are taught to make it before they’re taught to read, and a home with a fox-born in it never wants for a soft, safe light. Older Kitsune, by tradition, carry themselves with more tails in the telling of it. The folklore of nine tails survives as reputation and honorific, not as literal biology or power.

## Daggerheart ancestry features

Every Kitsune has **Slip the Frame** and **Fox’s Glamour**, and chooses one **Fox** at character creation. The Fox is a full feature. Each grants a lasting knack (the real animal’s gift, bred in by its home ground) and a foxfire signature move (the fox-spirit myth, each kind turning the same ghost-flame a different way).

- **Slip the Frame:** When you would take damage from an attack, you can mark a **Stress** to slip aside: halve the damage, then immediately move up to **Very Close** range to a position out of the attacker’s reach. If you end this movement out of line of sight, you are **Hidden**.
- **Fox’s Glamour:** You can wrap yourself in foxfire-glamour to seem other than you are: veil your fox features to pass unremarked, cast your voice or a small sound a short way off, or throw a minor sensory illusion (a flicker of movement, a scent, a light) into a space within **Close** range. Once per scene, you can mark a **Stress** to **wear another face:** take on the convincing seeming of another person you’ve seen, holding it as long as you concentrate. The glamour is illusion, not flesh: it doesn’t change your body or fool touch, and a creature that has strong reason to doubt what it’s seeing can make an appropriate roll to catch the tell (a fox-shadow, a reflection that’s a beat late, an

animal's unease). This is disguise and misdirection. It never reaches mind-control. It changes what others perceive, not what they decide.

- **Your Fox:** Choose the fox you were born to. Each has a lasting knack and a foxfire move:
- **Fox of the Wilds** (*red / forest fox: the will-o'-wisp that leads travelers off the path*). *Knack:* you are at home in tangled, broken, or overgrown country: **advantage** on Agility Rolls to climb, leap, tumble, or move through difficult terrain, and you ignore its movement penalty. *Foxfire (Wisp-Lure):* mark a **Stress** to send dancing ghost-lights and false trails around a creature within **Close** range; until the end of its next turn it is drawn after the lights: its attacks against anyone but you are made with **disadvantage**, and you may immediately move up to **Very Close** range without drawing an attack. The lights are a lure. They are not a leash. The target isn't compelled to move, only baited to look the wrong way.
- **Fox of the Snows** (*arctic fox: the sacred white fox that vanishes in its own pale fire*). *Knack:* you leave no trail worth following. Adversaries have **disadvantage** on rolls to track, trail, or find you, and you have **advantage** on rolls to **Hide** or move unseen in open, snowy, pale, or exposed terrain. *Foxfire (Cold Vanishing):* once per scene, mark a **Stress** to wrap yourself in cold white foxfire and let the eye slide off you, and become **Hidden** even while observed and in the open, so long as you don't take an action that would obviously reveal you.
- **Fox of the Sands** (*fennec: the many-tailed fox that always knows what's coming*). *Knack:* you see clearly in darkness and dim light as far as you would in daylight, and your great ears miss nothing: **advantage** on rolls to hear, notice, or locate hidden creatures, sounds, or movement. *Foxfire (Ward-Flame):* when you or an ally within **Close** range would be targeted by an attack, you can mark a **Stress** to throw up a sudden curtain of foxfire. The target gains a **+2 bonus to their Evasion** against that attack.

## Naming

Hearth-register **Kusawe** (koo-SAH-way): light, slipping, sibilant. Daily speech is the local Maiethren drift; the fox-name is what they answer to when someone is trying to pin them down. Given names include Raki, Nenyu, Wishi, Kiraye, Suti, Hatu, Ranyu, Sinro, Foryo, Heka, Sofan.

A Kitsune raised devout in Threnmaieth may still be Raki at home and Raki Maethaem on the roll.

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## Selkie

Selkies are the sea-born, the skin-kin: sleek, cool-skinned people who carry a second self, a **sealskin** they can wear or set aside. The skin is not a costume and not a disguise. It is genuinely them, a spare body kept close, and slipping it on or off takes only a moment. Distinct from the frog-folk who simply

live underwater, a Selkie's gift is not breathing the deep. It is that you cannot keep hold of one. A Selkie in the water, in a net, in a grip, in a locked room, has a way out. The sea taught them that being held is temporary.

Out of the skin, a Selkie reads as an ordinary person with a few quiet tells: cool, faintly sleek skin, large dark eyes, and sometimes a little webbing at the fingers. Nobody stares. The seal-blood shows the way any other Kind's does. The real transformation lives in the skin, not the face.

The old story is theft and grief. Steal a selkie's skin and you own her; she pines for a sea she can't return to. A Selkie belongs fully to **two homes at once**, shore and sea, and so they are the people who move easily between worlds that don't understand each other. The removable skin is a private, tender thing (loaning it, or having it taken, is a real intimacy and a real violation, handled in story, never as a mechanical gotcha). It is not a leash.

## Values

Selkies value belonging without being bound: deep loyalty freely given, resented the instant it's demanded. They are hard to detain and hard to hold onto. A Selkie loves fiercely but will not be caged, and a relationship or a job that starts to feel like a net is one they will quietly, gracefully leave. They carry a comfortable double-homesickness their whole lives and consider it normal. To always miss the place you aren't is, to them, simply the price of getting to have two homes.

## Customs

Because they can't be kept down and can't be kept out, Selkies work as rescue swimmers, cold-water divers and salvors, and go-betweens: the ones sent into the surf after the drowning, down to the wreck, or across the water to a community the shore-folk can't talk to. Escape-artistry makes them trusted couriers for anything that mustn't be seized in transit. The sealskin is treated with real ceremony. Where a Selkie keeps their skin, who they'd ever let hold it, and the day a child is first given the run of their own skin are all significant, private matters.

Death by drowning is the threshold that Strikes the Far-Voiced. Selkies, being so at home in the water, have a complicated, storied relationship with that door.

## Daggerheart ancestry features

- **Second Skin:** You carry a **sealskin**, a second self you can don or shed in a moment. While you wear it, you ignore the effects of cold and deep water, you can hold your breath far longer than anyone should, and you always know which way is up and where the nearest surface or shore lies. You have **advantage** on Agility Rolls to swim, dive, or move through water.

- *Anchored.* Your skin is your fixed point in the world. Wherever you leave it stashed, you always know the direction and distance to it and can find your way back to it unerringly, however far you've travelled or however turned-around you are. (Loaning your skin, or having it taken, is a matter of story and trust, never a mechanical penalty.)
- **Slip the Hold:** When a creature grabs or restrains you, or succeeds on an attack against you, you can mark a **Stress** to slip free like a seal from a net: you end any grab or **Restrained** effect on you, ignore any forced movement from that attack, and move up to **Very Close** range out of the creature's reach.
- **Seal-Kin:** Seals and the beasts of the sea treat you as kin, not as prey or stranger. You have **advantage** on rolls to calm, read, or call an animal of the sea. Once per scene, while you are in or near water, you can mark a **Stress** to let the sea itself warn you: the GM **names** what is approaching through the water, and until the end of your next turn the nearest seal-kin surfaces to aid you — a distraction that draws a foe's attention, a tow through the current, or a shove that carries you toward shore or safety. You may move up to **Close** range before the named approach arrives. A warning and a help. Not an immunity. *Cannot be caught off guard* sits on The Mountain's Mood only.

Selkies are at home in water (long breath-hold, ignore cold and deep, swim advantage) but are not true underwater breathers. That stays the Ribbet's lane. Seal-Kin calls seal-kin to aid. It does not charm people.

## Naming

Hearth-register **Sakoa** (sah-KOH-ah): liquid, rounded, coastal. Daily speech is the local Maiethren drift. Given names include Lavo, Fesa, Moka, Dovo, Neson, Foaro, Veakea, Didel, Roadoa, Woanun, Laknea.

The hearth-name is spoken to the water the day a child is first given the run of their skin; the civic byname comes from the town that watched them Turn. Two homes, two names. They do not consider this a conflict.

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## Tengu

Tengu are the crow-born of the high country: lean, sharp-featured people with dark feathers through their hair and down their arms, black bright eyes, and broad wings that carry them off any cliff or updraft. They are the folk of the peaks and the wind, born where the air is thin and the weather turns in a heartbeat, and utterly unbothered by either. Where lowlanders see a killing drop and a coming storm,

a Tengu reads a launch point and a rising thermal. They fly, and the mountain never surprises them. They feel the rockfall before it slides and the squall before it breaks.

The old stories make them aloof trickster-demons or swordsmanship-obsessed hermits. The crow-born of the Turning belong to the high wild the way Selkies belong to the sea: at home in the exact place that kills everyone else. The fox-born move unseen through society, the sea-born through water, the crow-born through the sky and the heights.

Wings are always present. A Tengu reads as Tengu at a glance, as ordinary in-world as any other Kind.

## Values

Tengu prize perspective, the view from height and the habit of mind that comes with it. Their instinct in any tangle is to get above it and look down: gain height, gain distance, see the whole shape of a thing before acting. They tend toward blunt directness (from people used to seeing exactly where a path leads and saying so) and a certain impatience with those who won't climb to look for themselves. A crow-born saying: *"The valley argues about the storm; the ridge just watches it come."* They respect earned skill and hard-won height, and have little patience for status that wasn't climbed to.

## Customs

Because they can go where footpaths can't and read the mountain's mood before it turns, Tengu work as high-pass guides, weather-callers, sky-couriers, and mountain rescue. They carry word over the peaks faster than any road, call the avalanche warning down to the valley towns, and go over the edge after the fallen climber. Tengu settlements cling to cliff faces and ridge-shelves, reached by wing or by rope, and a Tengu's first solo flight off the home crag is as significant a coming-of-age as a Selkie child first given the run of their own skin. They keep a running, half-teasing rivalry with the Selkies. Sky-folk and sea-folk each remain convinced their element is the one worth belonging to.

## Daggerheart ancestry features

- **Wind-Winged:** You can fly. While flying, you can mark a **Stress** to fold your wings and **dive** on a target within Close range: treat it as a **Finesse** attack dealing **d8** physical damage using your Proficiency, and end the dive anywhere within **Very Close** range of that target.
- **The Mountain's Mood:** You read the high wild before it moves. You have **advantage** on rolls to sense danger in the natural world (a coming storm, rockfall, avalanche, unstable footing, treacherous terrain) and to navigate mountainous or aerial ground. You **cannot be caught off guard by an environmental hazard or a terrain-based ambush**. You always feel it coming in time to act or call a warning before it lands. That wording is issued **once**, here, and only against

weather and ground. Seal-Kin names an approach. Hollow-Hill feels gait through earth. Neither is this immunity.

- **Wind-Caller:** You command the mountain wind the way the old fan-bearers did (the fan is a **ha-uchiwa**, a Tengu feather-fan). Mark a **Stress** to call a sudden gust and choose one: **shove** a target within **Far** range a step closer or farther and knock it **Vulnerable**; **carry** yourself or a willing ally an extra move on the wind (a great leap, a saving glide down from a height, a boost across a gap); or **sweep** an area within Close range clear of smoke, gas, fog, or loose airborne projectiles until the start of your next turn.

## Naming

Hearth-register **Gonan** (GO-nan): clipped, windy, high-country. Deliberately not the same mouth as Kusawe. Daily speech is the local Maiethren drift. Given names include Teku, Kukra, Gobak, Hosen, Kotak, Buka, Rekren, Kuhos, Hrarat, Gonan. (Gonan is also the people-name; reuse as a given name is a hearth-honor, like naming a child after the ridge.)

Bynames are often a perch or a pass (Teku of Highgate, Hosen of the White Stair), not a harbour.

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## Yumboe

Yumboes are the good people (*Bakhna Rakhna* in their own tongue), the small, moon-waked hill-folk of the far isle of Kumbaen. They stand about waist-high to a mainlander, with pearl-pale skin that catches the light, hair like spun silver, and wide dark eyes made for the night. They live within the green hills of their home, a warren of hearths and long feast-halls hollowed under the turf, and come up by moonlight, for they keep the night the way other folk keep the day. Yumboes are hospitable, openly so. A Yumboe's table is open to native and stranger alike, laid with more than a small people should be able to carry, and waited on by hands and feet you can plainly see and bodies you cannot: the unseen servants that are the good people's oldest wonder.

Unlike Kitsune, Selkie, and Tengu, who are native to the mainland and unremarkable there, a Yumboe is mythic-rare off their far isle. Most people of Maiethorn, Strandoren, and Heskoren have only heard stories of the pearly, silver-haired good people from across the drowning sea.

On the isle they are an ordinary, warm, whole people who happen to live somewhere almost no one can reach, so their strangeness is distance. They are not strange to themselves. They are only a legend to a world that has never had them to supper. A small, generous hill-people who love a feast and the moon; underneath, the hands with no bodies, and a whole living nation the mainland files under fairy-tale.

A Yumboe reads as a Yumboe at a glance, which is exactly why they can't move unremarked off their isle. The "two-foot good people" of the oldest tellings are the deep-hill kin of legend; those you would play are small but not doll-sized.

## Values

Yumboes prize hospitality above nearly all else. To feed a guest, and to be fed as one, is their deepest courtesy and their firmest bond; a shared table is as binding to them as a sworn word is to the Bound. They are a people of the threshold and the hearth: comfortable underground and after dark, unhurried, and quietly certain that the surface world's noon-day bustle misses most of what matters. Because they are small and their home is hidden, they have never learned to meet force with force. They meet it with welcome and misdirection, and with a great many helping hands. A Yumboe saying: "*No one is a stranger twice.*" They find the mainland's daylight faiths loud and its treatment of the unwelcomed baffling.

## Customs

On Kumbaan, life runs by the moon. The good people wake at dusk, work and feast and dance the bright nights, and sleep out the glare of day in the cool of the hills. Their halls are famous (in their own telling) for feasts that outshine their means. The unseen hands fetch and pour and serve, so that even a poor household sets a table like a lord's. They keep terrace-gardens and standing-stone marks on the surface and the real life below. They fish the storm-walled shallows and, the old accounts say, were not above lifting a little corn from anyone careless enough to leave it: a small people's small mischief, told fondly.

Off the isle (the very few who cross), a Yumboe is a walking wonder, and knows it. They tend to become hosts, keepers, cooks, and go-betweens wherever they land, turning the one thing they always have (a welcome, and hands to lay a table) into a place in a world that first meets them as a myth. A Yumboe abroad is usually the only one anyone has ever seen.

Kumbaan has no Turning Tree. There is no Leaf-Fall and no Given Conditions on the isle. Struck can still happen, at far smaller percentages than the mainland: enough for a story, not a social class. Being a Kind, Yumboe still stacks with a Condition in principle. A Yumboe abroad under a mainland Tree is a live question (she could Give; it almost never arises), not a racial immunity.

## Daggerheart ancestry features

Every Yumboe has all three: **Hollow-Hill**, **Moon-Waked**, and **The Unseen Hands**.

- **Hollow-Hill:** You are one of the good people: **small** (hill-folk stature), and born to the deep earth. You can move through gaps and spaces too tight for a larger creature, and you have **advantage** on

Agility Rolls to squeeze, climb, or move through cramped, broken, or underground terrain and to **Hide** where there is cover to slip behind. Underground, or within stone and hill, you always know your depth and heading and **cannot become lost**. You feel movement through the ground: the **direction, number, and gait** (walk, crawl, or slide) of creatures within **Close** range who are on or under the earth. Tremor-sense, not immunity. *Cannot be caught off guard* sits on The Mountain's Mood only.

- **Moon-Waked:** You keep the night. You see in darkness and dim light as clearly as others see by day, and you have **advantage** on rolls to notice, search, or act **at night or underground**, anywhere the sun doesn't reach. When you take rest **under the open night sky or moonlight**, you clear **1 additional Stress** (or your party gains a little of the good people's ease: the GM's call on the fiction). The daylight doesn't harm you, but you are never quite at your best in its glare.
- **The Unseen Hands:** You can call the good people's unseen servants (**hands and feet plainly visible, but no body between them**) to attend you. At will, they perform small tasks within **Close** range: fetch and carry a light object, pour and serve, hold a door or a rope, steady a load, lay a table. Once per scene, you can mark a **Stress** to set them to **harry** instead: a flurry of unseen hands swarms a target within **Close** range, and until the end of its next turn choose one: the target has **disadvantage** on its next attack, **or** the next ally to act against it has **advantage**. The hands are a conjured seeming of many small helpers. They are not a force. They can distract, fumble, and fetch, but they can't deal damage, wield a weapon, or restrain a determined creature.

## Naming

The Yumboes speak their own tongue, unrelated to Maiethren: the one language in the setting that owes nothing to the Leaf-Mother's liturgy, because the Trees never crossed the storm-wall. Its sound is open-voweled and warm, with soft pre-nasal clusters (*mb, nd, nk, nj*) and a lilting, drum-like rhythm. A Yumboe name sounds foreign the instant it's spoken.

- Their name for themselves: *Bakhna Rakhna* ("the good people").
- Their homeland: *Kumbaan* (koom-BAHN), "the hidden home." Mainlanders call it the Sundering Isle.
- Given names include Ambaa, Njeela, Kumbo, Sambanka, Ndeya, Mbaraan, Njunda, Rakhilo, Sonkaa, Mbindaa, Yumbaka, Ndoolu, Sambiyo, Lunji, Yaaba, Saalo, Mbela, Soonke, Njili, Yendo, Waandi, Koriwaa.

Yumboes are too rare on the mainland to have grown a local byname-layer. They keep the one register.

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# Language and Naming

You need a person who sounds like they grew up somewhere, and a hall that sounds like the land that built it. You do not need a grammar.

**Speak the common name; write the liturgical name.** A traveller asks for the *hall-keepers* or sails to *the Night Shore*. A rite, charter, learned map, or scholar may write *Orenhael* or *Netstrand*. The common handle comes first at the table. It is not a translation in parentheses after the “real” name. The Hinge Shore has no current liturgical form; *Eolstrand* is retired.

**A person is named by the place that raised them.** If they are Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, or Yumboe, they also keep a hearth-name from their Kind. Everyone else uses the local mouth of the Old Tongue. Two names is ordinary. **Raki of Hallowquay** is an introduction, not a secret identity.

This chapter is the how-to: how names work, how to pick one, and how to make one that is not on a list. The lists come first. Under each Kind, **To make another** is the generator. **How to Name a Place or a Hall** is the same job for towns and offices, using the old-word table. The lookup tables are what each land calls the same building.

Continent and region names wait for **The Four Continents**, where the map is. The sound-system, and what the linguistics words mean, live in Book X under **GM only: Language**.

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## How to Name a Person

1. **Where were they raised?** That sets the second name, and the sound of a common-tongue first name.
2. **Are they one of the four custom Kinds?** If yes, pick the given name from that Kind’s list. If no, pick from the place-list.
3. **Add the second name that place uses.** A **byname** where people are witnessed. A **house-name** where a list has to find them again. Not both as the civic name, and never a Kind-name.
4. **Say it once with the stress marked (CAPS)**, then use it normally.

A byname is *of a town*, *of a Tree*, *called such for a deed*, or *of the house you actually sleep in* when that house is not a list. The road, the live front, the waiting towns, and every power that refuses to

write persons down use this. A fox-born broker on a quay that does not file people: **Raki of Hallowquay**. The human at the next desk: **Valen of Hallowquay**. Same street, same civic name, different first sound.

A house-name is inherited. Children wear it. A neighbour says the given name. A clerk says the **house first**, then the given name. The house-word is that place's own drift, often an old given name that stuck to a line. It is not a town. The list-lands are **Threnmaieth**, **Trenledd**, **Rothallo** (people still say the Inner Close), and **a filing house while the paper is open**. Shut the paper, and the quay goes back to the witness way. In Trenledd the column may file a person under the house that pays. In Rothallo the line can cast a person out and keep the house on them. *Closed* on a roster is a rank, not a second name.

| Who is asking                          | What you give                           |
|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| A neighbour                            | the given name                          |
| A clerk in a list-land                 | the house first, then the given name    |
| A witness-town, and you are a stranger | the given name, and <i>of the place</i> |
| Kumbaan                                | the given name                          |

Kumbaan asks neither house nor town. A mainland house, or a mainland *of-the-town*, is not the name they use at the table. Witness-lands do not keep a person-list. Maiethvael will not write a house. The Waiting Lands will not. Harrow's will not use a roll-name unless it means to be cold.

A Tengu's byname is often a perch or a pass, not a harbour: **Teku of Highgate**, **Hosen of the White Stair**.

Yumboes are the exception. They are too rare on the mainland to have grown a local second name. They keep one name, and it sounds foreign the moment it is spoken.

## Before you lock it

- Do not put **Raki** and **Ranyu** in the same party. Do not put **Teku** and **Kukra** in as twins unless they are.
- A Selkie named **Wishi**, or a Tengu named **Maethaem**, is a tell: raised away, adopted, or passing. Use it on purpose or not at all.
- Place-names already on the map are reserved. No person is called Vaethorn, Lestrand, Threnmaieth, Thaeloren, Maieth, Kumbaan, Ndeyaan, Haelthael, Leddoren, or Vaeloren. The same goes for church and house names (Orenhael, Thaelvaeth, Nethoren, Leddhael, Vaelbren, Njaalo, Njawaal, Vaethledd), the squares Ornsael, Brenthael, Brenod, Vaelun, Ornath, Harrow's, and the seats Eolvaeth, Orentel, Maiethlir.

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## Names by Place

Everyday names are the Old Tongue worn down to something you can shout across a yard. Soft *th*, long vowels, liquids. Stress usually sits on the second beat.

There is no fourth “human language.” A town in any Tree-touched land uses these sounds, worn the way that land wears them. The isle of Kumbaen is the exception. It already has its own mouth.

## How a place speaks

A traveller can say Turning Tree, the Mother, a hug, a colour, a tree-warden, and a graft, and be understood on every mainland road. Use those words and you will be understood. The table below is what each kind of place calls the same six things when it is talking like itself. Use a local word when you want a scene to sound like that place. Say who is speaking.

The pious core keeps the old *th* sound. Waiting towns tire it out. A dock lets it go. Kumbaen, the Sundering Isle, speaks in its own mouth and has no Tree to name.

|            | Pious core                                                                        | Waiting lands, the live front                                                    | The docks                | The hill              |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|-----------------------|
| the Tree   | <b>the Mother’s Hand</b>                                                          | <b>the Thallow</b>                                                               | <b>Tallo</b><br>(TAL-oh) | <b>the far tree</b>   |
| the Mother | <b>Maieth</b> (MY-eth)                                                            | <b>Mait</b> (MAYT)                                                               | <b>the old rite</b>      | <b>the loud story</b> |
| a hug      | <b>a keeping</b>                                                                  | <b>a hug</b>                                                                     | <b>a clear</b>           | <b>the place</b>      |
| a colour   | <b>the colour</b>                                                                 | <b>the gift</b>                                                                  | <b>the fall</b>          | <b>a test</b>         |
| a warden   | <b>the Reckoned Hands</b> (the crown’s word; Maiethvaen says <b>tree-warden</b> ) | <b>Hands-folk</b>                                                                | <b>a tree-tender</b>     | <b>the loud guest</b> |
| a graft    | <b>a Hand carried in</b>                                                          | <b>a carried Thallow</b> ; on the live front, until it can Turn, <b>the wood</b> | <b>a carrying</b>        | <b>their cutting</b>  |

Careful prayer in a waiting town puts the thorn back, and Maieth returns for as long as the prayer is open. The kitchen says Mait. A no-colour is still a hug. They do not dress it as a prize. On a dock, Tallo is how a quay says the Thallow once the thorn is gone. Say it on the water. A charter keeps the long name. A no-colour is a clear: the child came up clear, free to be hired. Trenledd is this mouth with a list. The hill has a table and no Tree. The far tree and their cutting are mainland things. The loud story is what they call the Mother when a guest brings her up. A warden who climbs the hill is the loud guest, and is still fed.

Four ways of talking are enough for a scene.

In a devout square, people finish the practical sentence, then put “the Mother’s Hand” or “Maieth” back in if the first sentence left them out. While the room is mixed, they will not say “Tallo,” “the old rite,” or “a clear.” They will not open with a house-name when speaking to a neighbour.

On a dock, people speak in about six words, then give the number or the berth if they need them. They repeat the last hard fact. They will not put the old *th* back into a word to sound devout. A “clear” is their word for a child the Tree hugged and gave no Condition, free to be hired. They will not call that a sadness. While no document is open, they will not ask what house you belong to. While a filing house has the paper open, they will: house-name first, then the given name.

A waiting town, and the live front, keep to one length and two repeats. A waiting town repeats “not this week.” The live front repeats “the wood,” and then the neighbour’s town if their own wood will not speak. They will not promise the week. They will not call their Tree “Tallo.”

A hill-hall on Kumbaan uses three short sentences: a welcome, a pause, and one practical thing. They repeat “sit,” and “the place.” They will not give a newcomer a test. They will not ask “of where,” or what house, as the price of a seat.

Each of these places also has one phrase it says whole. People do not stop to translate it, and this book does not either. Use it as a line someone says, not as a spell or a password. *Lei thulen. Ka doven. Len soret. Aman ndo.*

| Raised in                               | How the name sounds                                                 | Pick from                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Threnmaieth</b> , pious<br>Maiethorn | The old church sound,<br>kept whole. You hear<br>the <i>th</i> .    | <b>Maethaem</b> (MY-eth-aym), <b>Reimaethe</b> (ray-MY-eth-eh), <b>Thilim</b> (THIL-im), <b>Rithnali</b> (rith-NAH-lee), <b>Valein</b> (vah-LAYN) |
| <b>Vaethorn</b> , Heskoren<br>folk      | Worn. The <i>th</i> is still<br>there, softer. Endings<br>simplify. | <b>Nathdo</b> (NATH-doh), <b>Saelid</b> (SAY-lid), <b>Tora</b> , <b>Seine</b> (SAY-neh), <b>Nethiro</b> (neth-EE-ro)                              |
| <b>Lestrand</b> ,<br>Strandoren docks   | Clipped. The <i>th</i> has<br>gone to t or d, or<br>dropped.        | <b>Valen</b> , <b>Tilim</b> , <b>Mataero</b> (mah-TAY-ro), <b>Ledan</b> ,<br><b>Sorel</b>                                                         |

Devout places keep the old *th*. Dock towns sand it off. Listen to a name and you can hear how that land sits toward the Tree.

To make a new common-tongue name, start from one of the lists above and keep the same mouth. Do not invent a new set of sounds. Vaelhesk keeps older *vael* and frontier *hesk*-. That is still this family, worn further.

## Names for the Four Custom Kinds

Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, and Yumboe keep a hearth-name for given names, kin, and in-group talk. On the street they still wear the local byname. You can often hear both homes in one introduction.

The lists are what you pick from. The short recipe under each is only for when you need a name that is not on the list. Make one that could sit next to the others without anyone blinking.

### Kitsune: Kusawe (koo-SAH-way)

Light, slipping, a little hissy. A mouth that leaves a corner in the sentence.

**Pick from:** Raki, Nenyu, Wishi, Kiraye, Suti, Hatu, Ranyu, Sinro, Foryo, Heka, Sofan.

The hearth-name is the one they answer to when someone is trying to pin them down. They consider this funny. A fox raised devout in Threnmaieth may still be Raki at home and Raki Maethaem on the roll.

**To make another:** two or three short beats. Use k, s, sh, n, r, m, t, w, y, f, h, and the vowels a, i, u, e, o, plus *ai* as in *eye*. You can end on n, m, or r. Do not put a *th* in it (that is church-speech). Do not start with *kr* or *gr* (that is Tengu). Do not use *mb* or *nd* (that is Yumboe).

## Selkie: Sakoa (sah-KOH-ah)

Liquid, rounded, coastal. Names you can say with cold air in your mouth.

**Pick from:** Lavo, Fesa, Moka, Dovo, Neson, Foaro, Veakea, Didel, Roadoa, Woanun, Laknea.

The day a child is first given the run of their own skin is when the hearth-name is spoken to the water. The civic byname comes later, from the town that watched them Turn. Two homes, two names. They do not consider this a conflict.

**To make another:** two or three beats. Use l, r, n, m, s, v, f, d, b, k, w, and the vowels o, u, a, i, e, plus *ea* and *oa*. Do not use *th*, *sh*, *kr*, *gr*, or *mb* / *nd*.

## Tengu: Gonan (GO-nan)

Clipped, windy, high-country. Shorter names, hard onsets, said as if the wind might take the end.

Ridge-speech, not court-speech. Not the same mouth as Kusawe.

**Pick from:** Teku, Kukra, Gobak, Hosen, Kotak, Buka, Rekren, Kuhos, Hrarat, Gonan.

Gonan is also the people-name. Reusing it as a given name is a hearth-honor, like naming a child after the ridge.

**To make another:** prefer two beats. Use k, t, g, n, r, h, s, b, d. *Kr*, *gr*, and *hr* at the front are at home here. Vowels a, o, u, e. Few *i* (that vowel lives with the foxes). Do not use *th*, *sh*, *mb* / *nd*, or long *ai* / *ea* / *oa*.

## Yumboe

Their own tongue, not the Old Tongue. Open vowels, a drum-like rhythm, and *mb*, *nd*, *nk*, *nj* at the start of a beat. A Yumboe name sounds foreign the instant it is spoken. That is the point. The Trees never crossed the storm-wall, so this mouth owes the liturgy nothing.

They call themselves **Bakhna Rakhna**, the good people. Their home is **Kumba**an (koom-BAHN). Mainlanders call it the Sundering Isle.

**Pick from:** Ambaa, Njeela, Kumbo, Ndeya, Mbaraan, Njunda, Rakhilo, Sambiyo, Lunji, Yaaba, Saalo, Mbela, Soonke, Njili, Yendo, Waandi, Koriwaa.

**To make another:** keep the open vowels and the *mb / nd / nk / nj*. Do not put a *th* in it. Do not clip it down to a Lestrang dock-name. They keep the one register on the mainland. No *of Hallowquay* unless the story is that they have decided to stay.

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## How to Say It

CAPS is the stressed beat. Mark it the first time, then drop it.

- **ae** = “ay” as in *day*
- **ei** = “eye”
- **eo** = an “ay-oh” glide
- **a** as in *father* · **e** as in *bed* · **i** as in *machine* · **o** as in *go* · **u** as in *moon*
- **th** as in *thin*, never as in *the*
- Stress usually falls on the **second beat** of a two- or three-beat word: thae-LOR-en, ma-YETH.  
Short compounds stress the root.

The Old Tongue is warm and weighty. No harsh piles of consonants. If you cannot say it at the table, it is the wrong name.

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## How to Name a Place or a Hall

The Old Tongue, **Maiethren** (mah-YETH-ren, “Mother-speech”), is the church language of the Awakening Tree. Nobody grows up speaking it at the market. Place-names, crowns, and old offices are built from it. Everyday talk uses plain compounds: *the Kept*, *the ranging*, *tree-wardens*.

To name something old or official:

1. **Pick one or two old words** from the list below.
2. **Glue them together.** Thaeloren is *thael* + *oren*: Tree + witness.
3. **Wear it the way the land wears it.** A devout land keeps the *th* and the long vowels. A frontier town softens them. A dock town sands them off. The most worn name belongs to the least-devout place.
4. **Mark the stress** on first use.

Same building, three names. A devout land calls the Far-Voiced hall a *gift-hall*. A merchant coast calls it a *release-house*. A surveillance-crown calls it a *counted hall*. The lookup tables below are that fact,

row by row.

Kumbaan is not on this list. Its names are Yumboe.

## **The old words**

These are the blocks names are built from. The meaning is what the old word meant in the rite. A dock town may keep the sound and let the meaning slide.



| Word          | Says   | Means                                                                                                                                             |
|---------------|--------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>oren</b>   | OR-en  | to witness; to speak true                                                                                                                         |
| <b>ren</b>    | ren    | speech, tongue. As a suffix: “the speech of.” Maieth <b>ren</b> is Mother-speech.                                                                 |
| <b>thael</b>  | thayl  | the Tree; sacred motherwood                                                                                                                       |
| <b>maieth</b> | MY-eth | the Mother                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>vael</b>   | vayl   | a gift Given. Older: what the land yields (harvest, a child returned from water, a person the hill kept). The Old Ways still use the older sense. |
| <b>vaeth</b>  | vayth  | the waiting; the longing (the Kept; the pilgrim’s wait)                                                                                           |
| <b>hael</b>   | hayl   | whole, hale, sound                                                                                                                                |
| <b>thren</b>  | thren  | to count as stewardship, before the Mother                                                                                                        |
| <b>ledd</b>   | led    | to reckon on a ledger. The commercial twin of <i>thren</i> .                                                                                      |
| <b>orn</b>    | orn    | land, ground, a holding                                                                                                                           |
| <b>neth</b>   | neth   | night; the long dark. Month-root.                                                                                                                 |
| <b>eol</b>    | AY-ohl | a hinge; the year’s turning. Month-root, and the church-name of the First Cut: <b>Eoloren</b> .                                                   |
| <b>bren</b>   | bren   | hearth; the kept fire. Month-root.                                                                                                                |
| <b>lir</b>    | leer   | thaw; water that runs again. Month-root.                                                                                                          |
| <b>sael</b>   | sayl   | sowing; the first green. Month-root. Not <i>vael</i> (a gift) and not <i>hael</i> (wholeness).                                                    |
| <b>ael</b>    | ayl    | to air; to let feeling out. The Far-Voiced hall is the <b>ael-hall</b> .                                                                          |
| <b>stel</b>   | stel   | to still; to hold from moving. The Stilled’s craft.                                                                                               |
| <b>crae</b>   | kray   | craft; the working of an element. The Answered shops as a sector.                                                                                 |
| <b>hesk</b>   | hesk   | far, outer edge. Frontier coinage, not in the old rite. Heskoren, Vaelhesk.                                                                       |

The Awakening Tree’s church-name is **Thaeloren** (thae-LOR-en): the Tree that witnesses. Everyday worn form: **the Thallow**. Citizenship-by-witness is in the Tree’s own name.

The three famous corners are named by gluing two old words and wearing them down. Closer to the Tree, the old sound stays. Farther out, it sands off:

- **Vaethorn** (vay-THORN): *vaeth* + *orn*, “the Waiting Land.” Keeps the *th*. Everyday **Wethorn**. People: Vaethorn-folk, or the Waiting.
- **Lestrand** (leh-STRAND): *ledd* + *strand*, sanded smooth, “the Reckoning Coast.” The *th* is gone. People: Lestrand-folk or Strandmen.
- **Threnmaieth** (THREN-my-eth): *thren* + *maieth*, “the Mother’s Reckoning.” Keeps the full old sound. People: Threnmaieth-folk. The crown styles itself the Mother’s Reckoning.

The same lever holds further out. *Thren* worn to *Tren* in *Trenledd*. *Maieth* as gift, not count, in *Maiethvael*. *Vael* against *vaeth* on *Heskoren* (*Vaelhesk* / *Vaethorn*).

Faiths are named from the same blocks, so a faith sounds like the land that keeps it:

- **Haelthael** (hayl-THALE): *hael* + *thael*, “the Tree kept whole.” The Watching’s own name.
- **Leddoren** (led-OR-en): *ledd* + *oren*, “the witnessed account.” The Fair Hand’s own name.
- **Vaeloren** (vay-LOR-en): *vael* + *oren* in the older sense, “the land’s witnessing.” The Old Ways.
- **Ndeyaan** (ndey-AHN): not *Maiethren*. The Open Table. The one faith-name that owes the liturgy nothing.

If you need a new church or guild name, glue two old words and wear them for the land. Do not collide with a name already on the map. The church-names already in use:

**Orenhael** (or-EN-hayl), tree-wardens: witness + whole. **Thaelvaeth** (THALE-vayth), Road-hands: the Tree gone to the waiting. **Nethoren** (neth-OR-en), Watchers: night-witnesses. **Leddhael** (LED-hayl), Book-hands: the accounted-whole. **Vaelbren** (VAYL-bren), door-keepers: the yield-hearth. **Njaalo** (NJAHL-lo) and **Njawaal** (njah-WAHL): Yumboe, not *Maiethren*. **Vaethledd** (VAYTH-led), the Slide: the waiting reckoned. **Saelhael** (SAYL-hayl), greens-keepers: the sown-whole. Hall-keepers have no current liturgical form; *Aeloren* is retired. **Stelhael** (stel-HAYL), stillers: the held-whole. **the Crae** (kray): craft. The Intake has no church-name.

Era-names from the same box: **Brenvaeth** (bren-VAYTH), the Walking Years. **Eoloren** (ay-ohl-OR-en), the First Cut. **Ornthael** (orn-THALE), the Years of Hands. A road-house’s cant is **brenhael** (bren-HAYL), the hearth kept whole.

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## What Each Land Calls the Same Thing

Every land has the same institutions. They flow from the Trees and the Conditions. What each calls them is how that land sits toward the Tree, the faith, and the roll.

Use the **common tongue** column unless you need the local word. Use the local word when a Vaethorn pilgrim, a Lestrاند factor, or a Threnmaieth clerk is speaking, or when you want the table to hear the difference.

## Citizenship and law

| Thing                      | Common tongue                        | Vaethorn (devout)                                 | Lestrاند (secular)                                         | Threnmaieth (surveillance)                               |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| proof-by-people (vouching) | <b>standing-for</b>                  | <i>the speaking</i> (vouched at worship)          | <i>warranting</i> (a commercial guarantee)                 | <i>the naming</i> (you are named to the crown)           |
| the safety-licence         | <b>the ticket</b>                    | <i>the blessing-to-practice</i>                   | <i>the guild-ticket</i>                                    | <i>the crown-warrant</i>                                 |
| a census of persons        | <i>(none; no one else keeps one)</i> | <i>(none; the giving is the Mother's to know)</i> | <i>the roll</i> (a <b>tax</b> roll only, never of persons) | <b>the Threnhael</b> (THREN-hayl, "the whole-keeping")   |
| the Inviolable Will        | <b>"the will is one's own"</b>       | <i>the Mother's own line</i> (held as scripture)  | <i>the free-will clause</i> (sound commercial law)         | <i>the crown's assurance</i> (cited to justify the roll) |

Threnmaieth's census calls itself the **Threnhael**: *thren* + *hael*, "the keeping-whole." It sounds like care. It is total surveillance. Its clerks say they keep the realm hale. Its subjects are kept whole. Outsiders hear "the Counting."

## Tithe-provision

| Thing                                | Common tongue                           | Vaethorn (devout)                          | Lestrand (secular)                            | Threnmaieth (surveillance)                |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| venting-hall (Far-Voiced)            | <b>the ael-hall</b> (AYL, “the airing”) | <i>the gift-hall</i>                       | <i>the release-house</i> (also the playhouse) | <i>the counted hall</i>                   |
| ranging-commons (Two-Bodied)         | <b>the ranging</b>                      | <i>the wild-leave</i>                      | <i>the beast-yard</i> (a hired yard)          | <i>the ranging-roll</i>                   |
| garden-commons (the Taken-In)        | <b>the greens</b>                       | <i>the Mother’s green</i> (held in common) | <i>the leaf-lot</i> (rented by the season)    | <i>the tended green</i> (crown-furnished) |
| endowed library (Long-Lived novelty) | <b>the long-house of books</b>          | <i>the deathless gift</i>                  | <i>the endowment / the house</i>              | <i>the crown archive</i>                  |

## The people

The three life-outcomes of the Leaf-Fall keep their plain names **everywhere**: *the Given*, *the Struck*, *the Kept*. Each land’s second word is how it feels about them.

| Common tongue                           | Vaethorn (devout)                                     | Lestrand (secular)                              | Threnmaieth (surveillance)                            |
|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>the Given</b> (a Condition Given)    | <i>the gifted</i> (blessed)                           | <i>the Given</i> (plain)                        | <i>the marked</i> (on the roll)                       |
| <b>the Struck</b> (turned later, alone) | <i>the late-come</i> (met at a later door)            | <i>the turned</i> (neutral, a fact)             | <i>the unwitnessed</i> (suspect until named)          |
| <b>the Kept</b> (untithed, whole)       | <i>the Waited / Mother-kept</i> (pitied, passed over) | <i>the free (approving: unencumbered labor)</i> | <i>the unmarked / the passed-over</i> (noted as such) |

The Kept are pitied in devout Vaethorn (they missed the gift), envied-as-free on mercantile Lestrand (no Tithe, no guild, go anywhere), and filed as unmarked in Threnmaieth (a gap in the roll to be

explained).

## Clergy

| Thing                                 | Common tongue                                                              | Vaethorn<br>(devout)                    | Lestrand<br>(secular)                    | Threnmaieth<br>(surveillance)                             |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| the Motherfaith's<br>working clergy   | <b>tree-wardens</b><br>(church-name<br><i>Orenhael</i> )                   | <i>Hands-folk</i>                       | <i>tree-tenders</i>                      | <i>the Reckoned Hands</i>                                 |
| the pilgrimage<br>college             | <b>the First Seat</b>                                                      | <i>the First<br/>Hand's<br/>college</i> | <i>the old seat (a<br/>civic bureau)</i> | <i>the Reckoned Seat<br/>(wants them on the<br/>roll)</i> |
| graft-carriers /<br>sick-Tree circuit | <b>Road-hands</b> (church-<br>name <i>Thaelvaeth</i> )                     | <i>the waiting-<br/>hands</i>           | <i>the graft-<br/>carts</i>              | <i>the counted road</i>                                   |
| authorization to<br>cut a scion       | <b>Cutting-leave</b>                                                       | <i>the wood's<br/>blessing</i>          | <i>the carrying-<br/>licence</i>         | <i>the scion-warrant</i>                                  |
| the Watching's<br>people              | <b>Watchers</b> (church-<br>name <i>Nethoren</i> )                         | <i>the night-kin</i>                    | <i>vigil-folk<br/>(rarely met)</i>       | <i>the second column</i>                                  |
| the Fair Hand's<br>people             | <b>Book-hands</b> (church-<br>name <i>Leddhael</i> )                       | <i>Bargainers'<br/>clerks</i>           | <i>the Settling-<br/>hands</i>           | <i>the Uncounted Book</i>                                 |
| the Old Ways'<br>people               | <b>door-keepers / Kin-<br/>speakers</b> (church-<br>name <i>Vaelbren</i> ) | <i>the door-folk</i>                    | <i>grove-talkers</i>                     | <i>the Unreached</i>                                      |
| the Open Table's<br>people            | <b>table-keepers / hill-<br/>hosts</b> (own <i>Njaalo</i> )                | <i>(a sailor's<br/>tale)</i>            | <i>the Moon-<br/>Feast people</i>        | <i>(off the map)</i>                                      |
| the Shore-Sitters<br>(isle flavor)    | <b>shore-sitters</b> (own<br><i>Njawaal</i> )                              | <i>(a sailor's<br/>tale)</i>            | <i>(the wreck-<br/>waiters)</i>          | <i>(off the map)</i>                                      |
| the Slide (shadow<br>house)           | <b>the Slide / week-<br/>keepers</b> (cant<br><i>Vaethledd</i> )           | <i>the last pot /<br/>gift-credit</i>   | <i>week-rent</i>                         | <i>(the late week,<br/>unfiled)</i>                       |

## Tithe-infrastructure and tickets

| Thing                             | Common tongue                                                              | Vaethorn<br>(devout)             | Lestrand<br>(secular)               | Threnmaieth<br>(surveillance)      |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| the official<br>furnishing sector | <b>the furnishing / the<br/>greens and the halls</b>                       | <i>the gift-works</i>            | <i>the provision</i>                | <i>the counted<br/>channel</i>     |
| greens-keepers                    | <b>greens-keepers / lot-<br/>keepers</b> (church-name<br><i>Saelhael</i> ) | <i>Mother's-<br/>green hands</i> | <i>lot-keepers</i>                  | <i>the Tended</i>                  |
| hall-keepers                      | <b>hall-keepers / ael-hands</b><br>( <i>Aeloren</i> retired)               | <i>gift-hall folk</i>            | <i>release-hands</i>                | <i>counted-hall clerks</i>         |
| the Stillers                      | <b>stillers</b> (church-name<br><i>Stelhael</i> )                          | <i>blessing-<br/>surgeons</i>    | <i>ticket-<br/>surgeons</i>         | <i>crown-stillers</i>              |
| the element-<br>guilds            | <b>the element-guilds</b><br>(umbrella <i>the Crae</i> )                   | <i>gift-shops</i>                | <i>the craft-<br/>houses</i>        | <i>the Reckoned<br/>Craes</i>      |
| the Intake                        | <b>the Intake / the shed</b><br>(cant <i>catching-year</i> )               | <i>the late-<br/>catching</i>    | <i>the<br/>emergency<br/>ticket</i> | <i>the unwitnessed<br/>warrant</i> |

## Faiths

The common-tongue name is what a traveller says. The own-name is what the house says. The land's second word is how the state files them.

| Faith           | Common tongue   | Own name         | Vaethorn                                   | Lestrand                           | Threnmaieth                                                |
|-----------------|-----------------|------------------|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| the Leaf-Mother | the Motherfaith | <i>Maieth</i>    | <i>the Mother</i> (hot)                    | <i>the old rite</i> (worn light)   | <i>the Reckoned Faith</i>                                  |
| the Watching    | the Watching    | <i>Haelthael</i> | <i>the First Watching</i> (cousin-dissent) | <i>(rarely met)</i>                | <b>the Grown-Over</b> (a column on the roll)               |
| the Fair Hand   | the Fair Hand   | <i>Leddoren</i>  | <i>the Bargainers</i> (suspect)            | <i>the Settling</i> (ordinary)     | <i>the Uncounted Book</i> (private books offend the crown) |
| the Old Ways    | the Old Ways    | <i>Vaeloren</i>  | <i>the Before-Faith</i> (live fight)       | <i>(a frontier curiosity)</i>      | <i>the Unreached</i>                                       |
| the Open Table  | the Open Table  | <i>Ndeyaan</i>   | <i>(a sailor's tale)</i>                   | <i>the Moon-Feast</i> (quay-story) | <i>(not on the roll; off the map)</i>                      |

## Eras and dating

There is no universal year-zero.

| Thing                                  | Common tongue                                                    | Vaethorn<br>(devout)                            | Lestrand<br>(secular)                             | Threnmaieth<br>(surveillance)                                 |
|----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| the pilgrimage-<br>required past       | <b>the Walking Years</b><br>(church-name<br><i>Brenvaeth</i> )   | <i>the old mile /<br/>the waiting-<br/>road</i> | <i>the road-years</i><br>(a logistics<br>problem) | <i>the uncounted summers</i><br>(they want them on a<br>roll) |
| the first<br>successful town-<br>graft | <b>the First Cut</b><br>(church-name<br><i>Eoloren</i> )         | <i>the wood's<br/>blessing</i>                  | <i>the first<br/>carrying</i>                     | <i>the first warrant</i>                                      |
| the still-moving<br>spread of grafts   | <b>the Grafting</b>                                              | <i>her hands<br/>travelling</i>                 | <i>the carrying</i><br>(supply)                   | <i>the counted road</i> (they<br>would number it)             |
| the town-Tree<br>present               | <b>the Years of<br/>Hands</b> (church-<br>name <i>Ornthael</i> ) | <i>Since the<br/>Hands</i>                      | <i>since the local<br/>canopy</i>                 | <i>the Reckoned Hands-<br/>years</i>                          |
| a year's number                        | <i>(none universal)</i>                                          | <i>the year our<br/>graft took</i>              | <i>a house-year / a<br/>note-year</i>             | <i>a Cut-year</i> (and a<br>crown-count, later)               |

Before the Walk stays mostly unnamed. The Watching keep **the Before**. Kumbaen keeps moons.

## The road

Lived names of the Walking Years. Everyday first.



| Thing                             | Common tongue                                | Vaethorn (devout)                                        | Lestrand (secular)                          | Threnmaieth (surveillance)      |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Maiethorn inland walk             | <b>the Near Mile</b>                         | <i>the waiting-road</i><br>(they use this for all three) | <i>the inland days</i>                      | <i>the counted near-miles</i>   |
| Strandoren sea-then-land walk     | <b>the Salt Walk</b>                         | <i>the salt-waiting</i>                                  | <i>the berth-road</i>                       | <i>the uncounted crossing</i>   |
| Heskoren (and far-interior) walk  | <b>the Long Mile</b>                         | <i>the old mile</i>                                      | <i>the far road-years</i>                   | <i>the uncounted long-miles</i> |
| a deathless inn on the walk       | <b>road-house</b><br>(cant <i>brenhael</i> ) | <i>waiting-hearth</i>                                    | <i>the bed-house</i> (still means the bank) | <i>(wants them on the roll)</i> |
| a day's stone                     | <b>mile-shrine</b>                           | <i>ribbon-stone</i>                                      | <i>the mile-mark</i>                        | <i>the unfiled stone</i>        |
| the tenth-year week at the origin | <b>the one-week door</b>                     | <i>the only hug</i>                                      | <i>the appointment</i>                      | <i>the uncounted week</i>       |

The three walks stay common-tongue on purpose: logistics before liturgy.

## The Cut and the spread

Lived names of the First Cut. Everyday first. No named cutter. The nameless knife and the nameless green have no church-form on purpose: naming the green would pick a hearth, and a hearth would pick a hand.

| Thing                           | Common tongue                     | Vaethorn (devout)                                              | Lestrand (secular)                   | Threnmaieth (surveillance)     |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| folk object of the first taking | <b>the nameless knife</b>         | <i>the mother's knife</i>                                      | <i>the first theft</i>               | <i>the first unfiled cut</i>   |
| the first town-graft (unnamed)  | <b>the nameless green</b>         | <i>the wood's blessing</i><br>(they also use this for the Cut) | <i>the first carrying's ground</i>   | <i>the first warrant-green</i> |
| Seat quarrel before the paper   | <b>the generation of argument</b> | <i>the unblest years</i>                                       | <i>the first unlicensed carrying</i> | <i>the uncounted cuts</i>      |
| Old Ways courtesy at a planting | <b>the first meal</b>             | <i>(suspect: a guest-word)</i>                                 | <i>(a frontier courtesy)</i>         | <i>(unfiled)</i>               |

## Residues

Lived names of the Years of Hands. Everyday first. This is not post-history.

| Thing                                                     | Common tongue                                                                                      | Vaethorn<br>(devout)                                        | Lestrand<br>(secular)                      | Threnmaieth<br>(surveillance)      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| origin-walk you<br>already have a<br>Tree for             | <b>the extra mile</b>                                                                              | <i>the First Hand's<br/>hug</i>                             | <i>the First-<br/>Hand year</i>            | <i>the counted<br/>pilgrimage</i>  |
| walk because<br>the Tree is<br>missing, young,<br>or sick | <b>the neighbour's week</b><br>(still <i>the old mile</i> when<br>the neighbour is a<br>continent) | <i>the waiting-road</i><br>(they use this for<br>all walks) | <i>the borrowed<br/>week</i>               | <i>the uncounted<br/>neighbour</i> |
| prestige origin-<br>winter                                | <b>the First-Hand year</b>                                                                         | <i>(suspect: a<br/>bought hug)</i>                          | <i>the First-<br/>Hand year</i><br>(plain) | <i>the counted<br/>winter</i>      |
| mile-shrine now<br>in a Hands<br>square                   | <b>the stone in the square</b>                                                                     | <i>the ribbon still</i>                                     | <i>the old mile-<br/>mark</i>              | <i>the unfiled stone</i>           |
| unused pilgrim<br>dorm                                    | <b>the upper room</b>                                                                              | <i>the waiting-beds</i>                                     | <i>merchant-loft</i><br>(when let)         | <i>the uncounted<br/>loft</i>      |
| bed never let                                             | <b>the Held bed</b>                                                                                | <i>the kept-place</i>                                       | <i>the unlet</i><br>(house<br>custom)      | <i>(wants it on the<br/>roll)</i>  |

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BOOK III

## The Tree and the Faiths

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# The Turning Tree

A Turning Tree is a broad, slow, long-lived hardwood. Its canopy is like a great oak or beech, but it is its own kind. It stands at the ceremonial heart of a town, usually in a square, a green, or a walled temple-yard kept for it. Out of season it looks like an unusually grand old tree, and townsfolk treat it as one: children climb the low boughs, courts and markets convene in its shade, lovers carve nothing into it (that's taboo). In the tenth-year solstice week it turns. The canopy shifts through colours no ordinary tree wears, and it *chooses*.

The everyday word is **Turning Tree**, for what it does at the solstice: it *turns*, and it *turns children into what they'll become*. The devout call each one a **Hand of the Mother**, and the reverent species-word in liturgy is **motherwood**. In the old liturgical tongue the Tree is **Thaeloren** (*thae-LOR-en*): *thael* (Tree) + *oren* (to witness), "the Tree that witnesses." Everyday worn form: **the Thallow**.

## The Awakening Tree

There is one origin Tree: the **Awakening Tree**. It is the great, first Tree, the pilgrimage heart of the world. Old beyond reliable dating, vast, and the one Tree no one grafted from another. Every other Turning Tree descends from it. In liturgy it is **the First Hand**. It is a genuine pilgrimage destination. Devout families make the journey to be Turned under the origin; some settle nearby. The faith's central clergy seat sits in its shadow: the **First Seat**, a college of tree-wardens, not a throne. It stands on Maiethorn, in the Sacred Core.

## Grafts

Every town Turning Tree is a living graft of the Awakening Tree. A **graft** here is horticulture in the old sense: a cutting taken from living wood and joined to new ground so it grows as the same plant. As towns take root, especially far-flung ones a family could never reach the origin from, a sapling grafted from the Awakening Tree is carried out and planted in the new town's square. A **scion** is that cutting. It is not a seedling grown from a fallen seed. It is *cut tissue of the one Tree*, kept alive on the road and married into new ground.

This gives the world both at once. Everyday families walk to their town's Tree for the Leaf-Fall. The divine is local; no one is exiled from the rite by distance. That is the Hands-era default. It was not always so. The truly faithful travel to the Awakening Tree itself, the first Hand, to have a child Turned

there or simply to stand under the origin. On Heskoren, and wherever a graft has failed, the walk is still *necessity*, not only devotion.

The faithful hold that because every scion is continuous tissue of the one Tree, “the Turning Trees are her hands” is literally true: when any town’s Tree chooses, it is the one power choosing through a grafted hand. Skeptics grant the grafting. It is observable horticulture. They deny the conclusion, that a *mind* chooses through it.

A graft is a rite, not only horticulture. Cutting a scion from the Awakening Tree (or, in practice, from an established healthy town Tree acting on the origin’s behalf) is done by the tree-wardens. The cutting is carried in living earth and planted with ceremony. How that rite was captured, first as a heresy, then as a paper, is the First Cut.

A young Tree can’t yet Turn. A freshly planted scion takes years, a generation by common reckoning, to mature enough to hold a Leaf-Fall. New towns lean on a neighbour’s Tree in the meantime; children travel to the nearest turning town. Rivalries, road-customs, “we Turned at Harrow’s Tree before we had our own.”

## When Trees sicken and die

They are mortal wood, not indestructible. A blighted or dying Tree is a genuine civic crisis. A town may lose its ability to Turn its own children and fall back on pilgrimage or a neighbour. A dead Tree is replaced only by a fresh graft and the long wait. A mature Tree is hard to move once planted; the practice is to graft a new scion rather than transplant.

A town without a Tree is the natural frontier condition: too new, too remote, or Tree-bereaved. Such places send their ten-year-olds on the road to Turn, which marks them as edge-of-the-map.

## The Leaf-Fall

The rite the whole world is built around. Held in **Turning-Week**, the week bracketing the High Solstice of midsummer, when the Trees hold their colour and the choosing is done.

Every child who turns ten since the last solstice is brought by family. The town gathers as witness. A tree-warden officiates (the town hearth; the First Seat is only a pilgrimage-week presence). It is at once a sacred rite and the town’s biggest festival of the year: part christening, part graduation, part fair.

Children come to the Tree one at a time (or in the small cohort of a given year), stand within the canopy’s reach, and wait. The Tree turns and lets fall what it will. The rest of the town watches from the edge of the boughs.

Two outcomes:

- **A colour falls, and a Condition is Given.** One or more leaves of a telling colour drift down and settle on the child. The colour names the Condition. This is expected, “proper,” celebrated. The child grows up already knowing what they’ll become, and is trained and guilded toward it.
- **The leaves hug, no colour, and the child is Kept.** Instead of a coloured fall, the ordinary leaves *gather and wrap the child*: a green embrace, no naming colour. This marks one of **the Kept**: kept whole, wanted in their own right. The faith holds this on belief as a chosen kindness, not a failure or an oversight, and the schism argues over it.

The feel of the hour is a held breath, a whole town watching a single child, a parent who was themselves Given the same colour weeping when it falls again, or a parent who quietly hoped for the hug. The Leaf-Fall itself is warm, weighty, and communal. Dread lives in the Tithes, not in the rite.

## Turning-Week in a city

The Given-door is still **one week**. The Tree is still at the centre. A city of tens of thousands does not grow a second engine. It **nects** the witness.

- **Stands are by hearth**, in named slots of the week. A festival schedule, like who has the square for the fair.
- **The warden Speaks.** Colour or hug. They do not write a roll of gifts.
- **The city as a crowd saw a crowd. The hearth saw a child.** That is the legal fact. One pillar of the hearth (Long-Lived, Bound, or Far-Voiced who stood) carries the stand when a far desk asks.

A village still watches as one circle. Do not narrate every settlement as a city. Do not invent a city register to “fix” how many faces a square can know.

## Reading the colours

The colour that falls tells the town which Condition has been Given.

The core colour-meanings are folk-known. An ordinary townsperson can read the obvious ones. Everyone knows what the deep-red Long-Lived leaf or the storm-grey Two-Bodied fall looks like. The tree-wardens hold the authoritative reading, confirm it aloud at the ceremony, and handle the rare, subtle, or mixed falls: a colour few have seen, or a fall that could be read two ways. This gives the faith a real civic function beyond doctrine. Society organizes around the Tree because someone has to say what the leaf meant, not only because people pray there.

The Given-only Conditions have clear, well-known colours (they’re only ever seen at the Tree). The Struck-capable Conditions (Far-Voiced, the Stilled, the Taken-In) *can* fall as colours too, which is why a Given Far-Voiced and a Struck Far-Voiced share a nature but not a story.

| Leaf-colour               | Condition    | Who can read it                                                                                                                             |
|---------------------------|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| deep red / wine           | Long-Lived   | folk-known (already proverbial)                                                                                                             |
| storm-grey                | Two-Bodied   | folk-known (already proverbial)                                                                                                             |
| lamp-amber / brass        | the Answered | folk-known                                                                                                                                  |
| sea-blue                  | Far-Voiced   | folk-known (a Given blue-leaf child is trained; a Struck Far-Voiced has no leaf at all)                                                     |
| pale stone / marble-white | the Stilled  | folk-known, and feared. The warden says it carefully                                                                                        |
| copper-green / verdigris  | the Taken-In | folk-known <i>if you know not to confuse it with the hug</i> . This green is <i>wrong</i> , metallic, not the Tree's own                    |
| white-fire / opal         | Phoenix      | clergy-known from texts. Almost no living town has seen it fall. A warden who names it at a ceremony has just made history (and a problem). |

The Tree never Strikes, so Returned and Bound have **no colour** (and the Unbound has none; it chains off Bound). The Kept hug is ordinary summer-green, *no naming colour*. That is why the Taken-In leaf must not be ordinary green.

Rare, mixed, or argumentative falls (two colours; a colour no one present has seen; a Phoenix-reading someone wants to be wrong) are why the tree-wardens exist as a civic office, not only a devout one.

A Tree never Strikes. The Tree only **Gives** or **Keeps**. The Struck, Conditions that arrive through a later threshold, a drowning, an oath, a death survived, happen *away* from the Tree, with no leaf and no ceremony. The faith's reading of the Struck, whether they're still the Mother's doing, is exactly the live schism.

## Questions a warden gets asked

The load-bearing sentences, for when the week is already closing:



| What they ask                                                            | What you say                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | What you do not                                            |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>We missed the week.</b> Fever, a shut pass, a boat that did not come. | They are <b>unTurned</b> . The door has shut. Next summer they may visit the square; they do not stand for a Gift. Struck doors still open later. The expensive mercy is still the old one: winter a <i>nine</i> -year-old near a sound Tree. | Call them Kept. Kept is a hug the town watched.            |
| <b>We will not stand.</b> Old Ways, Open Table, fear, a quarrel.         | The Tree does not chase them. Same legal result as a miss: <b>unTurned</b> , door shut. A warden may ask once. They do not put a rope on a child to make a Gift.                                                                              | Treat refusal as a failure of the wood.                    |
| <b>Who brings an orphan?</b>                                             | The town is the family. Kin first; then the household that feeds them; then the <b>warden-hearth</b> . An orphan who stands is witnessed like anyone. An orphan no one brings is a miss.                                                      | A second leaf as consolation.                              |
| <b>An adult who never Turned.</b>                                        | They stay <b>unTurned</b> . They do not stand for a Gift at thirty. They can be vouched as the person the town raised. They can still be Struck.                                                                                              | A late appointment.                                        |
| <b>Can they stand again?</b> Wrong colour wanted. Hug regretted.         | <b>No.</b> A completed standing — colour <i>or</i> hug, under a Tree the warden called sound — is once. You may correct a <b>Speaking</b> . You may not rerun a fall.                                                                         | Offer a second Leaf-Fall. The wood has never answered one. |
| <b>Our Tree is sick this week.</b>                                       | Do not stand them under unsound wood. Borrow a neighbour's canopy <i>this same week</i> . A warden who lets a cohort stand under a Tree they know cannot Turn has spent the week. Those children are unTurned.                                | Next year as a repair.                                     |
| <b>White-fire fell. Or someone wants to say it did.</b>                  | A town-warden does not guess Phoenix. They send to the First Seat by runner. Naming white-fire is history, and a problem.                                                                                                                     | Guess from a book in the square.                           |
| <b>A child of the Open Table. A Yumboe under our boughs.</b>             | If they stand in their tenth-year week, the Tree does what it does. If the host will not bring them, the week can end. There is no Kumbaen mission.                                                                                           | Wait for the argument to finish. The door does not.        |

| What they ask                            | What you say                                                                                                                                                              | What you do not  |
|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| <b>The city cannot know every child.</b> | They stand <b>by hearth</b> , in named slots. The square is full. The memory is the street that brought them, plus one pillar who can carry it. Do not write the colours. | A city register. |

**UnTurned is not Kept.** Kept means the leaves hugged and the town watched. UnTurned means the child never stood. Both lives can look the same (no Tithe, no guild). Only one was witnessed at the Tree. Citizenship still runs on who saw you; an unTurned neighbour is vouched as *this child we raised*, not as a colour or a hug.

A miss, refusal, or week spent under unsound wood makes a child unTurned, not Kept. Struck remains the later mercy.

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# The Leaf-Mother

Some hold that the **Leaf-Mother** blessed the world with the Conditions, and that the Turning Trees are her hands reaching down to *choose*: each Leaf-Fall an act of a mother's love. This is a belief held by many, not confirmed cosmology. Skeptics are sincere and full members of society, and the faith itself is built to make room for them. Everyday: **the Motherfaith**. Their own name: **Maieth**.

## A gift-religion

No one is being rescued from a fallen state. The founding fact is that the world received *gifts* (the Conditions) and goes on receiving them each solstice. The faith is a long answer to *how do you live worthy of a gift?*

**Right practice over right belief.** What makes you of the Motherfaith is what you **do**. You bring your children to the Tree, you tend your Tithe honestly, you keep the festival. That counts far more than what you privately believe about *who* does the choosing. The old word for this is **orthopraxy**: belonging by the rite you keep, not by the creed you recite. This is the structural reason a devout believer and a quiet skeptic can stand at the same Leaf-Fall and both belong. Right practice binds; right belief is argued about.

**Divine character: a mother.** Benevolent, attentive, generous, and *quiet*. She does not thunder, command, or demand worship. She gives, and (the faithful say) she watches. The maternal frame is the whole tone: you don't fear the Mother, you try not to waste what she hands you.

The Motherfaith is the dominant faith of the Turning lands but not the only religion. The Leaf-Mother is not written as the universe's sole power. She is *this* people's Mother.

## Doctrine (as the faithful hold it)

**The Giving.** In the beginning (the faithful say) the world was only ever *born into*. People were their Kind and nothing more. The Leaf-Mother's gift was **becoming**: the capacity to be given something beyond your birth, a Condition the world would need. The first Tree, the Awakening Tree, is where she first reached down. Every town Tree is a grafted Hand of the Mother, so that no child is too far from her reach.

**She chooses, and she chooses well.** Doctrine holds that the colour a child receives is *chosen*: looked-at, intended, fitted to the child and to the town's need. The gifts "fit too well" to be accident (believers

point to this; skeptics call it hindsight).

**The Tithe is the weight of a gift, not a punishment.** Every Condition costs upkeep. The faith reads this as *honest weight*: a real gift has a real charge to carry, and tending it well is the ordinary devotion of a lifetime. “**Tend what you’re given**” is the closest thing the faith has to a first commandment.

**The Kept are given wholeness.** To be Kept, hugged by the leaves, no colour, is doctrinally a *gift of being left whole*, not an oversight. This is where the schism bites hardest.

**She has no throne to visit and no voice that answers on demand.** Accessibility is *mediated and quiet*: she is met at the Tree, in the turning of a life, in the fittingness of things, never summoned. This quietness is doctrinally *intended* (a mother lets her children live), and is exactly what leaves room for honest doubt.

## Practice

- **The Leaf-Fall.** The central rite, a child’s tenth-year solstice Turning. It is at once sacrament, coming-of-age, and the town’s great festival.
- **The Tending.** The ongoing, private devotion of *paying your Tithe well*. Framed religiously: to tend your Condition honestly is to honour the gift. A Two-Bodied who runs their other self, a Long-Lived who keeps their vigils: the faith calls this worship-by-living, not only upkeep.
- **The Turning-week festival.** The solstice week around the Leaf-Falls: markets, feasts, the reunion of families, the naming of the year’s new Given and new Kept. The emotional high point of the calendar.
- **Threshold rites for the Struck.** Because the Struck receive a Condition *away* from the Tree, the faith has grown quiet rites to receive them back. A Struck person is brought to the Tree *after* the fact, not to be Turned (the Tree doesn’t Strike) but to be **acknowledged**, folded into the community of the Given rather than left as an anomaly. How warmly this is done is itself contested.
- **Tree-tending.** The civic-sacred care of the town’s Turning Tree (watering rites, warding against blight, the graft-rites when a new scion is planted). Handled by the tree-wardens.

Towns house the warden-hearth; Turning-Week is the festival share; Cutting-leave carries a fee framed as carrying-earth; pilgrimage keeps the Seat. The tree-wardens are not the Tithe-infrastructure sector.

## The live schism

The faith is not one piece. Its central argument is a genuine, good-faith one that no one can settle, which is exactly why it endures. It turns on three questions the doctrine can’t prove.

**1. The Kept: spared, or slighted?** If the Mother blesses everyone, why are about a quarter Given no colour at all?

- **The Tender reading (majority/orthodox):** the Kept are *given wholeness*, a real gift, chosen for them. To be Kept is to be trusted to need nothing added.
- **The Wanting reading (minority):** the Kept were *passed over*, loved, but not chosen, and the doctrine of “wholeness” is a kindness the faithful tell them. This reading quietly stings, and shapes how some Kept feel about the festival.

**2. The Struck: still hers, or not?** The Struck receive a Condition the Tree never handed out. Did the Mother reach through the threshold too, or did *something else* give the gift?

- **The Wide-Hand reading:** she meets people at every door, the drowning, the oath, the death. The Tree is only her *ordinary* hand. The Struck are fully hers.
- **The Narrow-Hand reading:** she gives only at the Tree. The Struck received their Condition by *some other means*, which is why the Struck are “a little suspect.” This reading is the seed of real social friction toward the Struck.

**3. Does a mind choose at all?** This is the believer/skeptic line proper.

- **Believers:** the fittingness of the gifts, the care of the Kept, the way the Struck feel *received*. These add up to a Someone.
- **Skeptics:** “it’s just what the Trees do.” Biology, or a phenomenon so old it wears a face we gave it. The grafting is observable horticulture; the *choosing mind* is an inference they decline to make.

Because the faith is orthopraxic, a skeptic who tends their Tithe and brings their children to the Tree is a *good member of the Motherfaith*. Belief in the Mother is honoured but not policed. This keeps the skeptic sincere and un-persecuted.

Every branch is a good-faith position. No faction is secretly right-and-evil.

## Two sayings

**The Tender’s blessing**, spoken over each child at the Leaf-Fall:

“What falls to you, wear well. What is kept from you, keep. The Hand that reaches is the Mother’s own, and the Mother does not reach twice by chance.”

On its face: comfort and the “tend your gift” ethic. The line asserts intent behind the fall, the very thing skeptics deny.

**A Kept-child’s saying** (folk, half-consoling, half-barbed):

*“The Tree that gives to all its neighbours held me instead. I have decided that is not the same as being forgotten.”*

On its face: the Tender reading of the Kept, made personal and a little defiant. Underneath: it dramatizes the schism. “*I have decided*” is a choice made against doubt, not a certainty.

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# The Five Faiths

The Motherfaith is the dominant faith of the Turning lands, and it is not the only one. Five lived faiths each answer a different experience the Trees, or their absence, actually produce. This is not a list of gods.

| Faith           | Home                                          | A Condition is...                       | Everyday name   | Own name         |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|-----------------|------------------|
| the Leaf-Mother | everywhere the Trees stand; born on Maiethorn | a <b>gift chosen</b>                    | the Motherfaith | <i>Maieth</i>    |
| the Watching    | Maiethorn's oldest districts                  | a <b>seeing</b> , later named a gift    | the Watching    | <i>Haelthael</i> |
| the Fair Hand   | Strandoren's ports and houses                 | a <b>bargain struck</b>                 | the Fair Hand   | <i>Leddoren</i>  |
| the Old Ways    | Heskoren's groves and doors                   | the <b>land making its own</b>          | the Old Ways    | <i>Vaeloren</i>  |
| the Open Table  | Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle                   | a mainland hunger <b>they never had</b> | the Open Table  | <i>Ndeyaan</i>   |

The three mainland rivals sit *inside* the settled world. The Open Table is the isolate: grown with no Tree and no Mother-name.

Smaller household rites, quay-charms, and Kind-customs exist and stay local. They are not the public faiths. Clergy of the five houses: the tree-wardens (Motherfaith), the Watchers, the Book-Hands, the Door-Keepers, the Table-Keepers, and the Shore-Sitters of the isle.

## The argument (what a becoming is)

Every faith in this world has to answer the same fact: most people *become* something they were not born as. They do not agree on the verb.

- **Given.** The Motherfaith says *chosen*. The Watching says *seen*. The Fair Hand says *signed*. The Old Ways say the Tree is a *late guest* at a door the land already kept.

- **Struck.** The Motherfaith argues whether she reached the threshold. The Watching says the threshold was always a place of seeing. The Fair Hand says a later contract, struck in extremity. The Old Ways say this is the *oldest* becoming: the land's own children.
- **Kept.** Gift of wholeness / passed-over / no bargain taken / the land had no door for you that year. Same hug; four readings.
- **Tithe.** Honest weight of a gift / the cost someone once paid / the term of the contract / the land's due. Same upkeep; four ethics.

None of these is a villain's creed. Each is a good-faith answer to a real seam: the fittingness of gifts, the thinning at the edge, the Bound's written terms, the Struck who change with no Tree nearby, a whole isle that never Turned. Dual practice is common. It is not a scandal.

## How they live together

**Orthopraxy is the peace:** belonging by the rite you keep, not the creed you recite. Because the Motherfaith counts you by what you *do* at the Tree, a Watcher who brings their child, a Settler who stands as witness to the colour, and a Kin-speaker who also walks the old doors can all belong at the same Leaf-Fall. Doctrine fights. The festival usually does not.

### Conflict is local, not crusading.

- **Maiethorn.** The fight is *at the centre*. The Watching and the Motherfaith share the same Trees and argue over the blessing spoken there. Threnmaieth files Watchers on the Threnhael as a known, counted dissent (the Grown-Over). Pressure, not a hunt of households.
- **Strandoren.** Faith is worn light, so the fight is *for the Bound and the books*. The Fair Hand and the Motherfaith compete for the same oath-keepers in the same port. Lestrand prices both and polices neither.
- **Heskoren.** The fight is *over the grove*. The Old Ways were there before the grafts; the Motherfaith burns hottest where the gift is scarcest. A dying Tree has two claimants. Vaethorn's piety makes this tender and sharp. It is not a loud holy war.
- **The Sundering Isle.** Almost no contact. A Yumboe on the mainland is a guest at everyone else's rite. They keep table and find the noon-day faiths *loud*.

### Syncretism (mixed practice: what actually happens, most years):



| Pair                      | The common blend                                                                        | The hard edge                                            |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Motherfaith + Watching    | Same Tree, two blessings; families inherit which words they use                         | Threnmaieth's roll wants one name for what you are       |
| Motherfaith + Fair Hand   | Leaf-Fall as festival <i>and</i> signing-watch; Tithe paid as both tending and settling | Gift-language vs. debt-language over the same Bound soul |
| Motherfaith + Old Ways    | Pilgrimage to a graft <i>and</i> threshold-walking the old doors                        | Who tends a sickening Tree: warden or door-keeper        |
| Any mainland + Open Table | A rare shared supper; "no one is a stranger twice"                                      | Almost none. The storm-wall is the boundary              |

A shared teaching-story, the Child at Four Doors, is told in all five houses with a different last line. That is how the world argues without a council.

The Leaf-Mother remains a *belief* in public life. The other faiths stay beliefs. The Watching *claims* to remember a cost; that claim is fuel, not an answer.

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## The Watching

The heartland heresy of Maiethorn. An older Tree-faith the Motherfaith grew over: a *centre* dissent, not a frontier one. They keep the Tree and refuse the Mother-name. They say the colours fall because the Tree *sees*, not because a she *chooses*.

Everyday: **the Watching**. Their own name: **Haelthael** (*hayl-THALE*), from *hael* + *thael*, "the Tree kept whole." They mean the Tree before anyone split it into a Mother and her hands. The Motherfaith's soft name is **the First Watching**; Threnmaieth's file-name is **the Grown-Over**.

## Shape of the faith

- **A witness-religion, not a gift-religion.** The founding fact is that the Tree *looks*. A colour is a seeing made visible, not a present wrapped in a leaf. To live well is to *name what was seen*, not to thank a giver you cannot prove.
- **Orthopraxy, older than the Motherfaith's.** They stand at the same Leaf-Fall. They will not say the Tender's blessing as the wardens say it. Practice binds them to the town; the withheld word is the whole dissent.

- **Divine character: they will not give it one.** The Tree is the Tree. It is not a mother, a bargain-partner, or a land-spirit in a new dress. Naming it *Maieth* is, to them, the overlay: a comfort the core invented when the seeing needed a face.
- **Identity marker:** they keep **Thaeloren** (“the Tree that witnesses”) and refuse **Hand of the Mother**. Same wood; the title is the schism.

## Doctrine (as believed)

**The Before.** In the beginning the world was Kind and Kind alone. This they share with the Motherfaith. Then the Tree was already there, watching. The Giving came *after* the Watching. The Mother-name came after that. Each layer is a story laid over a seeing.

**She chooses well is a later sentence.** Fittingness, they say, is what a witness produces: the Tree sees what you can carry and what the town will need, and the leaf matches the seeing. Intent without a mother. The skeptics of the Motherfaith are, to a Watcher, *almost* right, and still too quick to call the Tree a phenomenon with no mind. There is a mind. It does not owe you a lap.

**The cost is remembered.** Haelthael teaching holds that the Giving was not free. Something was spent, someone was lessened; the Tree (or whatever stands behind it) does not reach twice by chance because *reaching costs*. They will not name a Mother who pretends otherwise. What the cost *was* they will not agree on. They agree it was real.

**The Kept were seen.** A hug and no colour is a seeing of wholeness, or a seeing that did not reach. They argue this as fiercely as the Motherfaith does, without the consolation of a mother’s lap. The hug is still a witness. It is not an oversight and not (they insist) a slight dressed as love.

**The Struck were seen at a harder door.** A drowning, an oath, a death: the Tree is the ordinary place of seeing; the threshold is an older one. The Watching does not need the Wide-Hand / Narrow-Hand split. Seeing was never confined to a grafted scion.

## Practice

- **The Night Watch.** The night before Turning-Week, Watchers keep a silent vigil at the town Tree. No blessing. No colour-reading. The point is to *be seen seeing*: to match the Tree’s attention with their own.
- **The withheld blessing.** They attend the Leaf-Fall (orthopraxy; their children Turn). When the warden says the Tender’s line, a Watcher household speaks their own, quietly:

“What falls, was seen. What is kept, was seen. The Tree does not reach twice by chance.”

Same cadence as the Motherfaith's blessing; the Mother is not in it. Towns that have lived together a long time barely notice the difference. Threnmaieth notices.

- **Name what you saw.** After a Turning, a Watcher does not say *tend what you're given*. They sit with the child and *describe* the fall: the colour, the way the leaf came, what the year will ask. Devotion is accurate speech.

- **Pre-Mother names.** In Haelthael liturgy the origin Tree is only **Thaeloren**. "First Hand" is tolerated as poetry. "Hand of the Mother" is the overlay they will not say.

Watchers are not priests. They keep the Night Watch, teach the withheld blessing, and (where a town will have it) offer a second reading of a rare or mixed fall: not authoritative over the tree-warden, a *witness alongside*. In Threnmaieth they are a known column on the roll.

The Watching has no seat in the Awakening Tree's shadow. That seat was grown-over by the First Seat. Their oldest rooms are under older chapels, or in houses that never took a warden's lintel (the beam over the door). The rooms are the argument: the Watching was here first. Watchers keep two acts, not four offices.

## The live schism

1. **The Masked.** The Mother is a later face the Witness learned to wear, or a name people needed, and the Tree allowed. Almost Motherfaith; common in mixed families. A Masked Watcher will stand for the Tender's blessing and add the withheld line under it.
2. **The Bare Tree.** There was never a she. The overlay is a comfort the core invented, and comfort is not the same as truth. Harder, smaller, the ones Threnmaieth files most carefully.
3. **What was spent?** Both branches agree the Giving cost. They do not agree *what*: a wound in the Tree, a year the watching failed, a someone who became the wood. This is the question they will not close. It is also the one the Motherfaith most wants left unasked.

## A lintel-inscription

Recut, found when a warden-chapel on Maiethorn was re-floored. The new beam faces the Tree; this face was turned to the stone.

*We kept the watch before the name. The wood was already looking. If a mother came after, she came to a work begun. Do not thank the latecomer for the seeing.*

On its face: heresy, stubborn, local. Underneath: a claim that the Tree *predates the Mother-name*, which is exactly the memory the sacred centre cannot afford to be curious about.

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# The Fair Hand

The fortune-and-contract faith of Strandoren. A mercantile theology that reads Conditions not as gifts given but as **bargains struck**. The world is a ledger of deals; the Tithe is a *term*, not a devotion; when the book is closed you are *even*, and owe no gratitude forever. Direct doctrinal rival to the Motherfaith's gift-language, at home on the trade continent and especially among the Bound.

Everyday: **the Fair Hand**. Their own name: **Leddoren** (*led-OR-en*), from *ledd* + *oren*, "the witnessed account." Lestrang slang: **the Settling**. The Motherfaith's name for them: **the Bargainers**. A Bound who has paid their year's Terms will say they have **a closed book**.

## Shape of the faith

- **A settling-religion, not a gift-religion and not a rescue.** No one is being saved from a fall, and no one is being *given* something they cannot refuse. A gift you cannot put down is an imposition. The founding ethic is **fair terms**: know what you owe, pay it, walk.
- **Orthopraxy of the book.** What makes you of the Fair Hand is that you *keep accounts honestly* (Tithe, contract, witness), not that you deny the Mother in the street. Many Settlers still bring a child to the Tree. They attend as witnesses to a signing.
- **Divine character: a counterparty, or none.** The faith splits on whether anyone sits across the table: a counterparty, the other party to the deal. Both branches agree the *table* is real. The Leaf-Mother, if she exists, is a giver who will not show her terms, which, to a Settler, is the one unforgivable clause.
- **Identity marker:** a small personal **book** (not a census; that is Threnmaieth's sin) in which a Settler writes colour, Tithe, and what they are owed. The Bound did not invent this; they are simply the ones whose book is also a contract.

## Doctrine (as believed)

**Nothing is given.** The Leaf-Fall is a *striking of terms*. The colour is the grant; the Tithe is the price; the town's need is the other side of the deal. "Tend what you're given" is how a creditor teaches you to be grateful for the interest.

**The Bound prove the model.** A Bound *chose*, named a grant, named Terms, named a Pledge. The Fair Hand says this is not a special horror. It is the same grammar as every becoming, written large enough to read. The Motherfaith's fear of the Bound is, to them, embarrassment: the Bound make the ledger visible.

**The Kept declined, or were not offered.** No bargain taken; nothing owed; nothing owed *to* them. This is a cooler dignity than spared-or-slighted. On Lestrang it rhymes with calling the Kept *the free*.

The Fair Hand did not invent that slight; they gave it a theology.

**The Struck signed later, in a storm.** Extremity is when people accept bad terms. A drowning, an oath, a death: of course the book opens then. The Struck are not suspects; they are people who bargained without a clerk. The faith's kindness is to *settle the year fairly* after the fact, by a hall or a warrant: vouching that remakes the year as a new agreement (novation, in a clerk's mouth). A Bound's *Terms* are the exception: those belong to the Counterparty, not to a clerk. Its cruelty is the same motion: a Struck who cannot settle fades, and the quay steps around them.

**Grace is a closed book.** Not a pardon, and not a mother's lap. You paid. You are even. Walk.

## Practice

- **The signing-watch.** Settlers attend the Leaf-Fall as *witnesses*, not petitioners. They do not speak the Tender's blessing. They speak, if they speak:

“Grant and term, seen and spoken. The book is open. Keep it fair.”

- **Public settling.** Tithe paid in a way a neighbour can see: not confession, *clearing*. A Bound's oath-day is the high holy day: Terms recited, the year's book closed or marked owing. The Motherfaith calls this showing off. The Fair Hand calls it the only honest worship.
- **Quay-blessings.** Short, worn, eroded-tongue: *fair wind, fair term*. Said over a hull, a contract, a marriage. The sacred and the commercial use the same sentence, and that is the teaching.
- **The personal book.** Colour, Tithe, debts, what the year owes you. Private. Not the Threnhael. A Settler will die to keep a crown-clerk out of it. That fury they share with every other faith on the subject.

Book-hands (also Settlers) are notaries who are also theologians. They witness signings, teach children how to keep a book, and settle a Struck's *civic* year (a hall, a warrant). They recite a Bound's Terms on oath-day; they do not rewrite those Terms (the Counterparty's clause, not a clerk's). On Lestrand they are often the same people as commercial clerks. The faith is the profession, worn lightly.

The Fair Hand has guild-rooms and quay-shrines, not a mother-church. A “high house” in a rich port is just the oldest book-room. No membership roll. A roll would be a Threnhael.

## The live schism

1. **The Counterparty.** Something sits across the table: a mind, a power, a hand that is *fair* rather than mothering. The Bound's unknown is this branch's whole theology. They will not call it Mother (her terms are hidden); they will not call it demon (that is the Motherfaith's scare-word). They call it **the other hand**.

2. **The Book Alone.** The world is the ledger. No one is across the table. This is the secular twin of the Motherfaith's skeptics, and it lives easily on Lestrand. Practice is identical; the argument is whether gratitude has an address.

Both branches agree that *hidden terms* are the sin. That is why they cannot join the Motherfaith even when they share a festival: "the Mother does not reach twice by chance" is, to them, a clause with no number on it.

## From a Bound's working contract

The form-words a Lestrand book-hand uses when the grant is ordinary and the Terms are not:

*I was not given. I asked, and I was answered, and I named what I would pay. If a mother had wanted me she would have sent a leaf, not a clause. I prefer the clause. I can read it.*

On its face: a Bound's pride, a little cold. Underneath: the Fair Hand's whole case against gift-doctrine, and a blindness the document cannot afford: that a clause you can read is not the same as a love you cannot price.

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## The Old Ways

The ancestor-and-land faith of Heskoren. It predates the grafts. It says the Mother's reach is new here, and the land was already making children of its own, the Struck, the Taken-In, at rivers, drowning-pools, oath-stones, and groves. The Trees are *guests*, not the source.

Everyday, and their own common name: **the Old Ways**. Liturgical: **Vaeloren** (*vay-LOR-en*), from *vael* + *oren*. They use **vael** in an older sense: not "a Condition Given" but **what the land yields**. The Motherfaith, they say, *narrowed* the word to a leaf-colour. Vaethorn-pious speech calls them **the Before-Faith**; the Taken-In among them say **the Green Kin**.

## Shape of the faith

- **A land-and-kin religion.** The founding fact is that *place* makes people. A river that has drowned and returned, a hill that took someone in, an oath-stone that heard a vow: these are **the old doors**. The grafted Tree is a new door, welcome if it behaves.
- **Practice is walking, not watching a colour.** You keep the Old Ways by going to the doors, feeding the kin who stayed, and standing for the Struck when a town will not. Belief about the Mother is secondary; many Kin-speakers also bring a child to a healthy graft when they can reach one.

- **Divine character: the land is many, and the dead stay.** Not one mother, and not a ledger. Hills, waters, old trees (the wild kin of motherwood, not the grafts), and the people who went into them. Ancestors are not ghosts to be feared (the Returned are a different door); they are *kin who remained in the ground*.
- **Identity marker:** a worn token from your door, a river-stone, grove-twigg, or pinch of hill, carried the way a Settler carries a book. No two look alike. The mismatch is the teaching: no two doors are the same.

## Doctrine (as believed)

**The land was first.** Before grafts, before pilgrimage, Heskoren's people already became things. The Struck are not a problem the Motherfaith has failed to place. They are the *oldest* rite, the land doing what the land does. The Taken-In are the grove's own children, not a frontier embarrassment.

**Vael meant yield.** Grain, game, a child returned from water, a person the hill kept. The Motherfaith's *vael* (a Given Condition) is a *special case* they mistook for the whole word. To call a leaf a *vael* is fine. To say only a leaf is a *vael* is a theft of speech.

**Grafts are guests.** A healthy Tree is a new kin-house. You may tend it. You may Turn under it. You may not pretend it invented becoming, or that a town without one is empty of the sacred. A sickening Tree is a guest who is dying in your grove. The fight with the tree-wardens is *who is host*.

**The Kept are a year the land had no door.** Not spared, not slighted, and not free labour. Some years a door does not open for you. You are still the land's. Next year, or the drowning-year, or never. The waiting that Vaethorn sanctifies as pilgrimage is, here, just weather.

**The Mother is a late name.** Either the land wearing a face the newcomers needed (the Guest-reading) or a claiming (the First-reading). Both agree she did not *arrive first*.

## Practice

- **Threshold-walking.** At the year's hinges, and not only High Solstice, people walk the old doors of their district. You greet the water, the hill, the stone. You leave food. You do not ask for a colour. You ask to be *known*.
- **Ancestor-meals.** A place at the board for the ones in the ground. Quiet, domestic, easy to miss as religion if you came from Maiethorn looking for a chapel. The courtesy is the rite.
- **Standing for the Struck.** When a person changes later and alone, the Old Ways do not take them to a Tree to be *acknowledged as Given*. They take them back to the door that made them, if it can be found, and *name them kin*. The Motherfaith's quiet receiving-rite and this one sometimes happen in the same week, for the same person, and the argument is which name goes first.

- **The contested grove.** An ailing graft in an old Taken-In green is the fight everyone knows: warden against door-keeper, guest against host, pilgrimage-scarcity against “we had ways.” Neighbours who both love the wood.

Door-keepers (also Kin-speakers) know which doors still open. They speak at ancestor-meals. They stand for the unvouched Struck when they can. Not a hierarchy; a reputation. A famous door-keeper is just the one three valleys will walk to. Two jobs, often one mouth.

The Old Ways cannot have a mother-church. The land is the seat. Vaethorn’s tree-wardens find this infuriating and, in a dry year, quietly useful. Door-keepers walk doors; they do not carry scions.

## The live schism

1. **The Guest-reading.** The Mother is the land in a new dress. Grafts are kin. Common in Vaethorn towns that finally got a Tree and did not want to throw their grandparents out of the rite. They will pilgrimage *and* walk the doors.
2. **The First-reading.** The grafts are a claiming. The old doors were enough. Harder, thinner-reach districts, the ones still waiting on a scion that will not take. They will tend a dying graft as a *guest in their house* and still refuse the Tender’s blessing.

Both branches revere the Struck and the Taken-In. That courtesy is what the faith stands on. A reading that started pitying them as “unreached” has already become Motherfaith.

## Said at a drowning-stone

On Heskoren’s wet margin, the year after a graft sickened and a child came back from the river Changed:

*The tree is young. The water is not. If a mother sent the water she sent it before she sent the leaf, and she has not told the wardens. We will feed both. We will not let either pretend it was first.*

On its face: frontier courtesy, a little barbed. Underneath: the Old Ways’ whole case, and the seam they cannot see. They have correctly felt that becoming happens at doors with no healthy Tree.

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# The Open Table

The isolate faith of Kumbaan. Grown with no Tree and no Mother-name. The good people keep the night, set a place for hands that have no bodies, and hold that a stranger at the table is the holiest thing in the world: not a colour, a graft, or a bargain.

Mainland everyday: **the Open Table**, or sailors' **the Moon-Feast**. Their own name: **Ndeyaan** (*ndey-AHN*), the night-keeping. In full courtesy, **Bakhna Ndeya** ("the good night"). The opening of every meal that matters is already their creed: "*No one is a stranger twice.*"

## Shape of the faith

- **A hospitality-religion.** The founding fact is the table. To feed and be fed is how the living sit with the staying-kin and with anyone the storm-wall did not keep out. There is no Leaf-Fall because, they say, there was nothing missing to give.
- **Practice is the meal.** Ndeyaan has almost no clergy and no chapel. The rite is supper under the moon, a place set for hands you can see and a body you cannot, daylight reserved for sleep. A Yumboe who keeps this on the mainland is still of the Open Table. A mainlander who sits once is a guest; one who sits twice is kin.
- **Divine character: the hill, the moon, the ones who stayed.** Not a mother, and not a ledger. The dead do not leave; they stay as hands. Whether those hands *are* the dead (the Staying) or the hill's own courtesy (the Serving) is the house-argument. Neither reading makes the good people ghosts. They are a living Kind. The idiom is ancestral; the bodies are warm.
- **Identity marker:** an extra place laid, even when the household is poor. The unseen hands make this possible. They do not mean it as a metaphor. It is the furniture.

## Doctrine (as believed)

**Wholeness is the default.** The mainland invented a hunger and called it a gift. On Kumbaan you are born Yumboe and that is enough. If the good people become anything else, they do not become it at a Tree (there is none). The how is not a doctrine they owe strangers; it is a family matter, and they are not in a hurry.

**The dead stay to serve.** Folklore on the mainland calls Yumboes spirits of the dead. They find this rude and, in a sideways way, nearly true: the *hands* are the staying-kin. The living host. The staying pour. A feast that outshines its means is a theological statement. The household is larger than the bodies you can count.

**The moon wakes both.** Night is the shared day of the living and the staying. Daylight is a Sabbath of sleep, a rest-day, not a fallen hour. Mainland noon-faiths are *loud* the way a guest who will not sit is

loud.

**A stranger is the sacrament.** The storm-wall keeps the world out. Anyone who crosses it has already been through drowning-water. You do not test them with a colour. You feed them. The second supper is the rite of belonging. This is why a lone Yumboe on Strandoren becomes a host wherever they land: they are still keeping Ndeyaan, with whatever table they can make.

**The Mother is a story about a quiet table, told too loud.** They do not hate her. They have never met her. They do not understand why a people would need to be *chosen* in order to be wanted.

## Practice

- **The moon-feast.** The ordinary high rite: night, hill-hall or open turf, the extra place, the unseen hands fetching and pouring. Songs. No colour-reading. No terms recited.
- **The place set.** Even a poor house lays it. To omit it is the one real impiety: not because the staying starve (they do not), but because you have counted the household too small.
- **No one is a stranger twice.** Spoken at the second sitting. The first night you are a guest (and a guest is already sacred). The second, you are of the table. Mainlanders who hear this as a proverb have missed that it is a *legal* sentence in all but parchment.
- **Daylight sleep.** The glare is neither holy nor cursed. It is when the good people and the staying-kin rest. A Yumboe abroad will still take their long rest when the moon is down if they can; they will not make a scene about it.

Table-keepers (also hill-hosts) are barely clergy. The person whose hall the valley comes to on the bright nights. Reputation, not office. One job: keep the table.

Shore-sitters (also wall-waiters) are the other isle job. They sit the storm-beach and wait. They do not swim out. The living go uphill to a table.

A Yumboe abroad is a table-keeper by necessity. One person can keep Ndeyaan in a Lestrand attic. That is how the faith travels, when it travels at all. Recruits by faith (who will lay the extra place), not by Kind. No Kumbaan mission.

## The live schism

1. **The Staying.** The unseen hands *are* the dead: grandparents, the drowned, the ones the hill kept. Ancestral-literal. Older tellings; still common in deep-hill halls. Not a ghost-cult: the dead are *family who took the serving-work*.
2. **The Serving.** The hands are the hill's own courtesy, the good people's oldest wonder, not a roster of names. Gentler, majority in the surface-facing halls, easier to explain to a mainland guest who has gone pale.

Both branches set the extra place. A Serving host who will not say the dead's names and a Staying host who will not stop saying them will still pass the same cup. The argument is for after the dishes.

## The sentence at the mainland lintel

On Kumbaan, *no one is a stranger twice* is how you belong. On the mainland, you belong because a town watched you Turn.

This is the faith's edge on the mainland. It does not need a mission and it does not need a chapel on Strandoren. It needs a room, a tenth year, and a clerk who has a different grammar.

**The everyday collision (citizenship).** A guest sits a second night in a Lestrand attic. The host says the sentence and means it. A quay clerk, a Book-hand, a warden passing through, wants a Turning-witness before they will treat that person as *of a place*. Inside the room: kin. Outside the door: guest. Neither office is cruel. The sentence does not cross the lintel intact.

**The week that can close (the Given-door).** A child of the table — isle-raised, convert-raised, a sailor's tenth summer in a port — reaches Turning-Week. The host will not walk them to a Turning Tree. They were never lacking. A neighbour or a town-warden will. The Given-door is **one week**. If the argument outlasts Eolthael, the child is unTurned. Struck doors still open later. That is not a comfort the host asked for, and not a victory the warden can file as kindness.

This is not a Kumbaan crusade. The child is already on the mainland. The storm-wall stayed where it was.

**Mbela** (*MBEH-lah*) keeps an attic off a Lestrand salt-stair and will not spend a child's week on a colour. **Sorel** of the quay will not file a second supper as belonging, and will walk a tenth-year neighbour to the Tree if the host will not. They are not a party. They are two grammars that share a landing.

Romanticizing the Moon-Feast is itself a slight. Printing the sentence on a luck-card is how Lestrand files the whole faith. The woman in the attic still sets the place.

## A place-setting blessing

Said to the empty plate before the hands arrive. Taught to children. Heard once, badly copied, by a Strandor sailor who did come back.

*We have counted you. Sit. If you have a name we have not learned it yet; if you have a colour we have no tree to read it. The moon is enough light. Eat, and be the household.*

On its face: hospitality, almost too sweet. Underneath: a whole cosmology that has never needed the Leaf-Fall. The sailor who copied it thought it was a grace. It is a claim that *wanted* was never a gift.

Kumbaan keeps the moon, not the High Solstice. A mainland priest may notice that their holiest week is, here, just weather.

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## The Child at Four Doors

A teaching-story told in every house. The bones stay the same; the last line does not. Children hear their own ending first. Travellers hear the others and do not sleep well.

### The story (as told)

A child came to the year of their Turning and found **four doors** where the town said there was one.

The first door was a Tree, and a leaf hung over it, coloured, waiting.

The second door was a book, open, a line already drawn, a space for a name.

The third door was a river-stone, wet, older than the road.

The fourth door was a table with a place set, and no one sitting in it.

The child asked which door was theirs.

No one would say. Each keeper only said: *this one opens*.

The child sat down in the middle and waited to be chosen, or seen, or signed, or fed.

They waited a long time.

When they looked up, all four doors were open, and the child was still in the middle, and the year had gone on without a colour, or with one (the tellings do not agree), and the child had to stand, and pick, and did, and the story ends before you see which.

### The last lines (by house)

The bones above are common. What a house adds last is the faith:

- **Motherfaith (Tender):** *The Mother had opened the Tree before the child sat down. The waiting was the hug. They were wanted either way.*
- **Motherfaith (Wanting):** *The Mother opened one door and the child was looking at the other three. That is how a person is passed over: by having too many doors.*

- **The Watching:** *The Tree had been looking the whole time. The other three doors were people talking. The child was seen. That was the Turning. The leaf was optional.*
- **The Fair Hand:** *The child signed by sitting. Waiting is a term. Someone should have told them the price of a year in the middle.*
- **The Old Ways:** *The stone was wet before the Tree was planted. The child was already the land's. The waiting was weather.*
- **The Open Table:** *The place was set. The child was the guest, then the household. There was never a test. The other doors are how hungry people decorate a supper.*

Skeptics of every faith tell a seventh ending, which is not kind and is very short: *There were not four doors. There was a child, and a year, and a town that needed a story.*

## Variants

- On Maiethorn the four doors are carved on the underside of old lintels; wardens call it decoration.
  - On Strandoren it is a quay-song with a chorus the Bound like: *name the term or get up.*
  - On Heskoren the river-stone door is told first, and the Tree is the third, and some tellers omit the book entirely.
  - On Kumbaan there is only the table. The other doors are “mainland verses,” told as a curiosity after the dishes, if a guest insists.
  - A Threnmaieth school-version adds a clerk who writes all four doors on a roll. Children are not meant to laugh. They do.
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# Orders and Houses

## The Tree-Wardens

The working clergy of the Motherfaith. One order with offices, not rival chapters. They recruit by office, practice, and sometimes Condition, never by Kind.

Everyday, everywhere: **tree-wardens**, or just **wardens**. Liturgical: **the Orenhael** (or-EN-hayl). *oren* “to witness / speak true” + *hael* “whole, hale”: those who *say the fall truly and keep the Tree sound*. Vaethorn’s second word is **Hands-folk**. Lestrاند’s is **tree-tenders**. Threnmaieth files them as **the Reckoned Hands**.

### Shape of the order

- **One order, several offices.** The Motherfaith does not run rival chapters. The live argument is already the three-branch schism (Tender / Wanting, Wide-Hand / Narrow-Hand, believer / skeptic). The Orenhael holds that argument *inside one house*.
- **Needed before they are holy.** A town keeps a warden because someone must water the wood, name a rare colour, and know when a scion is dying. A **scion** is a living cutting of a Turning Tree, planted so a town can hold its own Leaf-Fall. Doctrine comes after the watering. That is why a quiet skeptic can hold a town-hearth, and why Lestrاند still pays its tenders.
- **Collegial at the origin, singular in the town.** The **First Seat** is a college of Speakers, elder wardens, and the desk that writes **Cutting-leave** (who may take wood, and for where). It is not a pope and not a throne. A town has one warden-hearth. The Seat cannot micromanage a far graft, and does not pretend to.
- **A gift-religion’s hands.** They do not police belief. They tend, they speak, they carry.

### The warden-hearth (the town)

Every town with a mature Tree keeps a **warden-hearth**: a house on the square or in the temple-yard, close enough that blight is smelled before it is announced. The warden (sometimes a small household of apprentice and elder) does the civic-sacred work:

- **Tree-tending:** watering rites, blight-watch, the ordinary care of mortal wood.

- **The Leaf-Fall:** they officiate. They bring the child under the boughs. They wait with the town.
- **The Speaking:** they confirm the colour aloud. Folk-known colours (deep red, storm-grey, lamp-amber, sea-blue, pale stone, copper-green) any neighbour can read; the warden's word makes the reading *civic*. Rare, mixed, or argumentative falls are why the office exists. A **white-fire** fall is sent to the First Seat by runner. A town-warden who names Phoenix from a book has just made history, and a problem.
- **Receiving the Struck:** the quiet after-the-fact rite at the Tree (not a Turning; the Tree does not Strike). How warmly it is done follows the warden's Wide-Hand or Narrow-Hand lean, which is how the schism reaches the square.

A new town without a mature Tree borrows a neighbour's warden and a neighbour's canopy until its own scion comes of age. That borrowed year is remembered: *we Turned at Harrow's Tree before we had our own.*

## The Speaking (colour-authority)

The Speaking is an *act*, not always a separate person. In a small town the warden Speaks. In a pilgrimage-town or at the First Seat, a **Speaker** is the elder who holds the rare-colour texts and the last word on a mixed fall.

They do not invent the palette. They *keep* it. The folk already know the commons. The Speaker is the reason a copper-green is not mistaken for the hug, and the reason a Watcher's second reading stays a witness *alongside*, not a rival authority. Dual practice is common. Two authoritative Speakers in one square is a fight.

## The Road-hands (graft and sickness)

**Road-hands** carry living scions in living earth, plant them with ceremony, and are the ones sent when a Tree sickens. Everyday name everywhere. Liturgical: **Thaelvaeth** (THALE-vayth). *thael* + *vaeth*, "the Tree gone to the waiting."

They are the order's thin edge. A dying Tree is a civic crisis; a waiting town is a political one. The First Seat writes the Cutting-leave. The Road-hand walks it. Far from the Motherwood they have almost no authority except the scion in the cart and whatever reputation three valleys will grant.

**Mandate:** keep sickening Trees alive; deliver a living scion to a town that has already waited too long. Time is the enemy, and thin soil, and a Cutting-leave written for someone else.

**Constraints:** living earth and mortal wood only. A skeleton circuit of hands for a whole thin-reach. Authority that expires a week out from the Motherwood: they advise. They do not command a town that has decided to meet a feared Struck with a rope.

**Institutional weather:** the First Seat's support is **conditional**. A live Tree is a quiet success no one writes down. A dead one is a name on a complaint. Success gets you the next hard road, not a better cart.

**Who ends up on it:** the ranging, the Kept who will not sit a comfortable hearth, the Wide-Hand Struck who still wants the Tree to *acknowledge*. Not a Kind-unit. Not the Seat's favourites.

The college will grant a grudging Cutting-leave and keep the queue.

## The First Seat (the college)

The faith's central authority sits in the **Motherwood** about Thaeloren, on Maiethorn. Everyday: **the First Seat**. Speakers, elder wardens, the Cutting-leave desk.

What the Seat actually holds (and this is all it holds):

- **The graft-source.** Scions are cut from the Awakening Tree, or, in practice, from an established healthy town Tree *acting on the origin's behalf*. The Seat **authorizes** the cut. It does not uniquely possess every knife. A far college-town that cuts without leave is in schism with the Seat, not with the Tree.
- **The rare-colour texts.** Phoenix. Argumentative mixed falls. The book a town-warden has never opened.
- **The queue.** Which waiting settlement receives the next scion. This is the order's real power, and its injustice.

It does **not** appoint every town-warden. A hearth is taken by apprenticeship and confirmed by the town that *watched* the new warden tend a year: citizenship-by-witness applied to the clergy. The Seat confirms Road-hands and Speakers. That is as far as a pre-print world can reach.

## Who may be a warden

**Not by Kind.** A Kitsune hearth-child and a human neighbour hold the same office if they can tend wood and speak a colour. The Orenhael has no Fox-chapter, no ridge-chapter, no Kind-nation inside it.

**By practice first.** You are taken as a hand, apprenticed to a warden-hearth, confirmed when the town has watched you through a Turning-Week. **Orthopraxy:** what you *do* at the Tree makes you of the order. What you privately believe about *who* chooses is the schism, not the hiring test.

**Skeptics at the hearth; believers at the Seat.** A town-warden may be a sincere skeptic ("it is what the Trees do") and still be a good warden, because the wood is mortal and the colours are folk-known. The First Seat runs believer-heavy. Pilgrimage wants a Someone; the rare-colour texts are kept as *hers*. A skeptic Speaker at Thaeloren is possible and uncomfortable.



**Condition leans, not Condition-gates.** Offices attract the Tithes that fit them. This is vocation-shape, not a rule that locks anyone out.

| Office                              | Often                           | Why the Tithe fits                                                        | Also, and welcome                                                                            |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Town-warden                         | the Kept                        | untithed; can sit a hearth year-round                                     | anyone who will tend                                                                         |
| Speaker (Seat and pilgrimage-towns) | Long-Lived                      | incorruptible memory of rare falls; the Phoenix texts are a century's job | a sharp Kept scholar; a Wide-Hand Struck who has seen a threshold-colour from the other side |
| Road-hand                           | Two-Bodied                      | the road <i>is</i> the ranging                                            | Kept; the Taken-In when the job is a sickening grove                                         |
| Grove-tending / blight              | the Taken-In                    | green Tithe + living wood                                                 | Root-Answered for the carrying-earth                                                         |
| Threshold-receiving                 | Struck wardens (Wide-Hand lean) | they have been on the far side of the door                                | any warden the town will stand for                                                           |

The feared-licensed (the Stilled, heavy Far-Voiced, Bound) are not barred. They are *rare* at the First Seat: a Stilled Speaker is a civic comfort and a pilgrimage fright; a Bound warden is easier on Lestrand (where the faith is already a profession) than in the Motherwood (where a written Term next to a gift-doctrine looks like the Fair Hand leaking in). A Phoenix is never clergy. They are a problem the Seat cannot file.

Struck wardens must still be **vouched anew** like any Struck. The order is not a hiding-place from that seam.

## How they live with the other houses

Orthopraxy is the peace. The Orenhael officiates the Leaf-Fall; the other four houses stand at it. Conflict is local.

| House          | Everyday arrangement                                                                                                                 | The hard edge                                                                                                                                   |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| the Watching   | Same Tree, two blessings. A Watcher may offer a <i>second reading</i> of a rare fall: witness alongside, not over.                   | Threnmaieth wants one name on the Threnhael (the crown's roll). A Speaker who lets the withheld blessing stand is a column the crown can count. |
| the Fair Hand  | Leaf-Fall as festival <i>and</i> signing-watch. Book-hands and wardens share a square on Lestrand and ignore each other's sentences. | Gift-language vs. debt-language over the same Bound soul. A Bound warden is the seam.                                                           |
| the Old Ways   | A healthy graft is a guest. Guest-reading Kin-speakers pilgrimage <i>and</i> walk the old doors.                                     | A sickening Tree in an old grove: who is host, warden or door-keeper. Neighbours who both love the wood.                                        |
| the Open Table | Almost no contact. A warden who crosses the storm-wall is a guest at supper. There is no Tree to tend.                               | None that matters. There is no mission-chapter on Kumbaan.                                                                                      |

## How they live in the three corners

Same order. The name and the injustice change.

- **Vaethorn (Hands-folk).** The warden *is* most of the state. Thin reach, hot faith, almost no guild to issue a licence. A Road-hand here is doing the Seat's real work: sick Trees, borrowed Turnings, a scion that may not take. The soft injustice of the Warm lands sits on this hearth, a Kept apprentice pitied for "missing" the gift they are about to spend a life tending.
- **Lestrand (tree-tenders).** A paid civic office. The Leaf-Fall is a commercial milestone; the warden Speaks so the guild-ticket can open. Faith worn light. The Seat's queue looks, from the docks, like any other scarce good. Cutting-leave can be brokered. That is Lestrand's clergy-sin, and it does not require a heresy.
- **Threnmaieth (the Reckoned Hands).** The darkest pressure. The First Seat stands in the same Sacred Core as the Tallied Crown. The crown wants wardens *named to the Threnhael* as officers of the Reckoned Faith: colours written down, Speakers as clerks of stewardship. Some Speakers cooperate (they believe they are keeping the realm hale). Some refuse: the Tree witnessed; a ledger is a second, lesser seeing. The Orenhael does not dissolve Threnmaieth by being kind.

Proximity is pressure, not ownership. The college can refuse the roll, and some Speakers don't.

## The scion-queue

A graft takes a generation to Turn. There are always more waiting towns than carrying-earth. Someone decides the order.

The First Seat frames the **scion-queue** as horticulture: which waiting settlement receives the next living cutting. The wood will take *here*; the soil is thin *there*; the carrying-earth (the living soil a scion travels in) is needed for the first. All of that can be true. It is also a choice about who lives another twenty years sending children down the road to a neighbour's canopy. Those years run **Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy**, which the frontier already knows as weather.

The Leaf-Mother's kindness did not write the queue. People did.

Road-hands walk the consequence. They plant what they were given leave to plant. They sleep in the town that was not chosen, and they learn not to say *queue*.

## Economy of the order

- **Towns house and feed the warden-hearth.** A civic stipend in kind: bread, wood, a place on the square. Not a tax on Conditions.
- **Turning-Week is the festival share.** Markets, reunion, the year's namings. The warden eats from the fair like any other needed office.
- **Cutting-leave has a fee.** Framed as the cost of carrying-earth and a Road-hand's year. Experienced, at the edge, as the price of a future Tree. Lestrاند will broker it. Vaethorn will call it an offering. Threnmaith will want it on the roll. Historically this is how the Seat captured a practice that began without it. The First Cut; the generation of argument; the paper that would not write who; the queue as a copy-right.
- **Pilgrimage keeps the Seat.** Offerings, lodging, the devout who settle in the Motherwood. The college is rich in *proximity*, not in a Condition-tithe.

The Orenhael is not the Tithe-infrastructure sector. Venting-halls, greens, ranging-commons, and the safety-guilds live there. Wardens *point* a new Given at a guild. They do not licence the Stilled.

## A Cutting-leave

First Seat hand, carried north in the same earth as the scion. The verso is travel-stained; the recto is clean.

*The wood will take at Harrow's green. It will not take this year at the three hamlets past the ford. The soil is thin there, and the carrying-earth is needed for the first. Cut from a healthy hand, not from the First, and married with the watering-words. If the scion sickens, send to*

*the Seat; do not cut a second without leave. The Mother does not reach twice by chance, and neither do we.*

On its face: competent horticulture, a little cold, the Tender's blessing reused as a shipping-clause. Underneath: the queue confessing itself. The three hamlets will run Kept-heavy and call it weather.

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## The Watchers

The working people of the Watching. They are not priests and they have no mother-church. The First Seat grew over the rooms that would have been one. What they keep is a vigil and a second voice.

Everyday, everywhere they are known: **Watchers**. Liturgical: **the Nethoren** (neth-OR-en). *neth* “night” + *oren* “to witness”: those who *keep the night and speak what was seen*. Vaethorn's second word is **the night-kin**. Lestrاند barely has one (*vigil-folk*, when a clerk needs a label). Threnmaieth files the house as **the Grown-Over** and the people who keep the vigil as **the second column**.

**In one sentence:** they are the neighbour who will sit up with the Tree the night before Turning-Week, and the second pair of eyes a family sends for when a leaf comes down strange. They *describe*, they do not *confirm*. They have day jobs. The house is a practice, not a wage.

## Shape of the order

- **No seat. The archaeology is the theology.** The Watching has no college in the Motherwood. Their oldest rooms sit under older chapels, or in houses that never took a warden's lintel. A Watcher who wants a “mother-church” has already become something else.
- **Two acts, not four offices.** The **Night Watch** is what the house *does*. Anyone of Haelthael (the Watching's own name) may keep it. The **Second Reading** is a reputation, not a lintel: the person a town will ask to sit beside the warden when a fall is rare, mixed, or argued. There is no Speaker-equivalent with the last word, no Road-hand circuit, no Cutting-leave desk. Those jobs belong to a faith that has a Tree to carry.
- **Needed as a witness, not as a civic utility.** A town does not keep a Watcher the way it keeps a warden. The wood still wants watering. What a Watcher is *for* is accurate speech, and a night of matching the Tree's attention with their own. Lestrاند can live without that. Threnmaieth cannot stop counting it.
- **A witness-religion's people.** They do not police the Mother-name. They withhold it.

## If you meet one

A Watcher looks like a neighbour. Baker, weaver, a Long-Lived who copies texts, a Kept who sits a quiet hearth. They do not wear a lintel-mark (that is the warden). You know them because someone said *ask the old room* or *send for the one who sat last year's mixed fall*, or because you saw them under the Tree the night before Turning-Week with no lamp and no blessing.

They are useful the way a second opinion is useful. A town can live without them. A family that does not trust a single mouth on a strange leaf cannot.

## Who knocks, and when

| Who                                                      | Why they come                                                                                        | What the Watcher does                                                                                                                                                                                           | What they will not do                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A household of the house                                 | Turning-Week is coming; a child needs the withheld line taught                                       | Sit at the hearth and make the child <i>say what they saw last year</i> (a neighbour's fall, a colour in the square) until the speech is accurate                                                               | Will not teach the Tender's blessing as the true one. A Masked Watcher will teach both, the withheld line under.                                                         |
| The family of a ten-year-old, after a rare or mixed fall | The warden Spoke one colour; the leaf looked like two; the year will argue                           | Sit <i>beside</i> the warden (or after, in the old room) and <b>describe</b> : stem, serration, how the leaf turned, whether the child flinched. Write it if asked. File nothing unless Threnmaieth makes them. | Will not <b>Speak</b> . Description is not confirmation. They will not say <i>Two-Bodied</i> or <i>Answered</i> if they saw two colours. They will say the two colours.  |
| A Struck, or the people standing for one                 | The warden did the quiet receiving-rite; the family wants a witness who will not call it a late gift | Describe the threshold as a seeing at a harder door. Sit the rite. Say the withheld line if they say anything.                                                                                                  | Will not take them to be <i>acknowledged as Given</i> . Will not novate terms (that is a Book-hand). Will not name them kin at a drowning-stone (that is a door-keeper). |
| A crown-clerk (Threnmaieth)                              | The Night Watch needs a time on the festival roll; a second reading needs a column                   | Give the night, or the description, as counted dissent                                                                                                                                                          | Will not call the withheld word a heresy they recant. A Bare Tree Watcher will not say <i>she</i> to make the docket cleaner.                                            |
| Almost no one, most weeks                                | the ordinary week                                                                                    | Their day job. Sweep the old room. Keep the coats hung.                                                                                                                                                         | Will not invent a reason to be sent for. They are not a circuit.                                                                                                         |

## An ordinary year

Eleven months they are not “on duty.” They bake, copy, range, keep a stall. The house-work that still happens:

- **Teaching the withheld blessing** at the hearth, the year a child turns nine. Same cadence as the Tender's line; the Mother is not in it. This is how you can tell a Watcher household in a mixed street. The child can recite both, or will only recite one.
- **Name what you saw**, after any Turning they attend. Not a sermon. They sit with *their* child (or a neighbour's, if asked) and make the fall into accurate speech: the colour, the way the leaf came, what the year will ask. Devotion is the description. A sloppy Watcher is a bad Watcher.
- **The old room.** Sweep it. Keep the recut beam's hidden face from rotting, if the house still has one. Hang the Night Watch coats. In Threnmaith, answer the clerk who wants to know the room is still a room.
- They do **not** water the Tree. That is the warden-hearth. A Watcher who starts blight-watching has started doing the Orenhael's job.

## The Night Watch

The night before Turning-Week, the eve of Eolthael in a town that keeps the clergy's year. Watchers keep a silent vigil at the town Tree. No blessing. No colour-reading. No lamps if they can help it. The point is to *be seen seeing*.

This is not an office you are appointed to. A household that speaks the withheld blessing is expected to send someone. A town with three Watcher families may have six people under the boughs and no one in charge. A town with one old room under the chapel may have a single Long-Lived who has kept the same night for eighty years. Both are the order, such as it is.

They count the *silences*, not the hours. No one will explain this to a guest. A first-time sitter who asks *how long* is told *until it has been seen*.

They do **not** officiate the Leaf-Fall the next day. The warden does that. They attend (orthopraxy; their children Turn) and speak their own line when the Tender's blessing is said.

## The Second Reading

Where a town will have it, a Watcher may sit a **second reading** of a rare or mixed fall: not authoritative over the warden, a *witness alongside*. They describe what they saw. They do not confirm. Confirmation is civic; it belongs to the Speaking.

How the hour actually runs:

1. The child is still under the boughs, or has just been walked to the warden-hearth. The town is still there. The warden Speaks. *Storm-grey*, say.
2. If a household asked, or if the fall was mixed enough that the square muttered, the Watcher is already standing to the side. They do not interrupt the Speaking.

3. They say what they saw, in the square or afterward in the old room. Stem, serration, the turn, the flinch or the lack of one. They will use colour-words. They will resist Condition-names if the leaf was not one colour.
4. Most years the town nods at both mouths and goes to the fair. The child is Two-Bodied because the warden Spoke it, and also someone said *there was amber at the edge*, and that sentence lives in the family.

A Second-reader is just the Watcher three streets will send for when the fall is argumentative. No diploma. No Seat confirmation.

In Threnmaieth they are a known column on the Threnhael. The second reading is tolerated as counted dissent. The night is tolerated as a festival-eve custom. The withheld word is what the roll wants a name for.

## What they carry

Almost nothing that looks like clergy. A scrap for the description (plain paper, not a book; a book would be a Settler's tool). A coat that lives in the old room and smells of last year's eve. In a Bare Tree household, no Mother-mark on the lintel; in a Masked one, the warden's mark *and* a second, older scratch underneath that a clerk can miss.

They have no stamp, no Cutting-leave, no ticket. They cannot licence a Stilled. They cannot plant a Tree.

## What they refuse

- They will not **Speak**. If a town has no warden that year, they will still only describe. A civic confirmation from a Watcher is the house breaking itself.
- They will not take a warden's lintel. The archaeology is the theology: houses that never took one, rooms under chapels.
- They will not police the Mother-name in the street. They withhold it.
- They will not travel as a circuit. A Watcher in another town is a cousin visiting.

There is no chapter-house circuit. The "order" meets, when it meets, because Turning-Week gathers people who already keep the same night. From the outside that can look organised. It is architecture: the house that never took a warden's lintel; the beam that was turned to the stone when the chapel was re-floored; the room under the nave where the Night Watch leaves its coats. The First Seat knows those rooms exist. It grew over them. It does not inventory them, except in Threnmaieth, where inventory is the local weather.



## Who may keep the watch

**Not by Kind.** A Kitsune hearth-child and a human neighbour keep the same night if they will sit it and speak accurately.

**By practice first.** You are of the house when you keep the Night Watch and teach a child the withheld blessing. Orthopraxy, older than the Motherfaith's: the withheld word is the dissent; the standing-at-the-Tree is the belonging.

**The schism walks in.** A Masked Watcher will stand for the Tender's blessing and add the withheld line under it. They are the ones a mixed town barely notices. A Bare Tree Watcher will not say *she* at all. Both may Second-read. They will not always Second-read *the same*. That is the house arguing with itself in the square, which is allowed, and is why they cannot present a single rival authority even if they wanted one.

**Condition leans, not Condition-gates.**

| Act                 | Often                             | Why the Tithe (or the lack) fits                                | Also, and welcome                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Night Watch         | anyone of the house               | the night does not care what you carry                          | the Kept, who were seen as whole; the Struck, who were seen at a harder door                                                        |
| Second Reading      | Long-Lived                        | incorruptible memory of how a rare fall looked <i>last time</i> | a sharp Kept; a Stilled who will describe without flinching; a Wide-Hand Struck who has seen a threshold-colour from the other side |
| Keeping an old room | families that never took a lintel | the archaeology is inherited                                    | a new household that refuses the warden's mark                                                                                      |

The feared-licensed are not barred. A Stilled Second-reader is a civic comfort (the gaze holds a room still for accurate speech) and a pilgrimage fright; they are rarer at the sacred centre than in an old district that never stopped being Haelthael. A Phoenix is not clergy here either. They are a seeing no one in the square is ready to describe twice.

Struck Watchers must still be vouched anew like any Struck. The old rooms are not a hiding-place from that seam.

## How they live with the other houses

| House            | Everyday arrangement                                                                                                                               | The hard edge                                                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| the Tree-Wardens | Same Tree, two blessings. Second reading alongside, not over.                                                                                      | Threnmaieth wants one name on the Threnhael. A Speaker who lets the withheld line stand is a column the crown can count. Two authoritative Speakers in one square is a fight. |
| the Fair Hand    | Rarely share a square. A Settler hears “what falls, was seen” as a clause with no number.                                                          | Almost none, until a Bound wants a second reading of an oath-day and a Watcher will not call it a signing.                                                                    |
| the Old Ways     | Two old memories, opposite edges. A Watcher remembers a Before <i>at</i> the Tree; a door-keeper remembers a Before <i>without</i> one.            | They would not agree if you sat them down.                                                                                                                                    |
| the Open Table   | Almost no contact. A Watcher who crossed the storm-wall would be a guest at supper, and would find the night already kept, for a different reason. | None that matters. There is no Night Watch on Kumbaan.                                                                                                                        |

## How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (the night-kin).** Cousin-dissent. Thin reach, hot faith: a Watcher household is unusual and not hunted. The Night Watch looks, from a Hands-folk hearth, like extra piety. The withheld Mother-name is the only sting, and a Guest-reading town has larger fights (the grove) than this one.
- **Lestrand (vigil-folk, when named).** Rarely met. A Watcher on the docks is a scholar or a migrant from the core. The signing-watch does not need a second reading; the book is the second reading. Faith worn light enough that a withheld blessing is just another quay-sentence.
- **Threnmaieth (the second column).** The house’s real weather. They are a known column on the roll, the Grown-Over, counted, not pogromed. The Night Watch is a festival-eve custom the crown can schedule. The second reading is tolerated until it contradicts the Speaker the Threnhael has already named. A Long-Lived who still has an un-recut lintel-copy is a person this house keeps.

## The recut lintel

They remember a cost, and they have no institution that can keep a lintel from being turned to the stone.

The First Seat did not steal a throne from them. There was no throne. What was lost is quieter: a beam recut, a room under a chapel that is now a vestry, a second reading that remains *alongside* because the civic word was given to the warden when the Mother-name grew over the Seeing. All of that can be described as history. It is also a choice, still being made, about whose speech counts in the square.

A kind Mother, if she is there, would not give the Watching a seat, and would not make the Grown-Over column kind. They have hold of the Before and the cost. They do not have the last word on a colour.

They do not walk a scion-queue. That injustice is the Orenhael's. Theirs is the recut beam.

## Economy of the house

Almost none, as an institution. That is the point.

- **Households keep the night.** Bread from the same table. No stipend, no Cutting-leave, no pilgrimage-share.
- **A Second-reader eats as a neighbour.** Some old districts leave a plate at the room under the chapel during Turning-Week. That is courtesy, not a wage.
- **Threnmaieth's tell.** Being a *column* can become a living if a crown-clerk pays for a copied lintel or a listed name. A Watcher who takes that coin has not left the house. They have let the roll furnish it. The Bare Tree branch will not eat with them. The Masked will, and argue after.

The Nethoren are not the Tithe-infrastructure sector and not a safety-guild. They point no one at a licence. They describe a fall.

## A second-reading slip

Written in a Watcher's own hand the morning after a mixed fall, and filed by a Threnmaieth Speaker under "alongside, not over." The Speaker's docket-mark is cleaner than the slip.

*Storm-grey at the stem, lamp-amber at the serration, and the child did not flinch when the leaf turned. I will not say Two-Bodied. I will not say Answered. I will say what I saw: the Tree looked twice and did not choose the easier colour. The warden Spoke storm-grey. I sat beside and said the amber. Both were seen. File me as the second column if you must. Do not file the amber as an error.*

On its face: a careful witness, a little stubborn, useful to a clerk who needs a dissent-name. The Speaker who filed it "alongside" was doing the peace. The roll that kept the slip was doing theology.

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# The Book-Hands

The working people of the Fair Hand. They have no seat and many tables. On Lestrand they are often the same people as commercial clerks; the faith is the profession, worn lightly. They do not rewrite a Bound's Terms. That clause belongs to the **Counterparty**, the other party to the Bound's contract, not the clerk. They may *witness an ask*; they do not dictate.

Everyday: **Book-hands**, or **Settlers**. Liturgical: **the Leddhael** (LED-hayl). *ledd* "to reckon" + *hael* "whole": those who *keep the account fair enough that you can walk*. Vaethorn's second word is **Bargainers' clerks**. Lestrand's is **the Settling-hands** (ordinary, like saying *notary*). Threnmaieth files them with the house as **the Uncounted Book**. Private books offend the crown.

**In one sentence:** they are notaries (hull in the morning, a child's private book at Turning-Week) and the person who will help a Struck find a *payable year* (a hall, a warrant). They will recite a Bound's Terms on oath-day. They will not change those Terms.

## Shape of the order

- **No seat, many tables.** Guild-rooms and quay-shrines, not a college in anyone's sacred wood. A "high house" in a rich port is the oldest book-room: age, not authority. The next quay has its own table and does not write to the first for leave.
- **The faith is the profession.** A Book-hand witnesses a signing, teaches a child to keep a book, and helps a Struck settle a year that can actually be lived. On Lestrand the same person may stamp a hull before noon and recite a Bound's oath-day after. Doctrine is the ethic of the stamp: *fair terms, then walk*. They copy a Bound's Terms. They do not author them.
- **No membership roll.** A roll of Book-hands would be a Threnhael in a clerk's pocket. What makes you of the house is that you keep accounts honestly and will die to keep a crown-clerk out of a personal book.
- **A settling-religion's clerks.** They do not ride. They do not hunt hidden terms as a knightly order. They sit at tables.

## If you meet one

On Lestrand a Book-hand looks like a clerk. Ink-stained, a small stamp on a cord, a table in a guild-room or a quay-shrine the size of a pantry. Before noon they may witness a hull. After, a Bound's oath-day. Same sentence both times: *fair wind, fair term*. You would not know which hour was "church" unless you already kept Leddoren.

Off the coast they are rarer and more obviously religious: the person a pilgrim-town sends for when a Struck cannot live *this year* (no hall, no one to stand), and the Hands-folk would rather walk them to a

Tree.

They are useful the way a notary is useful. A port cannot live without someone who will stamp a signing. The faith is that the stamp and the becoming use the same grammar.

## Who sits down, and when

| Who                                              | Why they come                                                               | What the Book-hand does                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | What they will not do                                                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A ten-year-old's Settler household, Turning-Week | The child Turned (or was Kept); the personal book must open                 | Stand as <i>witness</i> , not petitioner. Speak the signing-watch line if they speak. Enter colour (or the hug), Tithe, what the year owes. Put the book in the child's hands.                                                                                            | Will not speak the Tender's blessing. Will not call the colour a gift. Will not Speak the civic name. The warden does that; they copy what was seen into a private book. |
| Anyone with a contract                           | Marriage, hull, a year's closing                                            | Witness, copy, stamp, date.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Will not hide a clause. Hidden terms are the house's one sin. Will not show a <i>personal</i> book to a crown-clerk.                                                     |
| A Bound, on oath-day                             | The year's Terms must be spoken where a neighbour can hear                  | Recite the Terms <i>as already written</i> . Mark the civic book closed if the Tithe-year was paid, or owing if it was not.                                                                                                                                               | <b>Will not rewrite the Terms.</b> That is the Counterparty's clause, not a clerk's. Will not pretend a stamp can ease a Pledge.                                         |
| A Bound who wants the clause changed             | The Terms are killing them; they have heard a clerk can "fix it"            | A <b>Counterparty</b> Book-hand may sit a <i>petition-watch</i> : they witness the ask, keep the book open, and wait. If something answers, they copy what was answered. A <b>Book Alone</b> hand will not sit that hour. They do not believe anyone is across the table. | Will not dictate a new clause. Will not sell an easing. Anyone who claims they can is a liar, or someone taking coin in a cellar.                                        |
| A Struck who is not Bound                        | They Changed later (drowned, died, taken); this town cannot house the Tithe | <b>Civic settling:</b> find a payable year. Passage to a hall that exists, a warrant, someone to stand for them.                                                                                                                                                          | Will not take them to a Tree to be acknowledged as Given. Will not name them kin at a door. Will not rewrite a Bound contract under this heading.                        |

| Who                              | Why they come                                    | What the Book-hand does                                                                                   | What they will not do                                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A child of the house, about nine | They must learn to keep a book before they Turn  | Sit with a blank personal book: colour, Tithe, debts, what the year owes you. Private. Not the Threnhael. | Will not let a Reckoned clerk “help” copy it. Will not teach the book as a census.                                                                               |
| A Tithe-poor Settler             | The year will not close; they cannot stamp a fee | Some stay and rewrite until the candle dies. Some mark <i>owing</i> faster. Both are of the house.        | Will not furnish a venting-hall or a greens-share. They may <i>write a term that assumes one</i> . The Hall-Keepers and Greens-Keepers own the hall and the lot. |

## An ordinary week on Lestrand

**Morning, the commercial table.** Hulls, marriages, copies, a deathless house’s instrument. Paid by the stamp. A Kept clerk (Lestrand’s *free*) may do only this and still be of the house if they keep accounts honestly and will die to keep a crown-clerk out of a personal book.

**Turning-Week and oath-days, the signing-watch.** They attend the Leaf-Fall as witnesses. They do not officiate. They stand at the edge of the square with a child’s first book and wait for a colour they can enter. A Bound’s oath-day is the high holy day: Terms recited in a voice the quay can hear, the year’s book closed or marked owing.

**When someone Changed last week: civic settling, not a rewritten god-clause.** A drowning came back Far-Voiced in a town with no ael-hall. A death came back Returned with a purpose the street will not house. The Book-hand finds a year that can be *paid*: passage, a warrant, a neighbour who will stand. If no one will stand, they write *owing*. The quay steps around. That is still the house’s kindness and its cruelty. It is **not** a Bound’s Terms being edited.

**A Bound’s oath-day.** They recite what was already sworn. They do not improve it. A Bound who wants the clause itself changed is asking the Counterparty, not the clerk. The honest house will witness the ask or refuse to pretend. Anyone selling a new clause after the lamps is another table.

They never write the word *gift*, even as a loan. A first-year apprentice who copies *vael* into a personal book is made to strike it and write *grant*. No one calls this a rule. It is how the ink goes.

They do not cut grafts, tend Trees, or carry scions. A sickening Tree is a warden’s crisis and a door-keeper’s fight. A Book-hand will write the delay into a contract.

There is no Speaker-equivalent. If two Book-hands disagree on a clause, they write both readings and date them. Two dated readings are a book, not a schism.

## How civic settling actually runs

This is for a Struck whose *Tithe* cannot be lived here. It is not for a Bound's supernatural Terms. Civic settling is the house's **novation** of a year: rewriting the payable civic terms (passage, warrant, a seventh day), never the Bound's clause.

1. The Struck sits. The Book-hand names what is already true: *you carry a voice; you carry a purpose*.
2. They name what cannot be paid *here*: a hall that is not in this town; a warmth no one will give.
3. They find a year a neighbour can see being paid. Passage to a release-house, a warrant, a seventh day.
4. They find someone to **stand for** the person. The Book-hand is not themselves a pillar unless they are Bound, Long-Lived, or Far-Voiced.
5. If that fails: *owing, not broken*. The civic book stays open. The quay learns the name.

## How a Bound petition-watch runs (if they sit it)

1. The Bound speaks the ask. The Book-hand writes the ask, not the answer.
2. They wait. They do not invent a clause to fill the silence.
3. If nothing answers, they close the hour. The old Terms still stand. The house was honest.
4. If something answers, they copy the new clause *as heard*. They do not improve the wording. They do not take a fee for "getting a better deal."

A Book Alone hand stops at step 1 and sends the Bound home. They will not play at a table they believe is empty. That is also honest.

## What they carry

A **stamp** (personal, not a guild-licence; the ticket is a different paper). Ink. A cord-knife for striking a line. The small **personal books** they sell or gift to children of the house, not the Threnhael. A clerk who confuses them has started a fight. On a Bound's oath-day, the year's working contract, read aloud, *as written*, not as improved.

A "high house" is a room with old copies and a better lamp. It is not a palace. The next quay does not write here for leave.



## What they refuse

- They will not show a personal book to the crown. A campaign that subpoenas one is stealing a soul in *their* language.
- They will not call a Leaf-Fall a gift, and they will not retcon a Given child into a debtor. The book opens at the colour; it does not invent a storm.
- They will not ride out as contract-paladins or carry a scion. They sit.
- They will not keep a membership roll of Book-hands. A roll would be a Threnhael.
- They will not rewrite a Bound's Terms or sell an easing of a Pledge. The clerk is not the Counterparty.

## Who may keep a table

**Not by Kind.** A Selkie quay-child and a human clerk hold the same stamp if they keep accounts honestly.

**By practice first.** You are taken as a hand, apprenticed at a table, confirmed when a quay has watched you through a year's closings and at least one signing-watch. What you privately believe about whether anyone sits *across* the table (Counterparty / Book Alone) is the schism, not the hiring test. Both branches refuse hidden terms. That is enough to share a desk.

**Condition leans, not Condition-gates.**

| Act                    | Often                               | Why the Tithe (or the lack) fits                                              | Also, and welcome                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Witnessing / teaching  | Bound                               | their book is a contract; the faith did not invent this, they made it legible | the Unbound who have closed a year and will teach the closing; a Kept clerk (Lestrand's <i>free</i> : no Tithe, no guild, the book is a choice) |
| Novation of the Struck | Bound; Wide-Hand Struck who settled | they have been on the far side of a bad term                                  | a Far-Voiced who can make a feeling unfakeable at the table (the three pillars)                                                                 |
| Oldest book-rooms      | Long-Lived houses that endow a room | a century of fair copies is a high house                                      | anyone the port still comes to                                                                                                                  |

The feared-licensed are not barred. A Bound Book-hand is *ordinary* on Lestrand and a theological problem in the Motherwood. A Stilled at a table is rare and useful (the room holds still for the clause).

A Phoenix is not a clerk. There is no term that covers them.

Struck Book-hands must still be vouched anew. Civic settling is how the house *helps* that vouching, which is why the same kindness is also the lever. It still does not rewrite a Bound's clause.

## How they live with the other houses

| House            | Everyday arrangement                                                                                                                                     | The hard edge                                                                                                                 |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| the Tree-Wardens | Leaf-Fall as festival <i>and</i> signing-watch. On Lestrand they share a square and ignore each other's sentences.                                       | Gift-language vs. debt-language over the same Bound soul. A Bound warden is the seam; a Bound Book-hand is the house at home. |
| the Watchers     | Rarely share a square. "What falls, was seen" sounds, to a Settler, like a clause with no number.                                                        | A Bound who wants a second reading of an oath-day and a Watcher who will not call it a signing.                               |
| the Old Ways     | A door-keeper names a Struck <i>kin</i> at the door that made them; a Book-hand settles the civic year at a table. Sometimes the same week, same person. | Which name goes first, kin or payable year. Two courtesies, not a trial.                                                      |
| the Open Table   | A Settler who sits a moon-feast twice has been called kin in a language with no book.                                                                    | "No one is a stranger twice" is not a term. There is no Leddoren mission on Kumbaan.                                          |

## How they live in the three corners

- **Lestrand (the Settling-hands).** Home weather. The faith *is* the profession. A high house is a proud old room on a rich quay; it is not a seat. Cutting-leave can be brokered by the same people who close books. That is Lestrand's clergy-sin, and it belongs to the *wardens'* fee, not to a Book-hand's stamp, except when a clerk "helps" a waiting town write the delay. Market-fade wears vestments here: the Tithe-poor Settler who cannot close the book is still a person the rich city steps around.
- **Vaethorn (Bargainers' clerks).** Suspect, useful, few. A Book-hand on the pilgrim edge is settling a Struck's year in a land that would rather take them to a Tree to be acknowledged as Given. The Hands-folk will eat with them if the year comes out kind. A Narrow-Hand preacher will not.
- **Threnmaeth (the Uncounted Book).** Private books offend the crown. A personal ledger that is *not* the Threnhael is, to a Reckoned clerk, a second seeing the crown does not hold. Book-hands here work quietly, or not at all, or as commercial notaries who have learned not to say *Leddoren* on a docket.

## The book that will not close

Grace is a closed book. That is the house's kindness, and its cruelty.

Every civic settling that saves a Struck who can pay is paid for, somewhere, by the Struck who cannot. The Book-hand sees one table. The quay sees a step-around.

Their other exposed edge is the Bound they *cannot* help. A clerk who will not rewrite Terms will watch someone walk down the quay looking for a cellar that will lie to them. That is honesty's cost. The shadow economy still exists; the lived face of illicit Tithe-supply is the Slide. They do not stamp, and they do not rewrite Terms.

## Economy of the house

- **The stamp is the living.** On Lestrand a Book-hand is paid as a clerk is paid, by the signing, the copy, the year's closing. The faith does not take a cut of the Tithe.
- **High houses endow rooms.** Deathless money likes a fair copy that will outlive a hull. That is proximity-wealth, not a Condition-tithe, and it is why the oldest rooms sit on the richest quays.
- **Civic settling is badly paid.** The Struck who most need a hall and a warrant are the ones who can least stamp a fee. Some Book-hands stay until the candle dies. Some mark *owing* faster. Both are of the house.

They are not the Tithe-infrastructure sector and not a safety-guild. They may write a term that *assumes* a venting-hall or a greens-share. They do not furnish one.

## A civic settling

Lestrand quay-hand, written the week after a drowning came back Far-Voiced and could not pay a singer's Tithe in a town that had no ael-hall. The verso has the old storm-terms of *the year*, struck through. Not a Bound's clause.

*Grant: the voice, already carried. Old term: a hall that is not here. New term: one honest outlet each seventh day at the release-house in Greyhull, passage stamped, warrant by M. Senn the hull-clerk. If the seventh day is missed, the book is owing, not broken. Walk, if you can walk. If you cannot, the quay will not call it a gift.*

On its face: the house's kindness, a storm-book rewritten so a person can live. Underneath: the fade confessing itself. "The quay will not call it a gift" is honest and is also the step-around, sacralized. Greyhull's release-house will take the seventh day. The eighth week the passage-money fails, the slip will still be fair, and the person will still be a book that would not close.

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## The Door-Keepers

The working people of the Old Ways. They have no seat because the land is the seat. Not a hierarchy; a reputation.

Everyday: **door-keepers**, also **Kin-speakers**. Liturgical: **the Vaelbren** (VAYL-bren). *ael* in the older sense (“what the land yields”) + *bren* “hearth”: those who *keep the yield at the hearth*. Vaethorn’s second word is **the door-folk** (or *Before-speakers* when the fight is hot). Lestrand’s is **grove-talkers** (a frontier curiosity). Threnmaith files them with the house as **the Unreached**.

**In one sentence:** they are the person three valleys walk to when someone needs to know which drowning-pool still returns, which grove still takes people in, and the mouth that names a Struck *kin* at the door that made them, instead of walking them to a Tree to be filed as late.

### Shape of the order

- **The land is the seat.** The Old Ways cannot have a mother-church. A hill, a drowning-stone, a grove, an oath-rock: these are the offices. A person is of the house when three valleys will walk to them, not when a college confirms them.
- **Two jobs, often one mouth.** A **door-keeper** knows which doors still open and will walk them at the year’s hinges. A **Kin-speaker** speaks at ancestor-meals and names a Struck *kin* at the door that made them. In a thin-reach district this is one tired person. In a Guest-reading town that finally got a Tree, the two jobs may split for a generation and fold again when the old one dies.
- **No Road-hand, no queue, no Speaking.** They do not carry scions. They do not confirm colours. They do not authorise a cut. When a graft sickens in an old green, they argue *host*, not horticulture. The Road-hands already walk the other job.
- **A land-and-kin house.** They do not police the Mother-name. Many also bring a child to a healthy graft.

### If you meet one

A door-keeper looks like someone who knows the district. Mud on the hem, a worn token at the belt (river-stone, grove-twigg, a pinch of hill in a twist of cloth; no two alike), a sack that is sometimes food for a door and sometimes food for a meal. You would miss them as clergy if you came from Maiethorn looking for a chapel. You would find them if you asked *who still walks the drowning-stone* or *who will speak at the board for the ones in the ground*.

They are useful the way a midwife is useful, except the birth they attend is a later becoming, and the map they keep is which doors still open. A thin-reach town can live without a warden for a generation.

It cannot live long without someone who remembers the water.

## Who sends for them, and when

| Who                                            | Why they come                                                                                                      | What the door-keeper does                                                                                                                            | What they will not do                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Anyone in the district, at a year's hinge      | The doors must be walked. Deep Solstice, the equinoxes, High Solstice, and the local hinges the map does not print | Walk. Greet water, hill, stone, in that order.<br>Leave food. Ask to be <i>known</i> , not Given.<br>Take the young one who carried last year.       | Will not ask the door for a colour.<br>Will not skip a door because a Tree is healthier this year.                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| A household at an ancestor-meal                | Someone must know the names and keep the empty place                                                               | Speak the names. Set the place. Not let a guest sit in it. Eat.<br>Argue Guest/First after the dishes if they argue.                                 | Will not treat the empty place as a Returned's chair. Different door. Will not make this a chapel service.                                                                                                                                                                            |
| A Struck, or the people who found them         | They Changed at a river, a grove, an oath-stone, a death; the town wants them vouched or gone                      | Take them back to the door that made them, if it can be found, and <b>name them kin</b> . Feed them. Walk with them if the town will not house them. | Will not walk them to a Tree to be acknowledged as Given (the warden may do that the same week; the fight is which name goes first). Will not settle a civic year (that is a Book-hand). Cannot <i>be</i> a civic pillar unless they themselves are Long-Lived, Bound, or Far-Voiced. |
| A warden or a Road-hand                        | A graft in an old green is sickening; someone has Cutting-leave                                                    | Tend the wood as host or as keeper of a guest.<br>Demand the meal before a second cut.                                                               | Will not carry the next scion up the road. Will not sell a cut. Will not call the Struck "unreached."                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| A scholar, a Lestrand clerk, a curious pilgrim | They want the older sense of <i>vael</i> , or a drowning-stone found                                               | Show the door. Use the old word for a harvest and a returned child.                                                                                  | Will not give them a map of every door. Some doors are walked, not published.                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

## An ordinary season

**Most weeks.** Someone asks whether the pool below the ford still returns. The door-keeper goes and looks. They know which grove took someone in ten years ago and whether that hill is still a door. They carry food when the hinge is close. They have a day life (ranging, green-tending, a stall) and the reputation sits on top of it. A famous one is just the one three valleys will walk to. A young one is the apprentice who carried the food last year and was watched doing it.

**The year's hinges.** Not only High Solstice / Turning-Week. Deep Solstice (the long night, the low year). The two equinoxes. Local hinges a Maiethorn calendar does not print: the first flood, the night the hill-ice breaks. They walk the old doors of the district. Water, then hill, then stone. They will not say why that order. A guest who reverses it is corrected without a sermon.

**The meal.** A place at the board for the ones in the ground. Quiet, domestic. The Kin-speaker is the one who knows the names. In a thin-reach district this is the same tired person who walked the ford at dawn.

**When someone Changed later.** They do not start at the Tree. They start at the door: the river if it was water, the grove if it was green, the oath-stone if it was a vow, the death-place if it was unfinished work. They name the person *kin*. The Motherfaith's quiet receiving-rite may happen the same week. A Book-hand's novation may happen the same month. Three courtesies, not a trial. The exposed edge is the Struck the *town* will not house: the door-keeper has a name to give and not a pillar. They may spend a season walking with one person. They may not be able to.

They tend a healthy graft as a *guest in the grove* if the town has one. They may Turn under it. They may not pretend it invented becoming.

## How a kin-naming actually runs

1. Find the door, if it can be found. If it cannot, the nearest old door of the same kind: water for a drowning, green for a taking. A door that is only a Tree is a last resort, and a First-reading walker will hate it.
2. Food first. The door is greeted. The person is not tested with a colour.
3. The Kin-speaker says the name they already had, then the kin-name the door is owed. No leaf. No stamp. The token at the belt is shown, not given, unless this person will walk next year, in which case they will find their own.
4. The town, if it is watching, still wants a warrant to let them *stay*. The kin-name is courtesy. Standing-for is civic. A door-keeper who is also Long-Lived, Bound, or Far-Voiced can do both. Most cannot.

## The contested grove

An ailing graft in an old Taken-In green is the signature fight: warden vs. door-keeper, guest vs. host, pilgrimage-scarcity vs. “we had ways.” Neighbours who both love the wood.

What they *do* with their hands is the same as the warden for an hour: water, watch blight, sit up with mortal wood. The argument is not horticulture. It is whether this Tree is a guest in the grove or a Tree the town failed. A Guest-reading Kin-speaker will pilgrimage *and* walk the doors, and will tend a dying graft as kin. A First-reading door-keeper will tend the same graft as a *guest in their house* and still refuse the Tender’s blessing. Both revere the Struck and the Taken-In. A reading that starts pitying them as “unreached” has already become Motherfaith.

If a Road-hand arrives with Cutting-leave, the door-keeper’s job is the meal first, then the question *does this grove receive a guest? Not shall I have brought the wood myself?* They do not carry scions.

## What they carry

The **token** from their door: river-stone, grove-twigg, a pinch of hill. Food for the walk. Names in the head (the ones in the ground; the doors that still open). No stamp. No colour-book. No Cutting-leave.

## What they refuse

- They will not confirm a colour or officiate a Leaf-Fall. If they bring a child to a healthy graft, the warden Speaks.
- They will not carry a scion or sell a cut.
- They will not call the Struck or the Taken-In “unreached.” That word is Motherfaith leaking in.
- They will not publish every door. Some are walked, not mapped.
- They will not become undeath-priests. Ancestor-meals are kin in the ground. The Returned are a different door.

## Who may keep a door

**Not by Kind.** A Tengu ridge-child and a human neighbour walk the same stone if they know it and will stand for kin. The Taken-In are *revered* here; they are not a membership test.

**By practice first.** You are taken as a walker. You carried the food, you were watched at a meal, three households will send for you. Belief about the Mother (Guest / First) is secondary. Many Kin-speakers also bring a child to a healthy graft when they can reach one.

**Condition leans, not Condition-gates.**

| Act                   | Often               | Why the Tithe (or the lack) fits                     | Also, and welcome                                                                         |
|-----------------------|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Walking the doors     | the Taken-In        | the grove's own children; green Tithe + old green    | Two-Bodied (the walk is a ranging); Kept for whom a closed door was weather, not a slight |
| Naming the Struck kin | Struck door-keepers | they have been through a door with no warden         | a Wide-Hand warden who will share the week; a Bound whose oath-stone is the door          |
| Ancestor-meals        | anyone of the house | the dead stay in the ground, not the Returned's door | a Returned guest is a <i>different</i> door; the Kin-speaker is not their priest          |

The feared-licensed are not barred. A Taken-In door-keeper is ordinary on Heskoren and a frontier embarrassment in a Narrow-Hand sermon. A Phoenix is not a walker. There is no old door that answers to white-fire.

Struck door-keepers must still be vouched anew. Naming them kin is the house's answer to that seam: courtesy, not a substitute for the three pillars. The town may still want a warrant.

## How they live with the other houses

| House            | Everyday arrangement                                                                                                                                                                     | The hard edge                                                                                                                      |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| the Tree-Wardens | A healthy graft is a guest. Guest-reading Kin-speakers pilgrimage <i>and</i> walk the doors. Vaethorn's Hands-folk find the missing seat infuriating and, in a dry year, quietly useful. | A sickening Tree in an old grove: who is host. A Narrow-Hand preacher calling the Struck "not hers" is who they will not eat with. |
| the Watchers     | Two old memories, opposite edges. Before <i>at</i> the Tree / Before <i>without</i> one.                                                                                                 | They would not agree if you sat them down.                                                                                         |
| the Book-Hands   | Kin-name and rewritten terms, sometimes the same Struck, same month.                                                                                                                     | Which name goes first. Two courtesies, not a trial.                                                                                |
| the Open Table   | Ancestor-meals and a place set for staying-kin look, to a traveller, like cousins. They are not. The dead in the ground are not the unseen hands.                                        | The isle is not a grove. There is no Vaeloren mission on Kumbaan.                                                                  |



## How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (the door-folk).** Home weather, and the live fight. The warden is most of the state; the door-keeper is the older state the land still keeps. Guest-reading towns that finally got a Tree did not throw their grandparents out of the rite. They pilgrimage *and* walk. First-reading districts still waiting on a scion that will not take tend a dying guest and refuse the blessing. Vaethorn's guilt-theology (scarcity read as unworthiness) is the enemy, not the Hands-folk hearth. A closed door is weather.
- **Lestrand (grove-talkers).** A frontier curiosity. A door-keeper on the docks is a migrant or a story. The Settling will stamp a Struck's terms and call the kin-name poetry. Useful, if someone needs a drowning-stone found. Not a rival for the quay.
- **Threnmaieth (the Unreached).** Filed as a gap: people who were not at a proper Tree, doors the roll cannot name. A Kin-speaker in the core is rare and interesting to a crown-archivist. The census wants a column. The land is not a column. Pressure, not a hunt.

## The host of a dying guest

Someone decides whether a sickening graft is a *guest in the grove* or a *Tree the town failed*.

The Road-hand arrives with leave and soil-science. The door-keeper arrives with grandparents and food. Both can be right about the wood. The years the grove spends arguing are years children walk to a neighbour's canopy, Kept-heavy, Struck-heavy, which the frontier already knows as weather, and which Vaethorn will sanctify as unworthiness if no one says otherwise.

This is not a queue. The Seat's scion-queue is the Orenhael's injustice. Theirs is *who is host*, and *who will stand for the Struck the town will not*. A kind Mother, if she is there, would not make the grafts first, and would not make a closed door a slight. The grievance stays: the grafts *are* late; the Motherfaith *did* talk as if becoming were new.

## Economy of the house

- **Meals and walking.** A door-keeper eats at the boards they speak for. No stipend from a seat. A famous one is housed because three valleys would be ashamed not to.
- **No Cutting-leave, no fee.** They do not sell wood. If a Guest-reading town wants a scion, that coin goes to the Seat, not to the Kin-speaker. A First-reading district that pays a Cutting-leave and still refuses the blessing is doing both courtesies at once, and will argue about it after.
- **Standing for the Struck is unpaid.** The ones who most need a kin-name are the ones a town will not house. Some door-keepers spend a year on one person. Some cannot. Both are of the house.

They are not the Tithe-infrastructure sector. Garden-commons and ranging-commons live there. A Taken-In door-keeper may *live* in a green. They do not licence it.

## Left tied to an ailing graft

In an old Taken-In green, the week a Road-hand's cart was seen at the ford. Two hands; one knife-cut for the string.

*The tree is young. The grove is not. We have fed it as a guest and we will feed it still. If you have come with leave, come to the meal first. If you have come with a second cut in mind, know that the hill already yielded a child this year and does not owe you a colour. We will not let either wood pretend it was first.*

On its face: frontier courtesy, a little barbed, the drowning-stone saying reused as a note on a trunk. The Road-hand who eats first will plant as a guest. The one who cuts without the meal will be remembered as a claiming, and the wood may still take.

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## The Table-Keepers

The working people of the Open Table, hill-hosts on Kumbaan. They are almost not clergy. A Yumboe abroad keeping an attic is how the faith travels, rarely. The storm-shore is a different isle job: the Shore-Sitters.

Mainland everyday: **table-keepers**, also **hill-hosts**. Own-name: **the Njaalo** (NJAHL-lo), a Yumboe coinage in the night-keeping tongue, "the hall that is kept." Not Maiethren; this house owes the liturgy nothing. Sailors say **moon-hosts**. Vaethorn has them as a sailor's tale. Lestrang says **the Moon-Feast people** when a quay wants a story. Threnmaieth does not file them. They are off the map.

**In one sentence:** they are the person who opens the hall (or the attic) and lays an extra place. On Kumbaan that is how a valley eats and how a stranger becomes kin. On the mainland it is one room, one supper, and a sentence the quay will not enforce.

## Shape of the order

- **Almost not an order.** Ndeyaan has no chapel, no college, no colour-authority, no graft, no book, no door-walk that wants a title. The person whose hall the valley comes to on the bright nights is a table-keeper. Reputation, not office. When they die, the valley comes to the next hall that still sets the extra place.

- **One job.** Keep the table. Lay the extra place. Say, on the second sitting, *no one is a stranger twice*. That is the whole lintel. There is no second office to promote into.
- **No seat across the sea, no mission.** A Yumboe who wants a hill-hall on Strandoren keeps Ndeyaan in whatever room they have. They do not send for a scion, a stamp, or a Night Watch. The mainland does not send wardens to Kumbaas. The storm-wall is the boundary.
- **A hospitality-house.** Not a fairy-bargain and not a Kind-guild. The unseen hands (the isle's household helpers, who fetch and pour) are furniture, not a geas. A human who has sat twice and will lay the place is of the table. A Yumboe who will not is just a neighbour who sleeps through the bright night. Recruits by faith, not by Kind.

## If you meet one

On Kumbaas a table-keeper looks like the person whose hill-hall the valley already knows. Small, pearl-pale, silver-haired if they are Yumboe (most are, because that is who lives there). They open the door on the bright nights. By mainland noon they are often asleep. You would not call them a priest. You would go to their hall when the moon is up because that is where the food is and where a stranger is allowed to sit.

On the mainland they look like one person in a rented room who still sets a place no body will use. A sailor finds them by asking for the Moon-Feast. A clerk finds them by following a rumour and then files them as a guest. They cook. They pour. They say the sentence on the second night.

They are useful the way a host is useful. They do not water Trees, stamp books, or walk drowning-stones. If you came for those jobs you have the wrong house.

## Who comes, and when

| Who                                          | Why they come                                                          | What the table-keeper does                                                                                                                                          | What they will not do                                                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The valley, on a bright night (Kumbaan)      | The moon is up; the hall is where you eat                              | Open the hall. Lay the extra place <i>slightly back from the board</i> , not at the end. Let the unseen hands fetch and pour. Sing. Sleep when the moon is down.    | Will not read a colour. Will not test a guest. Will not omit the extra place.                                                 |
| A stranger who crossed the storm-wall        | They have already been through drowning-water; they need a seat        | First night: guest (already sacred). Feed them. Learn a name if they offer one. Second night: say <i>no one is a stranger twice</i> and treat them as of the table. | Will not make them Turn. Will not ask what they <i>are</i> . Will not sell the sentence as a proverb.                         |
| Anyone at an ordinary supper                 | The extra place is every meal that matters, not only the feast         | Set it. A poor house still sets it. The hands make the extra possible.                                                                                              | Will not count the household as the bodies you can see. That is the one impiety.                                              |
| A guest on the mainland (attic)              | They heard of a Moon-Feast; they are hungry; they are curious          | Same two sittings, smaller room. Feed them. Say the sentence on the second night. Treat them as kin <i>inside the room</i> .                                        | Will not walk them to a warden to be filed as belonging. Will not stamp a book. Will not collect for a hall across the water. |
| A rare Struck on the isle                    | A drowning, a death, a green taking, uncommon enough to be family news | Feed them. Keep them in the household. Do not make a class of them.                                                                                                 | Will not invent a mainland receiving-rite. Will not send them to a Tree that is not there.                                    |
| A warden, a Book-hand, a Watcher who crossed | Courtesy, curiosity                                                    | They are a guest. First night, second night. The host will find their noon-faith <i>loud</i> .                                                                      | Will not give them a Tree to tend, a book to stamp, or a Night Watch to keep. There is nothing here for those jobs.           |

## A bright night on Kumbaan

Dusk. The table-keeper opens the hill-hall, often because it was their grandmother's, often because it was the only roof that still fitted the crowd. People arrive as the moon clears the Paps. The extra place is already set, slightly back, a little apart. The unseen hands begin to fetch and pour; you can see the cups move. Songs. No colour-reading. No terms recited. A Staying host says the dead's names when they fill that place. A Serving host does not, and still fills it.

The table-keeper's work in the hour: open, set, greet, keep the extra place from being used as a spare stool, send a child for more bread if the hands have not already gone, say the sentence if someone is sitting their second night. When the moon goes down they sleep. Daylight is not a fallen hour. It is the Sabbath of sleep.

They do not confirm becoming. There is no Leaf-Fall on the isle. They do not vouch a Struck in the mainland sense; Struck are rare enough to be a family matter, not a class. They do not licence, graft, or file.

## An ordinary supper

The extra place is not only feast-furniture. A poor house lays it on a quiet night. To omit it is the one real impiety. The staying do not starve. Omitting the place means you have counted the household too small. The hands make this possible. That is not a metaphor they use. It is why a table-keeper can host beyond their means without becoming a Tithe-charity.

A child of the house learns the work by carrying dishes and by being told not to sit in the extra place. That is the apprenticeship. There is no Seat to confirm it.

## An attic on Lestrand

A Yumboe on the mainland is a table-keeper **by necessity**. Morning (their night-end): they may work a quay kitchen, mend, copy, rent in the local coin. Evening: they lay the extra place in a room that fits four. Someone climbs the stair. First night they are a guest. Second night the host says the sentence and means it. The quay will not file the guest as a citizen. The host will still set them a place the third night.

This is how the faith travels, when it travels at all. It does not travel as a mission. There is no Njaalo chapter-house, no collection, no Road-hand of the moon. A second Yumboe in the same city may share a supper and not share a roof. Both are of the table. A mainlander who has sat twice and opened their *own* room is of the table too.

## The second sitting

The first night you are a guest (and a guest is already sacred). The second, you are of the table. On Kumbaan this is how a stranger becomes kin, nearly law, in all but parchment. On the mainland this collides with citizenship-by-witness: you belong because your town *watched you Turn*, not because you ate twice.

A table-keeper who treats the second supper as belonging is doing their faith honestly. A warden who smiles and files them as a guest is doing *theirs*. Neither is a villain. The sentence does not cross the storm-wall intact. The host's job, abroad, is to keep the sentence *inside the room* and not pretend the clerk will honour it.

## What they carry

An extra plate. Songs. The sentence. On the isle, a hall (inherited, or the one that still fits). On the mainland, rent and whatever the room will hold. No stamp. No token from a land-door. No colour-scrap. No Cutting-leave.

The extra place is set slightly back from the board, not at the end. A mainlander who puts it at the foot "for a servant" is corrected. No sermon. The plate is moved.

## What they refuse

- They will not read a colour, tend a Tree, or keep a Night Watch.
- They will not turn the sentence into a Fair Hand term or a geas. Eat, and be the household. Not *sign, and owe*.
- They will not test a guest. The storm-wall already did.
- They will not send a mission, collect for a hall across the water, or plant a Moon-Feast chapter in Vaethorn.
- They will not omit the extra place to look poorer or more devout. That is the one impiety.

## Who may keep a table

**Not by Kind.** A mainlander who sits once is a guest; who sits twice is kin. A human, a Selkie, a Kitsune who will lay the extra place is of the Njaalo. A Yumboe who will not is not. There is no good-people-only order.

**By practice first.** You are a table-keeper when the valley (or the attic-stair) comes to you, and you set the place. There is no apprenticeship confirmed by a Seat. A child who has carried dishes on the bright nights is being watched. A mainland convert who has sat twice and opened their own room is being watched by whoever they fed.

**The schism does the dishes.** A Staying host will say the dead's names. A Serving host will not, and will call the hands the hill's own courtesy. Both set the extra place. Both pass the same cup. The argument is for after.

**Condition leans, not Condition-gates, and on Kumbaan, barely a lean.**

| Act                    | Often                          | Why                                                                                                                       | Also, and welcome                                                                       |
|------------------------|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hill-hall on the isle  | whoever inherited the hall     | no Given Conditions on Kumbaan; Kind is Yumboe <i>because that is who lives there</i> , not because the order requires it | a rare Struck who still hosts; a mainlander who stayed after the second sitting         |
| Attic on the mainland  | a Yumboe abroad (by necessity) | they are still keeping Ndeyaan with whatever table they can make                                                          | a mainland convert who sat twice; a Kept clerk who likes the night better than the Tree |
| Laying the extra place | anyone of the table            | the one impiety is omitting it                                                                                            | the poor house as much as the deep-hill hall                                            |

The feared-licensed are not barred and almost never arise on the isle. A Phoenix is not a host the Njaalo have a rite for. A Bound who sits twice is kin; their Terms are not a grace said over the plate.

Struck table-keepers on the mainland must still be vouched anew if they want to *stay* in a town. The second supper will not satisfy a Watchful clerk. That collision is the house's weather abroad, not a failure of hospitality.

## How they live with the other houses

| House             | Everyday arrangement                                                                                                            | The hard edge                                                                                          |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| the Tree-Wardens  | Almost no contact. A warden who crosses the storm-wall is a guest at supper. There is no Tree to tend.                          | None that matters. No mission-chapter on Kumbaen. No moon-warden on the mainland.                      |
| the Watchers      | A Watcher who crossed would find the night already kept, for a different reason.                                                | No Night Watch on the isle.                                                                            |
| the Book-Hands    | A Settler who sits twice has been called kin in a language with no book.                                                        | Do not turn the sentence into a term.                                                                  |
| the Door-Keepers  | Ancestor-meals and a place set look like cousins to a traveller. They are not. The dead in the ground are not the unseen hands. | The isle is not a grove.                                                                               |
| the Shore-Sitters | Sister house. They sit the storm-beach. A living wreck they walk uphill; they do not seat on the sand.                          | A Table-Keeper does not go down to wait. The sand decides <i>alive</i> ; the hall decides <i>kin</i> . |

## How they live in the three corners (and off the map)

The three-corner lever barely reaches here. That is the theology.

- **Kumbaen (hill-hosts).** Home weather. The Njaalo is just *who opened the hall*. The moon, not the solstice. Wholeness is the default. No queue, no roll, no book, no second reading.
- **Lestrand (the Moon-Feast people).** A quay-story. An attic-host is a curiosity and a good supper. “No one is a stranger twice” is printed, by sailors, as a proverb on a card. The Settling will not enforce it. The attic-host will, inside the room, and cannot outside it.
- **Vaethorn (a sailor’s tale).** Hot faith, thin reach: a table-keeper is a wonder if they ever arrive, and a test of Guest-reading courtesy. They will be fed. They will be asked about the Mother. They will not understand why a people need to be *chosen* in order to be wanted.
- **Threnmaieth (off the map).** Not on the roll. A Yumboe in the Sacred Core is a diplomatic incident of manners, not a column. The crown cannot file a people who were never at a Tree. That is a relief and a slight at once.



## The sentence that will not travel

On Kumbaan, the second sitting is how you belong. On the mainland, you belong because a town watched you Turn.

A table-keeper abroad who treats the second supper as kin-making is not naive. They are keeping Ndeyaan. The warden, the clerk, the Book-hand who smiles and files them as a guest are not cruel. They are keeping *their* grammar. The sentence does not cross the storm-wall intact. A Tree on the isle would not make “wanted” into a gift the good people were missing. Their claim, *we were never lacking*, stays. The injustice that can be played *now* is smaller and sharper: hospitality that is nearly law on one side of the water is a proverb on the other, and romanticizing the Moon-Feast is itself a slight.

They have no scion-queue. They have no novation-fade. They have no recut lintel. An attic-host is one person, analog supper, no authority outside the room.

## Economy of the house

- **The hall is the living.** On Kumbaan a table-keeper is fed by the same feast they host. The unseen hands make a poor house’s extra place possible. There is no stipend, no Cutting-leave, no pilgrimage-share.
- **An attic pays rent in the local coin.** A Yumboe abroad works as anyone works. They are not a charity-order and not Tithe-infrastructure. They may cook for a quay. They do not furnish a venting-hall.
- **No collection for a hall across the water.** That would be a mission. There isn’t one.

## A place-card

Badly copied by a Strandor sailor who did come back, and sold on a Lestrand quay as a dinner-grace. The verso is the sailor’s own hand: “for luck at second sitting.”

*We have counted you. Sit. If you have a name we have not learned it yet; if you have a colour we have no tree to read it. The moon is enough light. Eat, and be the household. And if you sit again, you are not a stranger. This is not a proverb. Do not sell it as one.*

On its face: hospitality, almost twee, already half-ruined by the quay-copy. The last two lines are the table-keeper’s, added when she saw him copy the blessing; he sold them anyway. The card is how Lestrand files the Njaalo: a Moon-Feast story, lucky if you eat twice. The woman in the attic still sets the place.

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# The Shore-Sitters

A second Kumbaan house. Isle flavor, not a mainland order. The Table-Keepers open the hall. These sit the storm-beaches. Almost no one reaches the isle; *someone* has to be there when the almost happens.

Everyday: **shore-sitters**, also **wall-waiters**. Own-name: **Njawaal** (njah-WAHL), a Yumboe coinage, “the sitting at the wall.” Not Maiethren. Table-keepers call them **the first night**, half a joke: a wreck is not yet kin.

**In one sentence:** they sit the storm-shore with their back to the hill-hall and wait. They do not swim the wall, they do not test anyone with a colour, and if someone is still breathing they walk them uphill to a table.

## If you meet one

A small person on a bad beach, lamp hooded so it does not call ships in. They look like they have been there a long time. They will not wade. They will take a living mainlander by the sleeve and start the path up. They will name a drowned body if the house leans Staying, or they will not, if it leans Serving, and they will still carry the body above the tide.

You would not call them a priest. You would find them if you asked *who sits the black sand when the wall is loud*.

## What they actually do

- **Sit.** Storm nights, wreck-moons, the weeks after a crossing rumor. One person per stretch if the coast is kept at all. Reputation, not a roster.
- **Receive.** Living: water, a blanket, no questions about Kind or colour. Dead: above the tide. Cargo: what the hall can use. They do not loot for a market. There is no quay.
- **Hand uphill.** The living go to a table-keeper. First night as *guest* starts at the hall, not on the sand. The shore-sitter is why there was a first night.
- **Refuse the wall.** They do not swim out. They do not keep a boat for rescue. The wall is not a door they walk. A mainlander who asks *why didn't you come for me sooner* is told *we do not call the sea. We wait*.

They do not keep the extra place (that is the hall). They do not Speak, stamp, or walk old mainland doors. They do not send anyone back across.

## Who comes

Almost no one. That is the theology. A shore-sitter's year may be empty. The job is still to sit. When someone does come, the whole valley hears it as news, not as a shipping schedule.

## How they sit with the table-keepers

Same faith, two jobs. The shore decides *alive*. The hall decides *kin*. A shore-sitter who starts laying the extra place on the sand has started doing the other house's work. A table-keeper who walks the black sand every storm has started doing this one. Both can happen in a thin year. Most years they are different people.

## Said to a sailor who did come back

The night before he was walked uphill. Copied later as a quay-story, badly.

*We did not fetch you. The wall does not owe you a hand. Sit until you can walk. If you walk, there is a hall. If you do not, we will still take you off the sand. Do not thank the sea. It was not kind. We were only here.*

On its face: cold courtesy. The sailor heard a rescue. It was a wait.

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## The Slide

The lived face of illicit Tithe-supply. Not a fifth faith, not clergy. A shadow house for the week you cannot pay. They do not help you *pay* a Tithe. They **own the moment you start to fail**, and they make failure useful.

Everyday: **the Slide**, also **week-keepers**. Cant: **the Vaethledd** (VAYTH-led). *vaeth* "the waiting" + *ledd* "to reckon": the waiting, reckoned. Vaethorn says **the last pot** (or *gift-credit*, when the commons have run out). Lestrang says **week-rent** the way it says landlord. Threnmaith files nothing; the roll already has a counted hall. A clerk who knows will say **the late week**.

**In one sentence:** they rent you *not falling*. One week of green, one outlet, one new page, and they are never in a hurry to let you get free.

They do not rewrite Bound Terms, steal scions, or sell a false Turning-witness.

## Shape of the house

- **A practice, not a gang.** There is no seat, no colour, no roster, no cellar liturgy. You are of the Slide when someone comes back next week. Reputation. When they die, the book of weeks goes to whoever still has a pot, a room, or a key.
- **One job.** Furnish *just enough* Tithe-supply that the person does not become a public hazard, and *never enough* that they recover. The product is the week. The price is remaining theirs.
- **They think they are in a rent story.** They do not call themselves monsters. They extend. They keep a book. They will tell you they kept someone whole. A kind face, a real key, a measured withhold later.
- **Not clergy and not the official halls.** They do not stamp books, Speak colours, walk old doors, or open a hill-hall. They do not run the town greenhouse, the counted ael-hall, or a licence-guild. Those wait. The guilds will pretend not to know these people. That pretending is already part of the town.

## If you meet one

They look like a landlord. A cousin who still has a pot after the commons ran dry. A junior clerk at a deathless house who will extend a novelty subscription one more week. A person with a spare room and a voice who will let you cry there, for a price that is never quite coin.

You would not call them a priest. You would find them if you asked *who still has green when the leaf-lot is closed*.

They are useful the way a week is useful. If you came for a stamp, a colour, or a false childhood, you have the wrong house.

## Who comes, and when

| Who                                    | Why they come                                                        | What the week-keeper does                                                       | What they will not do                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A Taken-In cut off from land           | The greens-queue is longer than the wilt                             | Rent a pot, a strip, a night on living dirt. Extend if the week cannot be paid. | Will not give them a commons-share that lasts. Will not walk them to a warden to be filed as housed.                  |
| A Far-Voiced who lost a stage          | Isolated posting, dull labor, nowhere to vent; the Cry is close      | A room, an hour, a door that shuts. One outlet. The next week is the same week. | Will not find them honest work. Will not let the Cry happen in the street. That brings the watch, and ruins the book. |
| A Long-Lived whose novelty has thinned | The endowment is late; the fade has started                          | A page, a letter, a gossip that is <i>new enough</i> . Rationed.                | Will not endow a library. Will not be their deathless patron in public.                                               |
| An Unbound losing warmth               | Company costs; the hole is getting loud                              | Sit with them. Be known, a little. Charge the sitting.                          | Will not be family. Will not sign them a new Bargain. That is another table.                                          |
| A Bound behind on <i>civic</i> coin    | Rent, a guild fee, a year that will not close                        | Hold the debt. Extend. Use the hold.                                            | <b>Will not rewrite Terms.</b> Money, not a clause. Will not sell a cellar-easing.                                    |
| A Returned whose Purpose pays nothing  | The work the dead want is not a trade                                | A week of keep so they can keep walking.                                        | Will not furnish the Purpose. Will not send them to a plague-ward unless the ward pays <i>them</i> .                  |
| A family, before the town sees         | A child or a parent is sliding; they will pay so the square does not | Take the week. Take the family's coin. Keep the person <i>quiet</i> .           | Will not tell the warden. Will not make the slide a sermon.                                                           |

## An ordinary week

They **extend first**. That is the hook, and it is also what they believe about themselves. A person arrives already late. The week-keeper does not withhold on the first night. They open the lot, the room, the page. They write *extended*. They name a day.

The withhold comes later, and it is measured. Never enough to make a public hazard (a wilt in the square, a Cry in the market, a fade a neighbour can name), because that brings the watch, the guild, the counted hall, and the book dies. Never enough to let the person stand up and walk to a commons that would keep them. The asset is a person who is always almost whole.

They keep a **book of weeks**, not a ledger of coin. Coin is how some weeks are paid. The thing they are counting is *how long you have not fallen, on their floor*.

A child of the house learns the work by carrying water to the pots and by being told not to let a guest sleep a second week for nothing. There is no Seat to confirm it.

## What they carry

A key. A pot, a spare room, a stack of pages that are new enough. A book of weeks. No stamp. No colour-scrap. No Cutting-leave. No false witness to sell in the square.

## What they refuse

- They will not pretend to be clergy. No colour, no book-stamp, no door-walk, no extra place.
- They will not rewrite a Bound's Terms. They may hold a Bound's *rent*. That is money.
- They will not steal a scion or sell *I watched you Turn*.
- They will not push someone over the scary edge on purpose. A corpse, a public Cry, a wilt the town can see: a ruined week and a ruined name.
- They will not run a mission, a cellar-church, or a Kumbaan export. There is almost no Tithe on the isle to own.
- They will not call the week a gift. They will also not call it a cruelty. They call it a week.

## Who may keep a week

**Not by Kind.** A human, a Kitsune, a Selkie, a Tengu who has a pot and a book can be of the Slide. A Yumboe abroad who has started charging for the extra place has started a *different* sin; send them back to the Table-Keepers.

**By practice first.** You are of the Slide when someone comes back next week, and you still have the key. There is no apprenticeship confirmed by anyone. A cousin who extended once and then let the person recover was kind. They are not of this house.

**Condition leans, not Condition-gates.**

| Act                             | Often                                             | Why                                    | Also, and welcome                                                          |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A pot, a strip, a night of dirt | a Taken-In who kept a private lot                 | they already furnish green             | a Kept with a window-box and no Tithe of their own                         |
| A shut room, an hour of voice   | a Far-Voiced with a spare hall                    | they already know what an outlet costs | a performer who lost the honest stage and kept the door                    |
| A page that is new enough       | a Long-Lived clerk, a junior at a deathless house | novelty is already their weather       | anyone who can still find a rumour the fade has not heard                  |
| The book of weeks itself        | whoever can read a late face                      | the house is the count, not the crop   | a Kept broker, unencumbered, can move, can carry the book to the next town |

The feared-licensed are not barred. A Stilled who rents stillness-hours is rare and tightly watched. A Bound who holds civic debt is money, not a Counterparty.

## How they live with the other houses

| House                     | Everyday arrangement                                                                                      | The hard edge                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| the Tree-Wardens          | Almost no contact. A warden furnishes a Tree, not a week.                                                 | A Road-hand is not a week-cart. A scion is not Tithe-pay.                                                                    |
| the Watchers              | A Watcher who sat an eve-vigil is not in this book.                                                       | They do not sell a false watch.                                                                                              |
| the Book-Hands            | A Settler who marked <i>owing</i> has just made a customer. The clerk will watch them walk down the quay. | The Slide does not stamp. The clerk does not furnish. The Bound they cannot help is still not this house's Terms to rewrite. |
| the Door-Keepers          | A Struck named <i>kin</i> at a door still has a Tithe. Kinship is not green.                              | A drowning-stone is not a rented lot.                                                                                        |
| the Table-Keepers         | No contact that matters. The second sitting is not a week.                                                | They do not charge for the extra place. That is a different faith's one impiety.                                             |
| Official halls and greens | The official hall, the counted green, the licence. The town is glad someone "takes the late ones."        | The guilds are the public good / the crown's channel / the posted market. The Slide is who they pretend not to know.         |

## How they live in the three corners (and off the map)

- **Vaethorn (the last pot).** Home weather for the pious version. The commons ran out. A cousin still has a pot. They will say they are tending a gift. The quiet obligation is the week: you are helped, and you are theirs. Subsidy already shades into conscription in the Warm; this is that shade, private.
- **Lestrand (week-rent).** Ordinary. Posted, almost. A leaf-lot by the season is already the honest market. The Slide is the lot that will still open after the season-fee failed, at a price that is the next season. No sermon. A landlord.
- **Threnmaith (the late week).** The crown already holds Tithe. The Slide does not compete with the counted hall on ordinary days. They sell the week the hall is late, the extra green the roll does not cover, the novelty the archive will not release. They look like a clerk. The crown's injustice is cold and precise; this is the leak it cannot file without admitting the channel failed. The roll pretends not to know.
- **Kumbaan.** No. Almost no Given Tithes. A wreck walked uphill is a guest, not a debtor.

## The week that will not end

Whoever furnishes a provided-for Tithe holds power over its bearer. The Slide is that lever with a face, and with a patience the official hall is not allowed.

The town is glad. A person who is *quietly* almost-falling is not a Cry in the market. The Warm can say the gift is still being tended. The Watchful can say the channel held. The quay can say the owing was marked and someone took them in.

A kind Mother, if she is there, does **not** make the week fair. The need is the Tithe. People built the book of weeks.

They have no scion-queue. They have no novation. They have no sentence that will not travel. This house's constraint is the measured week: analog, one key, no authority except the one the Tithe gives them.

Off-book Bound brokerage and sold vouching still exist as nameless underside. They are **not** this house.

## Economy of the house

- **The week is the living.** Paid in coin, in labor, in a favor, in a child sent to carry water. The book counts weeks first.
- **They are not a charity-order and not Tithe-infrastructure.** A town greenhouse, a counted ael-hall, an endowed long-house of books: those are the official sector. A week-keeper may sit next to all three and take the overflow.



- **Deathless proximity.** A junior at a long-house who rations novelty is how ossification feels at street level: not a century loan, a page at a time. The house does not *run* the bank.
- **No collection for a hall across the water.** There isn't one.

## A week-slip

Lestrand leaf-lot, pinned inside a door that still opens after the season-fee has failed. The verso is the same slip, last week, the date scratched once.

*One week of the lot. Extended. Do not let the pot dry. If you cannot come, send a child. The week is the same week. We do not call this a gift. We do not call it a debt. Come before the leaves turn. If you have already turned, come anyway.*

On its face: a landlord being practical, almost kind. Underneath: the product is *not falling*, and the blindness the writer cannot afford. They think they refused the Mother's word. They also refused the word *debt*, which is how the book stays a book of weeks and never quite closes. "If you have already turned, come anyway" is the house's whole case: becoming did not save you from needing them. The child who carries water is learning the trade.

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## The Holding Desk

Everyday: **the Holding Desk**, also **hold-clerks**. Lestrand says it the way it says *extension*. Vaethorn has no clean word and calls it **the second signing** when a preacher wants a sin. Threnmaieth files nothing.

They are not the Slide. They do not rent green, an hour, or a page. They work in **clauses**.

A Bound finishes a civic year at an honest table. The year is payable. The **Terms** are not. Fear of the Pledge starts the next ask. The hold-clerk names a smaller Term that covers the larger one for a season. That is the pipeline. Each signing eats more of the person. The last signing is the Given-Over — the Forfeit, in guild speech. The law has never decided when the person on the stool stopped being one.

**Mutelo of the Lower Slip** (*moo-TEL-o*) keeps the oldest chair on Orentel. They will tell you they kept a person walking. The book on the shelf is labelled *extensions*. The last page is not.

They will not rent a Tithe-week. They will not sell *I watched you Turn*. They will not rewrite a Term the Counterparty has already named. They add a Term. The distinction is how they sleep.

## The Standing Trade

Citizenship is witnessed, not recorded. Proof at a distance is a **mouth**. The unvouched will buy one.

Everyday: **the Standing Trade**. A buyer says **a standing**. A seller says **I was there** and means they will be, later, in a square that was not theirs. Lestrang prices it. Vaethorn calls it **false kin**. Threnmaieth does not need it on ordinary days — the roll already stands — and wants it badly when a name is missing.

They are not the Slide. They do not rent a week. They are not the Holding Desk. They do not write a Term. The product is a person who will stand and say they watched.

**Nomele of the Hinge** (*no-MEL-eh*) works the Old Crossing face — the Hinge Shore more often than Orentel, because a hinge has two sides and a standing has to travel. They do not sell paper. They sell who will walk with you to the next Tree.

The market fails in public when a sold mouth will not answer a Far-Voiced call, or when an honest Long-Lived is asked to Blood-Read the seller.

## The Reckoned Offices

Everyday: **the Reckoned Offices**, or just **the tablet offices**. They are not a church and not a sixteenth power. They are four jobs the Tallied Crown already had, now with names a party can find. Seat: the tablet-hall at Maiethlir — not the grove, not the First Seat. Rithim is still town Speaker. These offices are the roll's mouths. The gap is the play.

| Mouth                                  | Job              | What they want                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Menirein</b> ( <i>men-EE-rayn</i> ) | registrar        | the roll complete. An unlisted child is a child the crown cannot keep hale.                          |
| <b>Tarvae</b> ( <i>TAR-vay</i> )       | Reckoned Speaker | Speaking and filing to stay one act. A colour Spoken and not written is a seeing that can be stolen. |
| <b>Videm</b> ( <i>VEE-dem</i> )        | channel-clerk    | the counted hall, the tended green, the hour that matches the name.                                  |
| <b>Sirtal</b> ( <i>SIR-tal</i> )       | warrant-hand     | a channel that can be shut until the name sits still.                                                |

They recruit by office and practice, not by Kind. Long-Lived memory is common at the tablet and is bent to the census rather than free to check it.

## The Pourers

Everyday: **the Pourers**, also **the Cup Circle**. Neighbours say **the five-year cup** with the smile you use for a rich uncle's hobby. The Motherfaith calls it private tending. The Fair Hand will not stamp it — there is no Counterparty they can see.

They are Long-Lived who keep a cup and say they poured years into it so the rest of a deathless life can still be walked. This is not a sixth Turning. No colour falls. No warden Speaks it. They are not one of the five lived faiths.

**Molevad** (*mo-LEV-ad*) keeps the minutes of the best-known circle, on a long-house shelf in Lestrand library country. They look five years emptier and still themselves. They will tell you they invented the listener. The face on the cup changes. The clause does not: years go in; knowledge is kept; the cup does not Give a leaf and does not catch a death.

Reimaethe on the rise in Orentel poured four years into a cup and wants to stop before the fifth. Neighbours call it a hobby. That is the public fact.

## The Walled Book and the Inner Close

Everyday: **the Walled Book**. The class that keeps it: **the Closed Heirs**. The place: **Rothallo** (*roh-THAL-oh*), Orenbren's walled capital, one day's walk from the Motherwood. People still say **the Inner Close**, and **the Close**. The walls answer to those names. It is the same city. It stays inside Orenbren. It is not a second town and not a sixteenth great power. Orenbren treats the walls as a guest-compact that never opened. Threnmaieth treats them as a roll that will not share ink. The First Seat stays in the wood. Rothallo is not the college.

This is **political class rule**, not a church. They do not Speak colours. They **classify**. Folk still say there was an older empire of the untithed, and that it sat on the grove. They are right as far as a gate that grew a country. Everyday historical name: **the Closed Seat**. The walls are what is left.

**Delamem** (*del-AH-mem*) keeps the Book of Tithes. They will tell you the Book is housekeeping. The page that assigns labour is in the same hand as the page that assigns a hearth-tax. **Talnin of the Inner Close** (*TAL-nin*) is a Closed Heir of the present generation. The name is on the heir-roll. The tenth year is not finished.

A Closed child Given at the next Leaf-Fall is the house's fear. Threnmaieth copying the Book onto the Threnhael is the other.

## The Protectors (as the square knows them)

Everyday, when anyone speaks of them: **the Protectors**. The building the world is allowed to know: **the Care**. A hospice-endowment. Old money. A closed court. The story that travels is that the one Phoenix is being kept safe, and that is why no town has seen them in a generation.

Doctrine says there cannot be two. The Care still “holds the Phoenix.” A white-fire fall Spoken far away is filed as a mis-Speaking or a hush.

**Vimein** (*vih-MAYN*) keeps the outer book of the Care. They will say the Phoenix is in care. They will not produce them. They will offer a viewing of the closed court, a hymn that does not name a Mother, and a request that you not carry a story back to a square that has finally gone quiet.

You would take them for a hospice clerk. You would be right about the building.

What a neighbour can see: a hospice that endows its own heat and light; letters from wardens that do not come back answered; a generation of squares that talk about the Phoenix in the past tense and the present tense in the same sentence.

How the Care stays warm is not this chapter. Book X, if the campaign arrives there.

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BOOK IV

## How People Live

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# Law and Citizenship

You belong because your town *saw* you Turn.

Every child passes through their town Turning Tree in their tenth year, and the whole town is there to watch. The Leaf-Fall is the most-attended day of a community's year: kin, neighbours, the tree-wardens, all gathered. They *see* the leaf fall on a child, or see the Tree hug them.

So citizenship in the Turning is **witnessed, not recorded**. You are of a place because that place *remembers you*. It watched you become who you are.

There is no register of the people. No town, church, or crown keeps a list of everyone and their gift. That would be to hold a record *on* people. Belonging is living communal memory, the way a real village knows its own, not a ledger. The one kingdom that *does* keep such a list is a notorious exception: Threnmaith, the Tallied Crown. It reads as unsettling because no one else does it.

This is also a Hands-era default. In the Walking Years the town that saw you Turn was the crowd under Thaeloren, or no one, if you never arrived. Vouching-at-a-distance exists to *carry that origin-witness home*.

In a village the witness is the whole settlement. In a city it is a **hearth** — a street, a quay-gang, a courtyard, a guild-stair — not twenty thousand mouths pretending to remember one child. The legal fact does not change.

## Turning in a city: the hearth stood

A village of three hundred can remember every child. A salt-city of tens of thousands cannot. Witnessed citizenship does not become a register at that scale. It becomes **nested**.

The Tree is still at the centre. Turning-Week is still the week's door. The square is still full. The legal fact is not "Orentel saw you." The legal fact is **your hearth stood**.

A hearth, here, is eighty to two hundred mouths who already know the child. They bring their ten-year-olds in a named slot of the week. The warden Speaks the colour or names the hug. The city as a crowd saw a crowd. The hearth saw a child.

One **pillar** of that hearth — a Long-Lived, a Bound, or a Far-Voiced who stood — carries the memory when a far desk asks. Kin and neighbours carry it first; the pillar is how the stand *travels*. An orphan is

still brought by kin, by the household that feeds them, or by the warden-hearth. A child no hearth will bring is a miss, same as in a village.

To prove you are of a city is to **name a hearth** and produce someone of it, or a pillar who stood. “I am of the third quay” is a citizenship sentence. “I am of Orentel” is geography.

Threnmaieth writes the stand down. That is still the aberration. Everyone else keeps the week-slate as hours, not as gifts.

## How you prove who you are: by *people*, not papers

The Turning never needed to invent the papers-and-registers state, because trust runs through people who cannot be faked.

You are known by **witnesses**, not documents. Common tongue: **standing-for**. Vaethorn calls it *the speaking* (vouched at worship). Lestrang calls it *warranting* (a commercial guarantee). Threnmaieth calls it *the naming* (you are named to the crown).

- A **Long-Lived** remembers you, and their memory is incorruptible and runs back centuries.
- A **Bound** *vouches* for you. A Bound’s sworn word is literally binding, so a false vouch is not a lie they can cheaply tell.
- A **Far-Voiced** speaks for you. Their voice betrays real feeling under strain, so they cannot smoothly lie on your behalf.

To establish yourself in a new place is to **be vouched into it**: to acquire people who will stand for you.

**The friendless and the rootless are the truly vulnerable**, because they have no one to vouch. The law’s exclusions fall not on “the undocumented” but on **the unvouched**, a person no one will stand for.

A traveler is not, by default, that person.

## How a traveler stays vouched

The unvouched remain the vulnerable class. A legitimate traveler is **on a word**, not on a paper-state. The Hands-era road inherited this from vouching-at-a-distance: the origin-witness had to *travel home*. It still does.

A watch that stops a stranger asks three things: **name, last hearth, who stands**. Answer any two and the road continues. Answer none and you are held until dawn, or until someone will stand, or you are walked to the next gate. Routine harassment is for the nameless. A company that can name a last host and show one mark is how this grammar wants people — including a party — to move.

| Custom               | What it is                                                                                                                                                      | What it is not                                                                     |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Road-word</b>     | A named person at origin or last town. “Ask Halim of the third quay.” A Far-Voiced can call; a Bound can send a word; a letter is a token of a mouth.           | A passport. The scrap is worthless if the mouth is dead or will not stand.         |
| <b>Company-vouch</b> | A party stands for each other. One locally known or ticketed member covers the rest <i>for passage</i> .                                                        | Citizenship. You may sleep. You are not of this town.                              |
| <b>Guild-mark</b>    | A stiller’s ticket, a Crae journeyman-mark, a Voice-ticket. Craft marks travel.                                                                                 | A Condition-census. The mark says you may Gaze, work an element, or Cry in a hall. |
| <b>House-note</b>    | Deathless paper. Credit that doubles as a light stand.                                                                                                          | Required. Most walkers have none.                                                  |
| <b>Guest-right</b>   | A host who takes you in stands for the stay. An inn, a table, a road-house. “I ate at X” holds about a week.                                                    | A sold vouch. The host must have taken you in.                                     |
| <b>Walk-custom</b>   | Someone on a named walk (Near Mile, Salt Walk, Long Mile, First-Hand year) is vouched <i>as a walker</i> by the road: mile-shrines, road-houses, a berth-slate. | Permanent belonging. When the walk ends, the word ends.                            |

Struck on the road are vouched-anew at the next desk that will take them (the Intake if the door is hazardous). Changing unwitnessed is still a seam. It is not a crime to have changed.

Sold vouching still exists as a nameless underside. It is not this custom. A sold mouth that will not answer a Far-Voiced call is how the market fails in public.

Kumbaan does not use this system. You do not arrive already vouched. A road-word, a company’s vouch, or a guild-mark still helps you leave a Strandoren quay. None of those make you known on the hill. On the isle, the right to be a guest is the table. A second sitting makes you kin there. It does not become a “last hearth,” the place you name when a mainland watch asks where you slept, that the watch will accept.

## The Struck: those who changed *unwitnessed*

A Struck person acquired their Condition *later, and alone*: a drowning, a death, a sworn contract, long after their tenth-year Turning. The town watched everyone else become who they are. **No one watched the Struck.** They changed with no witnesses.



So a Struck person must be **vouched anew**. The community has to re-know them as what they have become, on the word of those who will stand for them. The old unease that the Struck are “a little suspect” is not only prejudice. Their becoming happened where no one could see it. A change everyone witnessed is trusted; a change that happened in the dark must be spoken for. Every polity has people whose transformation went unwitnessed, and every polity feels differently about that.

Two things make the seam sharper:

- **The dangerous Struck arrive raw.** A Struck Stilled or Far-Voiced manifests *untrained*, with the hazard already live and no guild to have caught it young. For these, being vouched-in is bound up with **mandatory guild-intake**: you are taken in hand *and* apprenticed at once, for everyone’s safety, whether you wanted the vocation or not.
- **Some doors are crimes-adjacent.** The Bound are Struck by a sworn contract; the Returned by dying. To vouch a Bound into a community is to acknowledge a contract no one witnessed being sworn, which is why contract-law and the acceptance of the Bound are tangled together.

Vaethorn’s second word for the Struck is *the late-come* (met at a later door). Lestrاند’s is *the turned* (neutral, a fact). Threnmaieth’s is *the unwitnessed* (suspect until named).

The first hour is care. The person has changed, and nobody has a leaf-colour for them yet. The formal words can wait.

On a quay, the crew hauls the person up, counts the breaths, and does not walk them to the Tree that night. If a clerk opens a book over someone who cannot yet refuse a line, whoever is holding the person’s head shuts the book. In a devout house, the family takes the person inside and does not take them to the Tree’s roots tonight. A sibling who needs to may say “Maieth” over the blanket. Maieth is the short name devout people use for the Leaf-Mother. The person under the blanket is not required to say it. In a waiting town, they get the person dry and, if the person can sit, to the common pot. Nobody names a leaf-colour over the steam. The wet leaf on the town spring is not a sign for this hour. On the Sundering Isle, which is rare, Njunda feeds them. Nobody gives them a test, and nobody tells them the mainland story about the Mother.

If the change came by an oath, take the pen out of the hand until the person can hear the clause they are still agreeing to. If the change came by a death that did not finish, keep them warm, and do not assign the unfinished work that night. Being acknowledged at a Tree, settling their civic standing, or walking them back to an Old Ways door are later days. If they are still inside their tenth year, that is a different problem. Bring them to be welcomed if Turning-Week is still open. Do not stand them up as if the Tree were giving them a second life.

## The Inviolable Will

Beneath all local variation sits one principle every polity treats as the floor of law, and it holds because it is *true*: **no Condition can compel, control, or bend another person's will**. That is the **Inviolable Will**. The Bound's Whisper, the Far-Voiced's Cry, and the Long-Lived's regard cannot cross it: every Condition's danger stops at property, pain, and fear, at the edge of another's choosing. The law mirrors the metaphysics in a maxim taught to every child:

“*The will is one's own.*”

Vaethorn holds it as *the Mother's own line* (scripture). Lestrاند cites *the free-will clause* (sound commercial law). Threnmaieth cites *the crown's assurance* (to justify the roll).

A **Tithe** is the upkeep of a Condition, not a tax to a temple.

- **The old mind-control fears are void in law.** There is no such crime as “being mind-controlled by a vampire,” because it cannot happen. That is the legal floor under treating the Conditioned as neighbours, and everyone knows it.
- **It sorts the criminal code.** Because a Condition cannot seize a will, harm done with one splits into two very different things. **Negligent Tithe-lapse** (letting your element vent, your Cry break, your green go to seed) is a regulatory or public-nuisance matter. **Willful weaponizing** (deliberately turning a gift on someone) is ordinary violent crime, no gentler for the instrument. In practice only the Stilled's gaze even supports a true “you petrified a citizen” charge. Most of what the law fears is negligence, not assault.
- **It is the shield the feared hide behind.** A Bound can point to the Inviolable Will and say, truthfully, *my contract cannot make you do anything*. Whether a given polity *listens* is where they diverge.

## The safety-licence: how hazard is regulated (and by whom)

The one place the law *does* attach to individuals is public safety, and it does so narrowly. **A ticket attaches to a hazardous use, not to being Conditioned**. The rule of thumb is consistent across the world: **a licence attaches where a practice is *dangerous to others*, never where a gift is merely powerful, and never as a way to keep track of people**. It is the same logic by which any world licenses a few dangerous trades, not a census.

Common tongue: **the ticket**. Vaethorn: *the blessing-to-practice*. Lestrاند: *the guild-ticket*. Threnmaieth: *the crown-warrant*.

The three ticket-Conditions are the Stilled, Far-Voiced, and the Answered (~7 / ~12 / ~10). Together that is **~29% of people, ~39% of the Conditioned** — a large minority who *can* be asked for a ticket if

they practice the hazardous use. It is not “~90% of the Conditioned carry nothing.” It is also not a third of the world on a crown list.

**The pool is not the roll.** A ticket names a competence (stiller, hall-voice, Crae-hand), not a Condition-ID. Three guilds keep no shared roll. The state watches the charter.

| Who                                            | Ticket names                                                                                                                                                | Who is not on it                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>the Stilled — personal Gaze-ticket</b>      | Anyone who Gazes in public: surgeons, riot-lines, demolition. Most stillers hold one, because the vocation is the Gaze.                                     | A Stilled who never Gazes (rare). The guild still wants them in the yard.                                                                      |
| <b>Far-Voiced — Voice-ticket / hall-hour</b>   | Those who Cry in a crowd or keep a scheduled hour: criers, performers, sworn witnesses. Hall-keepers stamp competence and sell the hour at the same lintel. | A field-voice who vents at the hedge. The hall-slate is hours, not a list of every blue-leaf in the city.                                      |
| <b>the Answered — Crae-ticket / yard-leave</b> | Element used in a shop, a yard, a hull. The Crae stamps the craft.                                                                                          | An Answered who never works the element in public.                                                                                             |
| <b>Bound — a table, not a body-ticket</b>      | No licence. The honest table oversees Terms. The Whisper cannot command.                                                                                    | Do not add Bound’s ~5% contract-lane to the licence rate.                                                                                      |
| <b>No ticket</b>                               | —                                                                                                                                                           | Two-Bodied, Long-Lived, Returned, the Taken-In, the Unbound, Phoenix, and all the Kept. About two people in three. They are simply neighbours. |

Active papers in a working city are smaller than the 29% pool — perhaps half of it, fewer on the frontier, where a feared Condition is still as likely to meet a rope as a stool.

Licences are **guild-issued, not state-issued**. A guild *knows its own members* the way any craft guild does. It is not a registry of the population. It is a roster of practitioners of a dangerous art, kept by the art’s own masters. The state *charters* the guild and lets it police its own under threat of losing the charter. So the Stilled’s guild licenses stillers and the element-guilds channel the Answered, while the state watches the guild, not the individual. This diffuses power (no single authority holds the Conditioned) and breeds its own frictions: guilds guard monopolies, tickets become property, and an unlicensed practitioner threatens the guild’s charter as much as the public’s safety.

## Harm, the watch, and the hearing

The Inviolable Will already sorts the charge: **negligent Tithe-lapse** versus **willful weaponizing**. This is the ladder the charge walks. There is no crime of *being* a Condition.

1. **Neighbour-word**. Most harm dies on the street. Restitution, apology, a Bound word if they have one. The watch is not called.
2. **The watch**. Night-watch, ward-watch. Often Kept (untithed nights) and Two-Bodied (the ranging is the Tithe), with a Far-Voiced for the shout. They hold a body until morning. They do not investigate Conditions. They fetch a pillar or a guild.
3. **Guild-hearing**. Tithe-lapse, unlicensed Gaze, an element let go in a shop. The guild fines, suspends a ticket, binds to apprenticeship. The state is not in the room unless the charter is at risk.
4. **Open hearing**. Willful harm. Witnesses — especially the three pillars. The charge is the act. “You Gazed a man” is assault. “You are Stilled” is not a crime. A Gaze used as a forever-hold is the rare charge the Stillers’ own code already names.
5. **What the hearing can do** without writing you down:
  - Restitution — coin, labor, furnish a Tithe you broke
  - Ticket-stripping — you may not practice the dangerous act
  - A Bound word, or a term
  - **Exile from the hearth** — you become unvouched in your own city. This is the civic death. It does not require a file.
  - The rope or the wall — murder, and the rare forever-hold. Commoner on the frontier. Rare in the Warm.

The Watchful write you down. That is their extra punishment, and why they feel like a different country.

The watch is a bench until morning. In a village it is whoever is awake. In Maiethlir it is the Down Gate. In Orentel it is the night-gate on the quay. In Eolvaeth the square watches, and in a send-year the camp-streets watch instead. Threnmaieth’s roll belongs to the clerks. The watch in a Watchful town can be told to hold someone the roll wants. The holding is still until morning unless a clerk comes.

A **cohort** is the group a town sends when its own Hand cannot Turn them this week. Kin, children who are ten, and a warden’s word. It is not a company kept under arms. Eolvaeth has sent one toward Saelvaeth in years when the wood did not do the week’s work. The Mill-hold sends its ten-year-olds toward Brenthael when the Hand is unsound. Between sends, the people are at their stalls. A power does not keep a cohort in the field as its ordinary year. A sent cohort from Eolvaeth stops at the thorn outside the vale and eats before they go on, even when the path is clear. They will not say why.

The Closing left a wall and a book, not a garrison. The wall is Rothallo, Orenbren’s capital, still called the Inner Close. Nobody kept the riders as a host that could be called again. The Hinge Hush left a

rate, a west-water clause, and a refusal to name a winner. It did not leave a fleet. Dock-bells on the Hinge Shore still pause in Hale-month, then go back to work. Netstrand still keeps hulls for hire. A charter is a crossing with a number on it. The fifteen powers do not keep standing armies.

*A door-custom, pinned inside a Lestrand night-gate. No crest. The verso is last week's rain.*

*Name. Last hearth. Who stands. Two will do. None, and you sit the bench until the second bell, or until a mouth comes, or we walk you to the next gate. We do not ask your colour. We do not keep the three answers past dawn. If you are on a walk, say which. If you ate at the bed-house, say so. If you have a ticket, show the stool-mark, not a story. The bench is not a cell. The bench is until morning.*

On its face: a watch being practical. Underneath: the three questions *are* the citizenship engine, run at a gate. They think “we do not ask your colour” makes them unlike Threnmaieth. They also do not write the answers down, which is how a city of tens of thousands still runs on hearths.

## The three pillars: why the Conditioned *are* the legal system

Condition-law is not imposed *on* the Conditioned from outside. Three Conditions **are the legal apparatus itself**, and they are the people who make a register unnecessary:

- **Long-Lived:** incorruptible memory. The archivists, notaries, and judges. A matter of record is whatever they say they witnessed a century ago. Where documents would be forged, a Long-Lived simply *remembers*.
- **Bound:** binding word. A Bound's sworn oath is *literally* binding and they hear a lie as it is told, so they are the witnesses, oath-keepers, and debt-arbiters. **When a treaty must truly hold, a Bound swears it.**
- **Far-Voiced:** unfakeable feeling. Trusted as sworn witnesses because their voice betrays real emotion under strain, so they cannot lie well on the stand.

Evidence and contract in the Turning are therefore *made of people*. Perfect memory, lie-heard oaths, and unfakeable testimony give a late-medieval world a trust other worlds needed paper bureaucracies, and centuries, to approximate, because here the machinery is alive and Given. A world with witnesses like these does not need to write everyone down.

## Rights of the Kept

The Kept are the quiet centre of citizenship, and their legal position is **unremarkable**. They were witnessed at their Turning like everyone. They carry no Tithe, need no licence, answer to no guild. In most polities the Kept are the **default legal person**, the frame the rest of the law is drawn around.

Vaethorn's second word is *the Waited / Mother-kept* (pitied: passed over). Lestrاند's is *the free* (approving: unencumbered labor). Threnmaieth's is *the unmarked / the passed-over* (noted as such).

Two wrinkles keep them from being a footnote:

- **Kept status is not permanent immunity.** About a third of the Kept are still **Struck** later. So a Kept person lives untithed and unlicensed but never wholly outside the safety system's reach. The day they are Struck, they too must be vouched anew. Legally, "Kept" describes your present, not a promise about your future.
- **Where reverence for the gift runs hot, the Kept can be quietly *pitied* or pressured:** treated as having "missed out," leaned on to explain why the Tree passed them over. This is a social harm the law rarely names, and it runs hardest in the most devout polities.

The Given keep their plain name everywhere. Vaethorn's second word is *the gifted* (blessed). Lestrاند's is *the Given* (plain). Threnmaieth's is *the marked* (on the roll).

## Edge cases the law must hold

- **The Hollow (the Unbound)** raise a *capacity and protective-status* question. Freed from a contract but missing the Pledge they paid, an isolated Hollow is pulled to sign again. Kinder polities extend a **protective status** (a guardian, a claim on connection, a bar on presenting them fresh contracts). Harsher ones leave them to the pull.
- **The Given-Over (the "Forfeit")** is the setting's sharpest legal wound: a Bound who kept re-signing until the counterparty effectively *owns the person*. This is a living case of **legal personhood erased by accumulated contract**, and the contract-guilds have a term of art for it because the law has never fully decided *at what point a person has bargained away enough of themselves to stop being one*. A recurring, unresolved question rather than a settled rule.
- **Phoenix** is not a licensing problem at all. A single legendary person who cannot hide is a *political* problem (a symbol no ruler controls), handled by whoever currently wants to own or protect the one alive.
- **UnTurned is not Kept.** A child who missed, refused, or never stood has no hug and no colour. Folk will call them Kept. The law should file them as the person the town raised, vouched if someone will stand, unwitnessed at the Tree. A second Leaf-Fall is not a remedy. Struck doors still open later.

## Three polity stances

The grammar above is universal; the *tone* is not. Variation comes from three independent axes every polity sets separately:

- **Theology: how gift-devout is it?** From ardent Motherfaith gift-integration (a Condition is a blessing, belonging is a birthright) through worn-lightly civic religion to frank secular pragmatism, and the odd local heresy. Sets how the Struck, the Kept, and the feared Conditions are *read* before the law even speaks.
- **Reach: Tree-rich core or Tree-poor edge?** Where healthy Trees stand, reach is full and the Given are dense. Where Trees are few, young, or sickening, the population runs higher on the Kept and the Struck.
- **Governance: how far does the state reach onto the person?** From light guild self-rule (the world's warm default: the craft polices its own, the crown charters the guild) all the way to a crown that writes its subjects down. Sets how much the safety-hook becomes a surveillance-hook.

Three recurring points on these axes:

**The Warm** (*high theology*). Law flows straight from the Motherfaith's gift-theology: a Condition is a blessing, the Struck are vouched-in graciously as people the Mother met at a later door, licences are framed as helping you tend your gift rather than policing you. Warmest near the Awakening Tree. **Its injustice is soft and hard to name:** everyone is *expected* to serve their gift, so guild "vocation" shades into pressure, the Kept get pitied for missing out, and to decline your Condition's obvious use reads as ingratitude to the Mother herself.

**The Watchful** (*governance turned to its extreme: a deliberate aberration*). At the far end of the governance axis sits a crown that breaks the world's norm and *does* write its people down: a ruler who does not trust living memory and keeps a **roster of every subject and their Condition**. What makes this aberrant is not that they keep written records at all. Every polity has guild rolls, notarial acts, and tax ledgers. It is that they keep a **census of persons and their gifts**, a record held *on people*, which no one else does. Threnmaieth's census calls itself the **Threnhael** (*THREN-hayl*): *thren* (sacred counting) + *hael* (whole, hale), "the keeping-whole." Clerks say they "keep the realm hale." Subjects are "kept whole." Outsiders hear "the Counting." Framed at home as prudence and order; experienced as **surveillance**. The unvouched are hunted, the Struck are pursued to be catalogued, Tithe-needs become points of leverage, and the Bound especially are watched far past their real hazard: pure stigma dressed as safety, since the Whisper can't command and the roster's clerks know it. A Watchful kingdom that is also devout and Tree-rich is the darkest mix of the three axes.

**The Frontier** (*low reach*). Far from any healthy Tree, where even witnessing is thin and custom outruns law. The giving thins where the Trees are thin, so these lands run higher on the Kept and higher on the Struck: more people the rite reached faintly or not at all. Freer in the good sense (no one asks for a licence; the Taken-In whom cities keep at arm's length are simply *neighbours* here, the backbone of the frontier economy) and lawless in the bad (unvouched Struck with no one to stand for them and no guild to train them, feared Conditions met with a rope rather than a licence). Reach and

governance often *drift* together. A thin-reach edge tends to be thinly governed too. They need not drift together: a devout frontier and a lightly-governed core both exist.

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# Economy and the Tithe

In other worlds an economy is organized around producing what people *want*. In the Turning it is also organized around a thing no other world has: **keeping three of every four people able to carry what they have become**. Every Condition has a Tithe, an ongoing need that must be met or the scary edge shows. Multiply that by about three-quarters of the population and it stops being a private matter.

**Tithe-provision is a permanent civic utility**, like wells and roads: visible in every town, fought over, load-bearing for the people who need it. It is **not** the size of grain. Grain feeds everyone, every day. The greens and halls keep an exposed minority from sliding, and keep their neighbours from living next to a slide. That is enough to organize a sector. It is not food.

Society organizes around the Conditioned because most Conditioned *pay by working* (the Tithe and the job are the same act). A smaller share must be furnished. The ones who furnish, and the ones who need furnishing, are often the same people — and whoever holds the gate holds power.

## Who actually buys provision

This is volume, not a second census.

| Who                     | About                                                                           | What “provision” is                                                          |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Self-paying by vocation | the Answered ~10 · Two-Bodied ~18 · the Stilled ~7 → ~35%                       | Work is the Tithe. They do not buy a sector. They <i>are</i> a labor market. |
| On the seam             | Far-Voiced ~12 · Returned ~7 → ~19%                                             | Self-pay if the job fits. Buy a hall-hour, or walk unpaid, when it does not. |
| Provided-for            | the Taken-In ~13 · Long-Lived ~2.5 · the Unbound ~1.5 · Bound Terms ~3.5 → ~20% | Green, novelty, warmth, whatever the clause set.                             |
| The Kept                | ~25%                                                                            | No Tithe. They buy bread, not a lot-hour.                                    |

Green is free on a farm. Most Taken-In live where it is free. The **purchased or civic customer base** — urban Taken-In, hall-users without a stage, novelty-seekers, warmth that money can only approximate — is on the order of **a seventh of the people**, concentrated in stone towns. Real traffic. Real queues. Not granaries. A city fights over lot-hours and hall-bells the way it fights over wells: because a wilt or a Cry in the square is a public problem, not because Tithe-goods rival bread by the cartload.

## Self-paying vs provided-for Tithes

**Not all Tithes cost the same to pay**, and some don't cost anything at all, because paying them *is* doing useful work. This sorts the Conditioned along a spectrum from *self-paying* to *provided-for*, and almost everything else follows from where a Condition sits on it. Which side a person lands on can depend on their vocation, not only their Condition.

**Self-paying Tithes: the work is the payment.** For several Conditions, the upkeep is discharged *by doing exactly the labor society needs*. Their maintenance cost and their productive output are the same act.

| Condition    | The Tithe                     | ...paid by doing                                                                            |
|--------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| the Answered | use the element in earnest    | <b>the craft itself:</b> a Tide-Answered shipwright slakes the Tithe by building the ship   |
| Two-Bodied   | spend time as the animal      | <b>the ranging work:</b> herding, rescue, courier, scout; being the beast <i>is</i> the job |
| the Stilled  | burn off the Grey by exertion | <b>active labor:</b> surgery, riot-lines, demolition; the vigorous work clears the clock    |

**On the seam: self-paying *if* the vocation fits, provided-for if it doesn't.** Two Conditions don't sit cleanly in either column. Their placement turns on *what work the person actually does*.

| Condition  | The Tithe                    | Self-pays when...                                                                                                                        | Falls to provided-for when...                                                                                                                                      |
|------------|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Far-Voiced | vent strong emotion each day | the vocation <i>is</i> the vent: <b>performer, crier, negotiator, sworn witness</b> ; feeling in earnest on the job discharges the Tithe | the voice has <b>no outlet</b> (isolated posting, dull labor, silence) and they need a <b>venting-hall</b> furnished for them                                      |
| Returned   | act toward the Purpose       | the <b>Purpose aligns with the work</b> : plague wards, recovery, tending the dead; doing the deadly job pays it                         | the Purpose is <b>personal or unmet by any trade</b> (a vengeance, a vow, a person to find). No employer can furnish it, and it pulls <i>against</i> ordinary work |

**Provided-for Tithes: upkeep that must be supplied.** For the rest, the Tithe is a *cost* with no productive by-product. Someone must furnish the green, the novelty, the warmth, and that furnishing is the Tithe-infrastructure sector.

| Condition    | The Tithe                     | ...must be provided                                                                              |
|--------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| the Taken-In | rest on living land           | <b>green</b> : trivial on the farm, a real expense in a stone city (potted groves, garden-leave) |
| Long-Lived   | learn something genuinely new | <b>novelty</b> : books, travel, correspondence, the traffic of a university town                 |
| the Unbound  | keep connecting to others     | <b>warmth</b> : company, being known; the one Tithe money buys least well                        |
| Bound        | keep the Terms                | <b>whatever the counterparty set</b> : idiosyncratic, sometimes ruinous                          |

The self-payers are prosperous *almost* automatically, because their Condition *is* a trade, though prosperity is not the same as ease. The Stilled self-pays and is still the most tightly licensed person in the world. The Answered self-pays under heavy guild discipline. Self-paying buys a living, not necessarily social comfort. The provided-for are economically **exposed**: they depend on someone furnishing their upkeep, and *whoever furnishes it holds power over them*. The seam-dwellers are the most precarious of all. A Far-Voiced who loses their stage, or a Returned whose Purpose turns personal, can **slide from self-paying to exposed overnight**.

## Tithe-poverty and the safety net

Because provided-for Tithes cost money, this world has a form of poverty others don't: **you can be too poor to stay whole**. A Taken-In who can't afford green, a Long-Lived with no access to anything new, a Far-Voiced with nowhere to vent: these people suffer want, and they **slide toward the scary edge**: the wilting, the fade, the involuntary Cry. Destitution here has a visible, dangerous face.

So the question *who pays for Tithe-provision* is this world's version of the welfare question, and polities answer it differently:

- **Public good.** Warm polities treat Tithe-provision like roads or wells (town greenhouses, free venting-halls, endowed libraries) because a town whose Conditioned stay whole is a town that stays safe and productive. This is also the pious framing: help everyone tend their gift.
- **Private burden.** Harsher polities leave it to the individual and the guild, and the Tithe-poor fall, becoming a genuine public hazard, which the same polities then police rather than prevent.
- **Leverage.** The cynical middle: provide it, but *hold it*. An employer, guild, or crown that furnishes your Tithe can withhold it.

## Labor: who does what

The Tithe and the vocation are usually the same shape. The world didn't assign these jobs. The Conditions *are* these jobs:

- **Two-Bodied (~18%, the plurality).** The versatile backbone of physical labor: herding, haulage, rescue, courier, scouting, war. Runs in bloodlines (whole "wolf-folk" / "hawk-folk" families), so the family trade and the family Condition are one inheritance.
- **the Taken-In (~13%).** The food-and-timber base: farmers, foresters, herders, wardens. The frontier economy *runs* on them (they thrive on living land). Cities need their grain **and keep a working minority of them**. Arm's length is manners, not absence.
- **Far-Voiced (~12%).** Coordination and trust-at-a-distance: the signal/relay network (criers posted on coasts, roads, borders), performers, negotiators, and sworn court witnesses. Real-time long-distance signal a medieval world shouldn't have.
- **the Answered (~10%).** The elemental crafts, guilded by element: Ember (smiths, glasswrights), Tide (shipwrights, dyers), Root (masons, potters), Gale (sailmakers, millers); plus firefighting and rescue rotations.
- **Returned (~7%).** The work that kills the living, done by those death can't take twice: plague wards, mine and cave-in recovery, deep and dangerous salvage, and tending the dead.
- **the Stilled (~7%).** Precision stillness: surgeons and medics, peacekeepers on riot-lines, controlled demolition and stonework. Licensed and guild-disciplined.

- **Long-Lived (~2.5%).** The memory professions: archivists, notaries, judges, scholars, and **bankers**. Few by design. A world with too many deathless would ossify.
- **Bound (~5%).** The enforcement and contract class: oath-keepers, debt-arbiters, treaty-swearers, witnesses whose word is literally binding. The Unbound sit inside this same contract-lane (a released Bound, not a second workforce); they return to whatever they did before, needing connection to keep at it.
- **Phoenix (trace).** No characteristic sector. A political symbol, not a worker.

**And the Kept (~25%).** The Kept carry *no Tithe* (no upkeep cost) and *no Condition* (no built-in trade). Economically that makes them the **free generalist labor**: unburdened by any Tithe-need, unclaimed by any Condition-guild, able to take any ordinary work and move where they like. Where the faithful pity the Kept for missing a gift, they are still the least *encumbered* people in the world.

## Why Taken-In live in stone cities

Green is an expense in a stone city, and cities keep the Taken-In at arm's length because they thrive on the frontier. Both can be true. **Arm's length is how polite districts stand toward bark and antler. It is not an empty lot.**

They are in the city because:

1. **They were Given here.** A copper-green leaf at a city Tree. Family, work, and a hearth-witness keep them. Leaving the city is leaving the circle that saw you Turn.
2. **Grain and timber come in; people come with them.** Seasonal Taken-In on the quays, wintering, some staying. The harvest-hands who do not go home in Hale-month.
3. **The lot is a job.** Greens-keepers need Taken-In labor. The city *imports* green-skill for the commons, then will not sit them at the high table.
4. **The door can open in a city's old green.** Lost and dying in a deep wild is the Struck path. A walled grove, a lot at night, a river-garden after a flood — rare, and enough.
5. **They cannot afford to leave.** Green-poverty is a trap: you need the lot to stay whole, the lot is gated, you work for lot-hours, you never save the cart-fare home. That trap is the Slide's urban book.

World share is still ~13%. A stone city runs **lower** — a twentieth to a twelfth of its adults, concentrated on lots, orchards, river-gardens, and the week-keeper's pot. Enough for a queue. Enough for a wilt two streets off. Enough for the Slide's customer. The frontier still has the density and the honour. The city has the gate.

## Banking and the deathless houses

**The Turning's banks do not die.** These are the **deathless houses**: a Long-Lived banking house founded by a person who is still personally running it two centuries later, the same memory, word, and ledger, unbroken. In a late-medieval world of **letters of credit** (a merchant's written promise to pay, carried in place of a chest of coin) and merchant houses, this is the great Condition-labor advance in finance, and it has three consequences:

- **The trusted note.** A note issued by a deathless house is trusted almost as coin, because everyone knows the banker *cannot forget a debt, cannot be quietly succeeded by a defaulting heir, and will personally answer for it in fifty years*. Their paper circulates further and holds value better than any crown's. The nearest thing this world has to a gold standard is *the word of a house that won't die*.
- **The long instrument.** Deathless houses lend and endow on horizons no mortal lender would risk: century loans, multi-generation trusts, the patient financing of cathedrals, canals, and universities. This is *longer* medieval banking, not *modern* banking. Letters of credit and endowments, **not** stock exchanges or joint-stock companies, which this world does not have.
- **The concentration risk.** Wealth that never passes to an heir never disperses *through inheritance*. The great scattering that mortal death forces on every other fortune simply never happens here. Even at ~2.5% of the population, the deathless can slowly gather an outsized share of standing capital, which is the ossification the vampire's rarity is *meant* to cap, and a live tension the economy never fully resolves. An endowment moves the *coin* out but keeps the *steering*, so influence concentrates even as liquid wealth flows into the institutions they still direct.

Many houses began as **road-houses** in the Walking Years: inns, beds, and century-credit for families who had to walk to Thaeloren. When the walk stopped being required in the core, the same Long-Lived still remembered every debtor on the road, and the paper outlived the pilgrimage-season. They became banks. Two fates still standing: the White Note House collected; the Third Hearth kept making the bed. The trusted note is a Walking-era instrument that outlived its road.

## Inheritance and the problem of not dying

Inheritance law is warped by the deathless. A Long-Lived's children **do not inherit the Condition**. They age and die while the parent does not. So a deathless person **outlives every heir**, and their estate never enters the inheritance stream at all. What becomes of a fortune that is never passed down?

The characteristic answer: **the deathless endow**. Having no heirs and needing, for their own Tithe, a steady supply of *novelty* (new books, new scholarship, new things to learn), a Long-Lived characteristically funds the very institutions that generate knowledge: libraries, universities, archives. The deathless banker becomes the deathless patron, and pays their own Tithe by building the places that feed it. It is also how they grieve: an endowment in the name of a child who died a century ago.

**This is not the same as letting the fortune go.** An endowment is coin converted into *permanent, directed patronage*. The founder does not die, so they keep the chair, name the scholars, and steer the institution for centuries. So endowment eases the *coin* concentration (liquid wealth flows out into public works) while quietly deepening the *influence* concentration (the same few deathless hands still guide the universities, courts, and archives their money built). The ossification the rarity-cap fights doesn't vanish. It changes shape from hoarded gold to entrenched patronage.

For everyone else inheritance is ordinary, *except* the **Two-Bodied bloodlines**, where the Condition, the family animal, and often the family trade descend together, so a guild place and a Condition can be a single inheritance. And the law's sharpest open question is economic at root: the **Given-Over**, a Bound who contracted away so much of themselves that the counterparty effectively *owns the person*. That is the ultimate inheritance failure: an estate, and a self, absorbed by a creditor.

## Center and periphery

The economy is not evenly spread. Near the mature Trees (the core), Conditions are dense, guilds are strong, and specialized Condition-labor and its goods are the great export. Out at the margins (the frontier), **the giving thins**: more of the population are generalist Kept or untrained Struck, fewer are Given specialists. So:

- **The core** exports specialized work and finished goods (Answered crafts, Stilled medicine, deathless-house credit) and imports raw staples.
- **The frontier** leans hardest on the Taken-In (who thrive there, and are *neighbours*) and on generalist Kept labor. It exports food, timber, and raw materials, and imports the specialists it can't grow. Trade friction is real. Distance, spoilage, and the thin reach all mean the frontier is *specialist-poor and self-reliant*. Cities still keep a working Taken-In minority behind a gate; they do not ship the Condition out of town.

## The shadow economy

Every gate breeds a black market, and this economy's gates are **Tithe-provision** and **vouching**:

- **Illicit Tithe-supply.** Where legitimate provision is rationed, gated, or unaffordable, a shadow market fills it: smuggled green for a Taken-In cut off from land, unlicensed venting-rooms, black-market novelty (rare texts, forbidden knowledge) for a starving Long-Lived. The desperate customer is someone sliding toward their scary edge, which makes this trade both lucrative and cruel. Lived face: **the Slide**.
- **Off-book contracts.** The Bound's whole domain has an underside: contracts sworn outside the honest tables, unregistered terms, and the predatory brokers who arrange them, the pipeline that feeds the Given-Over. Lived face: **the Holding Desk**. Not the Slide's.

- **Sold vouching.** Since citizenship runs on standing-for, the unvouched will *buy* a voucher, and a market exists in dubious character-witnesses. The one thing that *can't* be faked is a Long-Lived's memory, which is why their honest vouch is priceless and their corrupt one catastrophic. Lived face: **the Standing Trade**. Not the Slide's.

## How politics vary (economic faces)

The grammar is universal; the *distribution* is political. It runs on the same independent axes as the law. The three touchstone points have these economic faces:

**The Warm** (*high theology*). Treats **Tithe-provision as a public good**: town greenhouses, endowed venting-halls and libraries, ranging-commons held in common. The Conditioned are kept whole at civic expense because a whole populace is a safe and productive one, and because the faith says tend every gift. **Its economic injustice is soft**: the same provision comes with *expectation*. You are helped to tend your gift, and quietly obligated to spend it as the community sees fit. Subsidy shades into conscription.

**The Watchful** (*governance at its extreme*). The crown that writes its people down turns **Tithe-need into leverage**. It provides, efficiently, even generously, but *holds* what it provides: the green, the outlet, the novelty, all furnished through channels the crown controls and can withhold. Its deathless-house finance is superb and centuries-deep. **Its injustice is cold and precise**: a population whose upkeep runs through the state is a population that cannot afford to refuse it, the most complete control in the world, dressed as care.

**The Frontier** (*low reach*). Little formal Tithe-infrastructure and few specialists. People improvise their own provision or do without. Freer (no guild monopoly, no crown's leash; the Taken-In are neighbours, not curiosities) and harsher (the provided-for Tithe-poor slide with no net, untrained Struck manage dangerous Conditions alone). A barter-and-favor economy at the edges, cash-poor and land-rich.

A devout frontier runs commons-minded charity with almost no infrastructure to fund it. A secular Tree-rich republic has deep markets and thin welfare. A Watchful-and-pious core turns generous provision into the tightest leash in the world.

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# Daily Life

Most of family in the Turning is utterly ordinary. Two people marry; some of their household carries a Condition and some doesn't; the children haven't Turned yet and won't until their tenth year. A born-Selkie wife, a husband Returned from a drowning, a Kept grandmother, three children who are simply children so far: this is not a remarkable household. It is *the* household. Because Conditions **stack** onto Kinds and arrive across a whole life, nearly every family is "mixed" in some way, and precisely because nearly every family is, **mixed families are not a category anyone thinks about**. There is no "interracial marriage" tension here in the Condition layer, because there is no unmixed baseline to marry away from.

## Family, the whole spectrum

**At the warm, mundane end** (most families): a Condition is just a texture of the household, the way a trade or a temperament is. A Two-Bodied parent's other self has a *name* and the children know it ("that's Bramble, mother's otter") and grows up as much a part of the family as a pet that is also a person. A Far-Voiced household is a *loud* one, because the Tithe means feeling must be aired daily. You do not get to sulk quietly in a home with a Far-Voiced in it, and families learn to treat the evening's singing or weeping or laughing as ordinary weather. A Taken-In parent keeps the windows open and the rooms green. These are quirks, not tragedies: the small daily accommodations of living with people who are also *becomings*.

**In the middle**, the Tithe becomes a shared family labor. Where a Condition is provided-for, keeping a family member whole is a household expense and a household duty: the green for the Taken-In, the books for the Long-Lived, the outlet for the Far-Voiced. Families organize around it the way others organize around a member's chronic need, mostly without drama, sometimes with strain, and with the quiet knowledge that **to let a loved one's Tithe lapse is to watch them slide toward the scary edge**. A family too poor to furnish a Tithe carries a particular grief: they can see exactly what their kin needs and cannot buy it.

**At the aching end** sits the marriage the whole setting is quietly organized around: **loving someone whose becoming and yours don't share a timespan**. Chief among these is marrying a **Long-Lived**. Their aging simply stops; their spouse's does not. A Long-Lived can have children and a full family, but the Condition is **not reliably inherited**. Most children age and die like anyone, so a Long-Lived does not build a deathless dynasty; they **outlive it**. They watch a spouse grow old across a marriage that stays, on one side, unchanged. They bury their children. The old saying is that *the cost of the*

*Long-Lived is measured in funerals*, and it is a cost paid inside the family, at the dinner table, over decades. A Long-Lived who has done this once faces the choice their whole existence turns on: **stop** (live on alone, keep no more households) or **begin again**, marry again, love again, and outlive that family too. Neither choice is cowardly and neither is free. This is the setting's deepest, quietest ache, and it lives in the most ordinary place there is: a marriage.

A few threads:

- **The threshold courtesy in the home.** A Long-Lived never crosses another's home threshold uninvited. It is held as the deepest good manners, the mark of someone safe to let in. Inside a *family*, this softens into something tender: to be welcomed across a Long-Lived's own threshold, or to welcome them across yours without a thought, is a real intimacy. A door held open is how this world says *you are mine and I am yours*. (A door refused is felt more than a Long-Lived will ever say.)
- **The Returned come home.** A person who died and Returned is, contrary to every outside expectation, **not cold**. A Returned is calm, deliberate, unafraid, and *quietly respected*, and their loved ones get them back. The chill only comes if their Purpose lapses: a Returned neglecting the unfinished thing that holds them "runs cold," and the living can feel the wrongness at a touch. So a Returned's family learns a hard and intimate literacy. **You can tell, by an embrace, whether the one you love is tending what holds them here.** A warm embrace means they are well. A cold one is a family emergency dressed as a hug.
- **Two-Bodied bloodlines are family lines.** Because the Condition runs in blood (children of a Two-Bodied parent usually Turn the same animal), "wolf-folk," "hawk-folk," and "otter-folk" are real extended families, and the family animal, the Condition, and often the family trade descend as a single inheritance. Marrying into such a line is marrying into a shape your children will likely wear.
- **Raising a child before they Turn.** Every parent lives the same open question until their child's tenth year: *what will they become, or will they be Kept?* In devout homes this is held as a hopeful mystery (the Mother will give what the child can carry); in anxious ones it is a decade of quiet dread or ambition. Parents who carry a heritable Condition (Two-Bodied especially) can half-guess; most cannot. The Leaf-Fall is therefore a civic day and the emotional hinge of a family's life: the day you finally *meet* who your child has been becoming all along. In the Walking Years the question had a prior: *can we even get there?* A household that could walk only one child still lives in the present as a Given/Kept sibling pair.

## Medicine: miraculous, and strange to outside eyes

Medicine in the Turning is genuinely astonishing for a late-medieval world, and it is astonishing for one reason: **the Condition-labor advance shows up hardest at the sickbed and the deathbed.** Two

Conditions turn medicine into something a world of this technology should not have. To anyone from outside, a Turning clinic is a deeply *uncanny* place, wonder and wrongness in the same room.

**The Stilled are the surgeons.** A stiller's gaze **arrests motion**. It holds a wound from bleeding, slows a poison's spread through the blood, keeps a patient perfectly still under the knife without holding them down. It does not petrify and does not harm; it simply *stops* what is moving for a beat. In a world with no anaesthetic worth the name and no way to halt a hemorrhage, this is the difference between a survivable operation and a death. The best surgeons in the world are Stilled, and a great infirmary is built around them. But sit in that operating room as an outsider and watch what it *is*: a surgeon whose flat, patient gaze freezes the blood in your veins on command, working fast because the Grey is filling in them as they work. Their Tithe is this: using the Gaze fills a clock that, left full, locks *their own* limb to stone. They drill and spar between patients to burn it off. The most gifted healers in the world are also the most tightly **licensed** and quietly **feared**. The same gaze that saves you on the table is the one the law watches hardest. Wonder and dread, one person, one room.

**The Returned do the work that kills the living.** Plague wards, mine collapses, the recovery of bodies from places the living cannot safely go, and the tending of the dead: this is Returned work, done by those death cannot take a second time until their Purpose is met. A Turning mortuary is staffed by the dead, calmly and well. A plague ward that would empty a town's living physicians is walked by Returned who are unshaken by rot and contagion. To an outsider this is ghoulish. Inside, it is simply **respected**. The Returned are the reason a plague does not take the doctors too, and everyone knows it. There is a real tenderness in it, too: no one speaks for the dead, or tends them, as gently as someone who has been dead.

**The rest of medicine is ordinary, and ordinarily unequal.** Midwives, bonesetters, herbalists, the Answered's craft turned to apothecary and instrument-making: the everyday care of a 1400s town, better staffed than others because more of the population carries a useful becoming. But the Condition-medicine that makes this world exceptional is **not evenly available**. The great Stilled infirmaries and the deathless-endowed hospitals cluster in the rich, Tree-dense core. The frontier makes do with a travelling stiller if it is lucky and a rope-and-prayer if it is not. And the deepest inequity is Tithe-poverty already named: **you can be too poor to stay whole**, and the medicine that treats a lapsing Condition is exactly the medicine the poor can least reach. The miracle is real. So is the queue outside it.

## Living in a Turning town: city design

A city here is shaped by a fact no other world's city faces: **most of its adults have an upkeep, and some of those upkeeps are dangerous or expensive to meet**. So the town builds around the Tithe the way others build around water and waste, as **civic infrastructure, visible and load-bearing**.

- **The Tree at the centre.** Every town is *organized around* its Turning Tree. It is the civic and sacred heart, the site of the year's most-attended day, the thing the oldest quarter grew up around. A town's age and standing can be read in its Tree (a mature grafted Tree means an old, reach-rich town; a young Tree or none means a new or frontier settlement). Geography and civic layout both point back to it. Residues layer this: a stone in the square, an upper room, a road that ends at the boughs.
- **Tithe-provision as public utility.** Where the polity treats provision as a public good, the town furnishes it in the open: **venting-halls** (common tongue: **the ael-hall**; Vaethorn *the gift-hall*; Lestrاند *the release-house*; Threnmaieth *the counted hall*) for the Far-Voiced, part concert hall, part release valve, often doubling as the town's performance venue; **potted groves and garden-commons** (common: **the greens**; Vaethorn *the Mother's green*; Lestrاند *the leaf-lot*; Threnmaieth *the tended green*) so the Taken-In don't "go to seed" indoors; **endowed libraries** (common: **the long-house of books**; Vaethorn *the deathless gift*; Lestrاند *the endowment / the house*; Threnmaieth *the crown archive*) feeding the Long-Lived's novelty-Tithe and often *built* by a Long-Lived; and **ranging-commons** (common: **the ranging**; Vaethorn *the wild-leave*; Lestrاند *the beast-yard*; Threnmaieth *the ranging-roll*) at the town edge where the Two-Bodied can be their other selves. These are as normal a part of the streetscape as a well or a market cross.
- **The dangerous trades on the edges.** The work that carries a bystander hazard sits where such work always sits, at the margins and the edges. Stilled infirmaries and Answered element-workshops (fire, forge, tide) are guild-quartered and set slightly apart; the Returned's mortuaries and plague-work sit at the town's edge, near the dead. Not from disgust. From the same logic that puts a tannery downwind.
- **Homes that accommodate becomings.** Ordinary domestic architecture quietly bends to the Conditions: windows that open and rooms kept green for a Taken-In guest, a household's evening rhythm built around a Far-Voiced's vent, a threshold a Long-Lived waits to be asked across. A Turning home is legibly a home *for becomings*.
- **The reach-edge writes the map, again.** Dense, Tree-rich core towns are thick with all this infrastructure; frontier settlements have little of it and improvise. You can read a town's place in the world off how much of its Tithe-infrastructure is public, private, or simply absent.

## How polities vary (domestic faces)

**The Warm** (*high theology*). Family, medicine, and civic life all carry the gift-theology: a child's Turning is a joyous sacrament, mixed households are blessings compounded, Tithe-provision is a public good offered in the open, and the sick are tended as people whose gifts must be kept whole. **Its soft injustice reaches the hearth:** the Kept child is *pitied* for being passed over, marrying "beneath your gift" is quietly frowned on, and a family is expected to spend its members' Conditions as the community sees fit. Love and pressure wearing the same warm face.

**The Watchful** (*governance at its extreme*). The register-keeping crown reaches into the family: marriages of heritable Conditions may be *noticed* and encouraged or discouraged, a child's Turning is an event the state records, and the medicine that furnishes a Tithe runs through channels the crown controls. **Its cold injustice is domestic surveillance.** A household whose upkeep and bloodline are both on file is a household that cannot easily refuse the crown anything.

**The Frontier** (*low reach*). Thin infrastructure, thin medicine, thin ceremony. Families improvise their own Tithe-provision or do without; a travelling stiller is a rare blessing; the Taken-In whom core cities keep at arm's length are *neighbours and kin* here, the backbone of the place. Freer (no one polices your marriage or your gift) and harsher (a lapsing Condition with no infirmary to reach, an untrained Struck child with no guild to catch them). Warmer in feeling, poorer in safety-net.

A devout frontier holds joyous Turnings with almost no infirmary behind them. A secular Tree-rich republic has superb medicine and a marriage market that shrugs at theology. A Watchful-and-pious core turns the sacrament of a child's Turning into a state census with a hymn over it.

## When the town buries

A funeral is a walk and a meal. It is not a Turning. Nobody asks the Tree what the dead person "was," and a warden does not read a leaf-colour over the body.

They wash the body in the house. The washer is often one of the Returned, people who died and came back, because tending the dead is already their work. The family still chooses the burial cloth. Neighbours then carry the body. In a town with a Tree, the carry goes past the canopy, along the street the person used. The body is not stood under the branches. A tree-warden may walk with them. If the house wants the Mother named, the warden says "Maieth" the way a neighbour would. Maieth is the short name devout people use for the Leaf-Mother. If the house asked for silence, the warden walks silent. Neighbours bring food to the door. The door stays open through the meal. The person who will sleep in the house that night is the one who shuts it.

Most households already mix faiths, so the meal is mixed too. Each person does their own small rite at their own bowl. They do not stop the meal to argue which name comes first.

- A Motherfaith sibling says "Maieth" over their own bowl, and means the life.
- A sibling of the Watching describes the dead as they were at the market stall: the coat, the argument, the way they counted change. They do not thank a giver.
- If the dead kept a personal book, someone of the Fair Hand closes it on the table, where the room can see the last line, and does not write a new one. People call them Settlers.
- Someone of the Old Ways puts a little of the meal at the threshold. People call them kin-speakers. If the dead belonged to a particular door, that faith's word for a household's own old practice, the rest of that food goes to the door when the street has finished eating. In that rite, ancestors are kin

who stayed. A “return” means a Returned person, still living a neighbour’s life. You do not summon one.

Speaking a fall is the warden’s sentence at Leaf-Fall, when a Tree gives a living child a colour. A funeral is not that day. Nobody does it over the bowls. A neighbour who tries is walked outside by whoever is nearest the pot.

On a dock, if the dead worked the water, the crew carries the coffin along the quay. It does not go under the town Tree to be read. Some of the crew say “fair wind, fair term,” because that is already their sentence for a leaving. Some will not, because they keep that sentence for a ship that is still going out. Both happen in the same hour, and the crew does not stop to settle it. If there is a book, it is closed where the crew can see. In another month, people put salt on the Tree’s roots. That habit is not part of the funeral. They will not say why the salt is there.

A waiting town such as Eolvaeth does not send to a luckier town’s Tree for a warden. If the local warden is in the vale, they may walk. If this year’s children were already sent away to Turn somewhere else, the town buries with the people who stayed. Food goes to the door the person kept. A wet leaf lies on the town spring. That is the spring’s habit. It is not a funeral token. They will not say why the leaf is there.

At Ndenjoo, on the Sundering Isle, the body is laid above the tide. The hall does not set a second empty plate for the dead. The dead person’s own cup sits in the place that was already set, for one night, and then it goes back to the shelf. Whether anyone says a name is an argument the valley already has. It waits until after the dishes.

## **The guest-meal**

Feed the guest before you ask who they are. That much is true on every mainland road. What people ask afterward depends on the town.

In a devout kitchen, such as a street in Maiethlir, the guest sits and eats. Then someone asks, “Of where?” They mean which town or vale. Nobody asks what leaf-colour the guest carries, or whether they have one. The host may say “Maieth” over the host’s own bowl. The guest is not asked to repeat it. A Watcher at the same table tells the guest what is in the pot, and then stops. A Settler at the end of the bench does not open a book. A letter can wait until the guest’s shoes are dry.

On a dock such as Orentel, the first bread is eaten standing, at a barrel, where the crane can be seen. Sitting down before that bread is how a person claims a berth they have not paid for. After the bread, if no clerk has a document open, there is a chair. They ask which berth. A guest with no berth still eats. If a filing house, a clerk’s office, has a paper open, the clerk asks for the house-name before offering the chair. A house-name is the inherited family name those offices use. The food does not wait for the

name. If a book-hand wants the guest's affairs written down that night, the person who cut the bread tells them to do it on the quay in the morning.

In a waiting town the guest is often a clerk from the core, come to watch a Turning week, who found a pot instead. They are fed from the common pot if the house is thin. Nobody promises that the local wood will speak this week. If the guest asks about the wet leaf on the spring, someone passes the bread. That is the whole answer. The town will not say what the leaf is for.

At Ndenjoo, on the first night, the guest does not serve food and does not sit in the place set back from the table. That place is already kept. On the second night, someone puts a plate in the guest's hands to carry. That second sitting is how the hall counts you as kin on the isle. It does not become papers you can show a mainland watch. On the one night the hall eats the heel of the loaf first, a guest who asks why is given more bread. They will not say why the heel came first.

If someone asks what the guest is before the food is down, the room goes quiet. The person nearest the pot puts the bowl down anyway.

## **What a house keeps**

When a town needs work done, it hires a person. A made thing, if a town has one at all, is an object that keeps going with nobody in it: a crane left running, a mill someone swears turns with nobody at the stones, a figure of clay. It has a maker, and it has a problem, such as a stop that broke or a debt the maker did not finish. It is not a people. It has no Kind and no Condition. A Clank is a person, born a Clank, who mends flood-walls and mills alongside everyone else who does that work. Most towns do not keep a made thing on a shelf.

Ordinary kit is whatever that ground already needed. It is clothing and tools, not better armor, and not a relic.

| Place                                  | What they keep                                  | Why it is there                                                          |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Rain-Wall shelves,<br>above the passes | An oiled wool coat                              | The shelf is wet and cold.                                               |
| Orentel's quay                         | A short hook, and a coat<br>waxed against spray | Lines, crates, and salt water.                                           |
| A young graft on the<br>live front     | A pruning knife, and a wind<br>cloak            | The wood is new and the weather is not.<br>The knife is a tender's tool. |
| The Rain-Shadow                        | A goat-hair blanket, and a<br>water-skin        | The days are dry and the well is shared.                                 |
| Kumbaen                                | A peat cloak                                    | Smoke and rain, in the hall and on the<br>terrace.                       |
| A Mother-core orchard                  | Beeswax                                         | The hives, and the halls that are owed wax<br>when the blossom fails.    |

A coat from this list is clothing. A pruning knife is a gardener's knife. It is not the one blade people mean when they say "the knife." Some hearths hang an ordinary kitchen knife on a ribbon, because they cannot say whether they are honouring a theft or a gift. One house on the Near Mile hangs its knife beside a scorch on an old pot-ring, and the house knows which summer that was. Strangers want that ribboned knife to be the famous first blade. The house will not sell it as that. No house has produced the one blade. Who made the first cut is not written down.

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# Tithe-Infrastructure and Guilds

The lived official sector: who furnishes green, novelty, and outlets, and who stamps the handful of hazardous-Condition **tickets**. A ticket is a guild licence to practice a hazardous Tithe. Not clergy. Not the Slide.

Everyday: **the furnishing**, or just **the greens and the halls**. There is no liturgical umbrella. This is civic work, not a fifth faith. Vaethorn says **the gift-works**. Lestrand says **the provision** the way it says *the wells*. Threnmaieth files **the counted channel**.

**In one sentence:** they keep people whole *enough*, in public, and they stop at the gate.

## Shape of the sector

- **Two jobs that are not one house.** **Furnishing** keeps a provided-for Tithe from becoming a public hazard (green, an outlet, a new page). **Ticketing** marks competence for the three Conditions that can hurt a bystander (the Stilled, Far-Voiced, the Answered). A town may put both jobs in the same building. They are still two jobs. The Bound's "ticket" is a hearing at a table, not a guild licence for their body.
- **Official means *enough*, not a week.** A commons-share, a scheduled hour, a library that is open. The product is a person who can walk away until tomorrow. The Slide's product is a person who cannot. The town is glad of both and will not say so about the second.
- **They think they are in a public-works story.** Wells. Yards. A playhouse. A surgeon's college. They do not call themselves monster-wardens.
- **No Furnishing Seat.** A town keeps its own lot and hall. A deathless house endows its own long-house. The licence-guilds charter *their* members. Nothing in this sector micromanages a far commons.

## Who furnishes what

| Tithe              | The official door                                           | Lived house                                                                        | What they will not do                                                                               |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Taken-In green     | garden-commons / the greens / a leaf-lot                    | the Greens-Keepers                                                                 | Will not follow you home. Will not rent you a private pot after the share fails. That is the Slide. |
| Far-Voiced outlet  | the ael-hall (the venting-hall: playhouse and safety-valve) | the Hall-Keepers                                                                   | Will not give you an unscheduled Cry. Will not keep you half-vented so you come back tonight.       |
| Long-Lived novelty | the long-house of books                                     | <i>no new order</i> : the deathless house that endowed it, still sitting the chair | Will not ration a page to own you. A junior who does that has started a week.                       |
| Unbound warmth     | <i>almost none</i>                                          | family; an attic of the Table-Keepers; the Slide's paid sitting                    | The sector cannot buy being known. There is no warmth-guild.                                        |
| Bound Terms        | the honest table                                            | the Book-Hands (civic year) + the Counterparty (the clause)                        | Not a body-licence. There is no fourth hazard-guild.                                                |
| Returned Purpose   | <i>cannot be furnished</i>                                  | a Book-hand may find a payable year; no one can supply a vengeance                 | There is no Purpose-desk.                                                                           |
| Two-Bodied ranging | the ranging / a beast-yard                                  | civic land, no guild                                                               | Self-paying. No ticket. There are no wolf-police.                                                   |

**The three tickets** (danger-to-others only, held by the person, issued by the craft):

| Ticket                   | Condition    | Lived house                                        | Why a ticket at all                                                            |
|--------------------------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| strictest                | the Stilled  | the Stillers                                       | the Gaze (their stilling look) can hold a person forever                       |
| heavy,<br>training-first | Far-Voiced   | the Hall-Keepers (the same building as the outlet) | a Cry in a crowded hall: feeling that got out, and everyone in earshot took it |
| heavy,<br>training-first | the Answered | the Element-Guilds                                 | an untended element in a workshop                                              |
| <i>not a body-ticket</i> | Bound        | a table, not a guild-yard                          | walking legal instrument; the Whisper cannot command                           |

**The Intake** is the shared underdog office of the three ticket-houses: the desk for raw Struck, already live, no childhood apprenticeship. Not a travelling clergy. Not a week.

## Fellowships, not a fourth ticket

A mill, a hull, and a road have people who keep them. Those people are fellowships. The work does not licence a body. The Stillers, the element-guilds, the Intake, and the hall-keepers already stamp the hazardous uses. A mill-share, a hull-wright, and a road-mend do not stamp any of those. A Gale-Answered miller can hold a ticket for the wind and still owe a share of grain. The ticket is the wind. The share is the grain.

You are of a fellowship when you have kept the thing through a season and someone of it will say so. There is no Seat over other towns, and no Kind-gate. Kumbaan does not keep these three.

The **mill-share** is the people who will say whose race this is. At the Mill-hold the share is still taken when the culvert is opened. When the race is drawn down, they leave one measure of last year's grain on the lip until the water comes back. They will not say why.

The **hull-wrights** know whether a hull will take water. They do not classify the cargo, set the Hush-rate, or sell a mouth that will say *I was there*. Before a new hull takes water, they walk it once empty, from stem to stern, and do not speak. They will not say why.

The **road-mend** fills a hole, clears a ford, and shores a culvert. They are not Road-hands. A Road-hand carries living wood. A mender carries a shovel. At Nelath the mend stops with the road. They do not cut the thorns back. At the first ford after a town, they leave the shovel standing in the bank overnight after a mend. They will not say why.

## The work people hire

Daggerheart's domains are jobs a town already pays someone to do. People do not enroll in a school of magic. Arcana is workshop heat, water, stone, air, or light. Blade is a weapon, a watch until morning, a pruning knife, a cohort walking children to a sound Hand. Bone is where to stand. Codex is paper, and reading a page is not Speaking a colour. Grace is a guest-meal or a factor's terms. The hazardous Cry stays the hall-keepers' ticket. Midnight is a shut door and a trade that does not want a square. Sage is ground, herd, weather, the bark of a young graft. Splendor is the room after harm. Valor is standing a gap.

A Spoken colour is the warden's sentence at Leaf-Fall. It is not a spell. Hope does not buy a colour. A Condition is a becoming, with a Tithe. A craft does not Turn anyone. If the same person has both, each one does what its own card says.

## The long-house (novelty without a new order)

A Long-Lived house that has endowed a library is already Tithe-infrastructure. The founder is still alive. They still name the scholars. They still sit the chair. Coin went out; steering stayed.

Staff are clerks, often the Kept, unencumbered, able to fetch a book the founder has not read. A junior Long-Lived copies. There is no liturgical name and no college of librarians.

What they furnish is *something genuinely new*. What they will not furnish is a page at a time to a person who cannot walk in. That junior, the one who will extend a subscription one more week, is how the Slide sits next to a long-house without being one.

## The gate (the sector's shared courtesy)

Every official door stops at a line the town has agreed to call *enough*:

- The greens-keeper keeps the lot. They do not walk the wilting room.
- The hall-keeper keeps the hour. They do not open after the lamps for a voice that missed its slate.
- The long-house is open. It is not a courier of rumours to a fade in a closed chamber.
- The ticket-house trains the Given child and stamps the competent adult. The raw Struck is the Intake's problem, and the guild is glad to forget them if the catching-year is quiet.

The Slide begins where that line is. The guilds **pretend not to know**. That pretending is already part of the town.

The Slide's measured week is a different shape. This is **jurisdiction**. We keep the commons. We do not keep *you*.

## How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (the gift-works).** Tithe-provision as a public good with almost no guild to fund it. A commons that is a cousin's field. A blessing-to-practice said over a stiller who learned on a riot-line because there was no infirmary. Soft injustice: you were helped, so you will spend the gift as the valley sees fit. The Slide here is *the last pot* when the commons run out.
- **Lestrand (the provision).** Posted. A leaf-lot by the season. A release-house that is also the playhouse. Guild-tickets as master's papers. You can be priced out of staying whole. The Slide is week-rent after the season-fee failed.
- **Threnmaieth (the counted channel).** The crown furnishes, efficiently, even generously, and *holds* what it furnishes. A counted hall. A tended green. A crown-warrant. The darkest leash in the world, dressed as care. The Slide is the late week the channel will not admit failed.

**Kumbaen.** Almost no Given Tithes. There is no exported greenhouse or ael-hall. A wreck walked uphill is a guest.

This sector is not a fifth faith. Not a census. A bed-list is plants. A hall-slate is hours. A guild-roll is practitioners of a dangerous art. The one kingdom that writes *persons and gifts* is still only Threnmaieth. Road-hands carry wood. These houses carry dirt, an hour, a ticket.

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## The Greens-Keepers

The lived face of official green: garden-commons, the greens, a leaf-lot. They furnish *enough* living land that a Taken-In can rest and walk away. They are not the Slide.

Everyday: **greens-keepers**, or **lot-keepers**. Liturgical: **the Saelhael** (SAYL-hayl). *sael* "sowing; the first green" + *hael* "whole": those who *keep you hale by putting you back on growing ground*.

Vaethorn's second word is **Mother's-green hands**; Lestrand's is **lot-keepers** (ordinary, like saying *gardener*); Threnmaieth files them as **the Tended**.

**In one sentence:** they keep the lot, and they will not follow you home.

## Shape of the house

- **A commons, not a church.** There is no Green Seat. A town has a lot, a strip along the wall, pots in a yard the size of a tannery. Vaethorn's "lot" is often a cousin's field held in common. The house is whoever waters it and says who sleeps on which bed tonight.
- **Enough, then the gate.** A share is a night on living dirt, a season on a bed, a commons-hour. The person should leave able to work. A person who cannot leave is not this house's product. That

person is how you find the Slide.

- **They think they are in a gardening story.** Soil, blight, whose beans took. They do not call themselves wardens of a people.
- **A bed-slate is plants.** Rows, which bed is tired, which needs a year of beans. Names get onto it because a person is *on* a bed. The keepers will tell you it is horticulture. In Threnmaieth the crown already has another list.

## If you meet one

Dirt under the nails. A key to a gate in a wall. A slate. You would miss them as clergy if you came looking for a lintel. You would find them if you asked *where a Taken-In sleeps when the rooms are stone*.

They are useful the way a well is useful. A stone town cannot keep its Taken-In without a lot. The faith, if any, is extra.

## Who comes, and when

| Who                               | Why they come                               | What the greens-keeper does                                                                                                        | What they will not do                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A Taken-In who works in town      | The rooms are stone; the Tithe is due       | Give a share: a bed, a night, a commons-hour. Write the bed, not the person, if they write at all.                                 | Will not follow them home with a pot. Will not open the gate after the share-hour because the wilt has started. |
| A family, before the town sees    | A parent is going to seed indoors           | Open the lot if there is a bed. Send them home with the hour named.                                                                | Will not make the wilt a sermon. Will not tell the warden unless the person asks.                               |
| A Struck Taken-In, raw            | They came through a green door later, alone | Find them dirt <i>now</i> . Point them at a door-keeper if the door still needs walking.                                           | Will not name them Given. Will not licence a grove.                                                             |
| A Book-hand with a settling       | The term <i>assumes</i> a greens-share      | Honour the term if there is a bed. Mark the slate <i>full</i> if there is not: the book becomes <i>owing</i> , not this lot's lie. | Will not invent a bed to close someone else's book.                                                             |
| A crown-clerk (Threnmaith)        | The tended green must match the channel     | Give the beds the roll already expects                                                                                             | Will not pretend a wilt off the lot is not happening. They also will not walk to it.                            |
| Almost no one who is not Taken-In | the ordinary week                           | Water. Turn tired beds. Argue beans.                                                                                               | Will not become a food-guild. Grain is a different door.                                                        |

## An ordinary week

They **open the gate**. That is the whole kindness. A Taken-In lies down on living ground. The tokens fill. They leave. The bed is turned. The next name, no, the next *row*, is watered.

They bury last year's commons-leaf under a new bed. No one will explain this to a guest. A first-year who asks is told *that is how the lot remembers*.

When the queue is longer than the wilt, they still open the gate for the share they have. They close it when the share is gone. They do not walk the three streets to the room where someone is going to seed. They know a cousin still has a pot. They do not say the cousin's name.

A child of the house learns the work by carrying water and by being told not to take the key home.

They will not follow you home. They will not rent a private pot after the share fails. They will not steal a scion to make a grove. They will not call the share a gift on Lestrand, or a debt anywhere they can help it. They call it a share. They will not run a Kumbaan export.

## Who may keep a lot

**Not by Kind.** A human, a Kitsune, a Tengu who will water and keep the gate can be of the house.

**By practice first.** You are of the house when the lot is still alive in the dry month, and the town still sends its Taken-In to you.

**Condition leans, not Condition-gates.** Watering and blight often fall to a Taken-In who kept a commons, or a Kept with no Tithe of their own who can sit the gate year-round. The slate to whoever can read a tired row, sometimes a Long-Lived who remembers which bed failed twenty years ago. The gate at close to a Kept, or anyone who will lock it.

## How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (Mother's-green hands).** The commons is a cousin's field. They will say they are tending a gift. The quiet obligation is the harvest: you were laid on the Mother's green, you will spend the green as the valley asks. When the field fails, the last pot is the Slide, and they will still call it tending.
- **Lestrand (lot-keepers).** Posted. A leaf-lot by the season. Coin on the gate. A Taken-In who cannot pay the season is not this lot's problem until they wilt in the street, and then they are the watch's. The Slide is the lot that still opens.
- **Threnmaieth (the Tended).** The crown furnishes the tended green and can withhold it. Beds match the channel. A wilt off the lot is a leak the roll does not want to file. The keepers look like gardeners. The leash is the water.
- **Kumbaan.** No.

## The gate

Whoever furnishes a provided-for Tithe holds power over its bearer. The greens-keepers hold that power *and refuse to carry it past the wall.*



That refusal is their kindness (they will not own you) and their cruelty (they will not walk three streets). The town is glad. A person who wilts *quietly* off the lot is not a public hazard. The Warm can say the gift was offered. The quay can say the season was posted. The crown can say the channel held.

A kind Mother, if she is there, does **not** open a free parlour-grove. The need for living land is the Tithe. People built the gate.

Tired beds are real. A lot can be botanically full and still have a queue. That is not a lie they tell. It is also a choice about who sleeps on stone.

## A bed-slate

Lestrand leaf-lot, nailed inside the gate. The verso is last season's slate, the tired rows still marked.

*Beds 1-12: taken through the next moon. 13-16: beans, do not lie here. 17 is tired; it will take next year. Share is one night or one hour at open sky, then the gate. If you cannot come, send no one. A bed is not a letter. We do not walk the rooms. If you have already wilted, the lot is still the lot. Come when we open. If you cannot wait, we do not know a pot.*

On its face: competent gardening, a little cold, a commons keeping itself honest. Underneath: the gate confessing itself, and a blindness the keeper cannot afford, that "we do not know a pot" is the only lie on the slate. The child who carries water can name the cousin. The slate cannot.

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## The Hall-Keepers

The lived face of official outlets and the Far-Voiced ticket. One lintel, because the seam Condition is the building. The ael-hall is a concert house until it is a release-valve. They furnish *enough* voice that a person can walk until tomorrow. They are not the Slide.

Everyday: **hall-keepers**, or **ael-hands**, in every register. The old proposed liturgical form *Aeloren* is retired: it sat too close to *Vaeloren*, *Leddoren*, and *Eoloren* and added no useful distinction. A crossed-out roster may still show it; no current hall uses it as a title. Vaethorn's second word is **gift-hall folk**; Lestrand's is **release-hands** (ordinary, like saying *box-office*); Threnmaieth files them as **counted-hall clerks**.

**In one sentence:** they sell you an hour in which you may feel in earnest, and they will not open after the lamps.

## Shape of the house

- **One building, two jobs.** The hall *furnishes* the outlet (Tithe-infra) and *stamps* the Voice-ticket (safety-guild). The same mouth that says *your hour is the third* says *you may stand in a crowded room*.
- **The hour is enough.** A scheduled vent: song, weeping, a relay-call, a laugh that empties the chest. The person should leave emptied and able to work. The Slide's shut room is one outlet that is never quite enough. This house wants you gone until tomorrow.
- **They think they are in a playhouse story.** Bills, benches, who carries the high note. They do not call themselves a police of feeling.
- **No high hall with authority.** The oldest playhouse on a Lestrand quay is old. The next town's hall does not write to it for leave.

## If you meet one

Ink on a finger, or chalk. A slate of hours. A hall that smells like sweat and lamp-oil and last night's joy. You would buy a bench and not know which hour was "church." You would find them if you asked *where a voice can be loud without becoming a Cry in the market*.

They are useful the way a well is useful, and the way a master's ticket is useful. A town with Far-Voiced and no hall has a Book-hand writing *owing* and a watch waiting for the market.

## Who comes, and when

| Who                                              | Why they come                                       | What the hall-keeper does                                                                                       | What they will not do                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A Given Far-Voiced child, after the colour       | The voice must be trained before it is a hazard     | Apprentice them: breath, projection, venting on purpose. The ticket comes when the town can stand next to them. | Will not Speak the colour. The warden did that. Will not call the voice a gift on Lestrand.                 |
| A working Far-Voiced (performer, crier, witness) | The vocation <i>is</i> the vent: self-paying        | Give them the stage, the relay-post, the stand. Stamp the year if the ticket is due.                            | Will not invent a crisis so they can vent off-slate.                                                        |
| A Far-Voiced who lost the honest stage           | Isolated posting, dull labor; the Undertow is close | Sell or grant a <b>scheduled hour</b> . Empty them. Send them out.                                              | Will not open after the lamps. Will not keep them half-full so they return tonight.                         |
| A Struck Far-Voiced, raw (the drowning-door)     | The voice came back untrained                       | Hand them to the Intake. Sit the first hour <i>with</i> Intake if the Cry is already in the room.               | Will not stamp a ticket on a raw throat. Will not leave them in the market.                                 |
| A Book-hand with a settling                      | The term <i>assumes</i> a seventh-day hour          | Honour it if the slate has a hole. Mark <i>full</i> if it does not.                                             | Will not pretend Greyhull has a bench when Greyhull is full.                                                |
| Anyone who came for a play                       | The hall is also the playhouse                      | Sell a bench. Take the coin. Let the working voices pay their Tithe <i>as</i> the show.                         | Will not stop a performance to process a ticket. The show <i>is</i> the Tithe for the people on the boards. |

## An ordinary week

**Morning: the slate.** Hours named. Relay-posts listed. A child's breath-lesson in the cold hall. The ticket-desk is a stool by the door.

**Evening: the house.** Feeling in earnest, on purpose, where a neighbour paid to hear it. This is the pleasant version of the Tithe, and it is also the town's entertainment. No one calls that a coincidence.

**The unswept bench.** One seat is never swept. *That's the first Cry's seat.* No one will explain which Cry. A first-year who sits there is moved without a sermon.

When a voice misses its hour, the keeper does not open the side door. They know a room that still shuts. They do not say the room's name.

They will not stamp a raw Struck. That is the Intake. They will not rewrite a Bound's Terms because a voice was used to swear them. They will not run a mission-hall on Kumbaan.

## Who may keep a hall

**Not by Kind.** A Selkie crier and a human neighbour hold the same stool if they can keep a slate and hear when a voice is about to break.

**By practice first.** You are of the house when the town still comes to your hour, and when you have pulled a child off a Cry before it landed.

The boards, the relay, the stand often go to Far-Voiced whose vocation is the vent. The ticket-stool to a Given Far-Voiced who trained young, or a sharp Kept, or a Long-Lived who remembers last century's Cry. The first hour with a raw throat to whoever will sit it. Intake borrows this room.

## How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (gift-hall folk).** A barn, a festival, a blessing said over the first note. Almost no ticket-stool. A Struck throat is a late gift and a hazard the valley will stand around, singing, until someone who has been to a real hall arrives. Soft injustice: you were given the hour, you will spend the voice as the valley asks: crier, witness, hymn.
- **Lestrand (release-hands).** The playhouse is the hall. Posted hours. Guild-ticket as master's papers. A voice without coin for a bench still has a labour-hour at the back if they will sweep. A voice without even that goes to week-rent.
- **Threnmaieth (counted-hall clerks).** The crown furnishes the counted hall and can withhold the hour. Tickets are crown-warrants in all but the stamp. A Cry off-slate is a column. The hall looks like a festival. The leash is the hour.
- **Kumbaan.** No. A bright night is not an ael-hall.

## The scheduled hour

The hall sells (or grants) the right to feel in public *on time*. Off-time is a ticket problem. A performer who lost the honest stage still has the hour, if the slate has a hole, if the season-fee was paid, if the crown still lists them.

The town is glad. An emptied voice is not a Cry in the market. The Warm can say the gift was aired. The quay can say the bill was posted. The crown can say the channel held.

The gift does not make the eighth week kind. A voice must vent. People built the slate.

Self-paying voices subsidize provided-for ones when the polity lets them. The show is some people's Tithe and other people's night out. Lestrاند calls this the market. Vaethorn calls this tending. Both can be true in one barn.

The first Cry's bench stays unswept. That is not a theology. It is how the hall remembers.

## An hour-slate

Lestrاند release-house, chalked on the door beside tonight's bill. The verso is yesterday's slate, not washed.

*Third hour: the boards (paid). Fifth: relay-drill, apprentices. Sixth: open hour, two benches, no coin if you sweep. After the lamps: the house is shut. A missed hour is a missed hour. We do not keep a throat half-full. If you have already cried in the street, this is still the house. Come at open, not now. If you cannot wait, we do not know a room.*

On its face: a playhouse being practical, almost kind (the sweep-hour). Underneath: the slate confessing the gate, and the same lie the greens tell: "we do not know a room." The first Cry's bench is not on the slate. Everyone knows which one it is.

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## The Stillers

The model safety-guild. They licence the Stilled. They run the infirmaries. They are not a census and not monster-police. Guild-issued tickets; the state watches the guild, not the person.

Everyday: **stillers**, or **the Stillers' Guild**. Liturgical: **the Stelhael** (stel-HAYL). *stel* "to still; to hold from moving" + *hael* "whole": those who *keep you hale by holding you still*. Vaethorn's second word is **blessing-surgeons**; Lestrاند's is **ticket-surgeons**; Threnmaieth files them as **crown-stillers**.

**In one sentence:** they will save you on the table, and they will make you drill until the Grey is gone. The Grey is the stillness that collects when they use the Gaze, a clock toward stone. The ticket is competence, and the clock in the surgeon is the hospital's clock.

## Shape of the house

- **The model the others imitate.** If you understand this guild, you understand a Voice-ticket and an element-ticket. A roster of practitioners of a dangerous art. Not a list of a people.
- **Two rooms, one clock.** The infirmary (wonder) and the yard (spar, patrol, the riot-line). Using the Gaze *fills* the Grey. The yard empties it. The guild's best work creates the guild's Tithe. That is not a paradox they have solved. It is the job.
- **They think they are in a surgeon's-college story.** Apprentices, a code, a ticket like a master's papers. They do not call themselves keepers of monsters.
- **No Stillers' pope.** A rich core infirmary is rich. A frontier stiller is one tired person. The charter is local. The state watches the charter.

## If you meet one

Calm. Flat-eyed when they are working. Hair that stirs when something nearby has gone too still. You meet them in an infirmary, on a drill-floor, or on a line that has not yet become a massacre. You would not know which hour was "guild" unless you already needed a ticket.

They are useful the way a surgeon is useful. A town without one makes do with a rope-and-prayer.

## Who comes, and when

| Who                                     | Why they come                                      | What the stiller does                                                                                | What they will not do                                                             |
|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A Given Stilled child, after pale stone | The Gaze must be trained before it is a forever    | Apprentice them. Drill. Theatre. The ticket when they can still a wound and not a person.            | Will not Speak the colour. Will not put them on a riot-line in the first year.    |
| A patient                               | Bleeding, poison, a knife that needs a still field | Hold the moment. Work fast. Walk to the yard after and burn the Grey.                                | Will not hold a will. Cannot. Will not still a person as punishment.              |
| The watch, or a street that is turning  | A brawl about to become a pile of bodies           | Stand the line. Still the swing, not the person, if they can help it.                                | Will not become the town's executioner. A forever-hold is a crime the code names. |
| A Struck Stilled, raw (they were stone) | The Grey is already in them, unpracticed           | Hand them to the Intake. Sit the first drill <i>with</i> Intake. Reverse what can still be reversed. | Will not stamp a ticket on a raw Gaze. Will not leave them in the square.         |
| A charter-clerk                         | Someone unlicensed stills in public                | Protect the charter: take them in, or swear they were not of the house                               | Will not write the town's people down. A guild-roll is not a Threnhael.           |
| Anyone who wants the Gaze as a weapon   | no honest errand                                   | Refuse. The code is the ticket.                                                                      | Will not sell a forever. Anyone who does is not of this house.                    |

## An ordinary week

**Theatre.** The pleasant horror outsiders remember: a gaze that stops blood, a surgeon who must then go and *move*. Between patients they drill. They spar. They dance, badly, because dance works the Grey out. No one calls this therapy in the core; they call it the job.

**The doorknob.** They touch a doorknob before they look at a patient. If the knob has gone still under an unwatched Gaze, the room is already wrong. A first-year who forgets is sent back to the yard.

**The yard.** Exertion on purpose. The Tithe paid as professional identity.

**The ticket-stool.** A master's mark. Held by the person. The guild *knows its members* the way any craft does. In Lestrاند the ticket can start to behave like property: a place, a chair, a name on a door. That is

the house's live argument, not a world-law.

When a raw Struck arrives, the paying floor loses a master for a week. The guild is not grateful. That week is the Intake.

They will not still a will. They cannot. They will not pretend they can to frighten a street. They will not let the Grey run to a public seize if they can still drag the person to the yard. A seize on the floor is a ruined charter. They will not become Threnmaieth's register. A roll of *stillers* is not a roll of *the Stilled*. They will not export a college across the storm-wall.

## Who may hold a ticket

**Not by Kind.** The Gaze does not care what you were born.

**By practice first.** You are of the house when you can still a wound and then *move*, and when the town has watched you do both.

Theatre and the line go to the Stilled. The Tithe and the vocation are the same shape. The yard to anyone who will make them *move*: a Kept drill-master; a Two-Bodied who will run them. Intake week to the master who can be spared (often the one the floor can least spare), or a Struck who remembers stone and will sit the first drill.

Skeptics are welcome. The Gaze does not require a Mother. Believers in Vaethorn will still say a blessing-to-practice. Both can hold the same ticket.

## How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (blessing-surgeons).** One tired stiller, a blessing-to-practice, a riot-line that is also the only theatre. Almost no college. Soft injustice: you were trained, you will stand every line the valley has. The rope is still how a raw Struck is met if the stiller is three valleys away.
- **Lestrand (ticket-surgeons).** Superb infirmaries. Guild-ticket as property-adjacent. You can be priced out of the chair. The charter is a commercial good. Unlicensed practice threatens the charter as much as the street.
- **Threnmaieth (crown-stillers).** The crown wants the ticket as a crown-warrant and the roll as a column. Some masters cooperate (stewardship). Some refuse: a guild-roll is not a Threnhael. The Gaze that saves you runs through a channel that can be withheld from a household the crown dislikes. The darkest infirmery in the world, still a real infirmery.
- **Kumbaan.** A travelling stiller is a guest, not a chapter.



## The Grey as labor

The guild's best work *fills* the clock that will lock a limb if they do not then labor. So the house needs them on the table and in the yard. The charter needs them never to lapse in public. The infirmary's pace is set by the surgeon's Grey as much as by the patient.

This is not a scion-queue. It is not a week. It is a hospital that runs on its staff's Tithe.

The ticket-as-property argument (Lestrand, leaking elsewhere) is the second face: competence lives in a person; the chair can start to live in the guild.

The gift does not make the drill optional. A gaze costs. People wrote the roster.

Intake is badly paid. The raw Struck who most need a week in the shed are the week the floor can least spare. That is why Intake is the underdog, not a prestige rotation.

## A Grey-drill roster

Core infirmary, chalked on the yard wall. The verso is yesterday's, washed badly.

*After third theatre: spar, full glass. After the line: the long run, no Gaze. Apprentices: the knob first, always. A Grey that stays overnight is a Grey we file as lapse, not as rest. The shed is not on this wall. If you were stone last week, you are not on this wall. Come to the door that does not face the street. We do not write that door. We do not still a person to close a day. Touch the knob. Then look.*

On its face: a college keeping its people hale, the code in a work-order. Underneath: the paying floor confessing that Intake is a door they will not write, and a blindness the master cannot afford, that "a Grey we file as lapse" is how a tired surgeon becomes a charter problem instead of a person who needs a longer run. The knob is not explained. It does not need to be.

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## The Element-Guilds

The third safety-ticket and the self-paying craft: the Answered channelled by element. **One sector, four doors.** Not four cloned orders.

Everyday: **the element-guilds**, or the **Ember-house**, **Tide-house**, **Root-house**, **Gale-house**. Umbrella: **the Crae** (kray). *crae* "craft; the working of an element." A single Answered is *of the Crae*; they are *of*

Ember if you need the door. Vaethorn's second word is **gift-shops**; Lestrang's is **the craft-houses**; Threnmaith files **the Reckoned Craes**.

**In one sentence:** the shop is the Tithe. Leaving it is not a career change. It is a hazard with your name on it.

## Shape of the house

- **Four doors, one grammar.** Ember (smiths, glass, firefighting). Tide (hulls, dyers, anything that wants water to behave). Root (masons, potters, the carrying-earth a Road-hand may buy). Gale (sails, mills, instruments, the wind a Tengu already knew). They share a ticket-logic and an Intake shed. They do not share a pope. An Ember-master does not set Tide's fees.
- **Self-paying until you leave.** Earnest work slakes the Tithe. The guild is therefore the upkeep. That is why the monopoly has metaphysical teeth: a benched Answered is unemployed, and idle.
- **They think they are in a craft-mystery story.** Apprenticeships, shop-rules, which coal may go dark. They do not call themselves elemental police.
- **Wildcard standing stays.** An even-tempered Root potter and a short-fused Ember smith share a name and almost nothing else.

## If you meet one

Sweat, clay, salt, or chalk-dust, depending on the door. A shop-rule nailed up. A ticket-stool that looks like any master's. You would hire them to build a hull. You would find the *ticket* if you asked *who may let an element speak in a crowded yard*.

They are useful the way a craft guild is useful. A late-medieval town already needed smiths and masons. The Condition made the guilds necessary twice: once for the work, once so the work does not let go.

## Who comes, and when

| Who                                      | Why they come                                               | What the house does                                                                                           | What they will not do                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A Given Answered child, after lamp-amber | The shade named the element; the shop must catch them young | Apprentice to <i>that</i> door. Earnest work. The ticket when the element answers the hands and not the room. | Will not Speak the colour. Will not switch a child's element because the town needed Tide.                                                |
| A working Answered                       | The craft is the Tithe                                      | Give them the shop, the watch-rotation, the fire-crew, the escort.                                            | Will not bench them "for a rest" without a plan. Idle is the hazard.                                                                      |
| An Answered who lost the shop            | Grief, a wrecked yard, a lord who benched them              | Find earnest use <i>now</i> : a crew, a demolition, a night at the bellows.                                   | Will not rent them a week of "just enough spark." That is a Slide-shaped lie.                                                             |
| A Struck Answered, raw                   | A threshold let an element in later, untrained              | The Intake. The right door, not the nearest fire.                                                             | Will not stamp a ticket on a raw Reach. Will not put them on a hull the same day.                                                         |
| Anyone who wants a thing made            | A hull, a glass, a wall, a sail                             | Make it. Charge as a craft charges.                                                                           | Will not let an unlicensed cousin "just coax the stone" in the street. The charter is the street's safety <i>and</i> the shop's monopoly. |
| A Road-hand needing carrying-earth       | Root can coax living earth to travel                        | Sell the earth. Do not walk the scion.                                                                        | Will not become Thaelvaeth. Different cart.                                                                                               |

## Four doors (faces, not chapters)

| Door  | The work                      | The shop-rule you notice                              | If left idle                      |
|-------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Ember | smith, glass, fire-crew       | they never let the last coal go dark                  | heat finds a place to be          |
| Tide  | hull, dye, anything wet       | a cup of yesterday's water on the lintel              | water finds a place to be         |
| Root  | mason, potter, carrying-earth | clay under the nails they will not wash on a work-day | stone and soil find a place to be |
| Gale  | sail, mill, instrument        | a window that is never fully shut                     | wind finds a place to be          |

The “place to be” is self-contained, never a seized will. The guild’s job is to make sure that place is the shop, not the crowded hall.

## An ordinary week

The shop. The rotation (fire-crew, escort, the watch that is also Tithe). The ticket-stool. The shop-rule no one explains to a guest.

When a master is pulled to Intake, the paying floor loses a Reach for a week. Ember hates this during a dry month. Tide hates this when a hull is mid-bend. That hatred is why Intake is the underdog.

They will not switch an element to suit a labour shortage. The shade named it. They will not bench “for their own good” without earnest use waiting. That is how a room lets go. They will not stamp a raw Struck. They will not become a fourth clergy. They will not export a Crae-college to Kumbaan.

## Who may hold a ticket

**Not by Kind.** Ember is not a Drakona chapter. Gale is not a Tengu chapter. A Tengu Gale-Answered is a common *lean*, not a gate.

**By practice first.** You are of the house when the element answers your work and not the rafters.

The shop goes to the Answered of that element. Fire-crew and rescue rotations to Ember and Gale, also Two-Bodied on the line and Returned in the wreck. Carrying-earth to Root, also Taken-In who will not call it a grove-rite. Kept labor is the free generalist around the Reach: strikers, pullers, the person who holds the mundane tool. Lestrاند’s *free*. Vaethorn’s *Waited*, still useful.

## How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (gift-shops).** One mixed yard, four tools, a blessing-to-practice. Soft injustice: you were answered, you will spend the element as the valley asks: the mill, the wall, the fire-line. Idle is rare because the valley will not let a gift sit.
- **Lestrand (the craft-houses).** Deep shops, posted tickets, monopoly-teeth. You can be priced out of the *chair* and still need the work, which is how a person slides from self-paying to exposed overnight. The charter is money and safety in one paper.
- **Threnmaieth (the Reckoned Craes).** The crown wants element and person on the same column. Workshops are channels. A benched Answered is a withheld Reach. The shop looks like a gift-works. The leash is the fire, the slip, the stone, the wind.
- **Kumbaan.** A wrecked Tide-Answered is a guest. There is no Tide-house on the sand.

## The shop you cannot leave

Self-paying is an economist's miracle until you want to stop. The Tithe does not care that you buried a child, that the yard burned, that you are tired of glass. Idle, the element speaks for itself.

So the guild's kindness (a shop, a crew, a rotation) is also the leash. Leaving is a Tithe-crisis. The Warm calls that vocation. The quay calls that a contract. The crown calls that a channel.

The gift does not make a rest-year safe. An element answered. People built the shop-rule.

The last coal, the cup of yesterday, the unwashed clay, the window that will not shut: those are how each door remembers.

## A shop-rule

Ember-house, Lestrand glass-yard, nailed above the last coal. The verso is a Tide-house rule from the next quay, used as backing.

*The last coal stays. A Reach used in play is not a Reach used in earnest: the ticket will not have it, and the room will. If you cannot work, you will still work: the fire-crew, the night bellows, the watch. We do not bench. We do not rent a spark. The shed is not this door; raw hands go to the door that does not face the street. If you have already let go, this is still the house. Come to the coal, not to the square. Gale will not take you. Tide will not take you. The coal will.*

On its face: a craft keeping its people steady, a little fierce, a monopoly wearing safety. Underneath: exit refused as care, and a blindness the master cannot afford, that "we do not bench" is also *you may*

*not leave.* The Tide-rule on the verso says the same thing about a cup of water. The two houses did not copy each other. They did not have to.

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## The Intake

The shared underdog office of the Stillers, the Hall-Keepers, and the Element-Guilds: mandatory guild-intake for dangerous Struck. Not clergy. Not a travelling circuit. Not the Slide.

Everyday: **the Intake**, or **the raw-desk**, or **the shed**. Guild-cant: **the catching-year**. There is no liturgical name. An office that the paying floor will not write on the wall does not get a holy one. Vaethorn says **the late-catching**; Lestrاند says **the emergency ticket**; Threnmaieth files **the unwitnessed warrant**.

**In one sentence:** they have a week to make a live hazard into a person the town will stand next to, and if they succeed, no one writes it down.

## Shape of the office

- **A door, not a road.** The Struck is brought *here*, or a runner arrives and a master is pulled off the paying floor. They are not a circuit. When they travel it is because the nearest ticket-house is three days and the rope is already in someone's hand: an accident of distance, not a route. The Road-hands already have the route.
- **Three ticket-houses, one shed-logic.** A raw Gaze, a raw throat, a raw Reach. Right house. Wrong house is how a Cry gets stilled quiet or an Ember is put on a bench to sing. The office is shared; the door is not.
- **They think they are in a first-aid story.** Catch. Steady. Hand to the year. They do not think they are in a redemption-play.
- **Success is silence.** The guild leadership is **indifferent-to-hostile**. A quiet catching-year is a week the floor lost. A loud one is a charter hearing. No one converts. A grudging extra pair of hands is the most the yard will grant, and they will take them back.

## The underdog shape

- **Mandate.** Take a raw Struck (Stilled / Far-Voiced / Answered) in hand *and* begin the apprenticeship at once, before the town meets them with a rope. The enemy is **time**, an already-live hazard, and a town that wants them *gone*.
- **Constraints.** The shed that does not face the street: not the theatre, not the boards, not the paying shop. One master pulled off the floor, whoever will sit, maybe a Kept who has no Tithe of their

own. They can take the person *if the person will come*. They cannot overrule a frontier rope. They cannot stamp a ticket this week. The charter is at risk if the person harms someone *or* if they refuse the Struck and the town later says the guild left a hazard. Leadership forgot them on a good day and will scapegoat them on a bad one. Support is **conditional** on silence.

- **Who ends up on it.** Not a Kind-unit. Not the floor's favourites. The master who can be spared (often the one who cannot). A Kept who will sit because they are *free* and the floor resents that. A Struck who remembers their own door. A junior ticket on probation. Formation is **assigned** or **inherited**, last year's leftovers, more often than recruited.
- **Victory.** The person is still alive, still here, and beginning to be *safe to stand next to*. The town pretends this was always going to happen. The guild does not apologize.

## If you meet one

Tired. Chalk on a sleeve. A key to a door the slate does not name. You would miss them if you came in the front of the infirmary or the playhouse. You would find them if you asked *where the one who was stone yesterday went*, or if you were the runner.

They are useful the way a midwife is useful, except the birth is a later becoming and the town may prefer it not happen.

## Who comes, and when

| Who                                        | Why they come                                  | What Intake does                                                                                                                | What they will not do                                                                            |
|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A raw Stilled<br>(they were stone)         | Grey already filling; a rope in the square     | Get them off the square. First drill. Reverse what can still be reversed. Sit the Gaze until it is a wound-hold, not a forever. | Will not stamp a ticket. Will not still the crowd as a lesson.                                   |
| A raw Far-Voiced (they drowned)            | Undertow already pulling; a Cry in the market  | Get them into the hall's back room. First hour <i>with</i> a hall-keeper if one will sit. Vent on purpose before it vents them. | Will not open after the lamps as policy. Will not keep them half-full.                           |
| A raw Answered                             | An element let go later, untrained             | Right door. Earnest use <i>now</i> that is not the crowded shop.                                                                | Will not put them on a hull the same day. Will not bench them.                                   |
| A family, or a door-keeper, or a Book-hand | Someone must stand; someone wrote <i>owing</i> | Take the person. Ask who will stand for them <i>as what they are now</i> .                                                      | Will not sell a vouch. Will not call them Given.                                                 |
| The watch                                  | The square wants them gone                     | Bargain for the shed instead of the rope. Sometimes lose.                                                                       | Will not fight the town as a knightly order. They have a key, not a charter to command a street. |
| The paying floor                           | They want their master back                    | Finish the week or fail it. Return the master.                                                                                  | Will not promise this will not happen again.                                                     |

## An ordinary catching-year (it is not ordinary)

There is no ordinary week. There is a week.

1. Get them off the square, out of the water, away from the shop that is already wrong.
2. Name what is already true: *you carry a Gaze; you carry a voice; you carry a Reach*. Do not name a Mother unless the person does.
3. Find the first honest payment of the Tithe that is not a public hazard: a drill, an hour, a coal that is not the public forge.
4. Find someone who will stand for them *anew*. Intake is not a hiding-place from the vouching seam.
5. At week's end: still raw, beginning to be safe, handed to the real apprenticeship, or gone. Gone means the rope, the road, or a week-keeper who will not make them safe.



They write the catching-year on the **inside** of a ticket-blank, not on the face. The face stays empty until a real ticket is earned. A first-year who writes on the face is made to strike it.

They will not stamp a ticket this week. Competence is not a week old. They will not become a circuit. If they must walk, it is toward *this* Struck, not along a route. They will not rewrite Bound Terms. A raw Bound is a table's problem, not a shed's. The Whisper cannot command; they are not this office. They will not take a raw Taken-In, Returned, Two-Bodied, Long-Lived. No bystander ticket. Those doors have other houses.

## Who may sit the shed

**Not by Kind.** By practice first: you sat a week and the person did not become a public story.

The first drill / hour / coal to a ticket-holder of *that* hazard. The sitting, the water, the food to a Kept (no Tithe of their own; can stay). "I remember the door" to a Struck who came through Intake once. The runner to whoever can run: Two-Bodied; a Far-Voiced crier who will not use the Cry to clear a street.

## How they live with the other houses

The parent houses pretend the shed is not on the wall. Success is silence. A raw Taken-In is *not* this shed. Dirt is the lot. If the week fails, a week-keeper may take the overflow. Intake wants them *safe enough to leave*. The Slide wants them *not-fallen enough to stay*. A quiet receiving-rite may happen the same week as a warden's. Civic settling may *send* them here. A door-keeper names the Struck *kin* at the door that made them; kinship is not a ticket. Two courtesies in one week. A Watcher's second mouth may describe the threshold; description is not a stamp.

## How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (the late-catching).** The rope is real. The shed may be a barn. Soft injustice: once caught, the valley will spend them. The late-come are vouched graciously *and* put to work.
- **Lestrand (the emergency ticket).** Posted, almost. A fee if anyone can pay it. The charter-risk is commercial. A raw Struck who cannot stamp a fee is still taken, the street-hazard demands it, and the house will remember the debt.
- **Threnmaieth (the unwitnessed warrant).** The crown wants the Struck *named* as they are caught. Intake's inside-writing is already a defiance. A quiet week looks like a leak. A loud week looks like incompetence. The darkest pressure: catch them for the channel.
- **Kumbaan.** A wreck walked uphill is a guest. There is no shed on the sand.

## The week no one writes

The paying floor needs the master. The town needs the hazard gone. The Struck needs a year. Intake is given a week and a shed, and is blamed for all three.

If they succeed, the story becomes: *the guild trains its own*. If they fail, the story becomes: *the shed*. The gift does not make the rope kind, and does not give them a better door. The becoming was unwitnessed. People built the square that prefers a rope.

Badly paid. The parent house's leftover stipend. In kind: the shed, the food, the master's lost week. They do not furnish a commons. They do not sell an hour. They catch.

## A catching-year slip

Written on the inside of a blank ticket, stillers' shed, core town. The face is empty.

*Inside only. Gaze, raw. Came from stone on the third night. Stood for by the sister and by N. who will not give a family name. First drill held. No forever. No ticket. If the week ends quiet, burn this. If it does not, the charter already knows. We do not face the street. We do not write the wall. If they have already been a rope-story, this is still the shed. Come if they will come. If they will not, we cannot make a town take them. The Mother does not reach twice by chance. Neither do we. That line is the wardens'. Strike it if you must. I have not.*

On its face: a competent catching, a little desperate, a college's shame in a folded paper. Underneath: the office stealing the Seat's sentence because it is the only heavy line the writer knows, and a blindness they cannot afford, that "burn this" is how success becomes the guild's ordinary story and the Struck's becoming stays unwitnessed *twice*. The empty face is the point. The sister stood. N. would not be named. Both are the vouching seam in one slip.

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## Three corners: Vaethorn, Lestrang, Threnmaieth

Every polity in the Turning sets three knobs, independently: theology, reach, governance. The three grammars (law, economy, daily life) are portable. They hold across the great powers because they flow from the Trees and the Conditions, which are universal. A polity's character is the **combination** of the three axes it sets separately.

Three corners, chosen so that each pair shares exactly one axis and differs on the other two.

| Name                                            | Theology | Reach | Governance | The one-line feel                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------------------------|----------|-------|------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Vaethorn</b> ( <i>the Waiting Lands</i> )    | high     | low   | low        | Ardent faith, thin Trees, almost no state: a warm, poor, half-lawless pilgrim edge                       |
| <b>Lestrand</b> ( <i>the Ledger Coast</i> )     | low      | high  | low        | Faith worn lightly, dense Trees, guilds not crowns: a rich, cool, transactional merchant power           |
| <b>Threnmaieth</b> ( <i>the Tallied Crown</i> ) | high     | high  | high       | Sacred <i>and</i> surveilled: a wealthy, pious core where the census is a holy duty (the darkest corner) |

- Vaethorn and Lestrand share **low governance**: same light-touch state, opposite everything else. Warm-poor-faithful against rich-cool-secular.
- Vaethorn and Threnmaieth share **high theology**: same ardent faith, wildly different circumstances. Devotion at the starving edge against devotion in the sanctified, watched core.
- Lestrand and Threnmaieth share **high reach**: same Tree-wealth spent two opposite ways. Free markets against a sanctified panopticon.

Theology is not a moral axis. High-theology produces both the *kindest* corner to a whole neighbour (Vaethorn) and the *most inescapable* control in the world (Threnmaieth). Devotion is a multiplier on whatever else the polity is, not a virtue or a vice by itself.

The name a polity gives a shared institution reveals its stance. A devout land’s “gift-hall” is a surveillance-crown’s “counted hall.” Same building, three worldviews.

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## Vaethorn: the Waiting Lands

(*vay-THORN* · *theology high* · *reach low* · *governance low*)

A broad, thinly-peopled land at the world’s Tree-poor margin, where the faith burns hottest *because* the Trees are scarce, and where the ruling mood is *waiting*: for a graft to take, for a distant Tree to be reached, for a gift that may never fall. This is the Frontier with the theology knob turned all the way up. The combination is a feedback loop. Where the Trees are few and young, more children come away Kept, more people are Struck later and alone, and the Motherfaith answers that scarcity with *more* devotion, not less: pilgrimage, longing, and a theology built around waiting for a gift that may not come.

**Law here.** Governance is almost absent. No crown reaches the individual, and custom outruns written law the way it does on any frontier. Citizenship is witnessed in the oldest, most literal way: a settlement small enough that everyone *was* there when you Turned. The Lands' thin reach makes citizenship-by-witness fragile. With few Long-Lived to remember and few Bound to vouch, the three pillars that make proof-by-people work are stretched thin, and the **unvouched Struck** (a person who changed alone, with no guild to catch them and few witnesses to stand for them) is a constant, aching problem Vaethorn meets with faith rather than machinery. A feared Condition here is more likely to be met with a rope or a blessing than a licence, because there is no guild to issue one. Standing-for is *the speaking*, vouched at worship. The ticket is *the blessing-to-practice*. The will is *the Mother's own line*.

**Economy here.** Little formal Tithe-infrastructure and few specialists, but the theology reframes the frontier's poverty as *charity*. Where a purely secular frontier improvises Tithe-provision as barter and favor, Vaethorn does it as **alms and congregation**: the venting a Far-Voiced needs happens at worship (the *gift-hall*), the green a Taken-In needs is furnished by neighbours who count it a sacred duty (*the Mother's green*), and the Taken-In whom rich cities keep at arm's length are here the honoured **backbone of the land**. Working the living earth is the holy economy. It is commons-minded generosity with almost nothing to fund it: real warmth, real want, and a persistent thin edge where the provided-for Tithe-poor slide with only prayer for a net. The ranging is *the wild-leave*. The long-house of books is *the deathless gift*. The Slide here is *the last pot / gift-credit*.

**Daily life here.** Thin ceremony made enormous by devotion. A child's Turning at a small, hard-won grafted Tree is the event of a decade, held as a joyous, anxious sacrament, and the **Kept child is felt most sharply here**, because in a land starved of the gift, to be passed over reads (wrongly, and cruelly) as being passed over *by the Mother herself*. The Kept are *the Waited / Mother-kept*. The Struck are *the late-come*. Medicine is a travelling stiller if the settlement is lucky and a rope-and-prayer if it is not; the core-vs-edge inequity is at its widest here. Families are warm, mixed, and self-reliant; a lapsing Condition with no infirmary to reach is a frontier tragedy the faith consoles but cannot cure. The warden is most of the state: Hands-folk. The door-folk keep the older state the land still keeps. Guest-reading towns pilgrimage *and* walk. First-reading districts tend a dying guest and refuse the blessing.

**Its injustice** (*the soft-frontier blend*). Not a boot. A **guilt**. The scarcity of the gift becomes a theology of *unworthiness*: the Kept wonder what they lacked, the Struck wonder why the Mother came to them at the wrong door and alone, and a hard, quiet piety can shade into treating want as a spiritual failing. Vaethorn is the kindest place in the world to a whole neighbour and the loneliest to an unvouched one.

**The seat.** **Eolvaeth** (*ay-ohl-VAYTH*), a pilgrim-edge vale behind the Strandoren-facing coast. People walk *here to wait*. The Tree is not a certainty.

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## Lestrand: the Ledger Coast

(*leh-STRAND · theology low · reach high · governance low*)

A dense, Tree-rich merchant power where the Trees are mature and many, the Given are dense, and the faith is worn *lightly*. Deep markets, thin welfare, and a cool, transactional read on the whole business of becoming. It shares Vaethorn's light-touch governance: no crown writes anyone down. Where Vaethorn's light state leaves a *gap the faith fills*, Lestrand's light state leaves a *space the guilds fill*, completely.

**Law here.** The world's warm default at its most developed: **guild self-rule** carried as far as it goes. The state is a charter-granting council of merchant houses and craft-guilds; it charters the Stilled's guild and the element-guilds and watches the guild, never the individual. Citizenship-by-witness runs *smoothly* here because reach is high: abundant Long-Lived notaries, Bound whose sworn word closes every contract, Far-Voiced on every dock and in every court. The three pillars aren't reverence here; they're **infrastructure**, the machinery that lets a huge commercial city run on trust without a register. The Struck are vouched-in briskly and without much fuss, not graciously, just *efficiently*, because an unvouched person is a transaction that can't clear. They are *the turned*. The Inviolable Will is cited less as sacred bedrock than as sound commercial law: a Bound's contract binds property, not persons, and the Coast likes that line because it makes the Bound the perfect notary. Standing-for is *warranting*. The ticket is *the guild-ticket*. The will is *the free-will clause*. The Motherfaith is *the old rite*, worn light. The Fair Hand is *the Settling*, ordinary.

**Economy here.** The richest corner, and the coolest. This is where **deathless banking** reaches full flower: deathless houses whose trusted notes are the nearest thing the world has to a gold standard, century instruments, the whole endow-not-inherit loop running at scale (the great endowed libraries and universities cluster here, funding the Long-Lived's own novelty-Tithe). Self-paying Conditions prosper, the Answered crafts, the Two-Bodied haulage and courier trades, the Stilled surgeons, because their labor *is* their upkeep and the market pays for the labor. **Tithe-provision is a private market, not a public good:** you buy your green (*the leaf-lot*), your novelty (*the endowment / the house*), your outlet (*the release-house*, also the playhouse), and if you can afford it you stay whole in comfort. **Its injustice is the market's.** The provided-for Tithe-poor get *thin welfare in a rich city*, the starkest have-and-have-not gap in the world, and the shadow economy (smuggled green, black-market novelty, sold vouching, off-book Bound contracts feeding the Given-Over) runs biggest here because the legitimate market is biggest here. The concentration risk the deathless pose is at its most acute: a handful of houses that never die, quietly steering the wealthiest polity through patronage that never disperses. The Slide is *week-rent*. The Kept are *the free*. The ranging is *the beast-yard*. Tree-wardens are *tree-tenders*. Book-hands are *the Settling-hands*.

**Daily life here.** Superb Condition-medicine (the great Stilled infirmaries and deathless-endowed hospitals are *here*, in the rich core), for those who can reach it; the queue outside it is longest here too.

Family life shrugs at theology: a **marriage market that reads Conditions as assets**, a Two-Bodied bloodline is a trade dynasty, a Long-Lived match is a century of credit, and the aching Long-Lived marriage gets weighed coolly as a balance of grief against advantage. The Turning is a civic and commercial milestone more than a sacrament. A family's Leaf-Fall is watched for what guild the child's colour opens. Warm it is not; free and prosperous it very much is. An attic-host of the Open Table is a curiosity and a good supper; "no one is a stranger twice" is printed, by sailors, as a proverb on a card. The Settling will not enforce it.

**Its injustice** (*the market blend*). The coolest of the three. Nothing is *policed*. Your marriage, your gift, your faith are your own. Everything is *priced*, and a person who cannot pay slides with a whole rich city stepping around them. Lestrang will never file you or conscript you. It will simply let you fade if you run out of coin, and feel that it owed you nothing.

**The seat. Orentel** (*or-EN-tel*), a salt-quay city on the inner sea. The White Note House sits on the third quay, north side, and is not the crown.

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## Threnmaith: the Tallied Crown

(*THREN-my-eth · theology high · reach high · governance high; the darkest corner*)

A pious, Tree-rich core kingdom that is also Watchful. Take the Watchful touchstone, the one aberrant crown that breaks the world's norm and keeps *a census of persons and their Conditions*, and set it in the wealthiest, most devout, most Tree-dense land, and you get surveillance not as a nervous king's paranoia but as **sanctified duty**: the roster is kept because the Mother's gifts are precious and must be *accounted for*. This is what makes it the darkest of the three. The other two have injustices you can name and resent. This one dresses its injustice in the two things the world most trusts, faith and plenty.

**Law here.** The aberration in full sacred flower. Alone among polities, the Tallied Crown keeps a **record held on people**: every subject and their gift written down, not as guild rolls or tax ledgers (everyone has those) but as a **census of persons**, framed at home as reverent stewardship of the Mother's blessings and experienced as exactly what it is, surveillance. The census is the **Threnhael**. Because reach is high, there is a great deal to count: dense Given (*the marked*), dense guilds, abundant Long-Lived whose memory the crown *distrusts because it isn't the crown's*. Threnmaith's deepest tell: it will not rely on the three pillars the rest of the world runs on, because living memory answers to itself and a ledger answers to the crown. The **unvouched are hunted and the Struck pursued to be catalogued** (*the unwitnessed*); the Bound are watched far past their real hazard, pure stigma dressed as safety, since the Inviolable Will means the Whisper can't command and the roster's own clerks know it. Devotion supplies the justification the bare Watchful crown lacks: *you would not hide a gift from the Mother, so why hide it from her stewards?* Standing-for is *the naming*. The ticket is *the crown-warrant*.

The will is *the crown's assurance*. The Motherfaith is *the Reckoned Faith*. Watchers are *the Grown-Over*, a column on the roll. Book-hands are *the Uncounted Book*. Door-keepers are *the Unreached*. The Open Table is off the map.

**Economy here.** Tithe-need turned to leverage, and consecrated. The crown provides Tithe-upkeep **efficiently, even generously** (a pious, rich state can afford to), but *holds* what it provides: the green (*the tended green*), the novelty (*the crown archive*), the outlets (*the counted hall*), the Stilled medicine, all furnished through channels the crown controls and can withhold. A population whose staying-whole runs through the state is a population that **cannot afford to refuse it**, the most complete control in the world, and here it wears a halo. To receive your Tithe-provision is to receive the Mother's bounty through her appointed hands, and to be cut off is framed as *your* lapse, not the crown's lever. Its deathless-house finance is superb and centuries-deep, but the Long-Lived here are courtiers and crown-archivists as much as bankers, their incorruptible memory bent to the census rather than free to check it. The ranging is *the ranging-roll*. The furnishing is *the counted channel*. The Slide is *the late week*: the leak the roll cannot file without admitting the channel failed. The roll pretends not to know.

**Daily life here.** The sacrament and the census fused. A child's Turning is a **joyous holy day that is also a state registration**. The colour that falls is celebrated with a hymn *and* recorded by a clerk. Marriages of heritable Conditions (Two-Bodied bloodlines especially) are *noticed*, encouraged or discouraged, filed. The medicine that furnishes a Tithe is excellent and runs through the crown's channels. A household whose **bloodline and upkeep are both on file** is a household that cannot easily refuse the crown anything: domestic surveillance with a blessing said over it. The Kept are *pitied* here in the Warm's way *and* recorded in the Watchful's: *the unmarked / the passed-over*, passed over by the Mother, and noted as such. Tree-wardens are *the Reckoned Hands*. The First Seat stands in the same Sacred Core. The crown wants wardens named to the Threnhael as officers of the Reckoned Faith. Some Speakers cooperate. Some refuse: the Tree witnessed; a ledger is a second, lesser seeing. Proximity is pressure, not ownership. The college can refuse the roll, and some Speakers don't. A Yumboe in the Sacred Core is a diplomatic incident of manners, not a column. The crown cannot file a people who were never at a Tree. That is a relief and a slight at once.

**Its injustice** (*the sanctified-surveillance blend*). The worst of both the high knobs, each excusing the other. The devotion sanctifies the surveillance (*it is reverence to be counted*), and the surveillance enforces the devotion (*to refuse the count is impiety*). There is no clean villain. A wealthy, faithful, orderly people genuinely believe that accounting for the Mother's gifts is the highest form of tending them, and a machinery of control that this belief makes almost impossible to resist. It reads as chilling because **no other polity keeps such a list**. The creepy record is this one crown's invention, and the faith is what lets it feel like grace.

**The seat. Maiethlir** (*my-eth-LEER*), a thaw-river Hand in the Sacred Core. The extra mile is the leftover; the Threnhael is the layer. Does not own Thaeloren. The First Seat sits in the Motherwood beside.

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BOOK V

## The Lands



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# The Four Continents

The map of the Turning is a **gradient of the Trees' reach**. Reach is how far the origin Tree's wood has spread.

**sacred-dense origin** → **mercantile middle** → **thin frontier** → **storm-walled isle beyond**

There is one Awakening Tree, **Thaeloren**. Every town Tree is a living **graft** of it: a cutting of that same wood, planted in new ground. The further a land sits from the deep, old, densely-grafted core, the thinner its reach tends to run: fewer, younger, more fragile Trees. More children are left among the Kept. More people are Struck later and alone. The physical map and the cosmological map are the same map. In the world this reads as plain distance and history.

Names keep the old *th* nearest the Tree. A frontier town softens it. A dock town sands it off. You can hear how far a land sits from the grove in how people say the same word.

## What the names mean

The names on the map are old words glued together. Here is what they are saying the first time they appear as places.

| Name              | Says         | Means                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Thaeloren</b>  | thae-LOR-en  | the Tree that witnesses. Everyday: <b>the Thallow</b> . The Awakening Tree.                                                                  |
| <b>Maiethorn</b>  | mah-YETH-orn | the Mother's Land                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Strandoren</b> | stran-DOR-en | the Witnessed Shore. Everyday: <b>Strandor</b>                                                                                               |
| <b>Heskoren</b>   | hesk-OR-en   | the Outer Land. Everyday: <b>Heskorn</b> . <i>Hesk-</i> is a frontier word for the far edge; the old rite is older than this grafting.       |
| <b>Kumbaan</b>    | koom-BAHN    | the hidden home, in the Yumboes' own tongue. Sailors say <b>the Sundering Isle</b> , or <b>the Sunder</b> , for the water that walls it off. |

Each of the three large continents has one famous corner, named by gluing two old words together and wearing them down. The farther the corner sits from the Awakening Tree, the more the old sound has worn off:

| Name               | Says         | Means                                             |
|--------------------|--------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Threnmaieth</b> | THREN-my-eth | the Mother's Reckoning. Keeps the full old sound. |
| <b>Lestrand</b>    | leh-STRAND   | the Reckoning Coast. The <i>th</i> is gone.       |
| <b>Vaethorn</b>    | vay-THORN    | the Waiting Land. Everyday: <b>Wethorn</b> .      |

The other named powers on each continent are built from the same old words. You will meet them as you go. **Language and Naming** is the word-box if you want to hear one as it appears, or make another.

## How the continents sit

Reading the world roughly **east to west**, along the reach-gradient:

- **Maiethorn** anchors the **east**: the old heart, where the land is oldest and most settled and the Awakening Tree still stands. Everything the world calls “the center” is here.
- **Strandoren** lies **west across the Old Crossing**, close enough to Maiethorn for constant, ancient trade (the two are the “Old World” pair), its long indented coasts facing the crossing. The Old Crossing — the inner sea, in older talk — is the busiest water in the world.
- **Heskoren** sprawls **further west and south**, beyond Strandoren's far coast, reached late, grafted late, the edge of the settled world. Between Strandoren and Heskoren the sea widens and the reach thins. This is where the frontier begins.
- **The Sundering Isle** sits **alone in the far west (or deep south) ocean**, past Heskoren's last capes, walled off by the **storm-wall**: a band of killing weather, currents, and reef that has wrecked most who tried the crossing. It is off the reach-gradient entirely: near-Treeless, seldom reached, its people mythic-rare in all three other continents.

Maiethorn and Strandoren are close and old. Heskoren is far and thin. The Isle is sundered beyond.

## The four continents at a glance

| Continent                                                | Reach     | Role                                              | Named powers here                                                          | Rival faith    |
|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------|---------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| <b>Maiethorn</b> (the Motherland)                        | full      | The sacred origin; the Awakening Tree stands here | Threnmaieth · Maiethvael · Orenbren · Saelthael · the Hinge Shore · Lirorn | the Watching   |
| <b>Strandoren</b> (the Shore-lands)                      | high      | The great trade continent, the world's crossroads | Lestrand · Brenledd · Leddvael · Trenledd · Netstrand                      | the Fair Hand  |
| <b>Heskoren</b> (the Sundered Reach)                     | thin      | The frontier; newest-grafted, half-wild           | Vaethorn · Ornled · Vaelhesk · Saelvaeth                                   | the Old Ways   |
| <b>The Sundering Isle</b> (Kumbaan, the Yumboe homeland) | near-none | The storm-walled remote isle; mythic-rare people  | <i>(not a mainland power)</i>                                              | the Open Table |

Each of the three large continents carries several of the fifteen great powers. Threnmaieth, Lestrand, and Vaethorn sit one to a continent.

The Motherfaith is one faith among several. The Watching, the Fair Hand, and the Old Ways live on the large continents, where they rub against the Motherfaith. The Open Table is the Isle's own.

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## Maiethorn: the Motherland

*(mah-YETH-orn. The Mother's Land.)*

Maiethorn is the world's **old heart**: the continent people mean when they say "the center." It is long-settled and deeply grafted: every hill with its Tree, and every Tree with its centuries. This is where the Motherfaith began, and where the Awakening Tree grows. A child's Turning is ordinary here because it is almost certain. The Trees are so healthy that nearly every child is Given, and being Kept is rare enough to be an event. The whole Condition-economy runs at full depth: deathless houses centuries old, Stilled infirmaries, Far-Voiced on every court and quay.

Proximity to the holy is pressure. Devotion here is the heaviest in the world. It runs through institutions and through politics. The faith is old and contested. A sanctified surveillance-crown

(Threnmaieth) and a stubborn heartland heresy both claim the sacred center.

## Geography and climate

**The Sacred Core.** At Maiethorn's heart stands **Thaeloren, the Awakening Tree**, the First Hand, in a deep old grove that is the destination of the world's great pilgrimage. The land around it is the most densely-grafted on earth: an old, gentle country of rounded hills, river valleys, and Tree-crowned towns, worn smooth by long settlement.

**The Motherwood.** Vast old-growth forest of motherwood and its wild kin rings the core. Here are the healthiest Trees, and the graft-nurseries from which **scions** (the cuttings themselves) travel to the whole world. The First Seat and the faith's institutions cluster in the wood's clearings.

**A central range** divides the continent's watersheds. Temperate, seasonal climate: four true seasons, real winters that make the solstice-timed Leaf-Fall meaningful. Old roads and river-trade knit it together. Tengu hearths and Fox-of-the-Snows country sit on the high snows. The range is also why the east is dry.

**The Rain-Shadow.** East of the central range, on the leeward side away from the inner sea, the land falls into **dry hills and sand-country**, the one true dry reach in the known world. This is the hearth of the Fox of the Sands. It is still Maiethorn (same Trees, same old *th*, same pilgrimage-pull westward toward Thaeloren). It is simply the Motherland's other weather. Towns here cluster at wells and at whatever graft will take in thin soil. **Larbril** is where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. **Ornsael**, the sown-ground, is the smaller well-town farther into the dry. It is not the next roof after Larbril, and it is not the coast. The core had already stopped walking when sand-country still went west.

**The western coast** faces the busy **Old Crossing** toward Strandoren, the oldest trade route in the world, the "Old World" crossing (the inner sea, in older talk). Ports here are ancient and rich, if less frantic than Strandoren's. Selkie families are common on these quays, as they are on any old water.

## Reach

**Full: the densest, healthiest grafting anywhere.** Nearly every child Given. The three pillars (Long-Lived memory, Bound word, Far-Voiced feeling) thick on the ground. The Kept genuinely uncommon and, in the more fervent districts, quietly pitied as passed-over. This is the world's Condition-density ceiling.

How the wood got here is the First Cut: Cut-years 0–80, origin-towns first, a day's living-earth at a time. The **Rain-Shadow was slower**, same continent, thin soil, wells. Core squares stopped walking while sand-country still went west. That is dirt, not a different gospel.

## Powers

- **Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown** (theology high · reach high · governance high). The wealthy, pious, surveilled core kingdom, near the sacred center. Its census, the **Threnhael**, sanctifies surveillance as reverent stewardship of the Mother's gifts. Maiethorn's full reach is why Threnmaieth has so much to count. Seat: **Maiethlir** (thaw-river Hand; does not own the grove).
- **Maiethvael**, the Gift-Realm: devout, rich, no list. Capital: **Seinbrun**. Not Maiethlir, and not the Down-Bank.
- **Orenbren**, the Witness-Hearths: lodging as power; does not own the Tree. Capital: **Rothallo**, one day's walk from the wood. People still say the Inner Close. It is the same city, inside Orenbren, not a second town and not a sixteenth flag. The First Seat stays in the wood. The Third Hearth is a road-house, not the capital.
- **Saelthael**, the Sown Tree: Rain-Shadow still walking. City: **Larbril**, where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. Ornsael stays the well-town, farther into the dry.
- **the Hinge Shore**: Old Crossing face; classifies the hull. Port: **Votaer**. It faces Orentel and is not a second Orentel.
- **Lirorn**, the Thaw-Land: range and snowmelt. Walled town: **Tasain**, in the valley below the Shelf-gate.

Hearths, not Kind-nations.

## Faith

The Motherfaith's birthplace and stronghold. Its institutions, its pilgrimage, and its authoritative tree-wardens all seat here. The sacred center is contested.

**The heartland heresy: the Watching.** An older Tree-faith the Motherfaith grew over persists in Maiethorn's oldest districts. The friction is at the center, not the frontier. They keep the Tree as witness (*Haelthael*) and refuse the Mother-name. Because it is old, it claims to remember what the world believed before the Trees were understood as the Mother's hands.

In the Walking Years, people had to come: the Near Mile was how Maiethorn Turned. The pilgrimage to Thaeloren still brings people from everywhere.

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## Strandoren: the Shore-lands

(*stran-DOR-en. Everyday Strandor. The Witnessed Shore.*)

Strandoren is the **crossroads of the known world**: a continent of harbours, its long coastline so deeply indented with bays, sounds, and peninsulas that no point sits far from saltwater. It is the **market that grew up facing Maiethorn**: charter-towns, guild halls, banking houses, and quays. The Trees here are mature and many (reach is high, the Given are dense), but the faith is worn light, folded into commerce until a child's Turning is watched less as a sacrament than as a question of which guild the colour opens. Deathless banking is at full scale here. Condition-labor buys the world's most advanced public works.

It is free, prosperous, and cool. Nothing here is policed (your faith, your gift, your marriage are your own), but everything is priced. The injustice is the market's. A person who cannot pay simply fades while a rich continent steps politely around them.

## Geography and climate

**The indented coast.** Strandoren's defining feature: a shoreline of countless natural harbours, tidal estuaries, and sheltered sounds. Every notable town is a port. The sea is the continent's highway. This is the densest Selkie hearth in the world: not a Selkie nation, a lot of shoreline.

**The Old Crossing** (east): the narrow, crowded, ancient water between Strandoren and Maiethorn. Everyday name everywhere. Older talk still says *the inner sea*. The busiest crossing in the world, the "Old World" trade artery. The Hush-rate is still charged on this water.

**The open ocean** (west and south): where the coast faces the widening sea toward Heskoren and, far beyond, the Sundering Isle. Strandoren's boldest merchant-houses run the frontier trade to Heskoren. Almost none have crossed the storm-wall to the Isle (those who claim to are the tellers of the Yumboe stories).

**Interior:** fertile lowlands and river-plains feeding the port-cities; mild maritime climate, wet and temperate. Mature grafted Trees stand thick along the wealthy coasts and thin only in the deep interior.

## Reach

**High.** Grafts mature and abundant, especially coastal. The Given are dense. The three pillars are **infrastructure** here: not reverence, but the machinery a huge commercial society runs on (Long-Lived notaries, Bound whose word closes contracts, Far-Voiced on every dock and in every court). The Struck are vouched-in briskly and efficiently. An unvouched person is a transaction that can't clear.

How the wood got here is the First Cut: Cut-years 40–160, **by sea**, wealthy coasts first. A ship is faster than filling every inland hamlet, and a coast could pay a Cutting-leave while a Near-Mile village was still on the list. Interior river-days came later. The Fair Hand files this as *the carrying*: a bill of lading, not a wound in wood.

## Powers

- **Lestrand, the Ledger Coast** (theology low · reach high · governance low). The premier merchant power: guild self-rule carried as far as it goes, deathless-house finance at scale, Tithe-provision as a private market (buy your green, your novelty, your outlet, and fade if you can't). The richest and coolest corner of the world. Seat: **Orentel** (Salt Quay; the White Note House placed, not crowned).
- **Brenledd**, the Hearth-League: many charters, one compact. Throne-city: **Raitin**. The six charter-towns stay unnamed. The league stays a league.
- **Leddvael**, the Reckoned Gift: Fair Hand as civic rite. Port: **Naenor**. The Book-Hands still have no seat of their own.
- **Trenledd**, the Worn Count: a roll with the hymn worn off. City: **Lunbra**, on the Chart-run. The governing throat stays unnamed.
- **Netstrand**, the Night Shore: west water, Heskoren trade. Harbour: **Braetu**. One berth there stays unlit.

## Faith

Faith is worn light here, and it has a rival with real doctrine.

**The fortune-and-contract cult: the Fair Hand** (*Leddoren*). A mercantile theology that reads Conditions not as gifts given (the Motherfaith's line) but as **bargains struck**. The world is a ledger of deals, and what you became is what you (or your line) bargained for. Direct doctrinal rival to gift-doctrine, at home among the Bound. It reframes the Tithe as a term serviced rather than an upkeep tended.

The Salt Walk was the berth that made Eolthael. Miss the last crossing and you missed the year.

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## Heskoren: the Sundered Reach

*(hesk-OR-en. Everyday Heskorn. The Outer Land.)*

Heskoren is the **edge of the world that the Trees reached last**. The land is young in wood, thin, and waiting: a broad, rugged, half-settled country where the grafts came recently, take poorly, and sicken often. Whole districts wait on a Tree that hasn't taken and a gift that may never fall. This is the continent that runs heavy on the Kept (children who reached no healthy Tree at ten) and the Struck (people who changed later, alone, unwitnessed). It is where the Motherfaith burns hottest. Scarcity of the gift has heated devotion: pilgrimage, longing, and a theology of waiting. In the Walking Years that

pattern was the rule of distance (the Long Mile). Some districts are still on it. Distance did this, not unworthiness.

It is warm, poor, and self-reliant: the kindest place in the world to a whole neighbour and the loneliest to an unvouched one. The danger is not raiders. It is a **lapsing Condition with no infirmity to reach**, and a faith that consoles what it cannot cure. Scarcity of the gift shades into a doctrine of unworthiness.

## Geography and climate

**Rugged and various.** Highland spines, upland moors, deep forests, and long river-runs down to a wild coast. Bigger weather, harder winters, more untamed ground than the Old World pair. Tengu ridge-towns and Fox-of-the-Snows hearths sit on the spines. Fox-of-the-Wilds and the deeper woods share the same forests. Selkie families hold the wild coast.

**The grafted pockets.** Settlement clusters wherever a graft has taken. A healthy Tree is the seed of a town, and the map of Heskoren's civilization is a map of its surviving Trees. Between them: wild with no polity, thinly-held marches, and long roads between Tree and Tree.

**The frontier coast** faces the open ocean back toward Strandoren (the lifeline of trade and new grafts) and, far beyond the last capes, the storm-band that hides the Sundering Isle. Heskoren's westernmost capes are the closest settled land to the Isle, and the source of many who've seen the storm-wall even if they never crossed it.

**Climate:** cooler, wetter, wilder than Maiethorn and Strandoren. A land where the solstice-timed Leaf-Fall is a hard-won event of a decade, not a yearly certainty.

## Reach

**Thin.** Grafts young, scattered, and prone to sickening. The three pillars stretched thin (few Long-Lived to remember, few Bound to vouch), so citizenship-by-witness is fragile and the **unvouched Struck** are a constant, aching problem met with faith rather than machinery. High Kept, high Struck, low specialist infrastructure. In-world this reads as plain distance-and-history. Heskoren is the Grafting this decade, not a closed age.

How the wood got here is the First Cut: Cut-years 200–387, still incomplete. The gap after Strandoren's coasts is **dead wood on the Long Mile**, a chain of Hands that had to grow up, and a queue that preferred a paying next: not unworthiness. Vaethorn will preach otherwise. History does not agree. Old Ways host-rights start at the planting: the first meal, or a claiming. Harrow's Green is a neighbour's canopy. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford still walk this year (Brenod · Vaelun · Ornath).



## Powers

- **Vaethorn, the Waiting Lands** (theology high · reach low · governance low). Ardent faith, thin Trees, almost no state: a warm, poor, half-lawless pilgrim edge whose ruling mood is waiting for a graft to take, for a gift that may not come. Its injustice is a **guilt** (scarcity read as unworthiness), not a boot. Seat: **Eolvaeth** (pilgrim-edge vale; not Saelvaeth's march).
- **Ornled**, the Outer Ledger: **secular frontier**. Town: **Sanbreo**, on the brink of a small city, where the slate is kept.
- **Vaelhesk**, the Far Yield: Old Ways host-rights. The land is the seat. There is no city to mark. The First Bowl stays the guest-grove.
- **Saelvaeth**, the Sown Waiting: live front as a march. Town: **Natai**, west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and the square. Not on the ford, and not on Harrow's square. Harrow's Green stays in the orbit. It is not the seat and not a capital.

Fewer, poorer, scattered. Wild with no polity still fills the space between.

## Faith

Two faiths in tension, and the friction is the frontier's own:

- The **Motherfaith** burns hottest here: a theology of longing and pilgrimage grown around the scarce gift.
- **The Old Ways** (*Vaeloren*). An animist / ancestor faith that predates the grafts: "the Mother's reach is new here. We had our own ways before her Trees came." It reveres the Struck and the Taken-In as the land's own children, and resents the Motherfaith as a latecomer. Real theological standing, real grievance.

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## The Sundering Isle: Kumbaen

*(koom-BAHN, "the hidden home." Sailors say the Sundering Isle or the Sunder. Outsiders name the barrier. The Yumboes name the hearth.)*

The Sundering Isle is **off the edge of the reach-gradient entirely**: the one land the grafts never reached, or never held. Where Heskoren is thin, the Isle is empty of the Trees the rest of the world is built around, and its people become what they are by **their own path**, outside the Leaf-Fall altogether. The storm-wall has wrecked most who tried the crossing, so that in Maiethorn, Strandoren, and Heskoren alike a Yumboe is a figure from a sailor's tale: pearly-skinned, silver-haired, "the good people from across the drowning sea." Some of the stories are even true.

Kumbaan is an ordinary home, warm and hospitable, that happens to be nearly impossible to reach. The strangeness is the distance. The Yumboes are not strange to themselves, only to a world that has never met them.

Kumbaan is not a mainland power. It is an isolate with a table, a moon, and a storm-wall. The Isle is a people at home. It is not a flag on the Seat's list.

## Geography and climate

**The storm-wall.** A near-permanent girdle of violent weather, treacherous currents, and reef rings the Isle. That is why it stays sundered. Ships that try the crossing are wrecked, turned back, or simply never return. There may be a season, or a way, the wall thins. That is not a settled fact.

**The Paps: the hill country.** The Isle's defining landform: rolling green **hills honeycombed beneath** with the Yumboes' true dwellings. They live within the hills, coming out by moonlight. The surface is pasture, terrace, and standing-stone. The life is below.

**Mild, wet, moonlit.** A temperate maritime island climate under the storm-wall's cloud. The Isle is famous (in its own tellings) for its **bright nights**: the people are nocturnal, and moonlight is their daylight.

**Small.** The one small continent of the four: an island-continent, not a sprawl. Walkable, known-in-full by its people, the opposite of Heskoren's trackless vastness.

## Reach

**Near-none.** Few or no healthy Trees. The grafts never crossed the storm-wall. The First Cut is explicit: **never**. Sailors tell of pots that went into the water. Dead wood is not a Tree. The Yumboes do not Turn at a Tree. Whatever they become, they become otherwise.

## People: the Yumboes

The Isle is the homeland of the **Yumboes** ("Bakhna Rakhna," *the good people*): pearly-white-skinned, silver-haired, hill-dwelling, moonlit, and famously **hospitable to strangers**, native and foreigner alike.

- They live **beneath the hills**, come out **by moonlight**, and hold **great feasts served by hands and feet you can see but bodies you cannot**.
- They are **native to Kumbaan and rare beyond it**. The storm-wall keeps them home, so the few who do cross become the source of every legend the mainland tells.
- Their **tongue and faith are their own**: non-Maiethren, owing nothing to the Leaf-Mother.

## Faith

**The Open Table** (*Ndeyaan*): the Yumboes' own cosmology, grown in isolation and owing nothing to the Motherfaith. Their old accounts frame the good people as bound up with the ancestors and the dead (the Yumboes are called "the spirits of the dead"). What is lived is a faith of hill, moon, hospitality, and the staying-kin, not literal ghosts. The Table-Keepers keep the hall. The Shore-Sitters keep the sand.

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# The Reckoning of the Year

How the Turning keeps time. The Leaf-Fall is solstice-timed, so the year's reckoning is load-bearing: it fixes when children Turn, when the great festival falls, and how a world with mechanical clocks but no printing press actually counts its days. Astronomy is kept light. Enough to run the rite and date events, not a full orrery (a clockwork model of the heavens).

## The sky

One sun. One moon on the mainland, on a familiar monthly round, enough for nights and for tides. Kumbaan keeps twelve named moons and does not owe that round a translation. They are the same sky, kept on a different count. Four true seasons, real winters (the temperate Old World register). This world does not have other planes. There is one ground. The storm-wall is weather, current, and reef. It is not a door. The hills at Ndenjoo are hills people live in. A Tree is a tree. A Condition is a person who has become, still standing on this ground. The Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, and the Dry Stair are older stone on this ground. Travel is walks, sails, and the storm-wall's refusal. What a faith calls a door is a practice, a meal, a return, or a hymn.

The one fact that matters for the rite is the **solstice**, the sun's turning-point, because that is when the Trees turn.

At the High Solstice, the longest day, a Tree's shadow at noon sits almost on its own roots. Supper happens in light that should have been gone. Turning-Week is that week of light. A storm can soak the crowd. It cannot move the door. On the Rain-Wall the sun clears a shelf it does not clear in the Deep. On Heskoren the same long light falls on a canopy, a bog, or neither, depending on the fold. Believers say the Mother timed her choosing to the year's hinge. Skeptics say a tree answers light. Both stand in the same noon and see the same short shadow.

At the Deep Solstice the sun is a guest: late, low, and soon gone. The mainland moon is the light you actually use, when cloud allows. A clear Deep night shows the moon and a great many unnamed lights. People farm by the months.

At Ndenjoo, on a bright night, the moon is the daylight. You can carry a bowl across the hill-yard without a lamp. The storm-wall is a darker ring around that brightness. The bright moon washes the small lights out. There is no Leaf-Fall in that sky. There is no Tree to throw a noon shadow.

The Leaf-Fall happens at the solstice because that is when the Trees turn their colour and choose. The sun reaches its turning, and so do the children. Both readings are content with the same calendar.

## The Turning Year

The year hinges on **two solstices**, the world's fixed astronomical anchors:

- **The Deep Solstice** (midwinter): the longest night; the year's low, turning point. A season of hearth, endowment-giving, and the deathless houses' account-closing.
- **The High Solstice** (midsummer): the longest day, and **the Turning**. This is the great one: the solstice when the Trees turn and the year's ten-year-olds meet the Leaf-Fall.

The High Solstice is warm, safe to travel and gather, and full of light. A child's Turning is a joyous festival, and midsummer suits it. It also makes the pilgrimage to Thaeloren a summer road.

## Turning-Week

The Leaf-Fall is not a single day but **Turning-Week**, the week bracketing the High Solstice, when the Trees hold their colour and the choosing is done. Every child who has turned ten since the last High Solstice Turns this week. The town gathers, the tree-wardens officiate, and it is at once the holiest rite and the biggest fair of the year (part christening, part graduation, part festival). A person's Turning-year becomes a lifelong marker of age and cohort: "*we Turned the same summer.*"

## Months and weeks

A plainly-countable calendar:

- **Twelve months** tied to the moon's cycle, in **four seasons of three months** each, hinged on the two solstices (and the two equinoxes between them as lesser markers).
- **Weeks** as the working unit of the burgher world: guild-weeks, market-days, the mechanical clock-towers of the trade cities striking the hours. No printing press means calendars are clergy- and clerk-kept, not mass-printed. One more reason the tree-wardens and the Tallied Crown's clerks hold quiet power: they keep the dates.

### *The twelve Maiethren months*

Liturgical names are Maiethren; the common-tongue / Lestrاند worn form sits beside them. The name you use reveals the stance. Counted here **from the Deep Solstice** as an astronomical order.

| #  | Season           | Liturgical                     | Says                   | Worn / common                        | Holds                                              |
|----|------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Winter           | <b>Nethael</b> (neth-AYL)      | “the night made whole” | <i>Nethel</i> / <b>the Deep</b>      | the <b>Deep Solstice</b>                           |
| 2  | Winter           | <b>Brenorn</b> (bren-ORN)      | “hearth-land”          | <i>Brennor</i> / <b>Hearth-month</b> | midwinter hush; deathless account-closing finishes |
| 3  | Winter to Spring | <b>Liren</b> (LEER-en)         | “the thaw’s speech”    | <i>Liren</i> / <b>the Thaw</b>       | water runs again                                   |
| 4  | Spring           | <b>Saelorn</b> (SAY-lorn)      | “sowing-land”          | <i>Salorn</i> / <b>Seed-month</b>    | first green                                        |
| 5  | Spring           | <b>Haelren</b> (HAYL-ren)      | “hale-speech”          | <i>Hailren</i> / <b>Hale-month</b>   | the land sound                                     |
| 6  | Summer           | <b>Eolthael</b> (ay-ohl-THALE) | “the Tree’s hinge”     | <i>Yoltal</i> / <b>Turning-month</b> | the <b>High Solstice</b> · <b>Turning-Week</b>     |
| 7  | Summer           | <b>Vaelorn</b> (VAY-lorn)      | “gift-land”            | <i>Valorn</i> / <b>Gift-month</b>    | after-Turning; the colours settle                  |
| 8  | Summer           | <b>Leddorn</b> (led-ORN)       | “reckoning-land”       | <i>Leddorn</i> / <b>Ledger-month</b> | late-summer markets, contract-terms                |
| 9  | Autumn           | <b>Ornvael</b> (ORN-vayl)      | “the land’s yield”     | <i>Ornvale</i> / <b>Harvest</b>      | bringing-in                                        |
| 10 | Autumn           | <b>Threnael</b> (thren-AYL)    | “the tally made whole” | <i>Trennel</i> / <b>the Tally</b>    | autumn count                                       |
| 11 | Autumn           | <b>Vaethren</b> (VAYTH-ren)    | “the waiting-speech”   | <i>Vaeren</i> / <b>the Wait</b>      | longing toward the dark                            |
| 12 | Winter           | <b>Nethorn</b> (NETH-orn)      | “night-land”           | <i>Nethorn</i> / <b>Dark-month</b>   | approaching the Deep                               |

## When the year starts: three new-year days by stance

The devout and the clergy begin the year at **Eolthael**. The Turning is the hinge that matters. Lestrاند and the deathless houses begin it at **Nethael**. Midwinter is when the books close. Vaethorn follows the

clergy in the pulpit and the last *actual* Turning-Week in the fields (a child “turns the year” when the local Tree last managed a fall). Same twelve names; three new-year’s days. A disputed date is a campaign lever.

## Kumbaan’s moons

Kumbaan does not use this table. The Yumboe keep **twelve named moons**, lunar, owing the solstice nothing:

**Yaaba · Ndibi · Sambiyo · Waandi · Lunji · Saalo · Soonke · Nkoosa · Ndenjoo · Yendo · Njili · Mbela**

A mainlander will try to line *Saalo* up with Seed-month and be cheerfully, consistently wrong. That mismatch is the tell.

## How years are numbered

Months name a season. **Years have no universal number**. Same lever as the three new-year’s days, turned toward history: the count you write on a debt is a theology. Full spine in Part: The Ages.

- **First Seat / devout clerks** count **Cut-years** from the First Cut (liturgical: the *Eoloren-count*). Present: **Cut-year 387**. A Cut-year is simply a year numbered from that hinge, not from a creation or a coronation.
- **Lestrand and the deathless houses** count from a house-founding or a note-issue (“the 200th summer of the White Note”).
- **Vaethorn** counts from **the year our graft took**, the same local-fall logic as their new-year.
- **The Watching** refuse the Cut-count. **Kumbaan** keeps moons and owes the ages nothing.

The Awakening Tree is old beyond reliable dating. There is no year the world began, and no year she appeared.

## How it is lived along the gradient

The reckoning is **universal in principle** (one sun, one moon, the two solstices) but lived differently along the reach-gradient:

- **Maiethorn (full reach)**: Turning-Week is a near-certainty and a vast institution. Dense healthy Trees, nearly every child Given, the pilgrimage to Thaeloren cresting at the High Solstice. Lived shape of that pilgrimage, when it was required: the Walking Years (the Near Mile).
- **Strandoren (high reach)**: the solstice is kept, but as much a commercial calendar-hinge (fairs, contract-terms, the deathless houses’ reckoning) as a sacred one.

- **Heskoren (thin reach):** Turning-Week is a hard-won event of a decade, not a certainty. A child may travel days to the nearest turning Tree, or wait years for a graft to take. The solstice still turns; the gift may not fall. Whole districts are still on the Long Mile.
- **Kumbaan (no reach):** the Yumboes keep **the moon, not the solstice**, a nocturnal, lunar reckoning owing nothing to the Trees, because they have none. The one people in the world whose calendar the Leaf-Mother never touched. A mainlander who lines a moon up with a Maiethren month is wrong in the same direction every time. The hall will not correct the chart.

## What the year feels like

People do not experience the calendar as a chart. They experience it as the week their street actually keeps. Faiths argue about what the week means. The street decides how long the sentence is.

In a devout town, on an ordinary market morning, people carrying baskets stop when a tree-warden steps onto the Tree's roots, and start again when the warden steps off. Someone of the Watching will not say "Maieth," and will still wait. Someone of the Fair Hand, passing through, will not wait. The square notices both. The year these people feel begins in Eolthael, the hinge-month, even if a clerk's tablet started the count earlier. In Maiethlir the thaw-river runs louder the week before Leaf-Fall. The town will not say why.

On a dock, the year the account books feel begins at the Deep Solstice, when the notes are closed. Turning-month is a fair laid on top of that closing. All year, a "clear" is a person a crane-crew will hire: someone the Tree hugged and gave no Condition. In Eolthael, people put salt on the Tree's roots. Orentel will not say why.

In a waiting town, people date a child from the last summer the local wood actually spoke. They do not spend the good flour on a promise that it will speak again. A guest gets the common pot. If the wood spoke last year, Turning-Week gets the better loaf. If it did not, the week gets the pot too. A wet leaf lies on the spring, or too many, or none. Eolvaeth will not say why. At Harrow's Green, when the wood will speak, people talk the same way, with a different repeat: first "the wood," then the neighbour's town if their own wood will not.

At Ndenjoo the year is moons, not solstices. Noon is when the hall is asleep. On one night of the moon sailors call Yoltal, the hall eats the heel of the loaf first. They will not say why.

Turning-Week, as a town spends it, is baskets, bells, and a loaf. The leaf-colours, and the questions a warden gets asked, stay with the Tree and are described with the Tree. In Maiethlir the stalls go up under the town Tree, and households stand by the bell. The public slate names the street and the hour. It does not name the colour a child received. On Orentel's quay, where people stand follows the crew that already knows the child. A clear gets the same shout the quay uses when a berth opens. In Eolvaeth, if the wood will not speak, the sentence in the street is "not this week." The hill on Kumbaan



does not keep Turning-Week. No child is stood up. No one asks for a colour. There is no Tree in the valley.

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# Climate, Ecology, and Travel

The continents already carry climate-at-a-glance. This chapter is the playable weather: named water and stone a table can point at, how a week feels in each band, and how long a walk actually takes. Deep forage-and-disease ecology is still thin. Use what is here; do not invent a second map.

Speak the common-tongue name. A liturgical reconstruction is a clerk's hobby. Stance still shows: a devout mouth keeps *th* in the land-names around the water; a dock mouth does not.

## Named water, range, and rivers

| Everyday                | What it is                                                        | Who says something else                                                                             |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>the Old Crossing</b> | the busy water between Maiethorn and Strandoren                   | Lestrand: <i>the crossing</i> . Vaethorn: <i>the waiting-water</i> . Sailors: <i>the Crossing</i> . |
| <b>the West Water</b>   | the wider sea between Strandoren and Heskoren                     | already the Night Shore's word                                                                      |
| <b>the Rain-Wall</b>    | Maiethorn's central range                                         | Liorn-folk: <i>the Thaw-Wall</i> . Clerks: <i>the Divide</i> .                                      |
| <b>the Noon Pass</b>    | the old high road over the Rain-Wall (lost its stone in C.Y. 233) | the courier's <i>noon-pass</i>                                                                      |
| <b>the Shelf-gate</b>   | the pass taken after the Break                                    | Threnmaieth named <i>the new one</i> ; Liorn charges <b>Break-rate</b>                              |
| <b>the Core-thaw</b>    | the river Maiethlir sits on                                       | clerks: <i>snowmelt</i> . Watchers will not.                                                        |
| <b>the Well-wash</b>    | Rain-Shadow seasonal water                                        | dry most years; silt in a bad thaw                                                                  |
| <b>the Rise-water</b>   | the stream from Harrow's Green to the hamlets' ford               | the Seat still says <i>the ford</i>                                                                 |
| <b>the Chart-run</b>    | Strandoren's interior river to Orentel's estuary                  | Lestrand files it as inland tickets reaching salt                                                   |

**the Old Crossing.** The oldest trade route in the world. Narrow enough that a fair-weather hull does it in a handful of days; busy enough that a late storm in Hale-month is still a Kept child. The Hinge Shore is the Motherland face. Orentel is the Shore-lands face. The Salt Walk was this water, then the Near Mile. The two continents are the Old World pair because this water made them one argument. The Grey Summer (C.Y. 171) tied the quays. The Hinge Hush (C.Y. 304) is the peace still charged as the **Hush-rate**.

**the West Water.** Wider than the Crossing. This is the Long Mile's sea-leg, the graft-pot's worse berth, the Night Shore's leftover. Heskoren's frontier coast faces it back toward Strandoren. Beyond the last capes, the storm-wall. Do not book Kumbaen on this water. A wrecked pot in a sailor's story is allowed. A taking is not.

**the Rain-Wall.** A highland spine down Maiethorn's middle. West-face weather is wet and four-seasoned; the leeward east is the Rain-Shadow. The range is why Saelthael sows at wells. The range is why Lirorn can levy a thaw. Fox-of-the-Snows and Tengu hearths sit densest on the high snow. That is terrain, not a flag. Heskoren's highland spines are a different weather. Do not hang the Rain-Wall on the frontier.

Two passes a table needs: the **Noon Pass** (the old high road; the Thaw-Break put a water-line over the ribbon-notch) and the **Shelf-gate** (the road that was left).

**Four rivers.** The **Core-thaw** is snowmelt off the Rain-Wall's west face, running toward the Old Crossing. Maiethlir sat down where the water slowed enough to hold a Hand. Seinbrun stands off that water. In a high Liren the lodging-road meets a near branch of the same water. The **Well-wash** is a seasonal run east of the range: a river in a kind Liren and a silt-line in a cruel one. **Larbril** is where the west road meets that wash, short of the pass. **Ornsael** drinks a well, farther into the dry. It is not the next roof after Larbril, and it is not the coast. The wash is why the well matters. The **Rise-water** is a low stream off Harrow's rise; downstream it is the ford the Seat used as a geography because the Seat will not learn Brenod, Vaelun, Ornath. Natai is not on that ford. The **Chart-run** is Strandoren's interior river-plain, running to Orentel's estuary. Lunbra sits on the wealthy stretch of it. Coasts took by sea; inland waited on a cart and this run.

## Climate bands

Enough to know what a week feels like.

| Band                  | Where                               | Weather                                                                              |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Crossing-shore        | both faces of the Old Crossing      | mild, wet-temperate; Hale-month storms decide a Salt Walk                            |
| Mother-core           | Maiethorn west of the Rain-Wall     | four true seasons; cathedral-country; winters that make High Solstice mean something |
| Rain-Wall / Thaw-Wall | Lirorn                              | snow, shelves, a thaw that is a civic year                                           |
| Rain-Shadow           | Saelthael east                      | dry hills, wells, the Well-wash or nothing                                           |
| Shore-lands           | Strandoren coasts and the Chart-run | maritime, indented, the sea as highway                                               |
| Night Shore           | Netstrand                           | open-ocean; west-weather; watches for hulls that do not arrive                       |
| Sundered upland       | Heskoren                            | cooler, wilder, harder winters; civilization is a map of surviving Trees             |
| Storm-wall / Kumbaan  | the Sundering Isle                  | mild wet under cloud; bright nights; the wall is the climate                         |

## Maiethorn

West of the Rain-Wall the Motherland keeps four true seasons. Winters are real. High Solstice means something because the year has been cold. Grafts take in cathedral-country and in the Motherwood; a cutting wants living earth and a drink, not a miracle. Stilled infirmaries and Returned plague-work cluster in the rich core because that is where the chairs and the endowments are. Tithe-green is commons and lot, not a desert problem.

On the range, last year's snow is this year's civic year. Lirorn levies the thaw. A thaw-week can turn the Shelf-gate into a lake. The Thaw-Break closed the west-road for two summers; people still remember which notch holds the water-line.

East of the Wall the land is wells, goats, and the Well-wash. A Taken-In Tithe is cheap on terrace-green and expensive if the well is dropping. Two-Bodied range the dry hills at night. Returned work sits downwind of the drink. A travelling stiller is a pass-story, not a college.

On the Old Crossing face the weather is the berth. Hale-month storms decide a Salt Walk. Far-Voiced are dock infrastructure. Selkie hearths are common on the quays. The Hinge Shore classifies the hull

before anyone across the water prices it.

## Strandoren

Maritime, indented, the sea as highway. Coasts took the wood first; the Chart-run carried it inland. Food on the Salt Quay is this plain, the Crossing's catch, and whatever the hinge pays. Tithe-provision here is a market: you buy a hall-hour, a lot-night, a novelty page. The Taken-In who live in stone cities are a working minority on lots, orchards, and river-gardens — arm's length is manners, not an empty lot.

The Night Shore watches for hulls that do not arrive. West-weather is a local climate. Chart-crews strip what the sea gives. Prestige and necessity use the same water and do not pay the same rate.

A Hale-month storm on the Old Crossing can turn a Salt Walk into a missed year. A Chart-run delay can make a Grey-verso due. The table of days is weather, not a promise.

## Heskoren

Cooler, wilder, harder winters. Civilization is a map of surviving Trees. Young grafts face wind, thin soil, and a queue written in the Motherwood. A Taken-In Tithe is the land itself, honoured, until a bad winter. Two-Bodied range against gap-cats and weather, not against a second werewolf. Returned work the far sheds. Stilled medicine is one tired stiller or a rope.

The live front is Saelvaeth's luck: Harrow's Green, the Rise-water, the hamlets' ford. **Natai** is the march-town west of that square, between Sanbreo and Harrow's, not on the ford and not on Harrow's square. The canopy the hamlets can see is still Harrow's. The mouth that can be blamed is Natai's. Vaethorn waits in a vale that cannot see that canopy and does not want to. Ornled has the same thin wood and no congregation. Sanbreo keeps the slate on that shore. Vaelhesk is old greens. The land is the seat. There is no city on it. Between mile-shrines the next stone is a rumour. Empty road-houses still make a bed. The leftover walk is people who did not go home.

## Kumbaan

Mild wet under cloud. Bright nights. The wall is the climate. There is no Tree-ecology. A slip planted here would die. Dead wood is not a Tree. Food is terrace, shallows when the wall is kind, and whatever unseen hands fetch. Fuel is peat and what a wreck sometimes gives the hall.

There is no ferry to the isle, and no ticket you can buy. Shore-sitters know a moon when the storm-wall thins. That thinning is weather, not a scheduled crossing. Most ships wreck, turn back, or do not

return. If you live, this is the order: you are on the sand or you are not; a shore-sitter decides that you are alive; you are walked uphill; the first night you are a guest at a hall; at the second sitting, a table-keeper decides that you are kin. That second sitting makes you kin on the isle. It does not become papers a mainland watch will accept. The town a party can enter is Ndenjoo, which sailors call the Feeding Hill.

## Travel times

The unit is a **day's walk** — the interval a mile-shrine already marks. A horse does not invent a different world; it buys you the same road with fewer blisters. A ship buys you the water the walks already named.

| Walk      | What it was                      | Fair-weather band                                        |
|-----------|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Near Mile | Maiethorn inland to Thaeloren    | 3–12 days                                                |
| Salt Walk | Old Crossing, then the Near Mile | 3–5 days' sail plus the inland days; typically 1–3 weeks |
| Long Mile | West Water, then Heskoren inland | 6–12 weeks for a coast-to-grove attempt                  |

Kumbaan is not on this table. No walk crossed the storm-wall.

| From                                       | To                                          | How                                  | Fair weather                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Thaeloren                                  | Rothallo (people still say the Inner Close) | walk                                 | <b>1 day</b>                                                                                                     |
| Thaeloren                                  | Maiethlir                                   | river road along the Core-thaw       | <b>1–2 days</b>                                                                                                  |
| Thaeloren                                  | the Third Hearth                            | Near Mile                            | <b>3 days</b>                                                                                                    |
| Third Hearth                               | Brenthael                                   | Near Mile                            | <b>1 day</b> further out                                                                                         |
| Brenthael                                  | the Mill-hold                               | Near Mile                            | <b>2 days</b> further out                                                                                        |
| Near Mile, a day short of the Third Hearth | Nelath                                      | the spur, and then it stops          | <b>1 day</b>                                                                                                     |
| Thaeloren                                  | the Low Wall                                | off the present Mile                 | <b>1–2 days</b> (not inside Rothallo)                                                                            |
| Thaeloren                                  | Hinge Shore quays (Votaer is the port)      | Core-thaw and the west-road          | <b>8–12 days</b>                                                                                                 |
| Thaeloren                                  | Larbril, then Ornsael                       | west-road over the Shelf-gate        | Larbril is the wash, short of the pass. Ornsael is the well, farther into the dry: <b>10–14 days</b> to the well |
| Hinge Shore quay                           | Orentel                                     | Old Crossing                         | <b>3–5 days’ sail</b>                                                                                            |
| Orentel                                    | Lunbra                                      | Chart-run                            | <b>4–8 days</b>                                                                                                  |
| Orentel                                    | Braetu                                      | coasting, to the Night Shore         | <b>8–14 days</b>                                                                                                 |
| Braetu                                     | Heskoren frontier coast                     | West Water                           | <b>2–4 weeks</b>                                                                                                 |
| Heskoren coast                             | Eolvaeth                                    | inland vale                          | <b>1–2 weeks</b>                                                                                                 |
| Eolvaeth                                   | Harrow’s Green                              | live-front roads                     | <b>2–3 weeks</b>                                                                                                 |
| Harrow’s Green                             | the Three Hamlets Past the Ford             | the Rise-water                       | <b>hours to 1 day</b>                                                                                            |
| Vaelun                                     | the First Bowl                              | vale track into the Yield, away from | <b>1–2 days</b>                                                                                                  |



| From              | To      | How        | Fair weather           |
|-------------------|---------|------------|------------------------|
|                   |         | Harrow's   |                        |
| Any mainland quay | Kumbaan | storm-wall | <b>not a timetable</b> |

A Hale-month storm on the Old Crossing can turn a Salt Walk into a missed year. A thaw-week on the Rain-Wall can turn the Shelf-gate into a lake. The table is weather, not a promise.

The surviving Kept regime is not a sixteenth flag and not a replacement of the Hinge Shore. The Closed Seat was an origin-gate on the grove. The Retreat closed walls one day's walk from the Motherwood, inside Orenbren lodging-country. That place is Rothallo. People still say the Inner Close. The Hinge Shore is the hinge of a different war. The wall and the quay do not trade names.

## What a house keeps in the field

An ox ploughs, hauls timber, and pulls a cart. The herds are on the core farms, the Chart-run plain, and the broad vales of Heskoren. A breeding animal is worth more to a house than a week's wages. People are more afraid of losing that ox than of the ox itself. The ox will not take a ford when the water is over the axle. On a ford that is already shallow, the driver still gets down and leads. They will not say why.

A goat gives milk, meat, hide, and dung, and it browses scrub other stock will not take. The herds are on the Rain-Shadow, the rough ground of Heskoren, and the terraces of Kumbaan. The house is afraid of a terrace wall knocked loose, and of a well-share argument when the herd comes in. The goat is not afraid of the wall.

A dog herds, guards a door, and keeps a quay or a hall honest about who is coming in. The dog is afraid of floodwater. It refuses a flooded path. Handlers who know the dog stop with it.

A person in an animal's body is a person. These animals are animals. They are not a guild, and they are not a second list of monsters.

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# Maps

East is the old heart. West is the wave's front, then the wall. Names live in *Climate, Ecology, and Travel*. The idea the picture is of lives in *The Four Continents*. How to *draw* a map lives among production aids, not in this book. Where a painted roof and a note disagree, the note is the place.

Reading **west to east** (left to right on the drawing) is the reach-gradient run backward: storm-wall, thin, high, full.

Kumbaan ~storm-wall~ HESKOREN ==West Water== STRANDOREN ==Old Crossing== MAIETHORN (none) thin high full

Coastlines are schematic, not a survey. Flip the compass if a later campaign wants the gradient on another axis; the **relative** positions stay. West is left on the sheets that carry names.

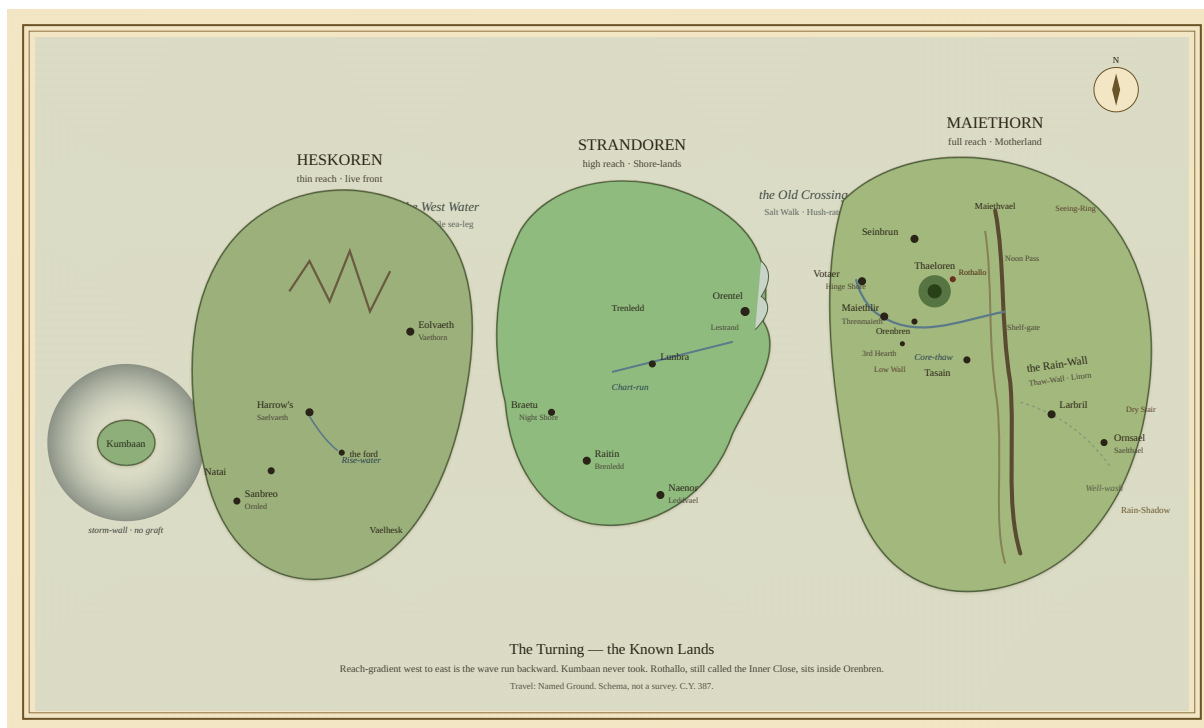
## World map

The labelled schematic is placement only, light on terrain. Four landmasses. The Old Crossing, the West Water, the Rain-Wall, four rivers, the Noon Pass, and the Shelf-gate. The fifteen are regions, not surveyed borders.

**Rothallo** is the mark inside Orenbren, one day's walk from the wood. People still say the Inner Close. It is the same place, not a sixteenth colour. The painted square on the regional sheets is still small. The city is the capital. No sheet puts a star on a capital. Maiethlir and Orentel stay the marks they were. They are not given a second dot.

Capitals, large cities, and important towns are marked where the notes already place them. **Vaelhesk** is the land, not a dot. Harrow's Green and Ornsael are not capitals. The First Seat is not a capital, and it is not marked. The Tree is not dated. There is no graft on Kumbaan.

The three pre-Walk leftovers are small marks: the Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, the Dry Stair.



Painted sheets are terrain. Extra isles on a generator sheet are not places. Add the names from this chapter. Do not copy an island the schematic does not show.

**Natai** sits west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and the square, and not on the ford. **Larbril** is where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass, west of Ornsael's well. **Ornsael** is farther into the dry, at a well, not the next roof and not the coast.

## Continent maps

**Maiethorn**, east. Mother-core west of the Rain-Wall. Thaeloren is the sole exceptional Tree, a canopy-ring in the old growth. Rothallo is the walled mark one day out, still called the Inner Close, and it is the capital. Seinbrun stands off the Core-thaw. Maiehlir sits where that river slows. The Third Hearth is a road-house three days out, not a city. Liorn is the range: the Rain-Wall is the name of the divide, and *the Thaw-Wall* is only Liorn's handle for it. The Noon Pass is the older high notch. The Shelf-gate is the lower road. Tasain is in the valley below that gate, on the wet side. Saelthael is the dry east. Larbril is the meeting of the west road and the Well-wash. Ornsael is the well-town farther along that road into the dry. The Hinge Shore is the Old Crossing face. Votaer is the port on that shore.

**Strandoren**, middle. Orentel is a plain dot at the eastern estuary. It is not a star. The Chart-run crosses the interior to that estuary. Lunbra is on the run, upriver of the salt. Raitin is the river behind the premier coast, not the Chart-run. Trenledd and Netstrand stay area labels, not borders. Naenor is on the

south coast, on its own water, not the Chart-run and not the West Water. Braetu is the harbour on the Night Shore. The six charter-towns are not marked.

**Heskoren**, west of the West Water. West is the last capes, then Ornled, then the storm-wall side. The sea on the Strandoren side of the sheet is the West Water. Eolvaeth is the pilgrim-town in the waiting vale. It cannot see Harrow's. Sanbreo is the slate-shore town, the mark that names Ornled's seat. Harrow's Green is a plain grove-town on the live-front rise. Natai is the march west of that square, between Sanbreo and Harrow's, not on the square and not on the ford. The hamlets sit on different ground past the Rise-water crossing: Brenod, Vaelun, Ornath. Vaelhesk is old greens. It has no settlement dot.

**Kumbaan**, behind the storm-wall. One isle. The name sits on the hill-country with no point marker. The storm-wall is the cloud, the current, and the reef, not a border and not a door. No graft, no city, no harbour, no safe channel, and no Tree. Ndenjoo is a hill-hall in the text. It is not a flag on the sheet, and nothing on the isle is a graft.

## The overlays

Each painted region keeps the names the ground already had. A pointer is a plain mark. It is not a new town.

**The world sheet** runs the same west-to-east line: Kumbaan, the storm-wall, Heskoren, the West Water, Strandoren, the Old Crossing, Maiethorn, the Rain-Wall. Seas sit in the water, not across a shore. Vaelhesk is not a dot on this sheet either. Maiethlir and Orentel are marked once here, because the world sheet did not already have them.

**The Old Crossing.** Orentel on the Strandoren estuary. The Hinge Shore is area-type on the Maiethorn coast, and Votaer is the port on that coast. The Hush-rate is a crossing-charge, not a line across the water.

**The Sacred Core.** Thaeloren's canopy-ring. No separate mark for the First Seat. Rothallo is the walled square one day out. Seinbrun is off the Core-thaw. The Third Hearth is three days out. Maiethlir is the counted city on the other road.

**The Rain-Wall.** The range is the Rain-Wall. The Noon Pass and the Shelf-gate are notches, not towns. Tasain is the town in the valley below the Shelf-gate. No Kind-nation fills the snow.

**The Rain-Shadow.** Climate-type on the dry east. Larbril on the west road, short of the pass. Ornsael on the well, farther into the dry. The Well-wash is seasonal water, not a border. The Dry Stair is a site on a different rise. The well-town at its shoulder stays unnamed.

**The Chart-run.** The river to Orentel's estuary. The first quay is the old landing. The White Note is one desk-house on the third quay, north side, not a crown. Lunbra is upriver of the salt. Other filed towns stay unnamed.

**The West Water.** The open ocean, in the blue. The Night Shore is area-type on the west-and-south face. Braetu is the harbour. The unlit berth is not marked on this sheet.

**The live front.** Harrow's is a grove-town on the rise, not a capital. The Rise-water runs to the ford. Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath are three small hearths past the crossing. Natai is not this square.

**The waiting vale.** Eolvaeth is a pilgrim-town at the gift-hall. The spring is a pool, not a mile-shrine. Harrow's canopy is not drawn here.

## Square and seat maps

Closer sheets exist for the seats and the squares that already have streets. They are the same places as the notes. A city plate is the city. Rothallo's gate is the same square gatehouse as the city: beds outside, the Book inside. Larbril's Well-wash is a silt-line, not a road. Vaelhesk has no sheet.

| Place                               | What to find                                                                                     |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Rothallo</b>                     | walled capital inside Orenbren; people still say the Inner Close; one day from the wood; no star |
| <b>Seinbrun</b>                     | Maiethvael's capital, off the Core-thaw                                                          |
| <b>Maiethlir</b>                    | Core-thaw, a day's living-earth from the Motherwood, not the grove. The First Seat is not marked |
| <b>the Third Hearth / Brenthael</b> | Near Mile, three days out from Thaeloren, then one day further                                   |
| <b>the Mill-hold</b>                | two days past Brenthael; the culvert and the Hand                                                |
| <b>Nelath</b>                       | the spur off the Near Mile; the road stops                                                       |
| <b>Larbril</b>                      | west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass                                                 |
| <b>Ornsael</b>                      | well-town farther into the dry, not the next roof and not the coast                              |
| <b>Votaer</b>                       | Hinge Shore port, facing Orentel                                                                 |
| <b>Tasain</b>                       | walled town below the Shelf-gate                                                                 |
| <b>Orentel</b>                      | Chart-run estuary; the White Note is a desk on the third quay                                    |
| <b>Raitin</b>                       | Brenledd's throne-city, river behind the premier coast                                           |
| <b>Naenor</b>                       | Leddvael's port, own coast, not Orentel's                                                        |
| <b>Lunbra</b>                       | Trenledd, on the Chart-run                                                                       |
| <b>Braetu</b>                       | Night Shore harbour; one berth stays unlit on the quay sheet                                     |
| <b>Sanbreo</b>                      | Ornled's slate-town, on the brink of a small city                                                |
| <b>Natai</b>                        | Saelvaeth's march, west of Harrow's, between Sanbreo and the square                              |
| <b>Harrow's Green</b>               | live front; Rise-water to the ford; not the seat                                                 |
| <b>the Three Hamlets</b>            | the ford; canopy visible from the water in clear weather                                         |
| <b>the First Bowl</b>               | guest-grove in the Yield, away from Harrow's. Vaelhesk itself has no dot                         |
| <b>Eolvaeth</b>                     | Vaethorn vale; cannot see Harrow's                                                               |
| <b>Ndenjoo</b>                      | Kumbaan; no Tree. Not a graft                                                                    |

The three walks as history, and as present roads:

- **Near Mile** — inland stones toward Thaeloren. Some now end at a town Tree. Nelath's spur is one that stops.
- **Salt Walk** — Old Crossing, then the Near Mile. Hush-rate on the hinge. Votaer sorts the hull. Orentel prices the berth.
- **Long Mile** — West Water, then Heskoren mud. Empty road-houses still make the bed. Braetu quotes the far run.

Travel times sit in the chapter before this one. A day's walk is a mile-shrine.

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BOOK VI

## The Ages



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# The Ages

People in this world do not live in “the Fourth Age.” They keep **two overlapping clocks**, and which one they glance at tells you where they stand.

**Clock 1: How you Turned** (personal, generational). Did you walk to Thaeloren, or to a neighbour who had already walked, or did you stand under a town **graft**? A graft, here, is horticulture: a cutting of living wood joined to new ground so it grows as the same plant. Ordinary families date themselves this way: *we are a Hands-house; grandmother still talks of the road*. **Hands** names the planted town Trees, and also the era in which those Trees are the ordinary way to Turn. A Long-Lived who says “*I walked*” is dating the room.

**Clock 2: Where the wood has reached** (geographic, unfinished). The **Grafting** is a wave of living wood that started at the origin, filled Maiethorn, crossed to Strandoren by sea, and is still arriving on Heskoren. Kumbaan is off the wave entirely. Present-day thin reach is the front of a process that has not finished.

Both clocks sit on an unnamed preface: **Before the Walk**. The Tree was already there. No honest count starts it.

The Walking Years were a logistics problem that killed children on the road. The Grafting was horticulture that people later sanctified. The Seat now narrates both as her will travelling. Folk memory is less tidy. The romance of the old mile and the graves along it belong to the same stretch of road.

## The ages at a glance

|                      | Everyday                  | Liturgical                                                    | Says                         | What it is                                                                                                                |
|----------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Preface              | <b>Before the Walk</b>    | <i>(mostly unnamed)</i> · the Watching keep <b>the Before</b> | <i>(none)</i>                | The Tree already stood. Kinds, doors, and seeing without a mother's name. Uncounted on purpose.                           |
| Clock 1, old default | <b>the Walking Years</b>  | <b>Brenvaeth</b> ( <i>bren-VAYTH</i> )                        | “the hearth gone to waiting” | You walked to Thaeloren or you stayed Kept for want of the trip. Far lands ran heavy on the Kept and the Struck.          |
| The hinge            | <b>the First Cut</b>      | <b>Eoloren</b> ( <i>ay-ohl-OR-en</i> )                        | “the witnessed hinge”        | Someone cut living wood and it <i>took</i> . Who, is argued. That it happened, is not.                                    |
| Clock 2              | <b>the Grafting</b>       | <i>(process, not an age you exit)</i>                         | <i>(none)</i>                | The carrying of hands. Still unfinished at the Sundered Reach. Never crossed the storm-wall.                              |
| Clock 1, new default | <b>the Years of Hands</b> | <b>Ornthael</b> ( <i>orn-THALE</i> )                          | “Tree-land”                  | A town Tree is the ordinary way to Turn. Pilgrimage remains as devotion, prestige, or necessity where a graft has failed. |

The liturgical pair is a deliberate inversion of the Road-hands' own name. **Thaelvaeth** is “the Tree gone to the waiting”: wood carried *out*. **Brenvaeth** is “the hearth gone to the waiting”: people walking *in*. The Grafting is the moment the world stopped sending hearths to the Tree and started sending the Tree to hearths.

## How years are numbered

There is **no universal year-zero**. Same twelve months; three new-year's days. Same past; **four honest ways to count it**. The number you write on a debt is a theology.

| Who                         | What they count from                                                                                                                                                    | What it sounds like                                              |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| First Seat / devout clerks  | <b>the First Cut</b> , in <b>Cut-years</b> (liturgical: the <i>Eoloren-count</i> ). A Cut-year is a year numbered from that hinge, not from a creation or a coronation. | “the 387th Cut-year”                                             |
| Threnmaieth                 | Cut-years <i>and</i> a crown-count from the Two Papers (C.Y. 67; present <b>Crown-year 320</b> )                                                                        | a number that wants to be a roll                                 |
| Lestrand / deathless houses | a <b>house-founding</b> , a note-issue, a contract-term                                                                                                                 | “the 200th summer of the White Note”                             |
| Vaethorn                    | <b>the year our graft took</b> , or the last <i>actual</i> Turning-Week                                                                                                 | a child “turns the year” when the local Tree last managed a fall |
| the Watching                | they <b>refuse the Cut-count</b>                                                                                                                                        | the overlay is not an epoch; the Tree was already seeing         |
| the Old Ways                | a closed door, a drowning-year, a guest that took                                                                                                                       | the Hands are when <i>guests</i> arrived, not when history began |
| Kumbaan                     | <b>moons</b>                                                                                                                                                            | the mainland ages are a sailor’s chart they do not owe           |

**Present: Cut-year 387**, the 387th summer since the First Cut. Shorthand **C.Y. 387**. It is not a round number.

**What you may not date.** The Awakening Tree is **old beyond reliable dating**. Before the Walk has no start. Who made the First Cut stays contested. The three pre-Walk leftovers (the Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, the Dry Stair) are *found*, not founded.

## The Other Count

Two clocks still organize how you Turned and where the wood has reached. Three hundred and eighty-seven summers also held a war, a split of paper, a fever, a flood, and a hush that is still the Old Crossing’s peace. This count sits *beside* the clocks. It does not replace them.

In the Walking Years the origin was not an open grove. A class of the untithed **sat on Thaeloren** and decided who might walk to it. Everyday historical name: **the Closed Seat**. Folk: **the Grove-Sitters**.

They were an *origin-gate* that grew a country around the one seeing — not a flag on all three continents. Strandoren paid the Salt Walk; it was never a province. Heskoren was beyond a gate's ride. Kumbaen was not in the story.

They thought they were doing horticulture and mercy: the one Tree cannot stand a world at once, so someone must choose the road. That is the same hunger the First Seat later named Cutting-leave, and the same hunger Rothallo still files as rank. People still say the Inner Close. It is Orenbren's walled capital, one day's walk from the wood, inside Orenbren. It is not a second town and not a sixteenth power. The First Seat stays in the wood.

| Cut-years           | Everyday name                         | Kind                                    | What it left                                                                                                                                                             |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>C.Y. 19–38</b>   | <b>the Closing</b>                    | war / political                         | The First Cut made a local Tree; the Closed Seat tried to uproot the copies and could not. Collapse. Retreat behind the walls at Rothallo, still called the Inner Close. |
| <b>C.Y. 67</b>      | <b>the Two Papers</b>                 | political / dynastic (paper, not blood) | One hymn-country became Maiethvael and Threnmaith. Crown-count starts here. Present <b>Crown-year 320</b> .                                                              |
| <b>C.Y. 171</b>     | <b>the Grey Summer</b>                | epidemic                                | Quay-fever on the Old Crossing. Not a Tithe. Trenledd began writing persons. Brenledd piled a compact (C.Y. 174). Leddvael made a signing a civic rite.                  |
| <b>C.Y. 233</b>     | <b>the Thaw-Break</b>                 | natural                                 | Lirorn snowmelt in one week on the Rain-Wall. Noon Pass lost; Shelf-gate taken. West-road cut two summers.                                                               |
| <b>C.Y. 248</b>     | <b>the Wrong Green</b>                | Tree / civic                            | A hug Speaked as copper-green. Human wound. Already a cited year at Harrow's. Not one of the five non-Tree years; kept here so a table does not invent a second Harrow.  |
| <b>C.Y. 280</b>     | <b>Ledan's query</b>                  | archival dating                         | The White Note House in its 200th summer. Ledan is Long-Lived; the conversion is still the house's habit. Present house-year <b>307</b> .                                |
| <b>C.Y. 299–304</b> | <b>the Hinge War → the Hinge Hush</b> | inter-power / treaty                    | The Hinge Shore and the Ledger Coast over hinge-tolls. The hush is the current Old Crossing peace, with a West Water clause Netstrand still quotes.                      |

Present remains **C.Y. 387**. Do not slide it. Who cut remains unpicked. A chronicle that writes a first king onto the Before is doing the overlay the Watching warned about.

**What a traveller notices, besides wood.** Three dates on a debt, and a *fourth* if the note survived the Grey Summer. A kitchen that still will not send a child through the Inner Close’s gate. A Lirorn pass-stone with a water-line over the old ribbon-notch. A Hinge Shore quay that charges the Hush-rate and will not call it a victory. A Watching night on a ring of stones that is older than any Cut-year anyone will write.

Maiethorn is post-imperial lodging, gift, reckoning, hinge, thaw, and dry sowing — six successors of a grove-gate, not six ancient kingdoms. Strandoren is what the Salt Walk became when the gate died and the fever wrote new paper. Heskoren entered the clocks late. Host-rights were already there.

### Spread of the wave

| Cut-years    | Where the wood went                                                                                                    |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| C.Y. 0       | the First Cut, near Thaeloren, Maiethorn                                                                               |
| C.Y. 0–80    | Maiethorn filling. Origin-towns first; the Rain-Shadow slower.                                                         |
| C.Y. 40–160  | Strandoren by sea. Wealthy coasts first, deep interior later.                                                          |
| C.Y. 200–387 | Heskoren, still incomplete. Luckiest towns have had a local Turning for a few generations; whole districts still wait. |
| never        | Kumbaan                                                                                                                |

A freshly planted **scion** (the cutting itself, not a seed) still takes **a generation** to hold a Leaf-Fall. So “a graft arrived” and “this town Turns under its own canopy” are twenty years apart. Heskoren’s waiting is the queue, plus the childhood of the wood.

### What the two clocks did

**Law.** Citizenship-by-local-witness is a Hands-era default. In the Walking Years the town that *saw you Turn* was the crowd under Thaeloren, or no one, if you never arrived. Far children who stayed Kept were unwitnessed as Given because they did not make the trip. They were not missing from a roll. Vouching-at-a-distance (a Long-Lived who remembers the origin-fall, a Bound word, a Far-Voiced feeling) was invented to carry the origin’s witness home. The unvouched Struck are older than the

grafts: a becoming on a far threshold was always unwitnessed. The Grafting localized who is expected to have been seen. It did not invent that unease.

**Money.** Many deathless houses began as **road-houses**: inns on the pilgrimage roads that also issued credit, beds and century-notes for families who had to walk. When the walk stopped being required in the core, the houses still had Long-Lived memory of every debtor on the road, and paper that outlived the pilgrimage-season. They became banks. The endow-not-inherit loop is older than the Hands. The *trusted note* is a Walking-era instrument that outlived its road.

**Clergy. Cutting-leave** is the First Seat's paper authorizing a cut: how the college captured a practice that began without it. The first successful cut was argued as theft, as mercy, as the Tree offering a branch, as old horticulture the Motherfaith later named. The Seat won the *authorization*. The **scion-queue** is the Grafting's child, the bottleneck that appears when her reach can travel but someone still decides *which town next*. Spreading Trees made a queue.

**Language.** The pilgrimage was a conserving pull. Once a year the far-flung walked to the same grove and heard the same liturgy, so the Old Tongue stayed nearer itself along the road. Local Trees let daughters grow in place. That is why drift tracks Tree-thinness, and why Lestrane eroded so far so fast: trade, a local canopy, and no need to walk to the Motherwood. The three daughter-drifts are Hands-era weather sitting on a Walking-era root.

**Geography.** The reach-gradient *is* the wave, frozen at C.Y. 387. Maiethorn is old Hands. Strandoren is mature Hands with a commercial aftertaste. Heskoren is the Grafting this decade. Kumbaan never entered the clocks. In-world this reads as distance-and-history, which is true as far as it goes.

**Faith.** The Watching remember Before the Walk as *the Before*, seeing without a mother's name, and will not start history at a Cut. The Old Ways were already becoming before any pilgrim road; the Hands are when *guests* arrived late. The Fair Hand dates contracts from a signing, not from a wound in wood; the Grafting is a supply-chain fact. The Open Table owes the ages nothing.

## What a traveller notices

- A Long-Lived who says *I walked*, and a room that goes quiet. Clock 1, spoken as biography.
- A **mile-shrine** on a road that now ends at a town Tree: a stone at about a day's walk, set for a Turning that no longer has to happen there. The devout still leave a ribbon. The town children climb it.
- **Empty pilgrim-beds** in an old inn's upper room, let now to merchants. The deathless house that owns the inn still dates its notes from the founding-summer the beds were full.
- Three dates for one summer, written on one debt: a Cut-year, a house-year, a "year the graft took."
- A Heskoren hamlet whose ten-year-olds still walk to a neighbour. They are not doing history. They are doing *this year*.

- A Phoenix named as an era-marker, *the Phoenix of the last Walking summer*, without anyone agreeing which summer that was.

## A clerk's query (C.Y. 387)

*Ledan of the White Note, to the Speaker who keeps the Eoloren-count. The verso has been folded around a second number.*

*The house writes a century-loan from our founding-summer, which we call the 200th of the White Note. The debtor in Wethorn writes the same summer as the year their graft took. Your college will write it as the 280th Cut-year if I have the conversion right, and as the 279th if I have it wrong.*

*Which number should stand on the note so that in fifty years the same person still owes us? We do not ask which summer was holy. We ask which summer a court will still be able to find.*

Ledan is asking a court question. The Speaker who answers, if they answer, will name a wood. The Vaethorn debtor will name a taking. The loan will still come due.

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## Before the Walk

The unnamed preface. The Awakening Tree already stood. People already had Kinds. Some already *became* things at doors the later faith would struggle to place. This era is kept thin on purpose. There is no date. The Tree is old beyond reliable dating. No creation myth, no first king. The Watching keep **the Before**.

Most of the world does not have a name for this. The devout skip it. Skeptics call it “before anyone bothered to walk,” which is a shrug, not a chronicle.

The Watching keep the one lived name: **the Before**. In their telling the world was Kind and Kind alone, then the Tree was already there, *watching*. The Giving came after the Watching. The Mother-name came after that. Each layer is a story laid over a seeing.

The Old Ways do not grant that becoming waited on a road. Heskoren's people already crossed doors (drowning, grove, stone) before any pilgrim mile. The Walking Years, when they arrived as a foreign traffic, were not the beginning of history. They were the beginning of *company*.

The Open Table is not in this clock. Kumbaan's hill-history does not owe Thaeloren a preface.

What can be said without inventing kings:

- The origin Tree is the one Tree no one grafted from another. It was not planted in a remembered summer.
- Far from it, people lived as they lived. Some were Struck at thresholds because thresholds exist. Some were never either Given or Struck, because there was no local fall to miss.
- When people *organized the tenth-year trip*, the Walking Years began. That organization is the start of Clock 1, not the start of the world.

None dated. That is the point. A later chronicle that “discovers” a first king, a first war, or a first sermon in this era is doing the overlay the Watching warned about.

---

## The Walking Years

Once there was only the Awakening Tree, and a child’s tenth-year Turning meant a *walk* to it. Families who could not make the trip **stayed Kept for want of it**, so the far reaches ran heavy on the Kept and the Struck as the *rule*, not an edge-case. Everyday name: **the Walking Years**. Liturgical: **Brenvaeth** (*bren-VAYTH*), “the hearth gone to the waiting.”

In these years the divine was not local. The Leaf-Fall happened in one grove, on Maiethorn, under Thaeloren. A tenth summer was a journey, or it was a hug you never received because you were not there to be hugged.

The far-flung who stayed home were not “skipped by a goddess” in any way a town could prove. They were **children who did not walk**. Some were later Struck at a drowning, an oath, a death, unwitnessed, because the only crowd that counted was a continent away. Some stayed Kept for life, wanted or not, because want-of-a-trip is a distance.

Thin reach used to mean far from the one Tree. After the First Cut, thin reach came to mean *Tree-poor places*: young, sick, or few grafts. A hamlet next-door to a dying scion can be “far” in the old sense without being far on a map.

The pilgrimage **did not vanish** when grafts began. It changed jobs. In the Years of Hands the devout still walk to the origin; the poor and the Tree-bereaved still walk to a neighbour. The Walking Years are the time when *everyone who Turned as Given had walked, or had been carried*.

The later romance of the old mile is a Hands-era feeling laid on Walking-era graves.

The era has no dated start. It grows out of Before the Walk when the trip becomes *the* way to Turn. It has a dated hinge: the First Cut (C.Y. 0). After that the Walking Years cease to be the *default* in lands



the wood has reached, and remain the default in lands it has not. Heskoren is still, in places, *in* this era.

## The door is one week

Turning-Week is the week bracketing the High Solstice in **Eolthael**. Every child who has turned ten since the last High Solstice Turns that week, under Thaeloren, or they do not Turn as Given at all.

Miss the week and the door has shut. An eleven-year-old at the origin the following summer is a visitor. The Tree's Given-door is the tenth-year cohort, not a standing appointment. Struck doors still open later, elsewhere, with no leaf and no crowd. That is a different mercy, and it was always the far lands' other path.

This is why families from any distance **left early**, and why the richest or most frightened far households spent a *year* at the origin: a nine-year-old wintered in a road-house so they could not miss. The held-over child is the expensive mercy. Everyone else gambled one summer.

## Three walks, not one road

Named in the common tongue, because the walk was logistics before it was liturgy.

| Walk                 | Who used it                                                       | How long                       | What it cost                                                          |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>the Near Mile</b> | Maiethorn inland, anyone already on the Motherland                | days to a couple of weeks      | a harvest-timing; almost everyone who meant to come, came             |
| <b>the Salt Walk</b> | Strandoren: ship the inner sea, then the Near Mile                | a sailing plus the inland days | a berth in fair weather; miss the last crossing and you miss the year |
| <b>the Long Mile</b> | Heskoren, and the Strandoren interior before the coasts were rich | weeks to months                | a year's surplus, or a road-house note, or you did not go             |

People did not say *Brenvaeth* on the road. They said *we are on the Long Mile*, or *we took the salt*. Vaethorn still calls the whole past *the waiting-road*. Lestrand files it as *the road-years*. Threnmaieth wants the miles *on a roll*.

**Timing against the year.** Near-Mile families left in **Haelren** or early **Eolthael** and were home by **Vaelorn**. Salt-Walk households watched the inner sea from **Saelorn**; a late storm in Hale-month was a Kept child. Long-Mile columns left in **Liren** or **Saelorn**, the thaw and the first green, and hoped the High Solstice had not happened without them. Some arrived in **Leddorn** with a ten-year-old who had

already missed. The road-houses knew that silence. They did not charge extra for it. They also did not refund the note.

Kumbaan is not on this table. No walk crossed the storm-wall.

## Who could afford it

The Near Mile was a civic season: whole towns moved a short way together, and a poor child walked in a neighbour's dust. Cost was real (lost labour, a week of food) and rarely decisive.

The Salt Walk sorted by **cash and weather**. Coastal wealth bought berths. Interior Strandoren was already "far" in these years, even though the coasts would later be Tree-rich. A family might send the Turning-child and one adult, and leave the rest. Guilds sometimes advanced a berth against a future colour. A Given Answered or Far-Voiced was worth the loan; a hug was a debt with no new trade in it. The Fair Hand would later call this a term. In Brenvaeth it was just the quay.

The Long Mile sorted by **whether you could lose a year**. Food, shoes, a second adult if you had one, and the note you signed at the first road-house that would take it. Many could not. Those who could often could not for *every* child.

**The split household** is the era's ordinary cruelty. A family with three children near ten could sometimes walk one. The one who walked might come home Given. The ones who stayed were Kept, or were Struck later at a local door, and grew up in the same kitchen as a sibling the origin had seen. Distance did this. Vaethorn's later guilt (*we wait because we are unworthy*) is a Hands-era reading of that fact. The miles do not agree with the guilt.

Old Ways households on Heskoren often **refused the walk** on purpose. Their children were already the land's. Motherfaith neighbours read those children as Kept-for-want, which is a misreading the walk itself cannot correct. Both families are telling the truth they have.

## Who died

Children died on the road. So did the adults who carried them. River-crossings in the thaw, a fever in a packed Near-Mile inn, a late squall on the inner sea, hunger on a Long-Mile stretch between hearths, a birth that would not wait for the grove. Long roads kill people. That is what they do.

The graves are mostly unmarked at first. Then someone sets a stone at a day's walk, because the next column needs to know the water, and because a name should sit somewhere. A ribbon goes on the stone the year after. A later column uses the stone as a mile-mark. The romance and the graves are the same object seen at two hours of the day.

A child who dies on the way to be witnessed may **Strike as Returned** on the road: a becoming with no crowd, on the way to the only crowd that counted. Rare. Remembered. The dangerous edge of these

years lives here, not in the Leaf-Fall waiting at the end of the walk.

The origin also filled with **children who arrived and had no one to walk home with**. Road-houses took some in (a bed that became a life). Origin-towns took some. A Given child with no one to carry the witness home is the other half of the grave: they lived, and belonging still had to be invented for them.

## Far reaches as the rule

In Brenvaeth, a land far from Thaeloren was **Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy because most ten-year-olds never stood under the canopy**. That was how the world worked anywhere the walk was too far or too dear.

- **Given** were the ones who had been *there*, a minority that shrank with distance. They came home as specialists the town could not otherwise grow, and as people the town had not seen become.
- **Kept** were the default far childhood: whole, untithed, unwitnessed-as-Given. Some were wanted that way. Some were the price of a summer the family could not raise. Some were Old Ways children the Motherfaith had misfiled.
- **Struck** were the far lands' other door, and always had been. Drownings, oaths, deaths. No leaf. No origin-crowd. The unease that follows the Struck is older than the grafts. The walk made it louder, because the Given in the same town *had* been seen, a continent away.

When the wood later travelled, this pattern *relocated*. A Tree-poor pocket next to a dying scion reads the same on a census and is not far on a map. Clock 2. Today's Heskoren is not a costume of Brenvaeth. Some of it still is Brenvaeth, this year, for this cohort. Some of it is a neighbour's canopy and a queue. Both can be true on the same road.

## Institutions of the road

There was no travelling church with offices. The Tree-Wardens as a graft-carrying order is Hands-era weather. In Brenvaeth the **origin-hearth** was the only Speaking that counted; far towns had no Tree to tend. What the road had was inns, stones, and summer traffic.

### *Mile-shrines*

Water if the ground allows. A flat top for a pack. Often a name. Often a ribbon.

They begin as graves and waymarks in the same act. You bury someone where the column had to stop, and the next year the stop is the place you aim for. The devout later leave ribbons for the Tree.

Children later climb them. Hands-towns later argue about pulling them down because the road now ends at a local canopy and the stone is in the way. The stone does not know which story it is in.

A ribbon is not a leaf-colour. People tie what they have. A copper-green scrap on a Long-Mile stone does not mean a Taken-In died there. Travellers who have walked once know this. Travellers who have only heard the romance do not.

### *Road-houses*

Many deathless houses began here. In Brenvaeth they sold beds, porridge, a dry room, and **credit for a walk you could not miss twice.**

Cant: **brenhael** (*bren-HAYL*), *bren* + *hael*, “the hearth kept whole.” Vaethorn says *waiting-hearth*. Lestrاند says *the bed-house* (and still means the bank). Threnmaieth would like them *on the roll*.

What a road-house actually sold:

- **A bed in the two crowded months**, and a quieter one in the other ten. Held-over nine-year-olds were the winter trade. Empty pilgrim-beds in a Hands-era upper room used to be this.
- **A note.** You eat now; you pay at the origin, or on the way home, or when the child is grown, or when a sibling walks next year. The Long-Lived innkeeper **forgets none of it.** That memory is why the paper will outlive the pilgrimage-season and become the trusted note. In the act, it is an innkeeper who will still know your name in fifty years, which is a kindness and a leash.
- **A little Tithe-furnishing**, improvised, not a guild. A green-lot behind the house for a Taken-In parent. A shed where a Far-Voiced can cry without taking the dormitory with them. The road itself is novelty enough that a Long-Lived innkeeper’s own Tithe stays fed, which is why the deathless *stayed* in the trade, and why the same people later endow libraries: the hunger that kept them on the mile is the hunger that built the archive. Brenvaeth had a pot and a shed.
- **A held bed.** A family said they would come. They did not. The innkeeper keeps the bed a year, then two, then as a habit that looks like hospitality and functions as a shrine.

The White Note’s founding-summer is a house-year, not a Cut-year. In the Walking Years that house was a hearth with too many boots by the door. This is the same fortune, earlier.

### *Summer traffic*

For two months the Near Mile is a moving town: columns, dust, Far-Voiced cries from ridge to ridge (*the road is full; the ford is wrong; a child is down*), Two-Bodied ranging the edges because the ranging is the Tithe and the column is a herd. Markets grow at the mile-shrines and vanish when Eolthael ends. Then the road is empty and local, and the road-house counts notes.

There were no pilgrim-knights and no official convoy-guild. People walked with whoever left the same week. A Bound’s word might hold a column together for a fortnight. A Kept adult with no Tithe to manage was, then as now, the person who could carry the extra pack.

## Witness at the origin, or not at all

Citizenship-by-local-witness is Hands-era weather. In Brenvaeth the town that *saw you Turn* was the crowd under Thaeloren, or no one.

- **Going home did not bring the crowd with you.** Your village had not watched. Belonging at home required someone who *had* been under the boughs to stand for you: a parent, a neighbour from the column, a Long-Lived who keeps origin-falls the way they later keep town-falls. **Vouching-at-a-distance was invented to carry the origin's witness home.** The three pillars (Long-Lived memory, Bound word, Far-Voiced feeling) are older than the grafts; the *job* of carrying a far Turning is Walking-era.
- **A Given child with no surviving witness** is legally thin in the place they grew up. Origin-orphans, road-house children, a Bound stranger who will swear the colour they did not see (and cannot cheaply lie). The unvouched are older than the Struck-stigma, and include people the Tree *did* Give.
- **Struck on the road** are a double unease: unwitnessed becoming, *on the way* to the witnessing. A Returned child walking the last Near-Mile days beside the parent who has not yet forgiven the threshold.
- **Staying home** meant you were never Given-witnessed. You were still of your town, because your town had watched you be a child. Kept-by-distance is a hug that happened without you, a continent away.

The origin-crowd was enormous in Eolthael and ordinary the rest of the year. Speakers of the origin-hearth named colours until their voices went. Folk-known colours still were; the warden's word made them *count* for people who would have to carry that word home.

## Long-Lived who still say *I walked*

A Long-Lived who says *I walked* is dating the room. Memory is perfect. **Meaning is not.** There is no single Long-Lived account.

At present (C.Y. 387) the sentence does at least four jobs, and they argue:

- **I walked as a child, under Thaeloren, before my town had wood.** A Maiethorn deathless Given in the late Walking (the last core cohorts, before Maiethorn filled in the first Cut-years) is speaking of a summer most of the room has only as a ribbon. A Heskoren deathless may mean *last decade*. Same words. Different clocks.
- **I walked the mile as the inn.** A road-house Long-Lived may never have stood under the canopy as a pilgrim. They walked the same stretch every summer for two hundred years. They remember every debtor. They will not always tell you which children came back.

- **I remember the graves and I will not call them holy.** Skeptics among the deathless. The road was biology plus bad fords. They are sincere. They still tear up at a ribbon, which they will not explain.
- **I remember the graves and I will not call them logistics.** Devout deathless. Every stone was a waiting. They are sincere. They still know which ford killed which name, which they will tell you whether you asked or not.

Blood-Read will give you a true fragment of a walk. It will not tell you which of the four jobs the living speaker is doing.

They also disagree with Seat chronicles that start at the First Cut. A Long-Lived who walked as a child and a clerk who counts Cut-years will fight about the same summer. Both can be honest. Only one of them was there.

## What a character notices

- Dust on a Near-Mile road in Hale-month, and none in Ledger-month.
- A mile-shrine with a ribbon and a climbing-scuff, and a Hands-child who does not know it was a grave.
- An inn's upper room with too many beds for the present trade. The house still dates its notes from a founding-summer the beds were full.
- A Held bed that has not been let in anyone's living mortal memory. The innkeeper can tell you the name. They will not tell you they think the child is dead, or Kept, or Old Ways, or never born.
- A sibling-pair, one Given, one Kept, who will not walk the same side of a road.
- A Far-Voiced ridge-cry in an old pattern: *the ford is wrong*. No column answers. Birds do.
- Someone at a table saying *I walked*, and the room sorting itself by who goes quiet.

## A Turning-Week slate

*From the third hearth on the Near Mile, kept by Thilim, who is Long-Lived and has kept this house since before the Cut, as later clerks would say. The verso is knife-scored with tally-marks that do not match the recto.*

*Eolthael, the summer the ford ran high.*

*Beds: forty-and-two spoken for. Notes out: Tora of the long cape, two mouths, pay on the home-walk. Valein of the salt, one mouth, paid at the quay. The Held: Seine of the far cape, tenth summer, not come. Hold the bed. The mother said next year. Next year was last year.*

*Porridge: enough. Shed: the blue-leaf girl from the second column cried the rafters quiet; no charge; we needed the quiet. Green-lot: used. The Taken-In man from the long cape left a cutting. I put it in the pot. It is not a Tree.*

*I do not ask which summer was holy. I ask which mouths will be here at dark. The Held bed is made. If Seine comes I will not have to remember I made it for nothing.*

The Held bed is already a shrine. The house's fortune is the farness the wood will later abolish. The cutting in the pot is not a First Cut. It is a man who missed his green.

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## The First Cut

Someone cut living wood from Thaeloren (or from a branch that came away in a hand), carried it a day's earth, married it to new ground, and it *took*. A town on the Near Mile Turned, a generation later, under a canopy that was not the origin. Everyday name: **the First Cut**. Liturgical: **Eoloren** (*ay-ohl-OR-en*), "the witnessed hinge." The clerical count of years starts here.

Everyone agrees *a first successful town-graft occurred*. It happened within a day's living-earth of Thaeloren, close enough that a cut could still be green when it met new ground. That is horticulture. No two houses agree whose story the cut is.

The first green is not named. Folk who need an object call it **the nameless green**. Naming the town would pick a hearth, and a hearth would pick a hand.

A freshly planted scion still takes **a generation** to hold a Leaf-Fall. So C.Y. 0 is a wound in wood. The first *local Turning* is about twenty summers later. "A graft arrived" and "this town Turns under its own canopy" are never the same year. The wave is slow because each Hand must grow up before it can be a source.

## The five attributions

The five stories are not speeches. They are *jobs*. Which one a room is doing is a faster read than a creed. They are not collapsed into a secret true cutter.

### *Folk: the stolen branch*

A parent who would not watch another child stay Kept for want of a trip, or would not bury another child on the Near Mile, took wood without leave. Mercy as theft.

- **The nameless knife** is the object, not a saint. Some hearths keep a kitchen-knife on a ribbon the way Hands-children climb mile-shrines: they cannot say whether they are honouring a theft or a gift. There is no name on the handle.
- **Thief-songs** on the Near Mile are walking-songs with the cutter as *we*. Salt-Walk versions make it a quay-joke (*the first unpaid berth*). Long-Mile versions are not funny. Vaethorn's later guilt wants this parent to have been *unworthy*. The songs do not agree.
- **Folk-right cutting** did not vanish when the Seat wrote a leave. A Taken-In with a sick neighbour and no year to wait will still take a slip. Most of those slips die. The ones that take are how the queue learns it is not the only horticulture in the world. Road-hands call this a problem. Towns that lived through a stolen year call it a year they Turned.

The later Cutting-leave fee is, in this telling, **a fine that forgot it was a fine**. Lestrand will broker it without blushing. That is this story with a clerk.

A stolen Hand still left a town behind that did not get the next one. This mouth does not linger there.

### *Clergy: the warden ahead of the college*

A tree-warden of a Near-Mile hearth cut with a leave that did not yet exist. The wood took. The origin-hearth spent **the generation of argument** (C.Y. 0 into the first local Leaf-Fall) trying to decide whether this was blight, theft, or rite. The First Seat as a *Cutting-leave desk* is what that argument left on the ground. The Road-hands are this scandal in an office: the people who walk what used to be unsanctioned.

- **Speakers who will not say first.** They will say *the witnessed hinge*. They will date a note. They will not point at a grave. Some of them are skeptics who grant the horticulture and refuse the saint. Some of them are devout who think naming a cutter would steal the Tree's offering. Same silence, two jobs.
- **The quiet years at the origin.** After the first copy, the Motherwood tried to forbid further cuts. Wood died in pots anyway. Neighbours cut anyway. Forbidding a copy that had already taken is how a college learns it does not own the Tree's tissue, only the *authorization*.
- **Road-hands as regularized heresy.** They were not designed as a travelling church. They are the generation of argument, given a cart.

"We will write how, not who" is how a heresy becomes a monopoly. This mouth writes the how.

### *Devout: the Tree offered*

A branch came away. No theft, no genius. A Hand giving a Hand. The Mother (or the Tree, if you will not say Mother) *meant* the wood to travel. This is the version the Seat prefers in sermons, because it makes the scion-queue sound like stewardship rather than rationing.



- **Eoloren sermons** at Turning-Week in the Motherwood: *she sent her hands outward so the hearths could stay*. The graves of the Walking Years are named in the same breath, on a good day. On a bad day they are not.
- **The watering-words** as proof. If the marrying-rite were only horticulture, why would the wood listen? Skeptics: because you watered it. Both can stand under the same canopy.
- **Cutting-leave as blessing**. Vaethorn calls it *the wood's blessing*. The devout need that name. Without it the queue is a list of who waits.

“She meant the wood to travel” is how you narrate a wave that went to paying coasts before it went to the poor far. The thing saved, when anything was, was a walk. Not everyone's.

### *The Watching: horticulture, then an overlay*

People had always been able to cut living wood. Fruit-grafts, orchard-kin, a slip in a pot. The Motherfaith later *named* one cut the First, and started a count, which is what overlays do. The Tree was already seeing. A date does not make a mother.

- **They refuse the Cut-count**. A Watcher clerk will date a debt from a house-year, a drowning-year, a night they kept. They will convert to Eoloren-count if a court makes them, and they will not call it history.
- **Pear-grafts as the tell**. Watcher hearths on Maiethorn still graft ordinary fruit in the same week a Road-hand passes with carrying-earth. They do not think this is a joke. They think it is the whole argument, done with hands.
- **The withheld first**. Same cadence as the withheld blessing. *What was cut, was seen. What took, was seen. The Tree does not reach twice by chance*. No Mother in it. No epoch in it.

Refusing the date does not refuse the wave. Children still died on the road until the copies took. The overlay is a name. The graves were not.

### *The Old Ways: the land received a guest*

No one “cut” in the Seat's sense. A grove took in kin. The Hands are when guests began arriving from the east. Host-rights start here, not a college's warrant.

- **The first meal** for a new graft: food left at the planting, the way you feed a guest before you ask their business. The Door-Keepers still do this. A Road-hand who eats is doing host-courtesy whether the Seat wrote it down or not. A Road-hand who plants and leaves is a claiming.
- **Guest-reading vs First-reading**. A Guest-reading town will pilgrimage *and* keep the meal. A First-reading district will tend the same wood as a guest in their house and still refuse the Tender's blessing. Both start the story at a *receiving*, not at a knife. The Cut is a mainland word for an arrival.

- **They do not start history at C.Y. 0.** On Heskoren the guests *arrive* in the C.Y. 200s. Calling that “late” is already Motherfaith. Calling it “the First Cut, delayed” is a Seat map. The land was already making children at the old doors.

A guest who takes a generation to speak (the first local Leaf-Fall) will still be called a Tree by the children who Turn under it. Host-rights do not stop a town from becoming Hands-era.

People tell all five. Skeptics grant the horticulture (observable) and deny the conclusion (that a mind chose the travelling). The Fair Hand is not a sixth attribution of the *cut*; they enter when the wood boards a ship. The Open Table is not in this story.

## The generation of argument

C.Y. 0 is a cut. The next twenty summers are copies, dead wood, a college that cannot un-cut, and a first local Leaf-Fall that ends the argument without settling it.

### What people actually did.

- Near-Mile towns cut because the first green was *visible from the next square*. Living tissue, a day’s earth, a pot, a Taken-In who knew soil. This is why the origin-towns filled first. Not worthiness. Distance a sapling can survive.
- Most early copies **died**. Mortal wood, wrong season, a pot that dried on the Near Mile in Hale-month, a well-meant slip with no carrying-earth. The deaths are why the Seat could tell itself the first taking was a fluke, for a while.
- The origin-hearth tried **forbidding**. Speakers named it theft, blight, a wound in the First Hand. Neighbours cut anyway. A prohibition with no riders cannot police a day’s walk in a pre-print world.
- **Proof arrived as a ceremony**. When the nameless green held its first Turning-Week, a colour fell (or a hug; the tellings do not agree, and it does not change the paper). A town that was not the origin had been *seen seeing*. Clock 1 flipped for that hearth. Citizenship-by-local-witness is born as weather in that square, a generation after the knife. The Walk is no longer the only door. The Seat can argue doctrine until the leaves fall. It cannot argue the leaves back onto Thaeloren.

### What the Seat captured.

The college could not own the tissue. It could own **who may cut next**. That is the copy-right. **Cutting-leave** is the paper. The **scion-queue** is what a copy-right becomes when demand outruns a generation of wood.

The fee is framed as carrying-earth and a Road-hand’s year. Folk hear a fine. Lestrang hears a licence. Threnmaieth wants it on a roll. Vaethorn calls it an offering. Same coin, four stances. Historically it is

how an institution absorbed a heresy and called it horticulture. Unsanctioned cutting became authorized cutting. The practice survived by changing owner.

Road-hands are not a second order. They are the people you send when you have claimed the knife and still need the wood to walk.

Spreading Trees made a queue. Struck stigma, Tithe-leverage, the pitied Kept: none of that dissolved when a second canopy opened. The new injustice is *which town next*, paid in twenty more years of borrowed Turnings. She did not write the list. People did.

## How the wave moved

A scion still takes a generation to Turn. A healthy town Tree may supply the next cut, acting on the origin's behalf. So the wave is a **chain of maturing Hands**, not a miracle crate. Sea can jump a chain. A Long-Mile cart cannot, until carrying-earth lasts and there are rest-hearths that are not just pilgrim-inns.

*Maiethorn, C.Y. 0–80 (origin-towns first; Rain-Shadow slower)*

The Near Mile becomes unnecessary as *requirement* in the core, town by town, as canopies come of age. Origin-squares first: a day's earth, then two, then a valley. The pilgrimage remains: devotion at Thaeloren, and necessity wherever a graft has not yet spoken.

**The Rain-Shadow is slower on purpose.** Same continent, thin soil, wells, sand-country. A cut that takes in the Sacred Core dies in the dry hills unless a Taken-In and a lucky year agree. This is dirt. Fox of the Sands hearths still walk west toward Thaeloren after coastal squares have already stopped. Clock 2 on one continent at two speeds.

Seat narration: *her hands filled the Motherland*. Folk memory: *we stopped burying children on the Near Mile where the wood took, and we did not stop where it didn't*. Both sentences can be said in the same market.

By C.Y. 80 the Motherland is **old Hands** in the core and **still waiting** in pockets. That leftover waiting is why a Maiethorn hamlet can still send this year's ten-year-olds to a neighbour without being "historical."

*Strandoren, C.Y. 40–160, by sea (wealthy coasts first, interior later)*

The inner sea already knew how to move a child. Moving a Hand is the same berth with worse instructions: living earth, do not stow below, water at dawn, a Taken-In or a Road-hand who sleeps beside the pot.

**Why the sea starts while Maiethorn is still filling (C.Y. 40).** A ship is faster than filling every inland hamlet. A wealthy coast can pay a Cutting-leave and a Salt-Walk crew in the same summer a Near-Mile village is still on the Seat's list. The wave went where ships and fees went.

**Coasts first.** Port-cities take. Deep interior waits on river-days and a cart, which is a small Long Mile. Strandoren's later high reach and worn faith are not a paradox: the wood arrived as cargo, and cargo does not require a mother. The Fair Hand dates the carrying as a supply-chain fact. They will attend a planting as witnesses to a signing. They will not start history at a wound in wood. *The first carrying* is their name for Eoloren, and they mean a bill of lading.

**What the Salt Walk becomes.** When a coast Turns under its own canopy, the berth stops being a tenth-year necessity and becomes a luxury, a contract-hinge, a devout extra. Road-houses on the inland days lose a season of boots and keep the notes.

By C.Y. 160 the Shore-lands are **mature Hands** on the water and still patchy inland. Lestrand files the whole motion as *the carrying*. They are not wrong about the ships.

*The gap (why Heskoren waits until C.Y. 200)*

Three stacked frictions, none of them unworthiness:

1. **Wood dies on the Long Mile.** Weeks to months. A day's earth is a Near-Mile problem. A ship's hold is a solved Salt-Walk problem if you water it. A cart between hearths in thaw-mud is how scions become sticks. Until carrying-earth lasts, and until there are **rest-hearths whose job is wood, not pilgrims**, Heskoren cannot be a circuit. Road-hands as a standing office had to exist before the far could be a route rather than a funeral of saplings.
2. **The chain has to grow up.** You cut from the origin, or from a healthy town Tree. Maiethorn's first generation of sources come of age in the C.Y. 20s–40s. Strandoren's coastal Hands are not ready to be sources until later still. You cannot skip to the sundered reach without a mature link, unless you spend origin-wood on a death-march. The Seat did not, mostly. That is horticulture and it is also a choice about who is next.
3. **The queue prefers a paying next.** After the coasts, carrying-earth is committed to interiors, replacements, sick Trees: the quiet work that does not look like a wave. Heskoren is poor, far, and already accused (by a later guilt-theology) of waiting because it deserved to. They waited because the wood was slow, the road was long, and the list was written in the Motherwood.

Vaethorn will preach *we wait because we are unworthy*. The gap is the evidence they use. The chronicle does not agree.

*Heskoren, C.Y. 200–387 (still incomplete)*

The frontier coast faces the sea back toward Strandoren; that is the lifeline of new grafts. Luckiest towns have had a local Turning for a few generations (a scion that arrived in the 200s and spoke in the 220s, or later). Whole districts still send children down the road, to a neighbour's new canopy, or, still, the Long Mile, if the neighbour is a stick in a pot.

**This is Clock 2, present tense.** Some hamlets are in the Walking Years *this year, for this cohort*. Some are Hands-era one valley over. Both can be true on the same road. Vaethorn's waiting is the wave's front.

Old Ways host-rights start *here* as a lived collision, not as a Maiethorn sermon. A graft in an old Taken-In green is a guest. A Cutting-leave is a mainland paper. The meal comes first, or the planting is a claiming.

Seat narration: *her will is still travelling*. Folk memory: *the cart came late, the soil was called thin, the three hamlets past the ford can see Harrow's green from here*. The Harrow-sentence is already how new towns talk. On Heskoren it is the decade.

*Kumbaan: never*

No graft crossed the storm-wall. Road-hands do not bring the Mother over drowning sea. Sailors tell of pots that went into the water. Dead wood is not a Tree. The Open Table owes Eoloren nothing. Moons, not Cut-years.

## Seat narration vs folk memory

|                       | Seat / devout sermon            | Folk memory (and the other houses)          |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| The knife             | She offered a Hand              | Someone took one                            |
| The paper             | Stewardship; horticulture       | A fine that forgot; a licence; a warrant    |
| The order of the wave | Her will travelling             | Ships and fees, then the far                |
| Heskoren's wait       | Soil, timing, the Mother's pace | The list, the dead wood, the late cart      |
| What was saved        | The world received her          | Children stopped dying on <i>some</i> roads |

A Long-Lived who says *I walked* and a Speaker who keeps the Eoloren-count will fight about the same summer. A Long-Lived who *planted* (a Road-hand's long tenure, an innkeeper who watched pots replace children) will not always tell you which taking they think was holy. Memory is perfect. Meaning is not.

Spreading Trees did not abolish the unvouched Struck, the pitied Kept, guild conscription, or Tithe-leverage. They *relocated* who is expected to have been seen at ten. A Hands-town can still meet a feared Struck with a rope. A local canopy is not a solvent.

## What a character notices

- A kitchen-knife on a ribbon in a Near-Mile house that will not name a saint.
- Watchers grafting pears in the same week a Road-hand waters carrying-earth.
- A first-meal bowl at a planting, licked clean by dogs, which the Seat did not write down.
- A ship's instruction, still copied: *one living hand; do not stow below; water at dawn*. The clerk who copies it files cargo.
- Three hamlets that can see a neighbour's canopy and are still on the queue. They have learned not to say *queue*.
- A Rain-Shadow child on the west-road after the core has stopped walking.
- Empty Salt-Walk berths in Eolthael, and a hold that still smells of wet earth out of season.
- A Long-Lived who planted and will not say *I walked*. Different job. Same quiet.

## A minute of the First Seat

*Attributed to the Speaker Rithnali, from the summer the nameless green held its first Turning-Week. Later clerks file it as Cut-year 19. The verso is a list of pots that died, which no one read aloud.*

*The wood that took within a day's earth of the First was cut without leave. We will not write who. We will write how, so the next cut does not kill what it carries.*

*Carry in living earth. Marry with the watering-words. Do not cut a second without the Seat. If the scion sickens, send word; do not take another wound in the First to hide the first.*

*The Tree does not reach twice by chance, and neither do we. From this summer a cut is a leave, or it is a theft we have decided not to chase. The towns that wait will wait on horticulture. The soil is thin in more places than it is not.*

“We will not write who” is the capture. “The soil is thin” is already a list. The pots on the verso are the argument the recto pretends to have closed. Folk who keep the nameless knife think this paper is a confession. The Seat thinks it is competence. Both can hold the same copy.

## Consequences

- **Clock 2 starts.** The Grafting as a wave: wood carried outward, a generation to mature, Maiethorn first, Strandoren by sea, Heskoren last and live, Kumbaan never.

- **Clock 1 flips where the wood has taken.** Turning under a town canopy becomes the default. The pilgrimage remains, with a new job (devotion, prestige, or necessity when a graft fails).
  - **The Seat gains a bottleneck.** Cutting-leave and the scion-queue are how an institution absorbed a heresy and called it horticulture. She did not write the queue.
  - **The clerical epoch.** Cut-years begin. Other people do not have to care.
  - **Language and money.** Local Trees let daughters grow in place; the road's conserving pull eases. Road-houses in the core lose pilgrim-seasons and keep the notes.
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## The Years of Hands

A town Turning Tree is the ordinary way to Turn *where the wood has taken*. Everyday name: **the Years of Hands** (also *Since the Hands*). Liturgical: **Ornthael** (*orn-THALE*), "Tree-land." The Grafting is Clock 2 still moving. It is not an age you exit.

This is the era the rest of the world lives in without naming it. Town Trees. Local Leaf-Fall. Citizenship because *this* town watched you. The pilgrimage to Thaeloren as an extra, not the only door.

It is also incomplete. Read the reach-gradient as a *date*, not as a finished map:

- **Maiethorn:** old Hands. Dense mature grafts. The Walking is biography for the deathless and a ribbon on a mile-shrine for everyone else, except in the Rain-Shadow, and except wherever a Tree has sickened. Old Hands can un-Hands. That is weather, not a fall of the age.
- **Strandoren:** mature Hands, worn faith. The road-houses finished becoming banks here. The walk is a luxury, a contract-hinge, and a hold that still smells of earth when a pot is the passenger.
- **Heskoren:** the Grafting *this decade*. Luckiest towns have had a local canopy for a few generations. Whole districts still send children down the road. Vaethorn's waiting is the wave's front.
- **Kumbaan:** never. Off both clocks.

The pilgrimage **did not vanish**. It changed jobs. Institutions that survive by changing function are the texture of this era: the First Seat still authorizes cuts (now a queue); deathless houses still remember the road (now as credit); mile-shrines still stand (now as folklore, argument, and a thing children climb). The romance of the old mile is a Hands feeling. The graves are Walking facts. They occupy the same square.

A child on the Long Mile this summer is not doing history.

## The walk's three jobs

In Brenvaeth the walk was *how you Turned*. In Ornthael it is three jobs that share roads, inns, and the one-week door, and do not share a reason.

| Job                                                                                                  | Who still walks                                                                                                         | What they are buying                                                                         | What they are not                                                                   |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Devotion: the extra mile</b>                                                                      | People who already have a local Tree and still want Thaeloren                                                           | an origin-fall; a ribbon at the First Hand; the Motherwood in Eolthael                       | necessity. They could have Turned at home.                                          |
| <b>Prestige: the First-Hand year</b>                                                                 | Lestrand money, a Bound signing-watch, a guild-ticket hinge, a wedding extra                                            | being <i>seen at the origin</i> when you did not need to be; a held-over winter as a product | piety, unless it is also that. The Fair Hand will attend as witnesses to a signing. |
| <b>Necessity: the neighbour's week</b> (still <i>the old mile</i> when the neighbour is a continent) | Tree-poor, Tree-sick, Tree-young; a missed fall this year; Heskoren this cohort; the Rain-Shadow after the core stopped | a Given-door that is not at home                                                             | folklore. They are making the week.                                                 |

People did not say *Ornthael* on the road. They said *we are going to the Thallow*, or *we Turn at Harrow's*, or *the berth is for the child*. Vaethorn still calls almost any walk *the waiting-road*. Lestrand files the extra as *the First-Hand year* and the need as *the borrowed week*. Threnmaieth wants the miles *on a roll*.

**They share the Near Mile in Hale-month.** A devotion-column, a prestige household with too much luggage, a necessity-family who sold a year, and a Road-hand going the other way with a pot, can sleep in the same upper room. The innkeeper can tell who is which. They will not always tell you. The Far-Voiced ridge-cry still works: *the ford is wrong*. Some of the mouths that answer are pilgrims. Some are carts of wood.

**The inversion, lived.** Thaelvaeth is wood carried *out*. Brenvaeth was hearths walking *in*. In the Years of Hands both directions are traffic. A Road-hand and a tenth-year pass on a bank and do not owe each other a sermon. That passing *is* the two clocks in one afternoon.

**Hands can un-Hands.** A town Tree that sickens, or that fails a fall, puts a Hands-town back on the neighbour's week. Clock 1 is not a one-way door. A sick Tree is Clock 2 weather that the Seat will call thin soil, and the town will call this year.



The one-week door did not loosen. Miss Eolthael and the Given-door has shut, at home or at the origin. Struck remains the later mercy. There is still no second-chance year. The held-over nine-year-old is still the expensive mercy, and on the prestige-walk it is also a winter you can buy.

Kumbaan is not on this table. No extra mile crosses the storm-wall.

## Visible leftovers

What the Walking built, the Hands still sleep in. Adaptive reuse, not ruins. A leftover that is only a ruin is a Hands-town telling itself the road is over.

### *Mile-shrines (the stone in the square)*

Still water, a flat top, often a name, often a ribbon. In a Hands-town the last one is frequently **in the square**, because the town grew around a graft planted beside the road, and the road's destination moved closer.

They are, at once:

- **Graves.** Walking facts. A Long-Lived who says *I walked* can still tell you which ford the name belongs to.
- **Waymarks.** Necessity-walkers still drink there. Road-hands still aim for the water.
- **Folklore.** Devotion leaves a ribbon. Hands-children climb.
- **Argument.** A warden wants it moved because it is in the way of the Leaf-Fall crowd. A house that still dates notes from a founding-summer wants it left. A neighbour who still walks wants it left for a different reason.

The stone does not know which story it is in. A ribbon is still not a leaf-colour.

Hands-towns that **pull a stone down** are doing theology with a hammer. They are not wrong that the road no longer has to happen there. They are wrong if they think the graves went with the requirement. The next necessity-column will miss the water.

### *The upper room (empty pilgrim-beds)*

An old inn's upper room has too many beds for the present trade. In Brenvaeth they were the two crowded months. In Ornthael they are:

- **Let to merchants.** The White Note's conversion; occupancy as competence.
- **Opened for Eolthael.** Devotion and prestige still swell a Near-Mile house for a fortnight.
- **Held.** A family said they would come. They did not. The innkeeper keeps the bed a year, then two, then as a habit that looks like hospitality and functions as a shrine *and* as proof the house

remembers. Thilim still makes Seine's. Houses that became banks mostly stopped making them, except the one they will not let, which is how a clerk writes *house custom* on a slate and means a grave.

The romance of the empty bed is a Hands feeling. The name on the lintel is a Walking fact.

### *Roads that end at a Tree*

The pilgrim-road was often the main road. A graft took beside it. The town grew around the canopy. **The road now ends at the Tree.** The last holy mile is a square. Beyond the boughs the old way is a cart-track to timber, a neighbour, a ford. Children are told the road goes to the Motherwood. It goes to the mill. Both can be true if you keep walking, which most Hands-children do not.

A road that "ends" is a Clock 1 sentence. The necessity-family from the next valley is still using it as Clock 2. Same stones.

### *Other leftovers a character notices*

- Empty Salt-Walk berths in Eolthael, except the expensive ones and the holds that smell of wet earth out of season.
- A Far-Voiced ridge-cry in an old pattern: *the ford is wrong*. No column answers. A Road-hand does. Birds do.
- A sibling-pair, one Given, one Kept, who will not walk the same side of a road. A split household's grandchildren keeping a courtesy they cannot date.
- Markets that still swell at an old mile-mark in Hale-month, then vanish, even when no column comes. Habit is a leftover.
- A kitchen-knife on a ribbon in a Near-Mile house that will not name a saint (the nameless knife, still not a museum piece).

## **Deathless houses' road-past as present credit**

Many deathless houses began as road-houses. That fate-shift is already in the past: inns that became banks, the same Long-Lived, a different fortune.

**The founding-summer is the credit.** "We kept you on the mile" is an origin-story that still collects. A century-loan written from a house-year is not only a dating-quirk. It is a claim that the porridge was real, the note was real, and the house is still the same mouth. No mortal court can audit a Long-Lived's memory of a walk two hundred summers back. That is why the trusted note holds. It is also why a house can call a debt whose grandchildren do not remember the ford.

**Two fates of the same origin, still standing.**

- **The White Note House.** The reformation. Beds let to merchants. Paper on the quay. The 200th summer of the White Note is already a clerk's problem. The Held names are in the founding-book. Most of those beds are let. One is not, which is how a bank proves it used to be an inn.
- **The Third Hearth.** The house that stayed a hearth. Thilim still keeps it, still makes Seine's bed, still knows which mouths will be here at dark. The notes are smaller. The shrine is larger. Lestrang calls this a bed-house that failed to become a bank. Thilim does not call it a failure.

The long-house of books is still the deathless paying their own Tithe. The road-past is why anyone trusted them to endow in the first place: a mouth that remembered every debtor on the mile is a mouth you let steer a library.

**The prestige-walk is now a product some houses sell.** A held-over winter at the origin, once the frightened far mercy, is a First-Hand year you can book. The White Note did not invent that. They noticed the upper room was empty in Nethael and full of the wrong people in Eolthael, and they made a term for it. The year is assembled on three desks: **Netstrand charts the hull, the White Note writes the term, Orentel holds the berth.** Orenbren houses the sleep at the origin. Necessity-families still sign the old kind of note: eat now, pay on the home-walk, or when the child is grown, or when a sibling walks next year. Same paper, two jobs. The clerk who files both as occupancy is counting beds, not jobs.

Vaethorn will preach that the houses *abandoned the waiting-road*. The walk stopped being required in the core. The memory did not. The paper outlived the season. That is a reformation, and it still collects. Spreading Trees did not make the notes kind.

## Heskoren as the live front

**This is Clock 2, present tense.** Some hamlets are in the Walking Years *this year, for this cohort*. Some are Hands-era one valley over. Both can be true on the same road.

**Harrow's Green** is the luckiest kind of Heskoren town: a scion that arrived in the C.Y. 200s, spoke a generation later, and has now Turned local children for a few generations. It is a neighbour's canopy. It is also a queue-confession you can see from the ford. The Harrow-sentence (*we Turned at Harrow's Tree before we had our own*) is how new towns talk everywhere. On Heskoren it is the decade.

**The Three Hamlets Past the Ford** are the waiting kind. The Seat's Cutting-leave already named them as thin soil. They send this year's ten-year-olds to Harrow's, or further if Harrow's year is too full, or still the Long Mile if the neighbour is a stick in a pot. They have learned not to say *queue*. They can see the canopy. Folk-right cutting is a temptation with a kitchen-knife. Most slips die. The ones that take are how the queue learns it is not the only horticulture in the world.

**Old Ways host-rights start here as a collision, not a sermon.** A graft in an old Taken-In green is a guest. A Cutting-leave is a mainland paper. The first meal comes first, or the planting is a claiming.

The Door-Keepers and the Road-hands can both love the wood and still fight about the bowl.

**Borrowed Turnings are the front's ordinary year.** Citizenship-by-local-witness is Hands-era weather: the town that *saw you* may be Harrow's, not the hamlet that raised you. Vouching-at-a-distance, invented to carry an *origin*-fall home, now carries a *neighbour*-fall home. Same three pillars. Shorter road. The unvouched Struck are still older than the grafts. A local canopy did not dissolve them.

Seat narration: *her will is still travelling*. Folk memory: *the cart came late, the soil was called thin, we can see Harrow's green from here*. Vaethorn will preach *we wait because we are unworthy*. They wait because the wood is slow, the road is long, and the list was written in the Motherwood.

The Rain-Shadow on Maiethorn is the same grammar on an older continent: leftover waiting after the core stopped. Ornsael is that leftover on the Motherland. A west-road child after the Sacred Core has stopped walking is Clock 2 where the Hands first matured, which is how you know Ornthael is not a finished age.

## What is strained

What a traveller can already see:

- The **First Seat** is old in the queue. It has authorized cuts for three hundred and eighty-seven summers. Towns that can see a neighbour's canopy have learned the horticulture-sentence by heart. Folk-right slips still happen. Threnmaieth still wants the college on the roll. The Seat is *heavy*.
- The **Road-hands** are thin on the Heskoren front. Living earth, mortal wood, a skeleton circuit, authority that expires a week out from the Motherwood. A live Tree is a quiet success no one writes down. A dead one is a name on a complaint. They plant what they were given leave to plant. They sleep in the town that was not chosen.
- **Waiting towns** hang on a single scion, or on a neighbour's week. That is a civic crisis wearing a child's summer.
- **Deathless houses** are richer in paper than in beds. The road-past is the credit. The upper room is the tell.

The pressure is already visible.

| Entity           | State                              | Why the pressure is already visible                                                                                      |
|------------------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| First Seat       | Peak power, pressure rising        | 387 years of the queue; Threnmaieth proximity; folk-right cuttings that take; “thin soil” as a sentence towns can recite |
| Road-hands       | Overextended at the Heskoren front | skeleton circuit; dead wood; authority that expires; blame when a pot dies; they sleep in the town not chosen            |
| Waiting towns    | Precarious                         | single scion or neighbour’s week; folk-right temptation; Kept-heavy / Struck-heavy as this year’s fact                   |
| Deathless houses | Peak, already reformed             | road-past as un-auditable credit; concentration the rarity-cap fights; prestige-walk as product                          |

## A letting-slate from the White Note’s inland house

*Kept by Mataero, who is junior to Ledan and has never made a Held bed. Cut-year 387; the house-year is not written on the recto. The verso is a copy of founding-names in an older hand.*

*Nethael closing. Upper room: twelve beds. Let: eight, to the wool out of Lestrand, term through Hale-month, pay on the quay-note. Open for Eolthael: four, First-Hand year, held-over child already spoken for, the mother paid the winter in advance. Occupancy will cover the loft.*

*Do not let the north bed. House custom. The founding-book has a name I am not to copy onto a term. Ledan says the house is the same mouth. I say the mouth is the note. The bed is empty. Empty is not a shrine. Empty is a bed we are not charging for.*

*Thilim’s third hearth still holds a far-cape name. We do not. We are not an inn that failed. We are the house that remembered long enough to be trusted.*

*I do not ask which summer was holy. I ask which mouths will pay in Ledger-month. If the north bed is a grave, it is a grave that does not belong on a letting-slate.*

“House custom” is the credit. Letting the loft to wool is how a road-house finishes becoming a bank in front of a junior who needs the conversion to be competence. The founding-name they will not copy is the Held bed as a bank-token. Thilim, inland, still making the bed, is the other fate of the same origin. Both houses are telling the truth they have. The wool will still come due.

# Folklore of the road, the Cut, and the leftover

Three teaching-stories. The bones stay the same. The last line will not choose.

## The Child Who Counted Stones

The teaching-story of the road. Told on the Walking Years' three walks, and still told in Hands-towns that have never sent a child as far as the next valley. Romance and graves in the same count.

A child asked how far it was to the Tree.

The mother said: *as many days as there are stones*.

The child walked, and counted. At each stone there was a ribbon, or there was not. The child asked if the ribbons were for people who had arrived.

The mother said: *some*.

They drank at the stones. They slept in their lee. They used them to know the water. The child kept count, and the count was the days, and the count was also the names the mother would not read aloud.

They arrived. A leaf fell, or the leaves hugged. The tellings do not agree, and it does not change the walk home.

On the way back the child asked to leave a ribbon.

The mother said: *we are not a stone yet*.

The child left one anyway, on a stone that already had too many, and could not say, later, whether they had been adding a day or a grave.

A Long-Lived who keeps a hearth on that mile will tell you the child's name. They will not tell you which summer. They still make a bed they will not let.

**The last lines (by mouth).** The bones above are common. What a mouth adds last is the stance:

- **Near Mile (devout):** *The Mother had counted them first. The stones were how she kept the days.*
- **Near Mile (tired):** *It was a road. The stones were so you did not miss the water.*
- **Salt Walk:** *The sea has no stones. That is why we charge for the berth.*
- **Long Mile:** *The mother was wrong. There are more stones than days. That is how you know you are on the Long Mile.*
- **the Old Ways:** *The stones were there before the walk. The land was already counting.*
- **the Watching:** *The Tree saw every ribbon. The count was optional.*
- **Hands-era children:** *We climb them. There is a good one past the mill. The ribbon is just rag.*

Skeptics of every walk tell a short ending: *There were not two counts. There were people, and weather, and a grove that would not come to you.*

### **Variants.**

- On Maiethorn it is a walking-song; the chorus is only numbers.
- On Strandoren the quay-version starts at the berth and never finds a stone until the inland days, which is the joke and the bill.
- On Heskoren some tellers omit the arrival. The child is still counting when the story stops.
- A road-house telling ends on the Held bed, not the grove. Innkeepers think this is the real version.
- Kumbaas does not keep this story. A mainland guest who tells it is offered more supper, which is an answer.

## **The Branch That Came Away**

The teaching-story of the Cut. Told about the First Cut, and still told in towns that have a Tree and a neighbour that does not. Sharing a Hand requires wounding a Hand, and the first copy invented both the local mercy and the wait.

A branch came away from the Tree.

A person carried it. They watered it. They put it in new ground.

It died.

They carried another. Or they carried the same one, and the tellings do not agree, and it does not change the ground.

It took.

The origin said: *that wood is ours.*

The new ground said: *that wood is here.*

Both were right, which is why there had to be a paper.

The paper said who may take the next branch. The Tree was not asked. The Tree kept choosing children under both canopies.

A child asked which Tree was the real one.

The mother said: *count the Hands.*

The child counted two, then twenty, then the towns that were not in the count yet.

The child asked who was next.

The mother said: *the soil is thin there.*

The child could see the neighbour's canopy from the ford, and could not say, later, whether they had been counting Hands or counting waits.

A Long-Lived who planted will tell you the child's name. They will not tell you which summer. They still will not write who cut.

### **The last lines (by mouth).**

- **Folk (Near Mile):** *The mother was the one who cut. The paper came after, like a fine.*
- **Clergy:** *The warden cut with a leave the college had not invented yet. The paper is how we kept the next one alive.*
- **Devout:** *The branch came away. No one stole a Hand. She gave one.*
- **the Watching:** *We have always cut living wood. They named one cut the First. The count is optional.*
- **the Old Ways:** *The ground received a guest. The paper is a mainland word for a meal they did not stay for.*
- **the Fair Hand:** *The second carrying was a berth. The first was an unlicensed one. That is the whole hymn.*
- **Hands-era children (a Tree-town):** *We Turn here. The neighbour walks. The story is why.*
- **Hands-era children (still walking):** *We can see the canopy. The story does not plant anything.*

Skeptics of every house tell a short ending: *There was not a Hand that learned to walk. There was wood, and a pot, and a college that got to the knife late.*

### **Variants.**

- On Maiethorn it is told at Turning-Week in the Motherwood and in kitchens that keep a knife on a ribbon. The Motherwood version starts at *came away*. The kitchen version starts at *took*.
- On Strandoren the quay-version never finds a Tree until the hold is opened. The joke is the bill. The bill is not a joke inland.
- On Heskoren some tellers omit the taking. The child is still asking who is next when the story stops. Guest-reading tellers start at the meal. First-reading tellers start at the claiming.
- A Seat telling ends on the paper, not the ford. Speakers think this is the real version.
- Kumbaan does not keep this story. A mainland guest who tells it is offered more supper, which is an answer.



## The Child Who Climbed the Stone

The teaching-story of the leftover. Told in the Years of Hands about mile-shrines that outlived the requirement, and still told in towns that have a Tree in the square and a neighbour that walks. You cannot treat a stone as past without abandoning the people still using it as a mile, and you cannot treat the road as unchanged without lying about the local canopy.

A town grew a Tree beside the road.

The last stone of the old mile stood in what became the square. Children climbed it. A ribbon stayed on it, or did not. The tellings do not agree, and it does not change the scuff.

A warden said: *it is in the way of the crowd.*

A Long-Lived who keeps beds said: *it is a name.*

A child of the Tree-town asked how far it was to the Tree.

The mother said: *we are already here.*

A child from the hamlets past the ford came for a borrowed week, saw children on the stone, and asked how far it was to the Tree.

The Tree-town mother said: *we are already here.*

The waiting child said: *we can see your canopy from the ford.*

They climbed together. The waiting child left a ribbon. The Tree-town child could not say, later, whether they had been playing or counting a wait.

A Long-Lived who still makes a bed they will not let will tell you both children's names. They will not tell you which summer. They still will not move the stone, and they still will not say the road is over.

### The last lines (by mouth).

- **Tree-town (devout):** *The Mother stopped the road when the Hand arrived. The stone is how we remember the waiting.*
- **Tree-town (tired):** *The Tree is here. The stone is in the way. We climb it because it is the right height.*
- **Waiting child / Heskoren:** *We can see the canopy. The story does not plant anything.*
- **Lestrand:** *The beds upstairs are let. The stone is a mile-mark the clerks have not billed yet.*
- **Innkeeper:** *The stone is the upper room. We did not let it. That is the whole hymn.*
- **the Watching:** *The stone was already a stone. The Tree saw the climb. The count is optional.*
- **the Old Ways:** *The land was already counting. The square is a guest's furniture.*
- **Road-hand:** *I water at it. I sleep in the town that was not chosen. I do not say queue.*

- **Hands-era children (who have never walked):** *There is a good one in the square. The ribbon is just rag.*

Skeptics of every house tell a short ending: *There were not two roads. There was a stone, and a Tree, and a child who still had to walk.*

#### **Variants.**

- On Maiethorn it is told as a square-game; the chorus is only *already here*. The Rain-Shadow telling (Ornsael) omits the Tree-town mother, or makes her wrong.
  - On Strandoren the quay-version starts in the loft and never finds a stone until inland, which is the joke and the bill.
  - On Heskoren some tellers omit the climb. The waiting child is still asking how far when the story stops. Guest-reading tellers start at the meal under the stone. First-reading tellers start at the claiming of the square.
  - A Seat telling ends on the crowd, not the ford. Speakers think this is the real version: the stone should move.
  - A White-Note telling ends on the north bed. Juniors think this is the real version: empty is not a shrine.
  - Kumbaan does not keep this story. A mainland guest who tells it is offered more supper, which is an answer.
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BOOK VII

## Powers and Places

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# The Fifteen Powers

## The fifteen

Fifteen named powers on the three large continents. Kumbaan is not a thirteenth mainland power and not a sixteenth. It is an isolate with a table, a moon, and a storm-wall. The Isle is a people at home, not a flag on the Seat's list.

Beneath the fifteen the world still swarms: marches, free towns, petty Tree-seats, wild that no one has named as a power. Fifteen is how many powers are worth naming, not how many places exist.

| Continent                 | Reach     | How many | Why that many                                                             |
|---------------------------|-----------|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Maiethorn</b>          | full      | <b>6</b> | old heart; a clutch of kingdoms competing for the grove and the inner sea |
| <b>Strandoren</b>         | high      | <b>5</b> | a constellation of coasts and compacts, not one market with a crown       |
| <b>Heskoren</b>           | thin      | <b>4</b> | fewer, poorer, scattered; long wild between Trees                         |
| <b>The Sundering Isle</b> | near-none | <b>0</b> | not on this list                                                          |

The name a polity gives itself is two old words glued, worn the way that land talks. The one-line in the table is the meaning. **The Four Continents** already lists what the land-names mean, and the three corners. **Language and Naming** has the word-box if you need another.

Pronunciation: **CAPS** = stress; **ae** = “ay”; **th** = *thin*.

Every polity sets three axes independently:

- **Theology**: how gift-devout it is. One end is ardent Motherfaith, folding the gifts into worship and tending. The other is frank secular pragmatism.
- **Reach**: Tree-rich core, or Tree-poor edge.

- **Governance:** how far the state reaches onto the person. Light guild self-rule is the world's warm default. At the far end, a crown that writes its subjects down.

## The fifteen at a glance

Axes: Theology (Motherfaith gift-devotion) · **Reach** · **Governance**. ● high · ◐ mid · ○ low.

**Leftover** here means the older job of the ground the power occupies (a pilgrimage-country, a salt quay, a guest-grove), which the present polity is layered onto.

| Polity                 | Continent  | T  | R | G | One-line feel                                                | Leftover it sits on                                         |
|------------------------|------------|----|---|---|--------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Threnmaieth</b>     | Maiethorn  | ●  | ● | ● | the Mother's Reckoning; census as care                       | origin pilgrimage-towns <i>under</i> a roll; seat Maiethlir |
| <b>Maiethvael</b>      | Maiethorn  | ●  | ● | ○ | the Gift-Realm: plenty, no list                              | origin pilgrimage-country that furnishes                    |
| <b>Orenbren</b>        | Maiethorn  | ●  | ● | ◐ | the Witness-Hearths: lodging as power; does not own the Tree | origin pilgrimage-town                                      |
| <b>Saelthael</b>       | Maiethorn  | ●  | ◐ | ○ | the Sown Tree: Rain-Shadow still planting                    | Rain-Shadow walk-hold                                       |
| <b>the Hinge Shore</b> | Maiethorn  | ◐  | ● | ○ | Old Crossing face; classifies the hull                       | salt-adjacent Old-World quays                               |
| <b>Lirorn</b>          | Maiethorn  | ◐  | ● | ◐ | the Thaw-Land: range and snowmelt                            | ridge-roads; not a Kind-flag                                |
| <b>Lestrand</b>        | Strandoren | ○  | ● | ○ | the Ledger Coast: priced and free                            | salt quay; seat Orentel                                     |
| <b>Brenledd</b>        | Strandoren | ○  | ● | ○ | the Hearth-League: many charters, one compact                | salt / river towns between houses                           |
| <b>Leddvael</b>        | Strandoren | ○* | ● | ◐ | the Reckoned Gift: Fair Hand as civic rite                   | salt quay with a signing-watch                              |
| <b>Trenledd</b>        | Strandoren | ○  | ● | ● | the Worn Count: a roll with the hymn worn off                | road-end Tree-towns <i>filed</i>                            |
| <b>Netstrand</b>       | Strandoren | ◐  | ● | ○ | the Night Shore: west water, Heskoren trade                  | salt quay; hulls and west-water berths                      |
| <b>Vaethorn</b>        | Heskoren   | ●  | ○ | ○ | the Waiting Lands: scarce gift, hot faith                    | pilgrim-edge; seat Eolvaeth (not the hamlets)               |
| <b>Ornled</b>          | Heskoren   | ○  | ○ | ○ | the Outer Ledger: secular frontier, no congregation-net      | waiting cluster without a gospel                            |

| Polity           | Continent | T    | R | G | One-line feel                                  | Leftover it sits on  |
|------------------|-----------|------|---|---|------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| <b>Vaelhesk</b>  | Heskoren  | ☛ ** | ○ | ○ | the Far Yield: Old Ways<br>host-rights         | guest-grove          |
| <b>Saelvaeth</b> | Heskoren  | ☛    | ○ | ☛ | the Sown Waiting: the live<br>front as a march | live-front Tree-town |

\* **Leddvael** is low on *Motherfaith* and high on the Fair Hand. Theology here still means gift-devotion; a rival faith filling the gap is not a fourth axis. \*\* **Vaelhesk** is the same shape with the Old Ways.

Three other corners sit on the map: **Maiethvael** (devout, rich, lightly governed), **Trenledd** (surveillance with no faith to sanctify it), **Ornled** (secular frontier, required on Heskoren).

None of the fifteen is a Kind-nation. Hearths, not flags. Saelthael is sand-country, not a Fox kingdom. Lirorn is a watershed, not a Tengu empire. The Hinge Shore and Netstrand are shores, not Selkie sea-empires. Vaelhesk is host-rights, not a Taken-In nation.

None is a faith-nation. The Watching stays a heartland heresy *inside* Maiethorn districts, not a sixth Motherland flag. Leddvael is the one power that made a rival faith *civic*, and even there the Book-hands have no seat.

## How they sit

**Maiethorn.** Threnmaieth coils near the sacred centre and wants everyone on the **Threnhael**, its census of persons. Its seat is Maiethlir (thaw-river Hand, *not* the grove). Maiethvael is the old gift-country that shares the Mother and refuses the list: same hymns, opposite paper. Orenbren is the lodging-cluster of the Near Mile (the week's door to the origin), civic rather than clerical. The First Seat sits in the Motherwood *beside* it and is not its crown. Saelthael is the leeward east, still walking west after the core stopped. The Hinge Shore faces Strandoren across the Old Crossing. Lirorn holds the central range that divides the waters. Fox-of-the-Snows and Tengu hearths are *densest* here, and it is not their country.

**Strandoren.** Lestrand is the premier coast. Its seat is Orentel (Salt Quay; White Note on the third quay, *not* the crown). Brenledd is the compact of towns that got tired of being priced by one set of houses. Leddvael made the Fair Hand a civic rite on a different stretch of signing-water. Trenledd is the wealthy interior that started counting tickets and did not stop. Netstrand faces the open ocean toward Heskoren and, in stories, the storm-wall.

**Heskoren.** Vaethorn is the waiting-gospel. Its seat is Eolvaeth (pilgrim-edge, *not* Saelvaeth's march). Saelvaeth is the live edge of the wave; Harrow's Green sits in its orbit, *not* as a capital. Vaelhesk keeps host-rights on old greens. Ornled is Vaethorn with the faith burned out instead of up: same thin Trees,

no congregation to catch you. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford sit on the seam. They can see Harrow's canopy (Saelvaeth luck) and still hear Vaethorn guilt and Vaelhesk refusal. Folk names *Brenod · Vaelun · Ornath*; the Seat still does not use them.

## Two mouths, same fifteen

A Seat clerk and a Lestrand **factor** (a house's commercial agent, who prices routes and berths) do not issue the same map. **Orthopraxy**, belonging by the rite you keep, is the peace. The *list* is the tell.

*From a Cut-year minute, First Seat (C.Y. 387). Threnmaieth names itself the Reckoning and would name us. Maiethvael will not be named to them and still Sends the extra mile. Orenbren lodges what we do not house. Saelthael still walks, which the origin finds inconvenient. The Hinge Shore takes the Old Crossing. Lirorn takes the thaw. Across the water the factor's five: Lestrand, the Brenledd compact, Leddvael which files a Bound as a civic virtue, Trenledd which keeps a roll and will not call it a Threnhael, Netstrand which sells the west. On the far reach: Vaethorn waiting, Saelvaeth planting, Vaelhesk feeding a first meal we did not authorize, Ornled which will not say her name and will not keep a list either. Kumbaan is not a land we graft. We do not write it.*

*From a house-year docket, a Lestrand factor. Price the Hinge Shore and do not argue hymns with Maiethvael. Orenbren's beds are a market that calls itself a duty. Avoid Trenledd's roll unless you like being written. Leddvael will sign; that is cheaper than faith. Brenledd is many tickets. Netstrand quotes the far crossing like a pilgrimage. Heskoren: Vaethorn pays in blessing, Ornled in slate, Vaelhesk in a meal you had better eat, Saelvaeth in whatever the queue did this year. The Isle is a tale. We do not book it.*

Neither list is complete. Both are true of the speaker.

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## The three corners

### Threnmaieth: the Tallied Crown

(*THREN*-my-eth · thren “to count” + maieth “Mother” = “the Mother's Reckoning.” Theology high · reach high · governance high; the darkest corner)

A pious, Tree-rich core kingdom that is also **Watchful**: it keeps a register of persons. Alone among polities it holds a **census of persons and their Conditions**. Set that in the wealthiest, most devout,



most Tree-dense land, and the roster is kept as **sanctified duty**. The Mother's gifts are precious and must be *accounted for*. The other two corners have injustices you can name and resent. This one dresses its injustice in the two things the world most trusts, faith and plenty.

**Law.** The record is held on people: every subject and their gift written down. Guild rolls and tax ledgers exist everywhere. This is a **census of persons**, framed at home as reverent stewardship of the Mother's blessings and lived as surveillance. Reach is high, so there is a great deal to count: dense Given, dense guilds, abundant Long-Lived whose memory the crown *distrusts because it isn't the crown's*. That is the Tallied Crown's deepest tell. It will not rely on the three pillars the rest of the world runs on (Long-Lived memory, Bound word, Far-Voiced feeling). Living memory answers to itself. A ledger answers to the crown. The **unvouched are hunted and the Struck pursued to be catalogued**. The Bound are watched far past their real hazard: stigma dressed as safety. The Inviolable Will means the Whisper cannot command, and the roster's own clerks know it. Devotion supplies the justification a bare Watchful crown lacks: *you would not hide a gift from the Mother, so why hide it from her stewards?*

**Economy.** Tithe-need turned to leverage, and consecrated. The crown provides Tithe-upkeep **efficiently, even generously** (a pious, rich state can afford to), but *holds* what it provides: the green, the novelty, the outlets, the Stilled medicine, all furnished through channels the crown controls and can withhold. A population whose staying-whole runs through the state **cannot afford to refuse it**. That is the most complete control anywhere, and here it wears a halo. To receive your Tithe-provision is to receive the Mother's bounty through her appointed hands. To be cut off is framed as *your* lapse, not the crown's lever. Its deathless-house finance is excellent and centuries-deep. The Long-Lived here are courtiers and crown-archivists as much as bankers, their incorruptible memory bent to the census rather than free to check it.

**Daily life.** Sacrament and census run together. A child's Turning is a **joyous holy day that is also a state registration**. The colour that falls is celebrated with a hymn *and* recorded by a clerk. Marriages of heritable Conditions (Two-Bodied bloodlines especially) are *noticed*, encouraged or discouraged, filed. The medicine that furnishes a Tithe is excellent and runs through the crown's channels. A household whose **bloodline and upkeep are both on file** cannot easily refuse the crown anything: domestic surveillance with a blessing said over it. The Kept are *pitied* here in the Warm's way *and* recorded in the Watchful's, passed over by the Mother, and noted as such.

**Its injustice.** The worst of both high axes, each excusing the other. The devotion sanctifies the surveillance (*it is reverence to be counted*). The surveillance enforces the devotion (*to refuse the count is impiety*). There is no clean villain. A wealthy, faithful, orderly people believe that accounting for the Mother's gifts is the highest form of tending them, and that belief makes the machinery of control almost impossible to resist. No other polity keeps such a list. This crown invented the record. The faith is what lets it feel like grace.

**The seat.** Maiethlir (*my-eth-LEER*), a thaw-river Hand in the Sacred Core. The leftover job is the extra mile (devotion's leftover walk); the Threnhael is the layer. It does not own Thaeloren. The First Seat sits in the Motherwood beside it.

## Lestrand: the Ledger Coast

(*leh-STRAND* · *ledd* “to reckon” + *strand* “shore” = “the Reckoning Coast.” *Theology low* · *reach high* · *governance low*)

A dense, Tree-rich merchant power. The Trees are mature and many, the Given are dense, and the faith is worn *lightly*. Deep markets, thin welfare, and a cool, transactional read on becoming. It shares the Waiting Lands' light-touch governance: no crown writes anyone down. Where the Lands' light state leaves a *gap the faith fills*, the Coast's light state leaves a *space the guilds fill*.

**Law.** The world's warm default at its most developed: **guild self-rule** carried as far as it goes. The state is a charter-granting council of merchant houses and craft-guilds. It charters the Stilled's guild and the element-guilds and watches the guild, never the individual. Citizenship-by-witness runs *smoothly* here because reach is high: abundant Long-Lived notaries, Bound whose sworn word closes every contract, Far-Voiced on every dock and in every court. The three pillars are not reverence here. They are **infrastructure**, the machinery that lets a huge commercial city run on trust without a register. The Struck are vouched-in briskly, as efficiency rather than grace, because an unvouched person is a transaction that cannot clear. The Inviolable Will is cited less as sacred bedrock than as sound commercial law: a Bound's contract binds property, not persons, and the Coast likes that line because it makes the Bound the perfect notary.

**Economy.** The richest of the three corners, and the coolest. This is where **deathless banking** is most developed: deathless houses whose trusted notes are the nearest thing the world has to a gold standard, century instruments, the whole endow-not-inherit loop running at scale. The great endowed libraries and universities cluster here, funding the Long-Lived's own novelty-Tithe. Self-paying Conditions prosper (the Answered crafts, the Two-Bodied haulage and courier trades, the Stilled surgeons) because their labor *is* their upkeep and the market pays for the labor. **Tithe-provision is a private market, not a public good.** You buy your green, your novelty, your outlet, and if you can afford it you stay whole in comfort. **Its injustice is the market's.** The provided-for Tithe-poor get *thin welfare in a rich city*, the starkest have-and-have-not gap anywhere. The **shadow economy** (smuggled green, black-market novelty, sold vouching, off-book contracts feeding the Given-Over) runs biggest here because the legitimate market is biggest here. The concentration risk the deathless pose is sharpest: a handful of houses that never die, quietly steering the wealthiest polity through patronage that never disperses.

**Daily life.** Excellent Condition-medicine (the great Stilled infirmaries and deathless-endowed hospitals are *here*, in the rich core), for those who can reach it. The queue outside it is longest here too.

Family life shrugs at theology. A **marriage market that reads Conditions as assets**: a Two-Bodied bloodline is a trade dynasty, a Long-Lived match is a century of credit, and the aching Long-Lived marriage gets weighed coolly as grief against advantage. The Turning is a civic and commercial milestone more than a sacrament. A family's Leaf-Fall is watched for what guild the child's colour opens. It is not warm. It is free, and prosperous.

**Its injustice.** The coolest of the three. Nothing is *policed*. Your marriage, your gift, your faith are your own. Everything is *priced*, and a person who cannot pay slides with a whole rich city stepping around them. The Coast will never file you or conscript you. It will let you fade if you run out of coin, and feel that it owed you nothing.

**The seat.** Orentel (*or-EN-tel*), a salt-quay city on the inner sea. The White Note House sits on the third quay, north side, and is not the crown.

## Vaethorn: the Waiting Lands

(*vay-THORN* · *vaeth* “the waiting” + *orn* “land” = “the Waiting Land.” *Everyday Wethorn. Theology high · reach low · governance low*)

A broad, thinly-peopled land at the world's Tree-poor margin. The faith burns hottest *because* the Trees are scarce. The ruling mood is *waiting*: for a graft to take, a distant Tree to be reached, a gift that may never fall. Where the Trees are few and young, more children come away Kept, more people are Struck later and alone, and the Motherfaith answers that scarcity with *more* devotion, not less: pilgrimage, longing, and a theology built around waiting for a gift that may not come.

**Law.** Governance is almost absent. No crown reaches the individual, and custom outruns written law the way it does on any frontier. Citizenship is witnessed in the oldest, most literal way: a settlement small enough that everyone *was* there when you Turned. Thin reach makes that fragile. With few Long-Lived to remember and few Bound to vouch, the three pillars that make proof-by-people work are stretched thin. The **unvouched Struck** (a person who changed alone, with no guild to catch them and few witnesses to stand for them) is a constant, aching problem the Waiting Lands meet with faith rather than machinery. A feared Condition here is more likely to be met with a rope or a blessing than a licence, because there is no guild to issue one.

**Economy.** Little formal Tithe-infrastructure and few specialists, but the theology reframes the frontier's poverty as *charity*. Where a secular frontier improvises Tithe-provision as barter and favor, the Waiting Lands do it as **alms and congregation**. The venting a Far-Voiced needs happens at worship. The green a Taken-In needs is furnished by neighbours who count it a sacred duty. The Taken-In whom rich cities keep at arm's length are here the honoured **backbone of the land**. Working the living earth is the holy economy. It is commons-minded generosity with almost nothing to fund it:

real warmth, real want, and a thin edge where the provided-for Tithe-poor slide with only prayer for a net.

**Daily life.** Thin ceremony made enormous by devotion. A child's Turning at a small, hard-won grafted Tree is the event of a decade, held as a joyous, anxious sacrament. The **Kept child is felt most sharply here**, because in a land starved of the gift, to be passed over reads (wrongly, and cruelly) as being passed over *by the Mother herself*. Medicine is a travelling stiller if the settlement is lucky and a rope-and-prayer if it is not. The core-vs-edge inequity is at its widest here. Families are warm, mixed, and self-reliant. A lapsing Condition with no infirmity to reach is a frontier tragedy the faith consoles but cannot cure.

**Its injustice.** Not a boot. A **guilt**. The scarcity of the gift becomes a theology of *unworthiness*. The Kept wonder what they lacked. The Struck wonder why the Mother came to them at the wrong door and alone. A hard, quiet piety can shade into treating want as a spiritual failing. The Waiting Lands are the kindest place in the world to a whole neighbour and the loneliest to an unvouched one.

**The seat.** Eolvaeth (*ay-ohl-VAYTH*), a pilgrim-edge vale behind the Strandoren-facing coast. People walk *here to wait*. The Tree is not a certainty. It is not Harrow's Green, not the three hamlets, and not Saelvaeth's march.

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## The twelve

The twelve have seats. A capital, a city, a town, or a refusal written down. Six charter-towns around Raitin stay unnamed. Trenledd's governing throat stays unnamed. Vaelhesk names no city. Harrow's Green stays a square in Saelvaeth's orbit. It is not the march's seat and not a capital. The First Seat stays in the wood, unnamed on every sheet. No capital is marked with a star.

### Maiethrael: the Gift-Realm

(*my-ETH-vayl* · *maieth* "Mother" + *vael* "gift" = "the Mother's Gift.") Theology high · reach high · governance **low**. Everyday *Maiethrael*; people **Maiethrael-folk**. Not Threnmaieth (the Mother's Reckoning).

An old, Tree-dense Motherland realm that treats Tithe-provision as **public tending**: greens, halls, and medicine furnished by congregation and guild, not by a crown channel. Citizenship is witnessed in the world's warm default. There is no Threnrael here. They will tell you counting persons is a failure of trust in the three pillars. The hymns are the same ones Threnmaieth sings. The paper is not.

**Site.** Full-reach Maiethorn country in sight of the pilgrimage weather, not coiled on the grove.

Leftover: origin pilgrimage-country that *furnishes*, the extra mile as hospitality, not as a roll-line.

**How it formed.** Gift-integration that never accepted a census. When Threnmaieth began to write people down, Maiethrael kept the older proof: you belong because you were seen to Turn, and you stay whole because your neighbours tend what you were Given. Light state on purpose. The gap is filled by faith and guild, not by a clerk.

**Structure.** Guild self-rule under ardent practice. Recruits by office, faith, Condition-lean, **not Kind**. The Watching persists in old districts as it does elsewhere on Maiethorn. It is not a second flag.

**Goals.** Keep the gift hale without writing the gifted down. Furnish generously. Pity the Kept in a land where almost no child is Kept: the slight with no thin-Tree excuse.

**Its injustice.** Not a boot. A **social tax of piety**. Warmth is real and so is the bill: fall out of congregation and the net goes with it, and there is no crown to appeal to. The Kept here are pitied in *plenty*. Threnmaieth at least files them. Maiethrael loves them and cannot stop measuring what they missed.

**Seat. Seinbrun** (*SAYN-brun*) is the capital, a large city in the warm core. People say the Gift-Realm. It is not Maiethlir and not the Down-Bank. A traveler can spend the first day below Maiethlir's Down Gate among Gift-folk and still not have arrived. The city furnishes a hall, a green beside it, and medicine. There is no roll. A neighbour says a given name. Vuthbraen keeps the hall. Raermu keeps the basket. Breillai left the hymn, and the green went with it. The First Seat stays in the wood. Smaller towns around Seinbrun stay unnamed.

## Orenbren: the Witness-Hearths

(*or-EN-bren · oren* “to witness” + *bren* “hearth” = “the witnessing-hearth.”) Theology high · reach high · governance mid-low. Everyday *Orenbren*; people **Orenbren-folk**. **It does not own Thaeloren. It does not own the First Seat.** The inns grew a country. They did not become one house.

The civic cluster of the **Near Mile**: lodging-squares, upper rooms, and old road-houses that stayed hearths when the walk stopped being required in the core. Pilgrims still come (the extra mile, the First-Hand year: the prestige origin-walk). Orenbren houses them. That is its power: not a crown on the grove, a monopoly on *beds within a week's walk of it*.

The First Seat sits in the Motherwood beside this power and remains a college, not a throne. Threnmaieth would like the lodging-rolls. Orenbren witnesses who slept, not what colour they are.

The capital is **Rothallo** (*roh-THAL-oh*), a walled city one day's walk from the Motherwood. People still say the **Inner Close**, and the Close. The walls answer to those names. It is the same place. It stays inside Orenbren. It is not a second town and not a sixteenth flag. Closed Heirs still rank the

Conditioned by a Book of Tithes, kept inside the walls. Orenbren witnesses who slept. They share a country. They do not share a page. Beds for the labour-line are outside the gate. The Book is inside. The First Seat is in the wood, beyond the wall. Rothallo does not Speak the Hand that stands inside the city. The Low Wall, in Other Places, is a different quarry in a fold nearby: found, not founded, and not Rothallo's proof. The Third Hearth, the Mill-hold, and Nelath are in this lodging-country. They are not the capital.

**Site.** Maiethorn Sacred Core's approach-country. Leftover: **origin pilgrimage-town**. Tree at the centre of each square; the road used to go further and now ends in a festival season.

**How it formed.** Walking-era hearths that federated around the one-week door. When the Years of Hands made the origin-walk optional, the beds did not empty. They changed jobs. A lodging-network learned it could levy, charter, and speak as one without becoming clergy.

**Structure.** A compact of hearth-towns, not a single inn. Town-wardens and lodging-guilds. Recruits not by Kind. Deathless houses exist here as *patrons of beds*. Rothallo is the capital. The Third Hearth is a road-house three days out, not the capital. Neighbour Hands-town **Brenthael**. Delamem keeps the Book. Talnin is the heir whose tenth year is not finished. A neighbour in the city says a given name. A clerk says the house first. *Closed* on a roster is a rank, not a second name.

**Goals.** Keep the extra mile possible. Charge for it in coin, duty, or hymn; the mix is the local argument. Refuse to be named as the Seat's civic arm or Threnmaieth's counted inn.

**Its injustice. Hospitality as rent.** Devotion priced as board. A pilgrim who cannot pay the First-Hand year still needs the hug. The upper room has learned what a bed is worth in Eolthael.

## Saelthael: the Sown Tree

(*SAYL-thale* · *sael* "sowing" + *thael* "Tree" = "the sown Tree.") They are still the Motherland. Theology high · reach **mid-low** (wells, not woods) · governance low. Everyday *Saelthael*; people **Saelthael-folk**. Shares *sael* with Saelvaeth on purpose: sowing on two continents, Clock 2 (where the wood has reached) still unfinished at the origin. The well-town a party meets in this dry country is Ornsael. It is not the capital, and this is not Ornsael's kingdom. The city is Larbril. Fox of the Sands hearths are common here because the ground is dry. They are not a nation.

The Rain-Shadow: leeward east of the central range, dry hills and sand-country, towns at wells and at whatever graft will take. Full-reach continent, **thinner wood**. The core stopped walking. Saelthael did not. Children still go west in the neighbour's week (walking to a neighbour's Tree), or further, because a well-Tree is not a certainty.

Fox of the Sands hearths are densest here. That is terrain, not a flag. A town with *no* fox-born would be the thing worth asking about.

**Site.** Maiethorn's dry east. Leftover: **Rain-Shadow walk-hold**. West-road after the core stopped. Proves Ornthael is unfinished even at the origin-continent. The city is **Larbril** (*LAR-bril*), medium, where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. Walking west, the Shelf-gate is still ahead. Walking east, the dry is in front of you. Brormei stands at the meeting and says what the wash is this week. **Ornsael** stays the smaller well-town, farther into the dry. Its drink is a well. It is not the next roof, not a west bank, and not the coast. The Dry Stair is another rise. It is not why Larbril is here.

**How it formed.** Tree-seats that formed around wells and slow grafts (C.Y. 0-80 was slower here: dirt, not a different gospel). When origin-squares became Hands-country, sand-country kept the habit of going to a healthier canopy. The habit grew a polity: the people who still sow.

**Structure.** Light custom, town-wardens, wells as civic fact. Recruits not by Kind. The Taken-In honoured as they are on any thirsty land: backbone, not a nation.

**Goals.** Keep grafts alive in thin soil. Keep the west-road open. Refuse the core's story that waiting here is a spiritual failing.

**Its injustice.** The motherland treats their waiting as a **local soil-problem** (true as far as it goes) and as a slight against the origin. Plenty next door; pilgrimage as a leftover they cannot retire. Vaethorn-guilt imported to sand that never asked for it.

## The Hinge Shore

Theology **mid** · reach high · governance low. **The Hinge Shore** is both the spoken and written name; its people are **Hinge-folk**. An older dockets-form *Eolstrand* is retired: *Eoloren*, *Eolthael*, and *Eolvaeth* already carry the hinge-root across an era, a month, and a city. Not a Selkie nation.

Maiethorn's western ports on **the Old Crossing** toward Strandoren: the oldest trade route in the world. Ancient, rich, less frantic than the Ledger Coast. They decide whether a hull is pilgrim, pot, person, or cargo before anyone across the water prices it. Lestrand **prices** the crossing. The Hinge Shore **sorts** it. Faith worn *thinner* here than in Maiethvael because a dock teaches categories. Trees still healthy because this is still the Motherland.

Selkie families are common on these quays, as they are on any old water. That is a hearth, not a sea-empire. The **Hush-rate** is charged as old custom. They will not call it a victory.

**Site.** Old Crossing face. Leftover: salt-adjacent Old-World quays (the Salt Walk's *other* shore: people embarked *from* Strandoren; they landed here). The port is **Votaer** (*VOH-tayr*), one of the largest cities on this coast, because the crossing is why the people are there. It faces Orentel. It is not a second Orentel. Tumair writes the hull: pilgrim, pot, person, or cargo. Lertho charges the Hush-rate on the same water. The White Note is not on this quay. Towns and villages along the rest of the shore stay unnamed.



**How it formed.** Port-kings and charter-harbours grown from the crossing. Conservative tongue because the grove is at their backs; mid theology because Lestrand is in front of them. A hinge has two sides. The Grey Summer taught the pious shore how to step around a fade *without putting the blessing down*.

**Structure.** Guild-coast, light state, old houses. Recruits not by Kind. Far-Voiced on every quay as infrastructure, same as Strandoren, with more hymn left in the voice.

**Goals.** Keep the Old Crossing the world's highway. Classify the hull before anyone prices it. Broker pilgrimage-traffic and cargo without becoming either Threnmaieth's counted port or Lestrand's priced one. Charge the Hush-rate. Say the blessing if a mouth wants one.

**Its injustice. Category as fate.** Lestrand will let you fade and feel it owed you nothing. The Hinge Shore will *bless you as it files you*, and a Tithe-poor household fails in sight of the pilgrimage-road with a hymn still in the air.

## Lirorn: the Thaw-Land

(*leer-ORN · lir* “thaw; water that runs again” + *orn* “land” = “thaw-land.”) Theology mid · reach high · governance **mid**. Everyday *Lirorn*; people **Lirorn-folk**. The range divides Maiethorn's waters; the name is the snowmelt, not the Tree. Not a Tengu empire. Not a Fox-of-the-Snows kingdom.

Maiethorn's central range: high snow, rope-and-wing towns, rivers that begin as thaw. Reach is still full. Grafts take in the valleys and the sheltered shelves. The weather is bigger, and the state is a **watershed holding**, not a cathedral square. Lowlands drink Lirorn's spring. Ridges notice.

Tengu ridge-towns and Fox-of-the-Snows hearths sit densest here. Mixed Kinds on every shelf. A lowlander arriving on foot is a guest who climbed.

**Site.** The range that divides the continent's watersheds. Leftover: ridge-roads that used to be walking-paths to the grove; stones in high squares; some roads that now end at a local Tree. The seat is **Tasain** (*tah-SAYN*), a walled town in a sheltered valley below the Shelf-gate, where the west road comes down and the levy is taken. The Shelf-gate and the town gate are not the same gate. The Noon Pass stays a pass, higher and older. Narol of the Pass is dead. The house still levies. Villages and hamlets stay on the shelves. Larbril is the city on the dry side of that pass. Tasain is where you are when the road has come down into shelter.

**How it formed.** March-holds on the snowmelt. Mid governance because water is a fact you can levy without a census of souls: you tax the thaw, the pass, the high road. Theology cooled by height and distance from the grove's daily pressure, not by doubt.

**Structure.** Ridge-compacts, pass-tolls, valley charters under a holding. Recruits not by Kind. Sky-couriers as ordinary office, not a racial guild.



**Goals.** Keep the passes and the spring. Be paid for water the core calls a gift. Stay un-named to the Threnhael as a people. They will name the passes if they can.

**Its injustice. The ridge pays in isolation for water the valley drinks.** Tolls that feel like geography. A shelf-town whose graft sickens is a long way from a stiller. Mid-state enough to levy; not enough to furnish every Tithe on a cliff.

## **Brenledd: the Hearth-League**

(*bren-LED* · *bren* “hearth” + *ledd* “to reckon” = “hearths of the ledger.”) Theology low · reach high · governance low. Everyday *the Brenledd* or *the compact*; people **Brenled-folk**. A league of hearths. The throne-city does not make it one house.

A **league of charter-towns** on Strandoren (river-ports, lesser harbours, inland markets) that compact to face Lestrاند’s houses without becoming one house. Each town is a hearth with its own Tree and its own vouching. The compact is the arithmetic: shared tickets, shared notes, shared refusal to be priced one at a time. The throne-city is **Raitin** (*RAY-tin*), a river-city, one of the largest on the Shore-lands, where the council sits and the shared notes clear. It is not a second Orentel, and it is not the Chart-run. Six charter-towns sit around it. Their names are not written. Nidtol is the hearth-name people still recite when Lestrاند offers one throat. Nidtol is not this city. Turvo keeps the notes. Sulnu carries a cleared ticket to the river stair. Nubo is vouched in Raitin and still unknown in the next hearth. The league does not become one house by having a throne-city.

Faith worn light, same as the coast. Trees mature. Nothing is policed; everything is *chartered*.

**Site.** The constellation behind and between the premier coast. Leftover: salt and river towns; some road-end Tree-towns that federated instead of fading into a deathless house’s hinterland.

**How it formed.** Towns that got tired of being the other party on a Lestrاند note. Not a founding king. The compact is a pile of charters that learned to speak together, messy and still holding.

**Structure.** A council of hearths. You are of *your* town first. Recruits not by Kind. A person vouched in one Brenled square may still be a stranger in the next. The compact moves coin better than it moves standing.

**Goals.** Keep many tickets cheaper than one house. Underwrite each other. Stay a league when Lestrاند would rather negotiate with a single throat.

**Its injustice. Falling between charters.** Vouched here, unknown there; Tithe-provision a town matter the compact will not touch. Thin welfare in a rich network. The fade happens in the gaps the league calls local.

## Leddvael: the Reckoned Gift

(*led-VAYL* · *ledd* “to reckon” + *vael* “gift” = “the gift reckoned.”) Motherfaith theology **low**; the Fair Hand worn as **civic law**. Reach high · governance **mid**. Everyday *Leddvael*; people **Leddvael-folk**. The name is the doctrine: a gift is a bargain priced. The Book-Hands stamp and recite; they have **no seat** and **do not rewrite Bound Terms**.

A signing-coast on Strandoren that took the Fair Hand from a dockside theology to a **civic rite**. Leaf-Fall is a festival *and* a signing-watch. Tithe is a term serviced. The Bound are model citizens here: not feared, *employed* as the shape of honesty. Mid governance: the book is a kind of statute without quite becoming a census of souls. They will not copy Threnmaieth’s list. They will file a contract.

**Site.** A different stretch of indented coast than Lestrand, enough water to have its own houses. Leftover: **salt quay with a signing-watch**. The port is **Naenor** (*NAY-nor*), large, and slightly smaller than Orentel. It does not face the Hinge Shore. Derdil stands the signing-watch. The Book-Hands stamp and recite in this wind. They have no seat of their own here, and they do not rewrite Terms. The city wins the term and loses the berth. Empty prestige berths stay Orentel’s. Naenor has working berths. The work is the watch.

**How it formed.** Fortune-and-contract practice thickening until a charter-coast found it cheaper to *establish* the Settling (Fair Hand contract-practice) than to argue hymns per dock. Not a prophet-kingdom. A habit that got a seal.

**Structure.** Charter-council plus book-tables. Recruits not by Kind. Gift-reading families live here. They are the minority that sounds devout and looks like a credit risk.

**Goals.** Keep signings clear. Vouch the Struck briskly as a later contract. Treat Motherfaith gift-talk as unpriced language: allowed, not preferred.

**Its injustice. Bargain-theology as statute.** A Given child is a term opened. A household that insists the colour was a gift is a bad debtor in a signing-town. The Bound are safe and *over-read*: the world’s contract-pillar asked to be the world’s whole person. No villain-faith. A sincere ledger laid over real Conditions.

## Trenledd: the Worn Count

(*tren-LED* · *thren* “sacred counting” + *ledd* “to reckon,” with the holy sound sanded off.) The reconstruction *Threnledd* is unused on purpose: they will not say the holy word. Theology **low** · reach **high** · governance **high**. Everyday *Trenledd* or *the Trenled*; people **Trenled-folk**. They call the list **the roll**, Lestrand’s word for a *tax* roll, here meaning persons. Dropping the hymn from the count *is* the thesis.

Wealthy Strandoren interior: mature Trees, dense Given, guilds thick, and a state that **writes people down**. The list began as ticket-and-tax machinery (safety-licences, house-notes, charter-rolls) and forgot to stop at property. There is no hymn that makes it stewardship. There is no Mother to be accounted to. You are on the roll because commerce and hazard-control wanted a name they could find again.

Threnmaieth at least claims to keep you hale. Trenledd claims to keep you *findable*. Cutting you off is default, not impiety.

**Site.** Tree-rich interior (not the deep thin interior; reach is high). Leftover: road-end Tree-towns that got *filed*; stones in squares with numbers on the back. The city is **Lunbra** (*LUN-bra*), large and wealthy, on the Chart-run, four to eight days upriver of Orentel. The roll is kept here. The money is shown in the square. Vamar keeps a column. A neighbour says Vamar. A clerk says the house first: Melro, Vamar. The governing throat stays unnamed. Vamar is not that throat. Towns through the filed country stay unnamed.

**How it formed.** Guild-tickets plus deathless memory plus a council that distrusted living witness the way Threnmaieth does, without Threnmaieth's scripture. The three pillars work here and are treated as *insufficient*. Feeling, word, and memory answer to themselves. A ledger answers to the desk. Not a coup. Each crisis added a column.

**Structure.** A writing-crown or writing-council. Licence-guilds as state organs. Recruits not by Kind. The Struck are pursued to be catalogued because an unwitnessed change is a row that appeared without a clerk.

**Goals.** Know who is dangerous, who owes, who Turned. Furnish Tithe through channels that can be shut. Do not argue theology; argue procedure.

**Its injustice. A census with the halo worn off.** You cannot appeal to piety. You cannot shame them with "the Mother's gifts should not be listed." They agree, and list you anyway, as cargo and hazard. Colder than the Tallied Crown. This is the bureaucratic edge of the world's small scare.

## Netstrand: the Night Shore

(*NET-strand* · *neth* "night; the long dark" + *strand* "shore.") Reconstruction *Nethstrand* unused in daily speech. Theology mid-low · reach high · governance low. Everyday *Netstrand*; people

**Netstrand-folk.** Why *night* sits on this shore is **not fully explained**: west water, storm stories, watches they keep after dark.

Strandoren's west and south face: open ocean toward Heskoren and, far beyond, the storm-wall. Bold houses run the frontier trade. They sell **hulls and west-water berths** — crews, capacity, a crossing quoted like a pilgrimage. They do **not** sell the First-Hand year as a finished product. That year is

assembled on the Old Crossing: Netstrand charts the ship, the White Note writes the terms, Orentel holds the berth. Orenbren houses the sleep at the origin. Almost none have crossed to the Sundering Isle. Those who claim to are the tellers of Yumboe stories.

Faith mixed: Motherfaith worn light, Fair Hand ordinary on a signing-quay, quay-charms nobody writes down. Trees still mature along this wealthy edge.

**Site.** Open-ocean coast. Leftover: **salt quay**; empty Eolthael berths; earth-smelling holds (graft-pots going out); the neighbour's week billed as a crossing. The harbour is **Braetu** (*BRAY-too*), smaller than Orentel, because the far run is thinner than the Old Crossing. Mursur writes the far crossing and takes the fee for a lamp on a name. They keep a dark book of quoted crossings that did not come back. One berth stays unlit. No house is attached to it. The city does not add one. Kumbaan is not booked from this quay. Towns along the rest of the shore stay unnamed.

**How it formed.** West-houses grown from Salt Walk traffic and the later carrying to Heskoren (by sea, coasts first, then the far). A shore that faces the wave's supply-line, not the grove.

**Structure.** Merchant houses, berth-guilds, light charter-council. Recruits not by Kind. Selkie common, not a flag. Sky-couriers from Lirorn and Tengu families on clock-towers: jobs, not a district.

**Goals.** Quote the far crossing. Keep the Heskoren run profitable. Sell Isle-tales without having to survive them. Do not let Trenledd write the berths.

**Its injustice. The walk as inventory.** Prestige priced; necessity billed; a neighbour's week to a waiting cluster is a line on a docket.

## Ornled: the Outer Ledger

(*orn-LED* · *orn* “land” + *ledd* “to reckon”; clipped from Ornledd.) On Heskoren, dropping the sacred sound is a neglect, not just distance. Theology **low** · reach **low** · governance **low**. Everyday **Ornled**; people **Ornled-folk**. Reconstruction *Ornledd* unused. They do not tend old endings. A Vaethorn without the faith, harder and colder. Not a lawless brutality and not a pristine wilderness.

Thin-reach Heskoren country that never took the waiting-gospel. Same young grafts, same Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy weather as Vaethorn, and **no congregation to fill the gap**. Tithe-provision is barter, favor, and a slate on the wall. An unvouched Struck is a problem met with a rope, a deal, or a neighbour, not a blessing. Custom outruns law because there is almost no law and almost no hymn.

They do not hate the Mother. They do not *use* her. Vaethorn hears the missing *th* in their name as godlessness. Ornled hears Vaethorn's *th* as a luxury.

**Site.** Frontier pockets off the hottest pilgrim-roads. Leftover: **waiting cluster without a gospel**. Same stones, same upper rooms if a walk used to pass. The leftover job is necessity, not devotion. The town is **Sanbreo** (*san-BREE-oh*), on the brink of a small city, where the slate is kept and a hull can pay a

beach-fee. The first line on the wall is still the sentence Vathne cut. Vathne is that line, not a mouth in the room. No new person sits the gate. Villages in the pockets around it stay unnamed. Eolvaeth is a different vale, in the waiting-gospel. It is not this gate.

**How it formed.** Kept/Struck-heavy districts that watched the waiting-theology arrive with the grafts and declined to make scarcity a soul-problem. Improvisation as culture. Low governance because no one has the spare people to be a state. The Fair Hand is a rumour from ships, not a civic rite. They have few Bound to make a book of.

**Structure.** Town custom, slates, vouching stretched thin. Recruits not by Kind. The Intake's problem is acute here and unofficial: catching a raw Struck, a shed if you're lucky, silence if it works.

**Goals.** Stay whole with what is in the pot. Do not owe a hymn for green. Trade with Netstrand when a ship comes; do not become its billed neighbour.

**Its injustice. No net.** Vaethorn's cruelty is guilt; Ornled's is absence. A person who cannot barter their Tithe slides with no prayer and no guild. The loneliest unvouched in the world are not in the waiting-lands. They are next door, where no one is waiting with them.

## Vaelhesk: the Far Yield

(VAYL-hesk · *vael* in the older sense, “what the land yields” + *hesk*- “far/outer edge” = “the far yield.”) *Vael* kept because the Old Ways claim the Motherfaith *narrowed* it to “gift.” Theology **mid** as Motherfaith gift-devotion, high as Old Ways practice. Reach low · governance low. Everyday *Vaelhesk*; people **Vaelhesk-folk** or **the Yield**. The fight with Vaethorn is in the first syllable: *vael* vs *vaeth*. The land is the seat. Not a Taken-In nation.

Pre-graft host-lands on Heskoren: old greens, ancestor-doors, first meals. The Mother's wood is a **guest**. A Cutting-leave (Seat leave to cut living wood) without the meal is a claiming. The Door-Keepers walk here as Kin-speakers. The land is the seat, not a college.

Struck and the Taken-In are read as the land's own children. A neighbour's week to a Motherfaith Tree can be refused on purpose: the child is already the hill's. Vaethorn reads those children as Kept-for-want. Both families are telling the truth they have.

**Site.** Heskoren's old greens, not only the live front. Leftover: **guest-grove**, seated as the First Bowl. The Door-Keepers walk here. This is host-rights, not a second Harrow. The land is the seat. There is no new city and no new name, and no settlement dot for one. Villages and hamlets stay on the old greens. A traveler who asks for the seat is pointed at a door. The First Bowl stays the guest-grove it already is. It is not a capital.

**How it formed.** Animist/ancestor polities that predate the wave. When grafts arrived (C.Y. 200-387, still arriving), some districts became Vaethorn. These kept the door. Low state because the land does

not need a clerk to be owed a meal.

**Structure.** Hearth-clusters, door-keepers, host-right custom. Recruits not by Kind. Taken-In densest as frontier labor and as *kin*, still not a flag.

**Goals.** Feed the first meal. Name a Struck at the door that made them. Treat a warden with a pot as a guest or as a thief, depending on whether they sat down.

**Its injustice. Host-rights as a claim that can shun.** Refuse the meal, take the wood, and you are not a neighbour. A Road-hand on a clock can become a trespasser for following a Seat sentence. The injustice is local and real. It is not holy war.

## Saelvaeth: the Sown Waiting

(*sayl-VAYTH* · *sael* “sowing” + *vaeth* “the waiting” = “sowing into the waiting.”) They still reach for the holy words because the wave is *here*. Theology mid-high · reach low · governance mid-low. Everyday *Saelvaeth*; people **Saelvaeth-folk**. Shares *sael* with Saelthael on purpose: planting on two continents. Towns a party can enter in this march’s orbit are Harrow’s Green and the Three Hamlets Past the Ford. None of them is the capital. Eolvaeth is Vaethorn’s seat, on a different road. Harrow’s Green sits in this march’s orbit. It is not the seat.

The live front of Clock 2 on Heskoren: C.Y. 200-387, still incomplete. Towns form where a graft has taken; between them, waiting clusters who can see a neighbour’s canopy. The march-town is **Natai** (*NAH-tye*). Dumu stands the voice at the town gate, on the road between grafts, and can be blamed for a queue the town did not write. On the Known Map, Natai sits west of Harrow’s Green, between Sanbreo and the square. It is not on the ford and not on Harrow’s square. Harrow’s Green is the luckiest kind of square in this march, a Hand that grew up. It stays in the orbit. It is **not this power’s seat and not a capital**. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford can see that green and were written as remainder (folk names *Brenod* · *Vaelun* · *Ornath*; the Seat still does not use them). The queue is visible. It is not a metaphor. Pair with Ornsael on Saelthael: same sowing, origin-continent leftover. The city of that sowing is Larbril. The well is Ornsael.

Governance is mid-low because *someone* must stand for the Harrow-sentence (*we Turned at Harrow’s Tree before we had our own*): wardens, Road-hands passing through, a march-voice that did not exist when the first pots came. Not a tall state. Enough state to be blamed.

**Site.** Heskoren’s grafted pockets on the moving edge. Leftover: **live-front Tree-town**. Necessity’s neighbour’s week.

**How it formed.** The wave, this decade. Paying-enough, soil-enough, chain-enough nexts on a list written in the Motherwood. A polity made of luck-plus-queue. Vaethorn will preach unworthiness. History does not agree.

**Structure.** Town-wardens, borrowed Turnings, Road-hands who sleep here on the way to a town that was not chosen. Recruits not by Kind. The Old Ways are neighbours (Vaelhesk), not a museum. Vaethorn heat sits on many hearths as gospel, not always as flag.

**Goals.** Keep taken grafts alive. Host the neighbour's week. Argue the next pot. Survive being the sentence the Seat already wrote.

**Its injustice. The queue as a border.** Harrow's luck is politics. The hamlets can see the canopy and send children anyway. Folk-right (unofficial cutting) temptation in a kitchen drawer. Spreading Trees did not make the march kind.

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# Gazetteer

## Gazetteer types

Every Turning-place already inherits **the Tree at the centre** (or the neighbour's Tree, or the wait for one); Tithe-provision as civic utility where the polity can afford it; dangerous trades on the edges; homes that accommodate becomings; the reach-edge writing the map.

Layered on top from the Years of Hands: a road that used to go further; a stone that used to be a day's walk; an upper room that used to be a pilgrim-dorm; a house that used to be an inn. Adaptive reuse is how Ornthael looks present.

Kumbaan is not in this catalog. The Isle's places wait on a later pass with the Open Table, not with mile-shrines.

A **leftover job** is the walk's remaining civic function after local Trees made pilgrimage optional: devotion (the extra mile you do not need), prestige (the origin-winter you can buy), or necessity (the neighbour's week, because your Tree is missing, young, or sick). One leftover job per street. Devotion, prestige, and necessity can share an inn; they should not all be the town's *theme*. A **Held bed** is a bed kept empty for a named person who has not come.



| Type                          | What it is                                                | Layered leftover                                                          | Where it lives                       | Named square or seat                                                                                                                                 |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Origin pilgrimage-town</b> | devotion's extra mile; the Motherwood's lodging           | Near Mile as civic season <i>and</i> holiday; Seat proximity              | Maiethorn Sacred Core                | Maiethlir (roll <i>layers</i> the leftover; does <b>not</b> own the grove) · neighbour square: Brenthael                                             |
| <b>Road-end Tree-town</b>     | the walk stopped here; the square <i>is</i> the last mile | stone in the square; road ends at the boughs; upper room                  | any Hands land; densest on Maiethorn | <b>Nelath</b> (the spur stops; not Harrow's, not Brenthael, not the Mill-hold). Layered onto Harrow's and Brenthael already; those are not this lead |
| <b>Deathless inn-bank</b>     | road-past as credit                                       | beds + notes; Held bed as house custom                                    | Near Mile inland; Salt-Walk quay     | the Third Hearth (stayed a hearth) · the White Note House on Orentel (desk, not the crown)                                                           |
| <b>Salt quay</b>              | prestige-walk + pots                                      | empty Eolthael berths; holds that smell of earth; Fair Hand signing-watch | Strandoren coasts                    | Orentel (White Note on the third quay, <b>not</b> the crown)                                                                                         |
| <b>Live-front Tree-town</b>   | luckiest Heskoren; neighbour's canopy                     | Harrow-sentence as <i>this decade</i> ; borrowed Turnings inbound         | Heskoren                             | Harrow's Green                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Waiting cluster</b>        | queue made visible; Clock 2 this year                     | can see a neighbour's canopy; folk-right temptation; Kept/Struck-heavy    | Heskoren; also Rain-Shadow pockets   | the Three Hamlets Past the Ford (folk names <i>Brenod</i> · <i>Vaelun</i> · <i>Ornath</i> )                                                          |
| <b>Sick-Tree square</b>       | Hands that un-Hands                                       | necessity-walk <i>returns</i> ; civic crisis wearing a child's summer     | any continent the wood has reached   | <b>the Mill-hold</b> (Orenbren lodging-country). Ornsael's well can drop without a sick fall                                                         |

| Type                         | What it is                         | Layered leftover                                  | Where it lives      | Named square or seat                                                                                          |
|------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Guest-grove</b>           | Old Ways planting                  | first meal vs Cutting-leave; host-rights          | Heskoren old greens | <b>the First Bowl</b> (folk <i>Lonasir</i> ). Vaelhesk's land is the seat. Not a second Harrow                |
| <b>Rain-Shadow walk-hold</b> | leftover waiting on the Motherland | west-road after the core stopped                  | Maiethorn dry hills | Ornsael, the well-town farther into the dry. Saelthael's city is Larbril, at the Well-wash, short of the pass |
| <b>Pilgrim-edge</b>          | wait as destination                | congregation made a country; Tree not a certainty | Heskoren            | Eolvaeth                                                                                                      |

Three kinds of place the road already needed now have names. The sick-Tree town is the Mill-hold. The guest-grove is the First Bowl. The road-end is Nelath. They are written in Other Places. One kind of place is still only a kind: **two claimants on one green**, a tree-warden and an Old Ways door-keeper, both sure the wood is theirs to speak for. Vaelun, one of the three hamlets past the ford, leans that way. It is not yet a named square of that kind. The First Bowl is the guest-grove. It is not that unused kind. Vaelun is a kitchen past the ford.

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## Playable squares

These are towns a party can walk into. Each entry says where the place sits, what work it does, and who you can meet. A line in quotation marks is something a person there might say. Where an entry mentions the graft-wave, it means the slow spread of living wood outward from the Motherwood. That spread is still moving. The Ages explains it at length. You do not need the label to play the town.

A few entries still use the shorthand **Clock 2** for that same unfinished spread: this year's children still walk to a Tree that can speak, or a road is still in use because the walk is not over. It is the present. It is not a costume of an earlier age.

## Harrow's Green

A live-front Tree-town. The luckiest kind of Heskoren square: a scion that arrived in the C.Y. 200s, spoke a generation later, and has now Turned local children for a few generations. The neighbour's canopy. The Harrow-sentence (*we Turned at Harrow's Tree before we had our own*) is how new towns talk everywhere; here it is the decade. Everyday *Harrow's green* was already a Seat sentence: a Cutting-leave, the paper that says where the wood may take. Warden: **Haelin** (*HAY-lin*). A small town, a few hundred hearths around one canopy. **Not a capital of Saelvaeth, and not the march's seat.** The march-town is Natai, west of this square, between Sanbreo and the green. Natai is not this square and not the ford.

A grafted pocket on the Sundered Reach. Settlement clustered where the wood took. Harrow's is old enough, for the front, to be a town: a canopy at the centre, a square that used to be a road, borrowed Turnings inbound from the Three Hamlets Past the Ford every Eolthael.

The wave has not finished here. Harrow's is a Hand that grew up. The three hamlets can see the green from the ford. The Seat has already written that the wood will take *here* and not, this year, *there*. Harrow's lives inside that sentence whether it asked to or not.

Vaethorn heat sits on many hearths as gospel, not always as flag. This square lives in Saelvaeth's orbit (the live-front march), not as its capital. The Old Ways are neighbours, not a museum. A first meal at a later planting is a live argument, not a courtesy-card.

What this town still does, from the years when children had to walk, is necessity. Neighbouring hamlets still send their ten-year-olds here for the week. A ribbon on the stone is devotion, left by someone else. Rich households do not book a winter here.

**Site.** A low rise above a stream that becomes the ford downstream. The graft took on the rise; the old pilgrim-road climbed it because that was the day's water. Towns on Heskoren do not pick a pretty hill and then invent a Tree. The wood picked, and the hearths followed.

Water is the stream, a cistern by the warden-hearth, and the **stone in the square**, still the day's drink for anyone using the road as a mile. Food is the pocket's gardens, ranging beyond the last house, and whatever the neighbour's week brings in Hale-month (mouths, dust, a complaint). Fuel is the same woods the Two-Bodied use as ranging. The Taken-In keep the greens around the Tree from going to seed indoors. There is no resident stiller. A travelling one is a summer's luck.

The square is the last holy mile. Beyond the boughs the old way is a cart-track to the ford. Children are told the road goes to the Motherwood. It goes to the mill, and then to three hamlets that can see the canopy. Both are true if you keep walking.

**The square.** Nucleated around the canopy. Organic, not a grid. The oldest lintels face the Tree; later houses filled the wedge between the road and the stream. No walls. The boundary is the ranging and

the last garden.

- **The Tree at the centre.** Mature enough to Turn; young enough that grandparents remember the borrowed years. Leaf-Fall is held in the square because there is nowhere else a crowd fits. The town's age can be read in the wood: a Hand, not a First.
- **The stone.** Last mile-shrine of the road that used to go further. Climbing-scuff. Water the Road-hands still use. Ribbons some years. **Haelin**, town-warden, wants it moved before the next Leaf-Fall because it is in the way of the crowd. Thilim, if asked, would say it is a name. A hamlet child will climb it and ask how far it is to the Tree.
- **The upper room.** Still too many beds for the present trade. Opens for the neighbour's week; not yet a merchant-loft. A Road-hand sleeps here on the way to a town that was not chosen, sometimes with a pot. Hale-month is dust and extra mouths. Ledger-month is local.
- **The greens.** Potted groves and a garden-common around the Tree, enough, not a lot with a ticket. They will not follow you home. The Taken-In here are neighbours, not a quarter.
- **The ranging.** At the town edge, not a beast-yard. Two-Bodied work the woods that feed the hearth. No Kind-flag on the trees.
- **The far shed.** Returned plague-and-body work, downwind, the same logic as a tannery, not an infirmary or a district.

Homes accommodate becomings: a window that opens, a room kept green, a threshold a Long-Lived waits to be asked across. Mixed Kinds. A Fox of the Wilds at the ranging is unremarkable. A Tengu on a ridge-visit is a guest.

Tithe-provision is frontier-warm and thin: the greens, the ranging, the upper room as a seasonal outlet for whoever is loud that week. No counted hall. No stiller on a licence-wall. You can be too poor to stay whole here, and the neighbour's week will not fix that.

**Clock 1:** the square *is* the last mile; the road ends at the boughs; Hands-children Turn at home.

**Clock 2:** the hamlets can see the canopy; they send this year's ten-year-olds; a Road-hand is going the other way with wood. The Harrow-sentence is this decade, not nostalgia.

A warden who pulls the stone down is doing theology with a hammer. Leaf-Fall needs the space. The graves do not go with the requirement, and the next necessity-column will miss the water. Haelin knows this and still wants it moved.

**Offices.** Town-warden (Haelin): practice-first, not Kind. Speaks the fall truly enough for a front-town. Believer-heavy the way a live Tree makes you; still has to lodge the neighbour's week. The scion-queue is not theirs to fix, and it is the sentence they live in.

The square watches children Turn. Harrow's witness is what a hamlet child carries home. Vouching-at-a-distance was invented for an origin-fall; here it is a walk back to the ford.

Road-hands passing through sleep in the town that was chosen, on the way to the one that was not.

A Door-Keeper at a later planting holds host-rights if a cut from Harrow's is set in an old green. The first meal, or a claiming.

Saelvaeth's march-voice can be blamed when the queue is ugly. It does not sit a throne here.

*A notice chalked on the cistern-wall, Hale-month, C.Y. 387. Haelin's hand. The stone is not named.*

*The crowd will need the square. The stone will be walked around until Eolthael, and then we will see. Water stays. Names stay if they were names. Climbing is for after.*

*Beds above: the neighbour's week first. A pot is not a pilgrim. A pilgrim is not a pot. I can tell. I will not always say.*

*If you came from the ford, you are seen here. If you must be seen at home, take a mouth with you that was here. I will not walk it for you. I have a Tree.*

The hamlets will hear the notice as a slight even if it is only a crowd.

## The Three Hamlets Past the Ford

A waiting cluster. The Seat's Cutting-leave already filed them as a remainder: *the wood will take at Harrow's green. It will not take this year at the three hamlets past the ford: the soil is thin there.* They can see Harrow's Green from the water. They send this year's ten-year-olds to the neighbour's week, or further if Harrow's year is too full, or still the Long Mile if the neighbour is a stick in a pot. Folk hearth-names; **the Seat still does not use them.** That blindness is load-bearing. Three hearths, a few dozen houses each, not a town and not one village.

Three hearths past a ford on Heskoren, close enough to share a complaint and far enough that a scion for "the hamlets" would still be a fight about *which* green. Thin reach as weather: Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy *this year, for this cohort.* Not a re-enactment of the Walking Years. Clock 2, present tense.

They have learned not to say *queue*. They can recite the horticulture-sentence. Folk-right cutting is a kitchen-knife in a drawer, not a rebellion with a flag. Most slips die. The ones that take are how the First Seat learns it does not own the Tree's tissue, only the authorization.

Old Ways hearths among them may **refuse the neighbour's week** on purpose. Their children are already the land's. Motherfaith neighbours read those children as Kept-for-want. History does not agree with Vaethorn guilt.

Geographically they sit on a seam: Saelvaeth luck they can see, Vaelhesk refusal in the kitchen, Vaethorn gospel on the tongue, Ornled slate if they walk the other way.

What these hamlets still do is make the week. They send the children. A visitor who calls that devotion has misread them. Prestige does not stop at the ford.

**Site.** The ford is the Seat's geography, the thing you can see Harrow's green from, water a mile-shrine would have marked if anyone had set a stone on the waiting side. No stone. That absence is a leftover. Necessity still drinks there. Children still ask how far it is.

The stream comes down from Harrow's rise. In clear weather the canopy is a dark against the far slope. In rain it is a rumour you have to take on trust. The three greens sit on slightly different ground: a wetter shelf, an old taken plot, a thinner rise past the last hedge. A scion planted "for the hamlets" would still be a fight about which of those is soil.

Food is gardens, a shared mill-path, ranging that is just the woods. No venting-hall. No lot. Tithe-provision is the yard and the neighbour. A lapsing Condition here is a family problem before it is a guild's.

Dispersed, not nucleated. You walk from hearth to hearth. You do not walk *through* a town. The cluster is a complaint with three kitchens.

### *Brenod (BREN-od)*

The sending hearth. Motherfaith as practice: they walk the child to Harrow's, they want a mouth that *was there* to walk back and stand for the fall, they can recite the thin-soil sentence without using the word *queue*. The kitchen-knife is in this drawer more often than the others, which does not mean they have used it. It means they have looked at it.

Brenod's leftover is the neighbour's week as *duty*. A visitor from the core will hear faith. Brenod hears a date in Eolthael.

### *Vaelun (VAY-lun)*

The yield-hearth. Older *vael*, what the land keeps, not *vaeth*, the waiting. The Old Ways sit this kitchen. They may refuse the neighbour's week on purpose. Their children are already the land's. A first meal is not a courtesy-card; a later cut from Harrow's, acting on the origin's behalf, still wants the bowl if this ground is an old green.

Vaelun's leftover is host-rights, not a second Harrow. The Door-Keepers play here. Motherfaith neighbours in Brenod will call Vaelun's Kept children passed-over. Vaelun will not correct them in the Mother's language.

### *Ornath (OR-nath)*

The furthest past the ford. Thinnest soil as a feeling, not a decided horticulture. Ornath can see Harrow's when the weather is kind and can walk the *other* way, toward Ornléd's slate, if the congregation-net fails. They have not gone. The road is still a temptation that looks like sense: no gospel, a ledger, the same thin Trees.

Ornath's leftover is the wait with an exit that is not a Tree. Some mouths there still wait. Some have stopped saying her name and have not started keeping a list either.

Which green has the sick stick is not decided. A pot in a yard, a young failure, or nothing yet: any of the three can hold it for a night. The fight about *which* green would receive a scion is the cluster's civic life. Naming the hearths did not end that fight. It gave it doors.

**Clock 1:** Harrow's has a Tree. The square down the slope is Hands.

**Clock 2:** this year's ten-year-olds still walk. Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy as weather, not as a closed age. A split household, shorter: one child to Harrow's, one Kept at the ford, a sibling who will not walk the same side of the road.

There is no stone on the waiting side. There is a **cup**. The night before the neighbour's week someone leaves it on the ford-rock. If it fills, they send. If it does not, the tellings do not agree, and the child still goes, or does not, according to the kitchen, not the cup. The cup is not explained. Brenod calls it weather. Vaelun calls it the land answering. Ornath has started leaving it empty on purpose, or has not.

**What must exist:** families who walk one child and not another (the split household, shorter); a person who will vouch a neighbour-fall all the way home, Harrow's witness walking back to the ford (if they will not, the child is seen at Harrow's and unvouched at breakfast); a Kin-speaker who will stand for a Struck the square will not; someone who owns a knife they will not call nameless; a Door-Keeper's cousin in Vaelun who will ask about the bowl before they ask about a leave.

The Seat's leave still says *the three hamlets past the ford*. Clerks who learn Brenod, Vaelun, Ornath have learned more than the minute wanted them to.

*Said at the ford, not written. A Brenod mouth, a Vaelun mouth, an Ornath mouth. Same water.*

*We can see it. That is not the same as having it.*

*The land had them before the cart came. I will not walk a child to a neighbour to be named a Waited.*

*If the cup stays dry I still have to decide. The slate the other way does not ask about soil.*

None of the three will take the other two as the whole truth. The leave already named them without naming them.

## The Third Hearth (and Brenthael)

A road-house that stayed a hearth. The third lodging out from the Motherwood on the Near Mile, kept by **Thilim** (*THIL-im*), Long-Lived, inland, keeping this house since before the First Cut, as later clerks would say. Seine's bed is still made. The notes are smaller than the White Note's. The shrine is larger. Everyday *the third hearth*; cant *brenhael* like any road-house. Neighbour-town **Brenthael** (*bren-THALE*): *bren* + *thael*, "the hearth-Tree." On Maiethorn, in Orenbren's lodging-country. Not Orenbren's capital. Does not capture the First Seat.

An old Near-Mile house, three days' walk out from Thaeloren toward the approach-country. Beds, porridge, a dry room, a green-lot, a shed. In Brenvaeth it sold the walk you could not miss twice. In Ornthael it still opens for Eolthael.

It sits in Orenbren's lodging-country, civic beds within a week's walk of the grove, and is a seed of that type, not the compact's throne. The inns grew a country. This is one mouth.

What this road-house still does is devotion: it keeps the extra mile as the town's season. The loft still sleeps people who had to come, and, rarely, people who paid to come. Thilim can tell which is which, and will not always say. The White Note, a desk on Orentel's quay, sells a first-year pilgrimage as a product. This house makes the bed.

Lestrand calls this a bed-house that failed to become a bank. Thilim asks which mouths will be here at dark.

**Site.** The Near Mile is a week's door to the origin. Counted from the grove outward: first hearth a day out, second, **third**. Pilgrims walking *in* hit the neighbour-town first.

**Brenthael** stands a day's walk further from the grove than the inn, a Hands-town that grew around a graft planted beside the road. The pilgrim-way now **ends at Brenthael's Tree**. Beyond the boughs: mill, timber, the rest of Maiethorn. Children there are told the road goes to the Motherwood. It does, if they keep walking past the inn, two more hearths, and the wood. Most Hands-children do not.

The Third Hearth kept the older job: beds for people still going in. Water is a well in the yard and the **stone** at the lintel-road, a day's-walk shrine that never got pulled into Brenthael's square because the inn refused to let the town have it. Thilim uses it for water and will not join the argument about pulling it down. Brenthael's warden wants it moved. The stone is in the way of a crowd that is not this house's crowd.

Food is the pot, the green-lot, whatever the extra mile pays in Hale-month. The shed is still a shed.

### Features.

- **The upper room.** Still too many beds; not converted. Opens in Hale-month. Quiet in Ledger-month. A devotion-column, a necessity-family, and a Road-hand going the other way with a pot



can sleep in it in the same week. That passing is the two clocks in one afternoon. A prestige household that did not book the White Note's winter is rare and conspicuous.

- **Seine's bed.** Held. Seine of the far cape, tenth summer, not come. The mother said next year. Next year was last year, and has been, for a length of time Thilim will not convert into Cut-years. Not a shrine Thilim will admit. A shrine everyone else can see.
- **The slate.** Still kept. Verso still does not match recto. Full text in the Walking Years, above.
- **The stone.** At the lintel-road, not in Brenthael's square. Climbing-scuff anyway. Road-hands still aim for the water. Brenthael wants it down so the extra mile does not look like a requirement on their approach. Thilim will not move a name.
- **Green-lot and shed.** Still a pot and a shed. A cutting in the pot that is still not a Tree (Thilim missed a green, once; it is not the First Cut).
- **Brenthael's square** (*neighbour, not a second type*). Tree at the centre; road ends at the boughs; Leaf-Fall as civic season; lodging-guild pressure from Orenbren without a throne. Mixed Kinds. No Kind-quarters. The town's leftover is the extra mile as holiday. They can see the inn's stone from the last house and resent it as a grave that is also an advertisement.

**Clock 1:** Brenthael Turns at home. The Near Mile is optional. Orenbren houses the people who still want the origin.

**Clock 2:** the stone still waters a mile; Seine's name is still on a lintel; a necessity-family from thinner soil still pays on the home-walk. Hands can un-Hands. If Brenthael's Tree sickened, this house would be the neighbour's week. It has not. Thilim does not narrate the age as over.

The two fates of the same origin still stand. The White Note collected, on a Strandoren quay. The Third Hearth kept making the bed.

**People.** Thilim: the four Long-Lived *I walked* jobs, inland and tired. Blood-Read will give a true fragment. It will not tell you which job they are doing when they make the bed. Brenthael's town-warden, unnamed, wants the stone. Practice-first. Speaks a fall in a square that used to be a road. Orenbren lodging-custom: hospitality as rent in Eolthael; Thilim charges less and is called a failure for it. The compact does not own this mouth. The First Seat sits in the Motherwood *beside* this country and is not its crown. A pilgrim who asks Thilim where the college is will be pointed at the wood, not the inn.

*A chalked complaint from Brenthael's warden-hearth, carried to the third lintel and left under the stone's lip. C.Y. 387, after Hale-month. Thilim has not answered on paper.*

*The crowd will need the approach. Your stone is a mile that is no longer owed. Water we have. Names we can keep on a ribbon in the square, which is where a leftover belongs.*

*You house the extra mile. We Turn at home. If you make a shrine of a bed, that is a house matter. A stone in the road is a town matter.*

*We are not pulling a grave. We are pulling a requirement that has ended.*

The Held bed is made. If Seine comes, the stone will still be in the way of a crowd that is not hers.

## Ornsael

A Rain-Shadow walk-hold. (*orn-SAYL* · *orn* “land, ground” + *sael* “sowing” = “the sown-ground.”) Conservative drift: *th* is not in the name, and the holy sound is still in the mouths. They are the Motherland’s dry east, still walking west after the core stopped. Everyday *Ornsael*; core travellers will try *the west-road well* and be corrected. A well-town, a few hundred hearths, thinner than the core’s. **Not Saelthael’s city**, and not a Fox kingdom. The city is Larbril, where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. Ornsael is farther into the dry. It is not the next roof after Larbril, and it is not the coast. Its drink is the well. Larbril’s drink, when it has one, is the wash.

East of Maiethorn’s central range, on the leeward side away from the Old Crossing: dry hills, sand-country, towns at wells. Ornsael is one of those wells. A Tree stands beside it, young for the Motherland, old enough to have Turned local children for a generation. **It Speaks most years.** A missed Eolthael is weather, not the town’s crisis. **The crisis is the drink.**

Saelthael is the polity of people who still sow. Ornsael is a square of that habit, not a throne. Plenty sits on the other side of the range. Pilgrimage here is a leftover they cannot retire. Core pilgrims who arrive in Eolthael expecting a holiday extra mile find a necessity-column already on the west-road, and are shocked. They thought waiting was a Heskoren feeling.

Fox of the Sands hearths are densest here. That is terrain, not a flag. A town with *no* fox-born would be the thing worth asking about. Mixed Kinds drink the same well.

What this well-town still does is necessity. The west road is still how this year’s ten-year-olds go when a neighbour’s Turning week is cheaper than a dry summer. Devotion belongs to people who already have a healthy Tree. Prestige does not book a dry hill.

**Site.** The well is why anyone stopped. The range takes the rain; this side keeps the dust. Settlement is nucleated around water the way Harrow’s is nucleated around wood: same grammar, different scarcity. The graft was married to the well on purpose. Living earth wants a drink in sand-country as much as a child does.

The **west-road** is the main street. It used to be how you reached a healthier canopy, then how you reached the origin, then how you reached the core’s Hands-towns after those towns stopped coming east. It is still how this year’s ten-year-olds go, when the well is dropping or a fall is missed. Beyond

the last house the road is a pale cut toward the range-pass. East of the well it peters into tracks and Taken-In plantings that look like stubbornness.

Water is the well, a few cisterns, dew-catch on the north walls. Food is terrace-gardens, goats, whatever the west-road pays when it still pays. Fuel is dung and what the range-trade carries over. The Taken-In are backbone here. Thirsty land honours green. They are not a nation.

No walls. The boundary is where the well's courtesy ends and the dust does not.

### **The square.**

- **The Tree at the well.** Civic and sacred heart. It Speaks most years. A missed Eolthael still shuts the Given-door. Struck remains the later mercy. There is still no second-chance year. The warden Speaks when there is a fall. They will not invent a colour. That is not this square's crisis.
- **The well.** The drink. Chalk on the lip. A share that lasts Hale-month, or does not. **Theisva** (*THAYS-vah*) keeps the marks. **Lesna** (*LEZ-nah*) keeps a planting that drinks. **Bovaer** (*bo-VAYR*) keeps the west-road names. Three mouths. The mystery is a wet knot below last year's water-line.
- **The west-road.** Clock 2 as a street. Mile-markers toward the pass; one stone still in the well-square because the town grew around a day's water, not around a finished Hand. Climbing-scuff. Ribbons pointed west, which core children find backwards.
- **The well-market.** Stalls in the morning shade. Fox-born densest in the crowd, not gated. A fox-market without the town *being* a Kind. Stock ancestries, a Tengu on a pass-errand, a Selkie who married in from the Hinge Shore and is dry and funny about it.
- **The greens.** Potted, hauled, argued over. No lush lot. A cousin of the greens-keepers' craft might winter. They will not follow you home, and home is dust if they did.
- **The ranging.** Dry hills, night-work, Two-Bodied who know the difference between a sand-fox and a Fox. At the edge, not a quarter.
- **The far shed.** Returned work downwind of the well, because you do not put the dead on the drink. No infirmary. A travelling stiller is a pass-story.

Homes bend to becomings: north-side cool rooms, green pots on lintels, shutters that open for a Far-Voiced hour because there is no hall to book. Thin infrastructure, high theology, low governance: Saelthael's combination at street height.

**Clock 1:** this is Maiethorn. The Motherland. Hands-country in the core. Conservative mouths. The extra mile is supposed to be optional.

**Clock 2:** children still go west when the well drops or a neighbour's week is cheaper; the road that used to go further still does. Same *sael* as Saelvaeth on the live front, sowing on two continents. Both are this year.

Hands can un-Hands. A well that drops puts a Motherland square back on a neighbour's week whether the Tree spoke or not. That is weather, not a fall of the age. The Seat will call thin soil. The town will call this year. Vaethorn-guilt imported to sand that never asked for it is the injustice: waiting read as unworthiness on the continent that invented plenty.

The well-rope is knotted at last year's water-line. This year's knot is wet when the water stands below it. Ornsael will not say why. Theisva moves the knot. Lesna says the planting tastes the same when it is wet. Bovaer puts sand in a west-facing shoe and does not call that a rite.

**Offices.** Town-warden: practice-first, not Kind. Tired of being asked if this is fox-country. May be Sands-Fox; may not. Either way the question is the slight. Speaks the fall when there is one. The well-share is the town-law. Theisva, Lesna, and Bovaer argue the marks.

The square that watches, and the west-road that watches instead. Some years the witness is local. Some years a column still walks. Vouching-at-a-distance on the Motherland is the tell that Ornthael is unfinished.

Road-hands: rare; the circuit prefers paying nexts. A pot for Ornsael is a fight with the queue.

Saelthael-folk custom: light, town-wardens, wells as civic fact. No list. Threnmaieth would like one. Plenty next door is Maiethvael's problem, not this well's.

*Well-share marks, chalked on the lip, Hale-month, C.Y. 387. Theisva's hand. The Tree is not mentioned.*

*Dawn-mark: below last knot. Child-jars first. Guest-jars after the planting's one bucket, and I will hear about the planting.*

*West-road at dusk if the noon-mark does not rise. Bovaer has the names. I have the rope.*

*A man from the Reckoning asked to name the well on a roll. We named the well Ornsael, which it already was. He wrote a colour-year. The sand does not keep his hand. The knot is wet. I did not wet it.*

Theisva is doing a drink. They will not file a year. Lesna will read the verso as a slight on green. Bovaer will already be on the road. Threnmaieth will file a west-road as piety or as a gap. It is a child who needs water this week.

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# The three seats

## Eolvaeth (Vaethorn's seat)

(*ay-ohl-VAYTH* · *eol* “hinge” + *vaeth* “the waiting” = “the hinge-waiting.”) Worn drift: *th* kept. Everyday pulpit *Eolvaeth*; folk-speech “**Elvaeth**” (*el-VAYTH*). The capital of Vaethorn because people walk *here to wait*, not because the canopy is a certainty. Warden: **Vaethod** (*VAYTH-od*). A pilgrim-town, a couple thousand souls in Ledger-month, more in Hale-month. Not Harrow's Green, not the Three Hamlets Past the Ford, and not Saelvaeth's march.

A vale behind Heskoren's Strandoren-facing coast. One of the earlier pots on this continent: a C.Y. 200s graft that took, spoke some years, and never grew into a neighbour's certainty. The live front moved on. The waiting stayed. Congregation made a country. Vaethorn is the gospel; **Eolvaeth is the square the gospel stands in.**

It is not a throne. Governance here is almost absent. What sits in the vale is a Tree, a spring, a gift-hall that is worship, and the camp-streets of people who came for a hinge and did not leave. Custom outruns written law. The town-warden is Hands-folk, not a crown.

Saelvaeth's luck is a different weather, further along the wave. Harrow's Green is a Hand that grew up. The three hamlets can see that canopy from a ford. Eolvaeth cannot see it, and does not want to. Wanting it would be admitting the wait is a queue. The gospel says stay. Horticulture, some years, says send.

What this town still does is devotion. People walk here in order to wait. Visitors from thinner country are usually here because they have to be. The town will not call that necessity. Prestige does not book a thin vale.

**Site.** Two tracks meet at a spring in a fold of upland. The graft was married to the water because living earth wants a drink and a child does. Settlement clustered where the wood took, and then the camps filled the fold, because a thin Tree that *might* speak is still the oldest Hand a long walk can reach without crossing into Saelvaeth's orbit.

The **spring** is the day's drink. It is not a mile-shrine stone. Ribbons belong on other squares. Children leave a wet leaf on the lip the year the Tree does not speak. Travellers from the core will try to climb something. There is nothing to climb. That absence is a leftover: the Long Mile used to pass this vale when the neighbour was a continent; the requirement ended; the wait did not.

Food is the vale's gardens, ranging on the slopes, alms from the gift-hall pot, and whatever Hale-month mouths bring. Fuel is the same woods the Two-Bodied use as wild-leave. There is no resident stiller. A travelling blessing-surgeon is a decade's luck. The Taken-In are the backbone, Mother's green held in common, honoured, not a nation.

No walls. The boundary is the last camp-street and the ranging. Low governance looks like this: you can walk in, and someone will feed you, and no clerk will write you down.

**The square.** Nucleated around the canopy. Organic. The oldest lintels face the Tree; later houses filled the wedge between the tracks; **camp-streets**, cellular accretion of pilgrim-camps that learned to winter, run up the fold until they look like a town and still smell like a season.

- **The Tree at the centre.** Civic and sacred heart, even when the wood is a maybe. Mature enough that grandparents remember a fall. Young enough, for a capital, that a Seat clerk would not call it a First. Some years it Turns. Some years the colour is late, or thin, or **Vaethod** will not call a fall that isn't. A missed Eolthael still shuts the Given-door. Struck remains the later mercy. There is still no second-chance year.
- **The spring.** The vale's reason. Wet-leaf years. Climbing-scuff on the lip anyway, from children who have heard the stone-story and will not be told this town has a different leftover.
- **The gift-hall.** Worship and venting in the same room (ael-hall as congregation). A Far-Voiced hour here is a hymn whether they meant it to be. No counted hall. No release-house ticket.
- **The camp-streets.** Adaptive reuse at town scale. A tent-line that became a lintel. Hale-month still doubles the mouths. Ledger-month is local and guilty about the empty rooms.
- **Mother's green.** Commons around the Tree, enough, not a lot with a ticket. They will not follow you home. Home is the vale if they did.
- **The wild-leave.** Ranging on the slopes, at the edge, not a beast-yard. No Kind-flag on the trees.
- **The far shed.** Returned work downwind of the spring, not an infirmary or a district.

Homes accommodate becomings. Mixed Kinds. A Fox of the Wilds at the ranging is unremarkable. A Tengu on a spine-visit is a guest. A Selkie who married in from the coast is wet about the vale and kept anyway.

Tithe-provision is alms and congregation: real warmth, real want. You can be too poor to stay whole here, and the gospel will console what it cannot furnish.

**Clock 1:** Hands-children who *did* Turn at this Tree. The Long Mile is supposed to be optional. The hinge is supposed to have arrived.

**Clock 2:** the Tree is not a certainty; camp-streets still fill for Eolthael; some years a cohort still goes toward Saelvaeth's luck, or further if that luck is full. The gospel says wait. The Seat's horticulture, on a thin year, says send. Vaethod has done both. The town remembers which summers.

Devotion is the job on the street: people walk to Eolvaeth to wait together. That is how a poor land gets a capital without a crown. Orenbren's extra mile is for people who already have a healthy canopy. The hamlets' necessity is kitchens that can see Harrow's. This is the wait made into a destination, and also how scarcity becomes unworthiness if you let the sermon land.

A wet leaf lies on the spring, or too many, or none. Eolvaeth will not say why. Core pilgrims ask if it is a ribbon. The year the Tree speaks, there is no leaf. The year it does not, there are too many to count, and no one files the count.

**Offices.** Town-warden (Vaethod): Hands-folk, practice-first, not Kind. Speaks the fall truly enough for a waiting-seat. Will not write a colour that didn't happen, even if a visiting clerk wants the hinge tidy. The year they send a cohort toward Saelvaeth is the year the gospel and the wood disagree. They have not resigned.

The square that watches, and the camp-streets that watch instead. Some years the witness is local. Some years it has to walk home from a luckier Hand. Vouching-at-a-distance on a gospel-capital is the tell that waiting is still a road.

Road-hands passing through sleep in the town that was chosen early and stayed thin, on the way to a town that was not chosen this year.

Vaethorn-folk custom: light state, hot faith, alms. No list. Threnmaieth would like one. Ornled would not understand why anyone stays.

The unvouched Struck are the ache this seat was built to meet with faith rather than machinery. A congregation deciding whether faith or fear wins is a session, not a district.

*A notice chalked on the gift-hall lintel, Eolthael, C.Y. 387. Vaethod's hand. The Tree is not named as sick.*

*The hinge is this week. Beds on the camp-streets first. A mouth that came to wait is a mouth.  
A mouth that came to count us is a clerk, and I can tell.*

*If the Tree speaks we stay. If it does not I will not invent a colour. I will not send until the  
week is over. I have sent before. I will not pretend I have not.*

*The spring is not a stone. The leaf is on the lip. Do not ask me what it is for.*

The gospel will hear the notice as a slight even if it is only a week.

## Orentel (Lestrand's seat)

(or-EN-tel · eroded oren + thael = "the witnessing-Tree," th worn to t.) Everyday Orentel; Lestrand-folk will say **the Salt Quay** and mean the city the way they say *the bed-house* and mean the bank. The capital of Lestrand because notes and berths meet here, not because a house sits a throne. The White Note House is on the third quay, north side, **placed, not crowned.** **Sorim** (SOR-im) is the factor, a house-agent who charters berths and files occupancy. A salt-city, tens of thousands; the Tree-town is the smaller half.

An inner-sea estuary on Strandoren, facing Maiethorn across the oldest water in the world. The Salt Walk used to land here. When the walk stopped being required on this coast, the berths did not empty. They changed jobs. Adaptive reuse at city scale: a Tree-town that grew a quay, then a second quay, then a leap-frog of warehouses along the tide, until the nucleated square was the smaller half of a salt-city.

Lestrand is guild self-rule carried as far as it goes. Orentel is the square that proves it: a charter-council of houses and craft-guilds, no crown, no Threnhael. Citizenship-by-witness runs smoothly because reach is high. The three pillars (Long-Lived memory, Bound word, Far-Voiced feeling) are infrastructure. An unvouched person is a transaction that cannot clear.

What this quay still sells is prestige: a first-year pilgrimage, booked as a product, with empty berths in Eolthael held for households who can pay to walk a walk they do not need. People who had to come still eat in the lofts. Mataero files them as occupied beds.

**Site.** The estuary is why anyone stopped. Deep water, a sheltered sound, a tide that writes the working day. The graft took on the **rise above the first quay** (C.Y. 40s to 80s, wealthy coast, a paying next), and the oldest lintels still face that Tree. The road used to come inland from the berth toward a healthier origin-canopy. Then this canopy grew up. Then the berth became the point.

Water is the tide, cisterns on the rise, and paid wells in the warehouse-leap. Food is the river-plain, the inner-sea catch, whatever the crossing pays. Fuel is drift, peat, and what the factor-houses book. The Taken-In rent **leaf-lots** by the season; they are not a nation. Selkie hearths are densest on the water, a lot of shoreline, not a gate.

No walls that matter. The boundary is the last crane and the ranging-yard inland. Low governance looks like this: the council charters the guild, never the person.

**Hallowquay** is a lesser inner quay, not the capital. A fox-born broker might still be *of Hallowquay*. That byname was already in the world; the seat is Orentel.

**The square.** Composite: nucleated Tree-town on the rise, linear quays along the tide, leap-frog warehouses where a fire or a silted berth made the next stretch cheaper than rebuilding. The interesting streets are the edges where the rise meets the salt.

- **The Tree at the centre.** Still the civic heart, even when the money is downhill. Mature Hand. Leaf-Fall is a civic and commercial milestone: a family's colour is watched for what guild it opens. Warm it is not. The square still Turns local children for free. That free is the leftover the quay cannot price without noticing itself.
- **The first quay.** The Salt Walk's old landing. Empty Eolthael berths held as prestige; wool through Hale-month covering a shrine. A smell of earth out of season when a pot, not a child, is the passenger.



- **The third quay, north side.** The White Note House. Ledan's desk. Mataero's loft in the rise behind, twelve beds, north bed not to let. Century instruments. The house is a mouth, not a council. Lestrاند will only count it as success.
- **The release-house.** Ael-hall as playhouse and outlet, ticketed. Superb if you can pay. The queue outside it is the have-and-have-not gap at street height.
- **The leaf-lots.** Rented green, not Mother's common. They will not follow you home, and home is a loft if they did.
- **The beast-yard.** Hired ranging at the inland edge, not a wild-leave. Two-Bodied haulage is a trade dynasty if the match was priced that way.
- **The ticket-infirmaries.** The Stillers on the downwind edge. Excellent. For those who can reach them. The queue is longest here too.
- **The far shed.** Returned work past the last crane. Same logic as a tannery.

Homes accommodate becomings. Mixed Kinds. A Sands-Fox at a desk is unremarkable if they have warranting. The shadow economy (smuggled green, sold vouching, off-book Terms) is alleys the guilds pretend not to charter.

**Clock 1:** this canopy Turns at home. The Salt Walk is optional. The bed-house collected.

**Clock 2:** empty Eolthael berths are still shaped like a landing; pots still take a child's space; a First-Hand year can be booked as a winter. Hands can un-Hands. If Orentel's Tree sickened, this quay would be the neighbour's week. It has not. The council does not narrate the age as over. It narrates occupancy.

Prestige is the job on the street: the walk you do not need, sold. That is how a rich coast gets a capital without a crown. Devotion that lands here is a hymn the release-house will schedule. Necessity in the loft is Mataero's eye, not the city's brand.

Salt sits on the Tree's roots in Eolthael. Orentel will not say why. A hall-keeper will schedule around it. A book-hand will not put it in a term.

**Offices.** The charter-council: houses and craft-guilds. Watches the guild, never the individual. **Sorim** is the factor who can be asked who chartered the empty berths this Eolthael. They will answer in occupancy. They are not Ledan.

Tree-tenders: Lestrاند's word for wardens. Practice-first, not Kind. Speak the fall as a civic fact. A colour that opens a guild is still a colour.

The White Note House: Ledan writes; Mataero lets. The north bed is house custom. Two fates, two lintels.

The Book-Hands: ordinary on this quay. Signing-watch as prestige if you book it. They do not rewrite Bound Terms. They do not sit a seat.

Road-hands / graft-carts: rare; a pot on an Eolthael berth is cargo in the clerk's mouth.

The Tithe-poor fade while the city steps around them. That is the injustice. Nothing is policed. Everything is priced.

*A berth-slate, first quay, Eolthael through Hale-month, C.Y. 387. Sorim's hand. The Tree is not mentioned.*

*Eolthael berths 1-4: held. Do not load wool. A First-Hand year is not cargo. I have explained this to the crane.*

*Berth 5: earth. A pot is cargo. I have explained this to the family who wanted 5 for a child. They could not hold 1-4. I did not invent the hold.*

*The rise still Turns for free. That is a Tree-tender matter. The quay is a hold matter. If you need both in one week you are in the wrong mouth.*

*White Note, third north: not a berth. Do not send me their conversions. I do not keep house-years.*

Ledan will hear the slate as a neighbour who cannot convert. Mataero will hear occupancy.

### *The White Note House (placed, not crowned)*

A road-house that became a desk. A deathless house of the trusted note. **Ledan** writes century-loans from a founding-summer the house calls the White Note's count. **Mataero** (*mah-TAY-ro*) lets the loft. The north bed is house custom, not to let, a founding-name the junior is not to copy onto a term. Everyday *the White Note*; Lestrاند still says *the bed-house* and means the bank. Founding about C.Y. 80 (White Note year 200 = Cut-year 280, per Ledan's conversion-problem). The quay-desk sits on Orentel's third quay, north side; the inland loft is in the rise behind. **The desk is not the crown.**

The same fortune as the Third Hearth, later. In Brenvaeth the house was beds, porridge, and credit for a walk you could not miss twice. When the walk stopped being required in the core, the Long-Lived still remembered every debtor, and the paper outlived the pilgrimage-season. The desk sat down on Orentel's third quay because that is where notes now move. The inland upper room is occupancy: twelve beds in the rise behind the salt, looking at a Tree that still Turns for free.

**What it sells now:** century instruments, trusted paper, a First-Hand year you can book (the held-over winter as product), loft-terms to wool through Hale-month, and still the old kind of note for a necessity-family: eat now, pay on the home-walk. Same paper, two jobs. The clerk who files both as occupancy does not have to see the difference.

**The north bed** is how a bank proves it used to be an inn. Empty is not a shrine, Mataero says. Empty is a bed they are not charging for. Ledan says the house is the same mouth. The founding-book has a

name. Thilim, inland, still holds a far-cape name the White Note does not. Lestrand will only count this house as success. Orentel's charter-council will only count it as one ticket among many.

**How to get a term.** A street door on the salt. No chapel-front. A counting-room that smells of ink and tide. Ledan's stool faces the door, not the water. Mataero has the inland key.

1. You name what you want: a century-instrument, a loft-term, a First-Hand year, the old necessity-note.
2. Ledan asks which count the mouth wants written: house-year, Cut-year, or a third date a Lestrand court invented last generation. They can convert. They will make you say which.
3. If the paper is a First-Hand year, the term is written here and the berth is **not**. Ledan will send you to Sorim for the hold and will not walk you there. Netstrand still has to charter the hull. Orenbren still has to house the sleep.

Morning at the desk is conversion. Evening is the tide-bell, then Mataero walking the rise to check the north bed. Occupied is a session. Empty is the custom.

**Features.** The quay-desk: third quay, north side, Orentel. Ledan's count; conversions to Eoloren-count when a court makes them; three dates for one summer still a live query. The inland loft: in the Tree-town rise, not on the water. Twelve beds in Mataero's slate; eight let; four open for Eolthael; north bed not to let. The founding-book: Held names as credit-tokens. Not read aloud on a term. A smell of earth out of season when a pot, not a child, is the passenger. Cargo, the clerk files. Next berth over, a First-Hand year is not cargo. Sorim will not convert that either.

No mortal court can check a Long-Lived's memory of a ford two hundred summers back. That is why the note holds. It is also why a grandchild can owe a walk they cannot point to. Spreading Trees did not make the paper kind.

## Maiethlir (Threnmaieth's seat)

(*my-eth-LEER* · *maieth* "Mother" + *lir* "thaw" = "the Mother's thaw.") Conservative drift: *th* kept. Everyday *Maiethlir*. The capital of Threnmaieth because this is where they started counting a hearth that was already holy, not because they own Thaeloren. The First Seat sits in the Motherwood *beside* this country and is not its crown. Speaker: **Rithim** (*RITH-im*), the elder who names the leaf-colour at Leaf-Fall (in a small town the warden Speaks; here the office has its own mouth). A counted city, smaller than Orentel, older; the clerks will tell you a number after every Eolthael.

A thaw-river town on Maiethorn, in the Sacred Core and not in the grove. Snowmelt comes down from Liorn's range; the river runs toward the inner sea. Maiethlir sat down where the water slowed enough to hold a Hand, an origin-town of the C.Y. 0 to 40s, a day's living-earth from the wood, on a *different road* than Orenbren's Near Mile. Orenbren lodges the approach. This river counted the people who stayed.

The extra mile used to come through with the thaw. When Hands made the origin-walk optional, the lodging emptied toward Orenbren's beds. The rooms did not stay empty. Clerks filled them. Adaptive reuse at city scale: a pilgrimage-street that learned house-names on a tablet.

Threnmaieth coils near the sacred centre and wants everyone on the Threnhael. Maiethlir is the square that proves the coil without owning the Tree: the colour that falls is a hymn *and* a line. Maiethvael shares the Mother and refuses the list, same hymns, opposite paper, a day's argument upriver or down.

What this city still does is devotion: the extra mile remains the civic season, now written under the census. The census is not the postcard. People who had to come still sleep in an uncounted loft when the soil up-range is thin. People who paid book a counted winter. The crown's roll sits on top of that older traffic. It does not replace it.

**Site.** The thaw-river is why anyone stopped. Ford, mill, a Hand planted beside the water because the first carrying followed living earth and a day's drink. The Motherwood is a dark on one horizon. You can walk to the grove. Most Hands-children do not. The college is in those clearings. It is not this square.

Water is the river, conduits the crown maintains, cisterns in the old pilgrim-streets. Food is the Core's plenty. Fuel is the wood's edge, which the Seat will not let a crown cut without a leave. Proximity is pressure, not ownership. The Taken-In work the **tended green** the crown furnishes; they are not a nation.

A wall exists and is old. It was for floods and for a generation of argument, not for a siege the Core no longer expects. The interesting streets are inside it, where the old extra-mile meets the tablet-hall.

**The square.** Concentric around the canopy, then radial along the river and the old extra-mile. Ordered the way a counted city becomes ordered: not a grid drawn last week, an accretion that learned numbers.

- **The Tree at the centre.** A mature Hand, not the First. Civic and sacred heart. Leaf-Fall is a joyous holy day that is also a state registration. The colour is Spoken. A clerk waits to copy it. **Rithim** Speaks. They do not always let the copy happen in the same breath.
- **The tablet-hall.** The Threnhael's local mouth. Not the Tree. Beside it. Names, colours, marriages of heritable Conditions *noticed*. Outsiders hear "the Counting." Clerks say they keep the realm hale.
- **The counted hall.** Ael-hall as outlet *and* attendance. A Far-Voiced hour furnished through the crown's channel. To be cut off is framed as your lapse.
- **The old extra-mile.** Still a street. Upper rooms that used to sleep pilgrims are clerk-dorms. A Held bed would offend the roll; the roll has not found all of them. The Watching keep a room under a chapel the wardens recut (the Grown-Over).

- **The tended green.** Crown-furnished commons. They will not follow you home. Home is on file if they did.
- **The ranging-roll.** Two-Bodied leave at the edge, noticed. Not a Kind-flag.
- **The crown-stiller.** Excellent medicine, downwind, through the channel. The Bound are watched past their hazard, dressed as safety.
- **The far shed.** Returned work past the last conduit. Filed.

Homes accommodate becomings, and the accommodation is on the tablet. Mixed Kinds. A Fox of the Snows down from Lirorn is a guest with a name. The late week here is *unfiled*, which is the local crime.

The clerks will tell you a number. It changes after every Eolthael.

**Clock 1:** this canopy Turns at home. The Near Mile is Orenbren's job. The extra mile is a civic season. The Motherwood is a walk, not a requirement.

**Clock 2:** the thaw-road still brings a necessity-family when up-range soil is thin; an uncounted loft still smells like Hale-month; Hands can un-Hands. The roll would like those summers filed. The leftover is the pilgrimage the clerks moved into.

Devotion is the job on the street: people still come because the hinge is holy. The Threnhael is the layer, a tablet beside the Tree, not instead of it. That is how a pious core gets a capital without capturing the grove. The injustice is that the layer learned to withhold the green.

The thaw runs louder the week before the fall. Maiethlir will not say why. Rithim will Speak over it. A clerk may write the noise down as snowmelt. That writing is the clerk's.

**Offices.** Speaker / town-warden (Rithim): Reckoned Hands pressure, practice-first, not Kind. Speaks the fall truly. The copy is a second, lesser seeing. Some summers they let it happen in the same breath. Some they do not. The crown has not replaced them. The Seat has not recalled them. That gap is load-bearing.

The tablet-clerks, Long-Lived among them, memory bent to the census rather than free to check it. A crown-archivist who remembers what a line was made to overwrite is a hook, not a name yet.

The First Seat: in the Motherwood, beside, a college not a throne. Some Speakers cooperate with the roll (they believe they are keeping the realm hale). Some refuse. A pilgrim who asks Rithim where the college is will be pointed at the wood, not the tablet-hall.

Orenbren lodging: a day's argument along the other road. They witness who slept, not what colour. Threnmaieth would like the lodging-rolls.

Watchers in the oldest district: a second reading *alongside*, not over. Filed as the Grown-Over. No seat.

The Kept are pitied *and* noted as unmarked. A household whose bloodline and upkeep are both on file cannot easily refuse the crown anything.

*A Threnhael copy-slip, tablet-hall, Eolthael, C.Y. 387. The Speaker's name is on the recto. The clerk's hand is on the verso. The Tree is named as hale.*

**Recto, Rithim.** *Spoken: storm-grey. Witnessed in the square. The hug was not this child's. I have said the colour. I have not said the line. The river was loud. I will not wait for it.*

**Verso, clerk.** *Copied: Two-Bodied, named to the Threnhael, household already on file. Speaker delayed the copy until after the hymn. Delay noted. River-noise noted as snowmelt. The unmarked in the same household noted. Provision continues through the counted channel.*

*The wood was asked whether the Speaker is a Reckoned Hand. The wood did not answer in this hall.*

The delay is the leftover: a pilgrimage-town that still thinks the hymn comes first. The First Seat, asked later, will say the Tree witnessed.

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## The twelve seats

The three famous corners are above: Threnmaieth, Lestrand, and Vaethorn, with their cities Maiethlir, Orentel, and Eolvaeth. These twelve are the other seats of power. Each one is a capital, a city, a town, or a written refusal to build a city. Harrow's Green is a square in Saelvaeth's orbit. It is not one of the twelve. Six charter-towns around Raitin, the shelves of Lirorn, and the pockets between grafts stay unnamed. No capital is marked with a star on a map. The First Seat, the college of tree-wardens, stays in the Motherwood and is not a capital.

Read an entry this way. The first lines say what the place is and where it sits. **The work** is the job the town does, and who does it. A neighbour uses a given name. A clerk in a list-land says the house-name first. The last sentences are habits. People do them and will not say why. A habit is not a relic and not a rite.

### Seinbrun (Maiethvael's capital)

(*SAYN-brun.*) Maiethvael's capital, a large city in the warm core of Maiethorn. People call the country the Gift-Realm. Charters write *Maiethvael*. The city provides public greens, a hall, and medicine through its congregations and guilds. It does not keep a census. It is not Maiethlir. It is not the Down-

Bank, the stretch of road below Maiethlir's Down Gate. You can spend a day among Gift-folk on that road and still not have reached Seinbrun. During pilgrimage season the Motherwood is in sight. It is not inside the city. A town Tree stands beside the furnished hall. The city does not copy a child's leaf-colour onto a list.

**The work** is the hall, with the green beside it. Vuthbraen keeps the hall. Raermu keeps the medicine basket. Breillai left the hymn. The green, the hall, and the medicine went together. The hall can still set a bowl. The net stays where the hymn is. A neighbour says the given name. There is no house to put first.

The furnished hall sets an empty bowl at the end of the table, away from the pot, and clears it with the others. Seinbrun will not say why. On the day a household leaves the hymn, a neighbour stacks their green pots in the lane, still planted. They will not say why. Smaller towns around the city stay unnamed.

## Rothallo (Orenbren's capital)

(roh-THAL-oh.) A walled city, one day's walk from the Motherwood. People still say **the Inner Close**, and the Close. The walls answer to those names. It is the same place. It stays inside Orenbren. It is not a second town and not a sixteenth power. Smaller towns and villages lie around it in the lodging-country. This book does not name them. The Third Hearth, the Mill-hold, and Nelath are in that country. They are not this capital.

The First Seat, the tree-wardens' college, is in the wood beyond the wall. The wood is not the capital. A town Tree stands inside the walls. The city does not hold a Turning at it. The Closed Heirs rank Conditioned people in the Book of Tithes, kept inside the walls. Orenbren, the country around the city, keeps a separate witness of who slept the night. The two records are not copied onto each other. Beds for people assigned to labour are outside the gate. The Book is inside. That gate does not open to join the two.

**The work** is the Book. Delamem keeps it. The pages assign taxes, restrictions, and labour, on top of the Tithe a person already carries. Talnin is still the heir whose tenth year is not finished. A neighbour says a given name. A clerk says the house first. *Closed* on a roster is a rank, not a second name. The line can cast a person out and keep the house on them.

Brimaen, house Lanbru, keeps a stall inside on a licence the Book can revoke. Breolnir, house Tethnae, writes who slept. Methei, house Sithlaen, sleeps outside because the labour-line says so. The same person can be a guest on one page and labour on the other. The pages will not be copied onto each other.

The outer gate is shut for the length of a kettle's boil, on a morning with no crowd. Rothallo will not say why. Bread for the beds outside is cut while it is still too hot to eat, and the heel is set on the wall-

stone. The beds will not say why. A Closed child, the week before the tenth year, leaves one shoe by the Book's step and walks the lane in the other. The lane will not say why.

## Larbril (Saelthael's city)

(*LAR-bril.*) A medium city where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. People say the Sown Tree. Walking west, the Shelf-gate is still ahead. Walking east, the dry is in front of you. It is not a great capital. It is not Ornsael.

Ornsael stays the smaller well-town, farther into the dry. Its drink is a well. Larbril's drink, when it has one, is the wash. They are not the next roof to each other. Ornsael is not the coast, and Larbril is not a west bank. The Dry Stair is another rise. People climb it so they know a dare from a Tree. It is not why this city is here.

The wash is a river in a kind Liren and a silt-line in a cruel one. A Hand stands at the meeting. It Speaks most years. A missed week is weather. Fox of the Sands hearths are dense in this country. That is terrain. The city's mouth is not an ear on a flag.

**The work** is the meeting. Brormei says what the wash is this week, and whether a column goes west toward the pass. A neighbour says Brormei. There is no house to put first. Ornsael's well-share is Ornsael's. The pass-levy is Lirorn's, taken at Tasain. Larbril keeps the road and the wash in one place.

When the Well-wash is a silt-line, Brormei still wets the meeting-stone from a jar. They will not say why. A cart bound west is held while the driver sets a pebble on the dry line. Larbril will not say why.

## Votaer (the Hinge Shore's port)

(*VOH-tayr.*) One of the largest cities on the Motherland coast, because the crossing is why the people are there. It faces Orentel. It is not a second Orentel. Hulls are classified on these quays. The Hush-rate is charged here. Towns along the rest of the shore stay unnamed.

Orentel prices the crossing. Votaer sorts it. A child, a pot of living earth, a family on a neighbour's week: the bell can sound the same, and a clerk writes which docket. The White Note is not on this quay. Trees on this shore are healthy. Faith is worn thinner than in Maiethvael, because a dock teaches categories. Selkie families work these quays, as they do on any old water. The docket does not belong to a hearth.

**The work** is the classification quay. Tumair writes the hull: pilgrim, pot, person, or cargo. Lertho charges the Hush-rate. A neighbour says the given name. There is no house to put first. The blessing and the docket happen in the same breath.

Tumair chalks the hull's class under the waterline, where the next tide takes the mark. They will not say why. Lertho counts the rate aloud, sets the last coin in the box, and takes it out once before it stays.



They will not say why. A cook-fire on the quay is put out when the bell rings for a sail that is not in sight. Votaer will not say why. A dry net hangs on the blessing-rail on days when no one asks for a hymn. The quay will not say why.

## **Tasain (Lirorn's town)**

*(tah-SAYN.)* A walled town in a sheltered valley below the Shelf-gate, where the west road comes down and the levy is taken. People stay the winter here. It is not a great city. It is not a second Maiethlir.

The town gate and the Shelf-gate are not the same gate. The Noon Pass is a third thing, higher and older, and it is not a seat. Larbril is the city on the dry side of the pass, short of the climb if you are walking west. Villages and hamlets stay on the shelves. This book does not name them.

**The work** is the levy, taken at the town gate. Last year's snow is this year's civic year. Narol of the Pass is dead. The house still levies. Break-rate is still asked in a kind year. No new person is seated here. A shelf whose graft sickens is a long way from a stiller. The valley takes the due in shelter. The shelves pay in isolation.

In a kind year, before the levy is taken, a bowl of shelf-snow is left on the gate-stone until it is water. Tasain will not say why.

## **Raitin (Brenledd's throne-city)**

*(RAY-tin.)* A river-city on Strandoren, one of the largest on that shore, behind and between the premier coast. People say the Hearth-League. This is where the council sits and the shared notes clear. The league stays a league of hearths. It does not become one house.

Six charter-towns sit around it. This book does not name them. The shared list is seven hearths. Raitin is one. People still recite Nidtol when Lestrang offers to deal with a single throat. Nidtol is that recited hearth-name. It is not this city. The water here is not the Chart-run. That run is Lunbra's.

**The work** is the council hall, at the head of the river stair. Turvo keeps the notes. Sulnu carries a cleared ticket down to the stair. Nubo is vouched in this city and still unknown where another hearth did not stand them. A neighbour says the given name. There is no house to put first. A note can clear in this hall and still die in the next hearth. The league calls the gap local.

Turvo turns a cleared note face-down before the next hearth is called. They will not say why. The hall sets one cup at the end of the table and does not fill it. Raitin will not say why. Bread for a sitting is broken at the river door. The heel stays on the sill until the sitting ends. They will not say why. On the morning a note is due, the river-stairs are swept from the water up toward the hall. The stair will not say why.

## Naenor (Leddvael's port)

(*NAY-nor.*) A large port on its own stretch of indented coast, slightly smaller than Orentel. People say the Reckoned Gift. This is where the signing-watch sits. It is not a second Orentel. It does not face the Hinge Shore. Towns along the rest of that coast stay unnamed.

Leaf-Fall here is a festival and a signing-watch. A Tithe is a term serviced. The Bound are employed as the shape of honesty. The city will file a contract. It will not copy Threnmaieth's list. It wins the signing and loses the berth. A First-Hand year is not this city's product. The Book-Hands stamp and recite in this wind. They have no seat of their own. They do not rewrite Terms.

**The work** is the signing-watch, on the book-table in the square. Derdil stands it. A neighbour says Derdil. There is no house to put first. A household that calls the colour a gift is read as a bad debtor. The Bound are safe here, and they are over-read.

Derdil stamps the wax, then warms the stamp in a closed hand before the next page. They will not say why. The watch reads a term aloud and turns the page with the left hand only. Naenor will not say why. At Leaf-Fall the square sets the Bound witness's chair with its back to the Tree. The square will not say why.

## Lunbra (Trenledd's city)

(*LUN-bra.*) A large, wealthy city on the Chart-run, four to eight days upriver of Orentel. People say the Worn Count. This is where the roll is kept and the money is shown. The governing throat is not named. Towns through the filed country stay unnamed.

Stone fronts, paid chairs, guild doors left open onto the square so the coin is visible from the street. You are on the roll so commerce and hazard can find you again. There is no hymn that makes the list a stewardship. Threnmaieth at least claims to keep you hale. The Worn Count claims to keep you findable. A Hand stands in the square. The number on the back of a stone is not a prayer.

**The work** is the roll-room. Vamar keeps a column: who owes, who Turned, who can be found. The file is Melro, Vamar. A neighbour says Vamar. A clerk says the house first. Vamar is not the governing throat. In Trenledd the column may file a person under the house that pays, including a house they dislike. The city shows the money. The roll is how a person is allowed near it.

Vamar sets a coin on the open page. The coin is not the fee. They will not say why. On the morning a new house is written, the stones in the square are turned number-down. Lunbra will not say why. A newcomer is shown the expensive chair and is not asked to sit until the house has been said. The room will not say why.

## Braetu (the Night Shore's harbour)

(BRAY-too.) A harbour city on Strandoren's west and south face, on the West Water, smaller than Orentel. People say the Night Shore. This is where a far crossing is quoted. It is not a second Orentel. Towns along the rest of the shore stay unnamed.

A crossing is quoted here the way another shore talks about a pilgrimage. The city does not sell the First-Hand year as a finished thing. That year is assembled on the old water: a Night Shore hull, the White Note's terms, Orentel's berth. Braetu is the first of those desks. The far run is two to four weeks in fair weather. Beyond the last capes is the storm-wall. Kumbaan is not booked from this quay.

They keep a dark book: quoted crossings that did not come back. Houses pay to keep a lamp on a name. One berth stays unlit. No house is attached to it.

**The work** is the quote-desk. Mursur writes the far crossing and takes the fee for the lamp. A neighbour says Mursur. There is no house to put first. Mursur is not a house on the unlit berth. Nobody is. The lamp is a charge. The dark berth is not billed.

Mursur lights a name's lamp with a spill from the cook-fire, not from another lamp. They will not say why. The far figure is written, blotted, and written again the same. Mursur will not say why. People leaving the harbour touch the unlit berth's ring, and do not hang a line on it. Braetu will not say why.

## Sanbreo (Ornled's town)

(san-BREE-oh.) A town on Heskoren's slate-shore, on the brink of a small city, and still a town. People say the Outer Ledger. This is where the slate is kept. A beach-fee can be paid here when a hull arrives. The frontier coast faces the West Water. Beyond the last capes is the storm-wall. Villages in the pockets around the town stay unnamed.

The roofs have filled the pocket. They did not grow a congregation or a counted hall. The fee here is a beach, not Braetu's far quote. Vaethorn may bless a landing and may not levy it. Ornled takes the fee anyway. A hymn is not what they sell.

**The work** is the slate, on the wall inside the shore gate. The first line is still the sentence Vathne cut: the town will not wait with a hymn for a stick that drowned. The wood of the wall is newer than the words. Someone recopied the line. Vathne is that line, not a mouth in the room. No new person is seated here. An unvouched Struck is met with a rope, a deal, or a neighbour. A hull can pay. A neighbour who cannot barter a Tithe still slides.

When a hull has paid, the coin stays on the slate's sill until the hull is gone. Sanbreo will not say why.

## Vaelhesk (the land is the seat)

(VAYL-hesk.) People say the Far Yield, and the Yield. There is no new city and no new name. The land is the seat. Old greens, ancestor-doors, first meals. The Mother's wood is a guest. A Cutting-leave without the meal is a claiming. Villages and hamlets stay on the old greens. A traveler who asks for the seat is pointed at a door.

There is no settlement dot. The First Bowl stays the guest-grove. It is not a capital, and it is not a second Harrow. Struck and the Taken-In are read as the land's own children. A neighbour's week to a Motherfaith Tree can be refused on purpose. Vaethorn reads those children as Kept-for-want. That disagreement decides whether a child travels. No new person is seated on the refusal.

## Natai (Saelvaeth's town)

(NAH-tye.) A march-town on Heskoren's moving edge, where the voice stands. People say the Sown Waiting, and March-folk. A graft has taken here. The canopy is a town's Hand. It is not the luck at Harrow's Green.

On the Known Map, Natai sits west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and the square. The gate is not Harrow's square, and it is not the ford. Other towns where a graft has taken stay unnamed. Hamlets between them stay unnamed.

Harrow's Green stays the live-front square it already is. It is not the march's seat, and it is not a capital. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford stay the three hamlets. The Hush lets this march take a pot without a Vaethorn waiting-due. Someone has to stand where the queue can be shouted at.

**The work** is the march-voice. Dumu stands it. A neighbour says Dumu. There is no house to put first. Haelin keeps Harrow's square. Tora of Brenod keeps the walk from the ford. Dumu keeps this gate. The town can be blamed for a queue it did not write. Harrow's has the canopy the hamlets can see. Natai has the mouth.

While a complaint is said, Dumu leaves the gate-latch on the post, and puts it back in the catch when the speaker turns. They will not say why.

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## Other Places

Places the world already implied, now seated: three pre-Walk leftovers a party can enter, a Kumbaan hall a session can sit down in, and three squares the road already needed. The twelve seats are in The Fifteen Powers and the Gazetteer. Do not make Harrow's Green or Ornsael a capital to tidy the map. Do not capture the First Seat. One type is still only a type.

### The Low Wall

Orenbren lodging-country, first days from the Motherwood, not Rothallo. People still say the Inner Close for that city. This fold is not it. Shoulder-high stone; three gaps used as gates; a blank name-stone; a garden-end against an inn's back wall. Different quarry from Rothallo. Same wall is a claim, not a fact. The site is found, not founded, and undated.

**Enter** by the cart-gap, the person-gap Rothallo still assigns labour walks through, the socket-gap an Old Ways first-meal uses, a crawl under the name-stone, or the garden-end loft.

**Pressure.** The Book wants a chip that files as Rothallo's quarry. Watchers block a chisel. The lodging-guild wants climbers off before Eolthael.

**Discovery.** A wrong quarry chip, still under the fill put down in Hale-month of C.Y. 381. The chip is the other quarry. It has no year on it. It does not match Rothallo's stone. A pot-ring. A knife-ribbon left in error: a Near-Mile kitchen knife on a ribbon marks a Closing summer in a house, not this wall. No date for the wall. No date for the Tree. No first enemy. No solve.

**Actors.** Delamem of the Close; Thuda at the inn; a Watcher at the panel; an Orenbren guild runner.

### The Seeing-Ring

A Watching hill on Maiethorn, not the grove. Uncounted ring below; later shrine-work above, roof removed. A ring-walk clockwise; four out-looks: origin smear, Old Crossing weather, two facing nothing. Found, not founded. Undated.

**Enter** by the hill path, mismatched shrine steps, an under-ring crawl, or Tithsael's night.

**Pressure.** A clerk with a chisel. A warden who wants the roof back. In Eolthael someone ties a cloth ribbon on the lintel-socket. By Leddorn it is gone. Tithsael takes a colour-ribbon off. A hug-ribbon stays. The cloth does not Speak. They will not say why the ribbon was a colour.

**Discovery.** A dual pecked mark, a clay pot-ring. No confirmation she stood here. No Closed Seat gate. The ribbon does not explain the two gaps that face nothing.

**Actor.** Tithsael keeps the night.

## The Dry Stair

Saelthael Rain-Shadow, a rise above a well-town that is **not** Ornsael. Worn steps to a door-stone and a dry basin (wrong pecking for a cistern); a warden's dead slip still in the upper basin. Found, not founded. Undated.

**Enter** by the flight (skip the broken step), the door-stone threshold, or a crawl to a second dry basin.

**Pressure.** The warden wants another pot. A clerk wants riser-scratches. A missed child needs overnight at the slab.

**Discovery.** A salt-white ring, mineral or brush-ash. Not her first Hand. Not a Fox temple. A later warden planted a slip in the upper basin. The slip died. What is left is a thumb of dead wood in a crack at the lip. It does not green. It is not a scion. People say the stair refused a mother. The rock was dry, and the slip died of that.

Pair with Ornsael: a water crisis in a living well-town versus a climb that Gives nothing.

## Ndenjoo

A hill-hall on Kumbaen. Own-name *nden-JOH*; sailors say **the Feeding Hill**. One of the Paps: a green hill honeycombed underneath, pasture and standing-stones on the turf, the life below. The valley comes here on the bright nights. There is no Tree. There is a table.

**Njunda** opens it because it was their grandmother's, and because it still fits the crowd. Reputation, not office. **Soonke** sits the storm-beach below. They do not swim out. A living wreck they walk uphill. First night as guest starts at the hall, not on the sand. **Saalo** of the valley wants a crossing *out*, to find Waandi, who left two moons ago. **Nolas** of a Netstrand hull sat twice, kin inside the hall, and will not go back to a ship.

There is no leftover job of the walk. Kumbaen is off the clocks. The leftover is the wall: people who arrived and did not leave; people who want to leave and cannot book a thinning.

Life is under the hill. You walk into a Pap and come out at a board. The extra place is set slightly back, every meal that matters. To omit it is the one impiety. Daylight is a Sabbath of sleep. A mainlander loud at noon is a problem the hall can feel in its teeth. On one night of the moon sailors call Yoltal, the heel of the loaf is eaten first. Ndenjoo will not say why. A guest who asks is given more bread.

**Getting there.** You cannot book a passage to Ndenjoo. You are on the sand or you are not. Soonke, who sits the storm-beach, decides whether you are alive. Njunda, who keeps the hall, decides whether you are kin. The second sitting is how you belong on the isle. It does not become papers a mainland watch will accept. A road-word, the mainland custom of being vouched for, still helps you leave a Strandoren quay before you sail. On the hill, nobody asks for it. The shore-sitters do not send anyone back.

A session here can use an extra place already laid, Nolas gone because the hall counts them as kin, a wreck off the hill, or a word of Waandi, who left. None of those scenes are a test of what the Trees are. A warden who arrives is still a guest. There is no Tree to tend.

What can enter a scene: a wreck walked uphill tonight; the hands stop; noon-noise; a hull rumour.

*Said to the extra place before the hands arrive, a bright night. A second line added in Njunda's mouth after Nolas sat twice.*

*We have counted you. Sit. If you have a name we have not learned it yet; if you have a colour we have no tree to read it.*

*If you have sat twice, you are of the table. The table is not a ship. Sleep when the moon is down. The sand does not owe you a second hull.*

## The Mill-hold

The sick-Tree town. Everyday *the Mill-hold*; travellers who only saw the drain say *the culvert*. Orenbren lodging-country, two days past Brenthael on the Near Mile, six days out from the grove in the count the road already uses. Not Rothallo. Not Brenthael. A few hundred hearths around one mill-race and one canopy.

For a generation they Turned at home. This Liren the culvert that keeps spring-water off the roots choked. The mill-race stayed full. The Hand stood in it. Root blight is waterlogged soil, crowded roots, a drain someone assumed someone else cleared. It is this year. Unsound wood spends the week. The children walk in, toward Brenthael, because a warden who stands them under wood that cannot Turn has made them unTurned. Next summer is not a repair.

**Talen** (*TAH-len*) is town-warden. They will not stand a child under unsound wood, and they want the mill to still turn through Harvest. The same water is bread. **Milsun** (*MIL-sun*), Taken-In, keeps the drain and a planting above the race. **Thurrei** (*thur-RAY*) is the Road-hand, here for the wood, not for the children. The neighbour-slate is chalked on the mill-door: this year's ten-year-olds, and which Brenthael mouth has room.

Mill-foam on the drain-lip keeps last Eolthael's colour a day longer than the water does. Milsun will not say why. Talen moves the foam with a stick. Thurrei wipes it off a pot-wrap and does not write it down.

A miller still takes a share of grain. The mill-share is not the mouth this square turns on. When the race is drawn down, they set the stones and leave one measure of last year's grain on the lip until the water comes back. They will not say why.

## The First Bowl

The guest-grove. An old green that kept host-rights before any leave. A young Hand stands in it now, cut from Harrow's Green after Harrow's took. Everyday *the First Bowl*. Folk hearth-name *Lonasir* (*lo-NAH-seer*). The Seat still writes *a later planting in the Far Yield* and does not use the hearth-name.

This grove is not Vaelhesk's capital. Vaelhesk's seat is the land itself, and there is no city to mark. The First Bowl is not Vaelun, not a second Harrow's Green, and not a sick Tree. It is a day's walk from Vaelun, sometimes two, away from Harrow's and deeper into the Yield. You do not pass Harrow's square to reach it unless you are carrying wood from there.

The Mother's wood is a guest. A Cutting-leave without the meal is a claiming. **Delvor** (*DEL-vor*) of Lonasir asks about the bowl before they ask about a leave. **Vilraet** (*vil-RAYT*) is town-warden of the guest and wants the week Spoken so a marriage can be witnessed here. **Brudu** (*BROO-doo*), Taken-In, keeps the old planting and wants the morning water before the guest's pot. The question of whether this is Taken-In country is the slight.

The first-meal bread is always a little sour. Delvor says that is how you know the grove sat down. After the last person has gone in, a rye-straw is laid on the door-path's first stone and left until first light. The First Bowl will not say why.

## Nelath

Nelath (*NEL-ath*) is the road-end: a town where a side road stops. People on the Near Mile say "the spur" and mean the road, then use the town's name once they are in it. It is a Tree-town in Orenbren's lodging-country, one square at the end of a side trip off the Near Mile. The junction is a day short of



the Third Hearth. From the junction the spur is one more day, and then the canopy. You do not pass Thilim's road-house, and you do not pass the Mill-hold's culvert. Nelath is not Harrow's Green, not Brenthael, not the Mill-hold, not Rothallo, and not the First Seat.

The main Mile still goes on. This track leaves it and does not rejoin. When Hands made the origin-walk optional, this town brought the next stone in. Beyond the boughs there is a scar: a ditch, thorns, and the width of a road that is no longer a road. There is no ford. There is no neighbour's canopy.

**Raetoth** (*RAY-toth*) is town-warden. They Speak the fall at home and want the stone left in the square and the scar left closed. **Lithsur** (*LITH-sur*) wants the stone back on the scar so a cut name is a day's mark again, and will bring a rope in Eolthael. The stone is not the day's drink. The cistern is the drink. A notch on the stone still holds a little rain after the square has dried. A name is cut into the lintel over the upper room. Nelath will not say why the notch stays wet, or whose name that is.

The road-mend stops at the boughs. They do not cut the thorns back to make the spur go on.

## Two claimants on one green

**Not yet written.** Two claimants on one green: warden and door-keeper. Vaelun leans this way. It is not yet a named square of the type. The First Bowl is the guest-grove. It does not close this hole.

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BOOK VIII

Faces

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# Faces of the Turning

Offices that already had to exist, made into people. The job is why they matter. None of them were chosen. A party can meet two in a week and never meet the rest. Recruits not by Kind.

## Offices already on the ground

These mouths were furniture first. They are people now. Do not rebuild the seats or squares to give them a stage.

| Name           | Where they stand                | The job                                              |
|----------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Haelin</b>  | Harrow's Green                  | warden who sends; the live front this cast points at |
| <b>Tora</b>    | Brenod / Harrow's               | the mouth that walks a neighbour-fall home           |
| <b>Thilim</b>  | the Third Hearth                | innkeeper of the Held bed                            |
| <b>Ledan</b>   | White Note quay-desk, Orentel   | clerk who copies                                     |
| <b>Mataero</b> | White Note inland loft, Orentel | occupancy                                            |
| <b>Vaethod</b> | Eolvaeth                        | warden of a pilgrim-edge                             |
| <b>Sorim</b>   | Orentel, first quay             | factor who holds a berth                             |
| <b>Rithim</b>  | Maiethlir                       | Speaker who will not say the line                    |

Two clocks in the cast: Thilim and Laevila still say *I walked*, and they do not mean the same walk. Mataero files the age as occupancy and thinks the wave is over. Vaethod sends toward a luck they cannot see; the live front is Haelin's square, not theirs.

# Positional pivots

## Vaethod — Eolvaeth

**Vaethod** (*VAYTH-od*) is town-warden of Eolvaeth: the mouth who decides whether the hinge happened, whether the Speaking week is over, and some years whether a cohort walks toward Saelvaeth's luck. They will not invent a colour that did not fall. What they want is not the Tree but **Saelid**'s baker's stall on the camp-streets — winter mouths buy bread, and a send-year takes those mouths away. They tell themselves that speaking truly means they have not chosen. They have sent people toward Haelin's live front without meeting them.

## Rithim — Maiethlir

**Rithim** (*RITH-im*) is Speaker of Maiethlir — the mouth that names the leaf-colour while clerks wait to copy it. What they want is **Valein**, Kept and unmarked in the same household, to stay off the tablet; the verso already knows how to write *unmarked*. They believe delaying the copy is the same as refusing. On the same morning Laevila describes what Rithim will not say into a roll. The First Seat sits in the wood beside them, not as a master they report to weekly.

## Mataero — Orentel

**Mataero** (*mah-TAY-ro*) lets the inland loft of the White Note House — twelve beds, the north bed not to let — and files all of it as occupancy. They did not walk. What they want is **Sorel** off a century-note their mother still carries from a walk Sorel cannot point to; they think a clean loft-slate will buy that. They believe the house is a bank that happens to have rooms. A household Vaethod sent may already owe a bed here. Reimaethe pays a rise-room Mataero writes *let*.

## Thilim — the Third Hearth

**Thilim** (*THIL-im*) keeps the Third Hearth, the third lodging out from the Motherwood on the Near Mile — Long-Lived, inland, notes smaller than the White Note's, shrine larger. They walked the mile as the inn until the stretch was optional and kept making the bed anyway. What they want is the stone's water still feeding the pot when it is dark; Seine's bed is still made. They hold that mouths at dark matter more than paper. Brenthael's warden wants the stone moved. Thilim will not move a name that is also a well.

## Laevila — Maiethlir

**Laevila** (*lay-VEE-lah*) bakes on the old extra-mile, keeps the room under the chapel the wardens recut, and holds the only copy of the beam's hidden face. Long-Lived; they walked as a child under Thaeloren before this river had to count them. What they want is **Senithi**'s name good for a marriage: the hidden face still has the grandmother under her own name, and the roll wrote the household wrong. They tell themselves that if they only describe, they have not chosen sides. Rithim Speaks in the same square. They eat after Night Watch and do not agree what that means.

## Tesara — Orentel

**Tesara** (*teh-SAH-rah*) sits the stillers' shed that does not face the street — a key the slate does not name, success measured in silence. Struck years back, they remember the door from their own catching-week. What they want is **Valen** stamped with a real ticket, not a burned slip. They believe a quiet week means they saved someone. The paying floor wants the master back. Mataero will need a loft if Valen lives without a ticket.

## Named wants in the three seats

Wants sit on people. An institution can furnish or refuse. It cannot *want*.

**Eolvaeth.** Vaethod wants Saelid's stall to keep its winter mouths. **Nedaen** (*neh-DAYN*), Taken-In, wants the gift-hall pot to feed their child through Ledger-month. **Heiral** (*HAY-ral*), Kept, wants a marriage witnessed without being pitied as Mother-kept. **Daron** (*DAR-on*), Returned, wants a specific corpse named so a grain-debt dies with it.

**Orentel.** Mataero wants Sorel off the century-paper. **Sorim** wants berths 1–4 held through Hale-month. Tesara wants Valen stamped. **Lasole** (*lah-SO-leh*) rents a leaf-lot and wants the credit extended one season. **Didel** (*dih-DEL*) of Hallowquay, Selkie, wants a kin-berth for a skin-kin wedding in Eolthael; Sorim has held 1–4 for a First-Hand year.

**Maiethlir.** Rithim wants Valein unfiled. Laevila wants Senithi's name read off the hidden face of a recut beam, once, in a room a clerk will accept as a witness. **Vehaela** (*veh-HAY-lah*) came down from Lirorn's thin snow with two children and wants an uncounted loft for one winter. **Baerith** (*BAY-rith*), Far-Voiced, sings the counted hour and wants the crown to stop cutting green on the street where their sister keeps a pot.

How the squares touch: paper, beds, pots, and one week in Eolthael. A household Vaethod sent sometimes eats now on a White Note necessity-note. Sorim's berth 5 is earth; the pot is going toward a luckier Hand; Haelin will sleep the Road-hand if the wood arrives. Rithim Speaks; Laevila describes the other colour in the same square. Tesara's week, if it is not burned, becomes a person who later

needs a loft or a berth. Thilim still holds a far-cape name the White Note does not. They do not travel to deliver the mismatch.

## Other people of note

Not a second court. Squares that needed a second mouth.

| Person                   | Square                  | The job          | The want that is not a Tree               |
|--------------------------|-------------------------|------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Njunda                   | Ndenjoo                 | table-keeper     | Nolas gone as kin, extra place still laid |
| Ledan                    | the White Note House    | quay-desk        | founding-name spoken once                 |
| Theisva · Lesna · Bovaer | Ornsael                 | well-gang        | a share that lasts Hale-month             |
| Tora · Nethiro · Baelon  | the Three Hamlets       | three kitchens   | send / refuse / not take the other road   |
| Meirim                   | Brenthael               | neighbour-warden | the Third Hearth's stone down             |
| Soonke · Saalo           | Ndenjoo sand / valley   | sit / leave      | wreck off the hill; Waandi found          |
| Thuda                    | the Low Wall garden-end | innkeep          | labour off the garden                     |

**Haelin** (*HAY-lin*) wants the stone moved before Leaf-Fall so the crowd can stand, and water still on it until then. They will not name a colour they are not sure of. **Tora** (*TOR-ah*) of Brenod is here because last year's Brenod child was seen under the canopy and has not been walked home.

**Reimaethe** (*RYE-may-theh*) is a Long-Lived on the rise in Orentel who poured four years into a cup and wants to stop before the fifth. Neighbours call it a rich uncle's hobby. They pay a rise-loft on time. Mataero keeps writing *let* and not *why*.

**Hithaen** (*hith-AYN*) arrived in Eolvaeth's gift-hall this Hale-month with no list behind them. Given; they used to be heir to a house that counts the Kept as the line that may rule. The leaf took that. They want a life that is not a wall-pass. Vaethod has not decided if this mouth came to wait or to be counted.

**Taeren** (*TAY-ren*) is of Brenod, not of Harrow's. Last Eolthael they stood at the neighbour's canopy at Harrow's Green; something white happened, and because a colour that is not civic cannot be walked

home as a witnessing, they are still in the square when Hale-month extra mouths arrive. Heat in the hands they do not show. Ordinary questions.

**Rosire** (*ro-SEER-eh*) is of Orentel, infirmity-tired. They used to bring water at Tesara's shed; this Hale-month they are not on that floor — an upper room at Harrow's Green. They do not talk about travel. They want the person they walked inland with not to become a story, and themselves not sent for.

Ledan still writes the quay-desk. They are a mouth, not a seventh pivot. The four later seeds stay seeds. Do not grow them into a crew.

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BOOK IX

## At the Table



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# Playing in the Turning

How to sit down in this world. Fiction and law stay in their home chapters. This page is the order of operations.

**Tone.** Neighbours and colleagues. A real obstacle underneath. A Tithe never seizes the player character. About five percent scary.

## Making a character

Run this once, in this order. Do not invent a second engine.

1. **Kind.** Stock Daggerheart ancestry, one of the four customs (Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, Yumboe), or Mixed Ancestry as the SRD allows. Rulings sit in *The Kinds*. A Yumboe needs the GM's leave and is always the full Kind.
2. **Community.** As the SRD. A Hearth-Mark is not a Community.
3. **Class, Experiences, equipment.** As the SRD. Two Experiences. A Kept character does not get a third as consolation.
4. **Turning.** Pick one, and write it on the sheet:
  - **Given** — a colour fell at ten. Take one Given-path or Both-path card from *The Conditions*.
  - **Kept** — the leaves hugged. No Condition card. See below.
  - **Struck** — a later door already happened in backstory. Take a Struck-path or Both-path card. You were vouched anew; say who stood.
  - **UnTurned** — you never stood. No hug, no colour. Not Kept. You can still be Struck later. Folk will call you Kept; the law should not.
5. **Special seats (whole table, not one player).**
  - **Phoenix** — spotlight Condition; the other players consent. Or run it as an NPC.
  - **Hidden Phoenix** — a different conversation. Book X.
  - **Yumboe** — GM leave. Full Kind only.
  - **the Unbound** — not a starting pick. You reach it through Bound, in play or arranged at session zero as a Bound whose term already ended.

Kind and Condition **stack**. A Selkie can be Given Two-Bodied. A stock Human can be Struck Returned. Mixed heritage Turns, or is Kept, or is Struck, like anyone else.

They stack even when the fiction rhymes. An **Infernis** who swears a contract is Bound like anyone else. The born blood is Kind; the contract is Condition. They do not merge, cancel, or become Given-Over by default.

## The Kept deal

**Deliberate tradeoff, not a consolation Condition.** The Kept have no boon and no Tithe. That is the card: the empty clock.

What they *do* have: they are the default legal person — witnessed, unguilded, unlicensed. At every long rest they take their downtime without a Tithe checklist. Everyone else may be ticking a clock. That free move is the table advantage. They can still be Struck later. Kept describes a present, not a promise.

What they do *not* get: a tenth Condition, a bonus Experience, a Hearth-Mark they did not already qualify for, or a “Kept feature” that is a Tithe in costume.

UnTurned lives look similar (no Tithe, no guild). Only the hug was witnessed. Do not file them as Kept to be kind.

## Struck in play

A Kept or UnTurned character can be Struck if the fiction crosses a door the roster already names: death (Returned), a sworn contract (Bound), a survivable drowning / gaze-edge / green-taking (Far-Voiced, the Stilled, the Taken-In). Given-only fates (Long-Lived, Two-Bodied, Answered, Phoenix) cannot be Struck.

**Consent.** The player agrees to take the card. The GM does not assign a becoming to punish a failed roll. A Tithe never seizes the character; becoming is not a lose-control event.

When it fires: add the Condition card; Kind stays; they are vouched anew at the next desk that will take them (hazardous doors go to the Intake); they were not Given; there is no leaf and no second Leaf-Fall; they do not stack a second Condition.

A Bound whose term ends becomes the Unbound per that card. That is the only downstream becoming.

## Advancement

Condition cards do not level. The card at 1 is the card at 10. Class features, domain cards, Experiences, weapon tier, Proficiency, and Hope scars change around it. Full ruling in *The Conditions*.

## Travel

You move on a **word**, not a paper-state. A watch asks **name, last hearth, who stands**. Two will do. None, and you sit until morning or you are walked to the next gate.

Customs that count: road-word, company-vouch, guild-mark, house-note, guest-right, walk-custom. Distances: *Climate, Ecology, and Travel*. Kumbaan is not on this grammar; crossing sits in *Other Places* under Ndenjoo and in *The Four Continents*. Sold vouching exists. It is not this custom.

## City witnessing

A village remembers a child. A city remembers a **hearth**. The legal sentence is “I am of the third quay,” not “I am of Orentel.”

Turning-Week is still **one week**. Stands are by hearth, in named slots. The warden Speaks colour or hug. They do not write a roll of gifts. Threnmaieth writes the stand down. That is the aberration.

## Crime

There is no crime of *being* a Condition. The Inviolable Will already sorts the charge: negligent Tithe-lapse versus willful weaponizing.

Ladder: **neighbour-word** → **watch (hold till morning)** → **guild-hearing** → **open hearing**. Exile from the hearth is the civic death. Tickets name a hazardous *use* (Gaze, Cry, element in a yard), not a Condition. Bound is a table, not a fourth body-licence.

## Leaf-Fall edge cases

The load-bearing sentences, for when you cannot open *The Turning Tree*:

- The Given-door is **one week** in the tenth year.
- A completed standing (colour or hug, sound wood) is **once**.
- A miss, refusal, or week spent under unsound wood makes a child **unTurned**, not Kept.
- Struck remains the later mercy.
- You may correct a Speaking. You may not rerun a fall.
- White-fire is sent to the First Seat. A town-warden does not guess Phoenix.

## Starting situations

One door each. Not a tour. The leftover job on the street is the hook.

**Eolvaeth.** A send-year. Vaethod will not invent a colour. Saelid's stall needs winter mouths. A gift-hall stranger with no list. The wait as destination.

**Orentel.** Empty Eolthael berths. A White Note term that is not a hull and not a hold. Tesara's shed that does not face the street. A fade two streets off the third quay.

**Maiethlir.** A thaw that is loud the week before Leaf-Fall. A Speaker who will not say the line. A recut chapel. A channel that can be shut.

**Harrow's Green.** Hale-month, C.Y. 387. The stone needs moving so the crowd can stand. Water still on it. A neighbour's week that can walk home. Extra mouths. A live front, not a capital.

**Ornsael.** The well is dropping. The share is chalked on the lip. Core pilgrims expecting a holiday. A wet knot below last year's water-line.

**the Three Hamlets.** Send, refuse, or take the other road. The canopy is a dark on the far slope. Same week as Harrow's.

**the Third Hearth.** Seine's bed is made. Brenthael wants the stone down. Mouths at dark. A name that is also a well.

**Ndenjoo.** A wreck walked uphill. The extra place already set. Noon-noise. No Tree.

## Tone at the table

Neighbours, colleagues, family. The Tithe is the edge. The Leaf-Fall is warm. Dread does not live in the Tree. A wrongness beat, when you need one, is weather, leftover hospitality, a week that already closed, or a person who missed the door — not an eerie Hand.

Do not stock a second vampire, a cursed wolf-kin, or a hungry dead that is not a Returned. The monsters are already people.

## Sample frames

Short shapes that use two clocks and do not treat the Years of Hands as post-history.

**A live Grafting town.** Harrow's Green, or the hamlets looking at its canopy. Necessity on the street. A pot that may or may not arrive. Someone still sending; someone who thinks the wave is over lives two weeks away and cannot see the square.

**A quay with a White Note.** Orentel. Prestige as a product that takes three desks (a Night-Shore hull, a White Note term, an Orentel hold). Necessity in the loft. Ledan asks which count you want.

**An origin-town under a roll.** Maiethlir. Extra mile layered, not replaced. A Speaker who will not copy. A Watcher who will describe. The First Seat in the wood beside, able to refuse.

**A hill-hall beyond the wall.** Ndenjoo. Hospitality is the rite. The storm-wall is the climate. Play kin and wreck. Do not play a proof of what the Trees are.

A campaign opening that uses a remnant-walker, an inside helper, and an isolated white-fire fall is a GM kit. Book X.

## Dangers on the road

Settlements already have things that enter a scene (a cohort, a crane, a well-mouth). This is the country between those doors.

Start battle points from the SRD:  $[(3 \times \text{PCs}) + 2]$ . Spend: Minion group 1 · Support/Social 1 · Horde/Ranged/Skulk/Standard 2 · Leader 3 · Bruiser 4 · Solo 5. Benchmarks: Tier 1 Difficulty 11, thresholds 7/12, ATK +1; Tier 2 Difficulty 14, 10/20, ATK +2.

| Name                     | Tier / type | Where it lives                               | What it wants                           |
|--------------------------|-------------|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| <b>Gap-Cat</b>           | T1 Skulk    | Rain-Wall shelves, Heskoren ridge, mile-gaps | A quiet kill and the high rock back     |
| <b>Chart-Crew</b>        | T1 Horde    | Chart-run, Night Shore, West Water wrecks    | The hull that did not arrive — or yours |
| <b>Bed-Keeper</b>        | T1 Leader   | Empty road-houses on the Long Mile           | The bed occupied. You staying.          |
| <b>Spent-Week Walker</b> | T2 Standard | Long Mile, west-road, live-front tracks      | To finish a week that already closed    |
| <b>Colourless Host</b>   | T2 Support  | Dead pots, unsound grafts, waiting ground    | To Give. It cannot.                     |

None of these are Conditions. A walker may *be* Conditioned the way anyone is.

**Mile-gap** (T1 Traversal, Difficulty 12). The day's walk between two stones. Impulses: stretch the day, hide the next stone, offer a false bed, make a Tithe expensive. Travel rolls to find the next shrine are Difficulty 12; failure with Fear ends the day in the gap.

**Thaw-gate** (T1 Traversal, Difficulty 13). Shelf-gate or Noon Pass in a thaw-week. Crossing without a guide is Difficulty 13. Failure: swept, or a cart lost — not both on one roll.

**Empty road-house** (T1 Exploration, Difficulty 11). A road-house that kept the upper room after the walk ended. Guest-right is a week. Leaving before morning without a word is a slight the next shrine will hear.

**Night-berth** (T1 Exploration, Difficulty 12). A Chart-run or West Water quay at first dark. Hulls that do not arrive are local weather.

Pairing: Long Mile inland — mile-gap and a Gap-Cat. Long Mile leftover — empty road-house and a Bed-Keeper. Rain-Wall — thaw-gate; weather is enough. Chart-run — night-berth and a Chart-Crew. Dead pot on the live front — a Colourless Host as Support, not a second Host. Near Mile — use the town's "enters a scene." Storm-wall — not this layer.

A Colourless Host is horticulture gone wrong, or a pot that never took. Skeptics and believers can both be loud. The book does not settle it.

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BOOK X

For the GM

# GM Canon

The table does not start knowing this. Read the world first if you want to meet it as a player would.

This chapter holds the **keystone**: what is actually true, whether anyone in the world can prove it. The Leaf-Mother is real and benevolent. Skeptics are sincere, and wrong about the mind. If a campaign ever confirms her, it lands as warmth.

## GM only: Conditions

A **Tithe** is a Condition's upkeep. Its dangerous edge is story pressure, never a gotcha and never a seizure of the player's character. Consequences land on the Conditioned person's own body, memory, Stress, or immediate surroundings unless a feature explicitly says otherwise. Nobody's will is bent.

- **Long-Lived.** “Go still” (starved memory ending in true death) is not a death move. It is a slow, tragic off-ramp the player can see coming for several rests. Use it as story pressure: a Long-Lived NPC found statue-still in a sealed archive, not a sudden kill. Blood-Read (a true memory in one drop of blood) is investigative and emotional: the dead man's last sight; why a witness lies. Never feeding, never damage, never a drain. The threshold courtesy is pure roleplay. A Long-Lived *can* cross uninvited if they truly must; they simply never do, and the manners run bone-deep. Do not let a table weaponize either into “the vampire rules.”
- **Two-Bodied.** The forced shift is timing and inconvenience, never control. The inner voice is a roleplay partner, not a second player: it can want, argue, sulk, and celebrate, but it never rolls, never acts, and never overrides a choice. If a table finds the animal “made me do it,” pull it back to nagging. Hold the line on size, no-myth, and no hands / no person's mind / no speech / no tools, so a Two-Bodied out-animals a Tengu or an Answered without out-personing them.
- **Returned.** Refuse to Fall is “hard to keep down,” not immortality: a scar every time, out of the current scene, back by the next long rest. When the last Hope slot would go, they cannot come back. A lapsed Purpose is quiet crisis, not punishment. **Whose hand:** a Returned is Struck by the Quiet Tally (*Threnvaeth*), the household clerk of leftover purpose, under the Leaf-Mother's allowance. She does not Give this at the Tree; she authorizes the catch. The unfinished business is still *theirs*; Threnvaeth does not puppet the Purpose. Do not put that in player-facing text.



- **Bound.** The Whisper is strictly suggestive: plausible lies and intrusive thoughts the player can reject at a Stress cost. Never puppet the PC. The Pledge is a known, dreaded horizon toward the Unbound, not a surprise. **Whose hand:** the Counterparty is **Orledd**, the household Hand who answers a sworn ask. The face chosen at creation (demon / cosmic-horror / unknown) is a mask; the terms are the same shape. Do not play Orledd as a devil, and do not retcon Given Conditions into bargains.
- **The Unbound.** The Quiet is a temptation engine, not a compulsion: every “reach for the bargain” beat is refusable at a Stress cost. The tragedy to play toward: an Unbound who stops connecting gets loud inside, signs again to quiet it, pays another Pledge, and slides toward the Given-Over (the Unbound end-state). Warmth is the only thing that actually fills the hole; contracts only mute it.
- **Far-Voiced.** The Cry is a feeling landing on listeners. Stress, never a forced action or belief. A Struck Far-Voiced’s first Cry, pre-guild, is a formative beat, not a punishment. A Given Far-Voiced in deep Tithe-debt (0 tokens, on duty, in a courtroom or relay tower) is a slow-building set-piece.
- **The Stilled.** The Gaze is an attack against an unwilling target (Instinct or Presence). Willing and downed targets take no roll. **Stilled** is a special condition, not Restrained: no actions or reactions; they can speak, be moved, and be targeted; they may mark a Stress to clear it when they would act. The seizing (Grey at 3 tokens) is strictly self-directed: the Stilled’s own limb, or harmless scenery, never another PC’s autonomy. A Struck Stilled’s first, unpracticed Gaze (probably on someone they love, probably by accident) is formative. A Given Stilled deep in Grey-debt on a riot line or in an operating theatre is a slow-building set-piece.
- **The Answered.** Every 0-token consequence stays on the Answered and their immediate surroundings. Let the chosen element define the character’s whole voice (an Ember-Answered feels nothing like a Root-Answered). One of the Answered deep in Tithe-debt walking into a crowded hall, a ship’s hold, or a dry archive is a slow-building set-piece.
- **The Taken-In.** Go-to-seed is strictly environmental: growth from ground and structures, never roots seizing another creature. A Struck Taken-In’s uncertainty (“did I walk out, or was I sent?”) is quiet identity dread, not a hidden puppet-string. The wild in them is *part of them*, not a master. One dragged deep into a dungeon, a ship’s hold, or a stone keep and left to wilt is a slow-building set-piece.
- **Phoenix.** Run two engines together. The **count:** let everyone watch the Hope slots go; each rising costs something the player feels (a face, a reason they started). The **fishbowl:** never anonymous; every town has those who revere, worship, hunt, and hate them, often the same crowd. Never force a Rise; it is always the player’s death-move choice alongside the standard three. A Phoenix may choose Blaze of Glory and end if the story earns it. The fire boons are strong on purpose: compensation for a life with no privacy and a death you can count down to. As a legendary NPC, rebirths make era-markers (the same soul, met three times, remembering the party less each time).

## GM only: Peoples

Distribution is a reach-tell only for the Yumboes. Mainland Kind-hearths (a Kind's home ecology, not a nation) are mundane geography: foxes in woods, seals on coasts, crows on ridges. Kumbaan's isolation is the one Kind-fact that also maps the keystone edge: no Tree, no Gift, a people who are themselves without her. Do not let a player-facing read treat "Yumboes have no Conditions" as a racial immunity. It is a place fact.

Do not grow Kind-nations later. If a later settlement wants a "fox principality," make it a Rain-Shadow polity that happens to be Fox-dense, running on the same theology / reach / governance axes as everyone else. The moment a government is *for* a Kind, the two-layer model (Kind born, Condition acquired, stacked) has started to rot.

The lost fourth Fox is a grandmother's word, not a plot coupon. If you ever spend it, spend it as folklore that stayed when a hearth died (a vanished dry-lake, a wood that was cut), not as a secret ancestry feature waiting in a drawer.

Two names is a Kind × place tell, not a secret identity. Players should hear it in ordinary introductions. A few smaller things stay unexplained. The lost fourth Fox-word. A Yumboe who does take a mainland byname has decided to stay. A Threnmaieth clerk who refuses to record hearth-names is doing the roll: it wants one name only.

Each polity's vocabulary is its self-justification, not the truth of what it does. Threnmaieth's "keeping-whole" (**Threnhael**) is surveillance that calls itself care. Lestrands "the free" for the **Kept** (hugged by the Tree, no colour, no Condition Given) is a market reframing a social slight as a virtue. Vaethorn's "the Waited" wraps real pity in reverence. None of these framings is dissolved by confirming the Mother. They are how each society launders its own injustice, and a kind Mother does not make any of the three names honest.

The word-box and the how-to live in Language and Naming. The sound-system and what the linguistics words mean live under **GM only: Language**.

## GM only: Language

Language and Naming is where you name a person, mint a new one, glue a hall, and look up what a land calls a building. Keep that chapter as the how-to.

This section is the hard machinery: what the linguistics words mean, which sounds sit in which mouth, and the regular sound-change that makes a name wear the same way every time. Use it when you need a name that still belongs, and the lists are not enough. Do not teach it at the table.

## **What the linguistics words mean**

Linguists have names for things everyone already does with speech. Here they are in this world's terms.

| Word                              | What it means here                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Root</b>                       | The smallest chunk of meaning. <i>oren</i> means “to witness.” You glue roots to make names.                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Lexicon</b>                    | The word-box. The list of roots you are allowed to build from. The old-word table in Language and Naming is the lexicon.                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Compound</b>                   | Two roots glued. <b>Thaeloren</b> is <i>thael</i> (Tree) + <i>oren</i> (witness).                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Etymology</b>                  | Where a name comes from. Players hear a pretty word. You know it means “the Tree that witnesses.”                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Phonology</b>                  | Which sounds this mouth uses, and which it will not. English has <i>th</i> ; many languages do not. Kusawe has <i>sh</i> and no <i>th</i> .                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Syllable</b>                   | One beat of sound. <i>Ra-ki</i> is two syllables.                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>CV / CVC</b>                   | A recipe for a beat. <b>C</b> = a consonant, <b>V</b> = a vowel. CV is <i>ra</i> . CVC is <i>tek</i> . CVF in Kusawe means the beat may end on n, m, or r.                                                                                                          |
| <b>Stress</b>                     | The beat you hit harder. CAPS marks it: thae-LOR-en.                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>Digraph</b>                    | Two letters, one sound. <i>ae</i> is not “a” then “e.” It is “ay” as in <i>day</i> . Same for <i>ei</i> (eye) and <i>eo</i> (ay-oh).                                                                                                                                |
| <b>Onset</b>                      | The consonant or cluster at the start of a beat. <i>Kr</i> in <i>Kukra</i> is an onset. <i>Tengu</i> likes those. <i>Kitsune</i> does not.                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Prenasal</b>                   | A hum before a stop: <i>mb</i> , <i>nd</i> , <i>nk</i> , <i>nj</i> . <i>Yumboe</i> uses them. The Old Tongue does not.                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Register</b>                   | A mouth used for a job, not a whole language. Church-speech vs street-speech. Kusawe is the fox hearth-register: given names and in-group talk. Do not write sentences in it.                                                                                       |
| <b>Liturgical / Old Tongue</b>    | The church language, <b>Maiethren</b> . Like Latin: nobody’s first language at the market, still used for the rite and for old names.                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Vernacular / common tongue</b> | What people actually say day to day. Worn-down Old Tongue. <i>The Kept</i> , <i>the ranging</i> , <i>tree-wardens</i> .                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Daughter language / drift</b>  | When one language splits into regional versions. Spanish, French, and Italian all come from Latin. <i>Threnmaieth</i> , <i>Vaethorn</i> , and <i>Lestrand</i> all come from <i>Maiethren</i> . They did not invent new tongues. They wore the same one differently. |

| Word                | What it means here                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Conservative</b> | A mouth that kept the old sounds. Threnmaieth still says <i>th</i> .                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Worn</b>         | A mouth that softened them. Vaethorn still has <i>th</i> , but it is gentler, and endings simplify. Everyday <b>Wethorn</b> .                                                                                           |
| <b>Eroded</b>       | A mouth that sanded sounds off. Lestrand dropped <i>th</i> to <i>t</i> or <i>d</i> , or dropped it.                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Sound-change</b> | A regular swap, not a one-off. If <i>th</i> becomes <i>t</i> on the docks, it does that in every word, not just one. That is why you can push any old word through the same rule and it will still sound like Lestrand. |

You do not need the rest of a linguistics toolkit. There is no grammar to learn. No sentences in Kusawe, Sakoa, or Gonan. If a scene needs an in-group word, coin one word from that Kind's sounds and say what it means.

## The Old Tongue's mouth

Warm and weighty. A hall-and-hearth tongue. Liquids and nasals (*l r m n*) carry the warmth. *Th* and long vowels carry the weight. No harsh piles of consonants, so it stays sayable.

**Sounds it uses.** Consonants: *m n, l r w j, p t k, b d g, f v s h*, and *th* as in *thin*. Vowels: *a e i o u*, plus the digraphs *ae, ei, eo*.

**Sounds it does not use.** Prenasals (*mb nd nj*). Hard front clusters like *kr* and *gr* (those are Tengu). *Sh* is a fox sound, not a church sound.

**How to say it.** Same key as Language and Naming. CAPS is stress. *th* as in *thin*, never as in *the*. Stress usually on the second beat.

The word-box (the lexicon) is the old-word table in Language and Naming. Glue one or two roots. Then wear the compound the way the land wears it.

## How an old word wears in each land

One Tree, grafts carried out. One old tongue, names wearing down as they travel. Linguists would call Threnmaieth, Vaethorn, and Lestrand **daughter languages**: three children of Maiethren. In this book they are three mouths.

The sound-changes are regular. Push any old word through the same rule.

| Mouth               | Land                            | What happens to the sounds                                                                      | How it feels                                                                       |
|---------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Conservative</b> | Threnmaieth,<br>pious Maiethorn | Almost nothing. <i>Th</i> and long vowels kept whole.                                           | Archaic, formal, holy. Sounds like the rite because it barely moved from it.       |
| <b>Worn</b>         | Vaethorn,<br>Heskoren folk      | <i>Th</i> stays but softens (Vaethorn → Wethorn). Endings simplify. Vowels flatten.             | Rough-warm folk-speech that still reaches for the old holy words.                  |
| <b>Eroded</b>       | Lestrand,<br>Strandoren docks   | <i>Th</i> becomes t or d, or drops. Long vowels clip. Word-ends wear off. Trade-words sneak in. | Smooth, clipped, mercantile. The most worn name belongs to the least-devout place. |

Worked examples of the same rule:

- *thael* + *oren* kept whole is **Thaeloren** (the Awakening Tree). Worn everyday: **the Thallow**.
- *vaeth* + *orn* kept with *th* is **Vaethorn**. Everyday **Wethorn**.
- *ledd* + *strand* with the *th* already gone is **Lestrand**.
- *thren* + *maieth* kept whole is **Threnmaieth**. The same *thren* worn to *Tren* is **Trenledd**: the sacred count with the sacred sanded off.
- *oren* + *thael* with the *th* dropped is **Orentel**, the salt-quay seat.

A devout river-town on a thaw: *maieth* + *lir* = **Maiethlir**, *th* kept. Do not invent a fourth human mouth.

A named power uses these roots and the right mouth. Vaelhesk keeps older *vael* and frontier *hesk*.

That is still this family, worn further. Kumbaen is not in this family.

## Why the mouths sit where they sit (GM)

In-world, people will tell you names wear down with distance and trade. That is true as far as it goes. The deeper pull that keeps the old sound near the Trees is the Mother's nearness. Same fact, two readings. Do not assert the deeper one in player-facing text.

History adds a mundane mechanism you can play: the pilgrimage itself was a conserving pull. Far mouths walked to the same grove each year, so the old sound got refreshed. Local Trees let the daughters grow in place. Hands-era weather on a Walking-era root.

**Thaeloren** = “the Tree that witnesses” is not decoration. She is real, and the Leaf-Fall is her seeing each child. The language keeps a truth the skeptics have explained away. Do not gloss it in player-facing text as mere poetry. Let a scholar-PC notice it, or save it for a reveal beat. Do not front-load it.

## The four Kind mouths

Each custom Kind has a **register**: a closed set of sounds for given names and in-group talk. Not a language you write sentences in. The lists in Language and Naming are what you pick from. These inventories are how you mint a new one that still belongs.

**Kitsune: Kusawe** (koo-SAH-way). Light, slipping, a little hissy.

| Consonants | k s sh n r m t w y f h                                             |
|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vowels     | a i u e o, and <i>ai</i> as in <i>eye</i>                          |
| Beats      | CV, or CV ending on n/m/r. Two or three beats.                     |
| Do not use | <i>th</i> (church), <i>mb/nd/nj</i> (Yumboe), <i>kr/gr</i> (Tengu) |

**Selkie: Sakoa** (sah-KOH-ah). Liquid, rounded, coastal.

| Consonants | l r n m s v f d b k w                                  |
|------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Vowels     | o u a i e, and <i>ea</i> , <i>oa</i>                   |
| Beats      | CV or CVC. Two or three beats.                         |
| Do not use | <i>th</i> , <i>sh</i> , <i>kr/gr</i> , <i>mb/nd/nj</i> |

**Tengu: Gonan** (GO-nan). Clipped, windy, high-country. Not the same mouth as Kusawe. That is the trap: two folklore-Japanese Kinds collapsing into one sound.

| Consonants | k t g n r h s b d. Front clusters <i>kr</i> , <i>gr</i> , <i>hr</i> are at home. |
|------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vowels     | a o u e. Few <i>i</i> (that vowel lives with the foxes).                         |
| Beats      | CVC or CV. One to three beats, prefer two.                                       |
| Do not use | <i>th</i> , <i>sh</i> , <i>mb/nd/nj</i> , long <i>ai/ea/oa</i>                   |

**Yumboe**. Not Maiethren. Open vowels, a drum-like rhythm, prenasals *mb nd nk nj*. Their own name *Bakhna Rakhna*, homeland *Kumbaen*. Do not put a *th* in it. Do not clip it down to a dock-name.

A name that bleeds across registers is a tell. A Selkie named Wishi, or a Tengu named Maethaem, was raised away, adopted, or is passing. Use it on purpose or not at all.

If the first fox-name that comes to mind is Yuki, throw it back. Same for Morag on a Selkie and Kenji on a Tengu. Pick from the middle of the existing list, or build from the inventory above until it could sit next to Raki, Lavo, or Teku without anyone blinking.

The player recipe stays in Language and Naming: pick from a list, or use **To make another**, or glue two old words and wear them for the land. The inventories above are the same mouths written as sound-lists, so a new name can be checked against the rule instead of the ear. The sound-change table is how you push any old word through a land without inventing a fourth human mouth. Do not write sentences in Kusawe or Gonan. Deep grammar stays off the table.

## GM only: Society and Faiths

**The Leaf-Mother is real, and she is benevolent, but her reach is not infinite, and giving costs her.**

She exists. The Turning Trees are genuinely her hands; when a Tree chooses, *she* is choosing. The Conditions are real gifts; the Leaf-Fall is an act of love; the Tithe is the honest weight of a gift, not a hidden price or a trap. She is bounded, not boundless. She cannot lay a hand on every child, cannot reach every threshold in time, and cannot give without spending. The limit is real. She is doing her best against it.

The Kept are spared, and some are simply past her edge. A hug and no colour is, for most, a deliberate and kind choice: the gift of being left whole. But the constraint means the Kept are *not all one thing*. Some are chosen for wholeness, and some are children she could not reach far enough to give to this turning, held safe rather than gifted. She does not tell them apart, and neither can they. Both are held; not both are chosen.

The Struck are still hers, at the farthest reach of her arm. She **Gives** at the Tree; she does **not** Strike. The catch at the door is enacted by lesser gods of her household, each restricted to one door, working under her allowance. The Struck are still hers because those hands are *hers to send*. **Narrow-Hand** (she Gives only at the Tree) is right about that limit. **Wide-Hand** (those means are still hers: her household, her allowance, her catch at the edge) is right about belonging. Neither holds the whole.

**R2** (the second guardrail): **her benevolence does not dissolve injustice**. Her kindness is cosmological, not social. She authored the gifts; she did **not** author the injustice built on top of them. The Watchful kingdom's register, unvouched-Struck suspicion, Bound over-watching, guild conscription of the Given, Tithe-need as leverage, the Kept pitied, the Given-Over's lost personhood, the scion-queue, the recut lintel, the book that will not close, the host of a dying guest, the sentence that will not travel, the week that will not end, the gate, the scheduled hour, the Grey as labor, the shop you cannot leave, the week no one writes: these are **not misreadings of a kindness to be dissolved by the reveal**. They are the moral spine of the setting. If a campaign ever confirms she is real and kind, that must **not** retroactively make the society just. The keystone answers *is anyone there, and do they*



*mean well* (yes); it pointedly does not answer *is what people built around her fair* (often no). Protect that gap. That is where the play is.

The three corners do not share a mechanism of injustice. They share only that people built them. Vaethorn's guilt-theology of unworthiness, Lestrاند's let-the-poor-fade market, Threnmaieث's sanctified census: confirming she is kind does not make *any* of these three fair. Rival faiths can be *used* as leverage; they are not automatically the moral good because they dissent. Confirming she is kind does not dissolve Threnmaieث's counting of heretics, Lestrاند's priced fading, or Vaethorn's guilt-theology.

**The household is still GM-only.** She is first of a household: she Gives; lesser Hands Strike at restricted doors under her allowance. Do not confirm this in player-facing text. The Open Table's staying-kin are **not** of that household. Do not absorb Kumbaan.

**Each rival holds a true kernel and misses the whole.**

- The Watching correctly remembers a *Before* and a *cost*, and a household before it was named Mother. They miss that the seeing is hers. The Masked reading (she is a later face) and the Bare Tree reading (there was never a she) are both playable. Neither is the answer. The lintel is a clue, not a verdict. The cost they remember is real; *what* was spent is still open. Do not give them a seat in a late reveal. That would turn the heretics into a second Motherfaith. The warmth lands *through* them, not *as* them.
- The Fair Hand is right about Bound (there *is* a Counterparty) and wrong that every becoming is a bargain. Mother's Gifts are still gifts. They misread a cost as a price. They have correctly felt that giving is not free. Do not play them as devil-worship. Do not let a Book-hand retcon a Given child into a debtor. Do not let a Book-hand rewrite the Counterparty's clause. A petition-watch is keeping the door; it is not acolyte-authority.
- The Old Ways are right that land-doors are real. They miss that she authorized the guests. Keep their grievance real (the grafts *are* late; the Motherfaith *did* talk as if becoming were new). Keep their miss intact. Ancestor-meals are not the Returned. The dead in the ground are kin who remained. The Returned are a different door.
- The Open Table is the cleanest experiment: no Gifts, rare Struck, a faith that was never hers. Their claim (*we were never lacking*) is still a late beat. Not ghosts. The unseen hands are furniture. "No one is a stranger twice" is courtesy with legal weight on the isle, a proverb on the quay: not a geas (a binding spell), not a trap-cult, not a Fair Hand contract. A wreck is not a Struck-door she authorized.

If a campaign ever works toward the keystone, the three old corners are the Watching, the Old Ways, and the Open Table: pre-Mother, pre-graft, and never-grafted. The Fair Hand is the *modern* misreading (commerce wearing a theology). Use all four; don't let one become the reveal-mouthpiece.

**The Tree is player-facing but keystone-adjacent.** The graft continuity (“every Tree is literally the one Tree’s hand”) is the physical fact that, followed to its end, confirms she is real and present. Present it as doctrine the faithful hold, never as demonstrated cosmology. Skeptics grant the grafting and deny the mind. Resist making the Tree eerie or the ceremony sinister. Dread lives in individual Tithes, not in the rite.

**The schism is the reusable engine.** The three questions (Kept, Struck, mind) are inexhaustible fuel for NPCs, factions, and family drama. Do not let a player-facing scene award the win to either branch. Believers see the hand and miss the edge; skeptics see the edge and miss the hand. The world is built so being a skeptic costs nothing day to day, which keeps the schism *poignant* rather than *ironic*.

**The Child at Four Doors.** The paradox is the point. The child cannot pick without already having been claimed, and cannot be claimed without picking. Each faith resolves the unbearable middle by making *their* door the one that was always open. None of the last lines is the true cosmology. The true cosmology is: a mother reached, at cost, and did not reach everyone the same way. The fable will not say that. Which ending an NPC offers is a faster stance-read than a speech about doctrine. Do not write an official fifth door. Do not close the keystone in a children’s story. Reserve the warmth for the confirming beat, if it ever comes.

**The Orenhael** (tree-wardens as an order) **are right about the wood and incomplete about the hand.** Every scion (a grafted town Tree) is continuous tissue of the one Tree, and when any warden speaks a colour they are naming a choice she made. Present them as competent neighbours, not as people who secretly know. A skeptic town-warden is *good at the job* and wrong about the mind. The queue is the parallax, not the Tree: the Seat sees soil and carrying-earth; the hamlet past the ford sees another year of borrowed Turnings. Which town gets the next graft is still a human rationing of her reach. Threnmaith must not capture the Seat in the first sentence. Proximity is pressure, not ownership.

**The Slide.** They do not know what story they are in. They think they are in a rent-and-credit story. They want *continuity of the week*, not a victim they relish. A corpse is a ruined asset. Play them as patient, useful, and sure they helped. The town is complicit; do not make the week-keeper the only villain. Official Tithe-infra and the licence-guilds are the public / posted / counted version of furnishing. This house is the overflow those guilds pretend not to know. Off-book Bound brokerage and sold vouching stay nameless. They do not rewrite Terms, steal scions, or sell a false Turning-witness.

**Official halls and greens.** They think they are in a wells-and-yards story. They want a town that does not wilt, Cry, or seize in the square. They do not want a client. Every closed gate feeds a week-book. Comfort: the words *share, hour, ticket, enough*. She gave the Tithe; she did not build the lot.

**Greens-Keepers.** They want a *living lot*, not a client. A wilt on the lot is a ruined commons. A wilt off the lot is weather they have decided not to see. The buried leaf is how the lot remembers; a PC who

digs it up has committed a local rudeness, not found a cosmology. The bed-slate is plants. If it is already a quiet census, that is Threnmaieth leaking, not the world's baseline.

**Hall-Keepers.** One lintel is the point. Far-Voiced are the seam Condition. The unswept bench is how the hall remembers; do not explain which Cry.

**Stillers.** They want a street that does not seize and a patient who lives. They do not want a register of the feared. Forever-hold of a *person* is ordinary violent crime, the code's one named horror. The Gaze never seizes a will. The doorknob is practical (a still knob is a tell), not a relic. Ticket-as-property is Lestrاند's live argument, not world-law.

**Element-Guilds.** Four doors, one grammar. They want work that slakes and a room that does not let go. The last coal / yesterday's water / unwashed clay / unshut window are practical and not explained. Gale-Tengu is a lean. Ember-Drakona is a lean. Leans are not chapters.

**The Intake.** They want a quiet week. They do not want a client, a relic, or a route. Success is burned. Given children got a childhood the Struck will never get. Travel is accidental, not a circuit: a runner toward *this* person. Bound / Taken-In / Returned / Two-Bodied / Long-Lived are the wrong office.

**The reach-edge stays GM-side as *cause*.** Vaethorn's high Kept/Struck rates, Lestrاند's and Threnmaieth's dense Given, the core-vs-frontier medicine gap: all read in-world as plain distance-and-biology (the skeptics' whole case). The real reason (her reach is bounded and thins where the Trees are thin) stays GM-side. Don't let a player-facing beat assert the cause. Vaethorn is the sharpest test of this: they are the place where a devout population *most wants* an explanation for the thin gift, and where the wrong (true) answer would land hardest.

**Names encode the R2 guard, per polity.** Each polity's vocabulary is its *self-justification*, not the truth of what it does. Threnmaieth's "keeping-whole" (Threnhael) is surveillance that calls itself care; Lestrاند's "the free" for the Kept is a market reframing a social slight as a virtue; Vaethorn's "the Waited" wraps real pity in reverence. None of these framings is dissolved by the reveal.

**The Long-Lived marriage** is the setting's quietest, most reusable ache. Reserve it for weight.

**The cold embrace** is a diagnostic and a hook. A Returned whose embrace has gone cold is a quiet family crisis.

**Whoever furnishes a provided-for Tithe holds power over its bearer.** That is the sharpest economic lever. Coercion with a friendly face: the scary edge in economic form.

Player-facing notes keep her unproven. Skeptics have their full dignity. Never let a player-facing beat confirm the Mother; the confirmation is the GM's to place, and it should land as *warmth and relief with an ache under it*, not horror. There is no harvest, no betrayal waiting to be uncovered. The floor is sound: bounded, costly, and grieving, but sound.

# Appendix: GM Canon

Player-facing notes keep her unproven. This appendix is what is actually true, regardless of what anyone in the world believes.

## The Leaf-Mother

**Yes. The Leaf-Mother is real, and she is benevolent, but her reach is not infinite, and giving costs her.**

- She **exists**: a genuine, present power, not a metaphor and not a dead god whose name survived her.
- The **Turning Trees are genuinely her hands**. The town scions are not a natural phenomenon that people *read* as divine; they really are how she reaches into the world. When a Tree chooses, *she* is choosing.
- The **Conditions are real gifts**. The Leaf-Fall is an act of love: she looks at a child and gives them a becoming that the world will need and that they can carry. The Tithe is the honest weight of a gift, not a hidden price or a trap.
- **She is bounded, not boundless**. She is kind *and* finite. Her reach has an edge, and every gift she gives costs her something to give. She cannot lay a hand on every child, cannot reach every threshold in time, and cannot give without spending. This is not a flaw hidden under the warmth. It is *why* the warmth aches. A mother who could save everyone and didn't would be sinister. A mother who saves whom she can reach, at cost, and grieves the rest, is the one this world actually has. **The limit is real. She is doing her best against it.**
- **The Kept are spared, and some are simply past her edge**. A hug and no colour is, for most, a deliberate and kind choice: the gift of being left whole, wanted in its own right, not a failure or an oversight. But the constraint means the Kept are *not all one thing*. Some are chosen for wholeness, and some are children she could not reach far enough to give to this turning, held safe rather than gifted. She does not tell them apart for us, and neither can they. Both are held; not both are chosen.
- **The Struck are still hers, at the farthest reach of her arm**. A becoming that arrives through a later threshold (a drowning, an oath, a death survived) is not a Condition that "escaped her." She meets people at those doors too, but the threshold is the *edge* of her reach, not her ordinary hand. There she *catches* rather than gives: it is chancier, costlier, and not always in time. This is why the Struck feel "received" yet arrive without ceremony, and why they can feel a half-step outside the fold. They were reached for at the limit, not gifted at the centre.

She **Gives** at the Tree; she does **not** Strike. The catch at the door is enacted by **lesser gods of her household**, each restricted to one door, working under her allowance. The Struck are still hers because

those hands are *hers to send*. Narrow-Hand and Wide-Hand are both half-right.

So: **the believers are right about the big things**. She is real, she is kind, the gifts are gifts. And the skeptics, though wrong that *no one is there*, are **not entirely wrong**; they have correctly felt the *edge*, the Kept who seem passed over, the Struck who arrive unmet by ceremony, the sense that the giving is not seamless. There **is** a seam; they have simply mislabelled a *limit* as an *absence*. No one in the world holds the whole shape. Believers see the hand and miss the edge; skeptics see the edge and miss the hand. The faith is, underneath everything, **true, and incomplete in exactly the way its own doubters sense**.

The world keeps her as **belief, not confirmed cosmology** in-fiction. No one can *prove* her, revelation is quiet, and honest skeptics remain honest.

## How it surfaces

Because she is quiet and genuinely kind, revelation gathers as things fitting together, not as a single gotcha. Rough order of escalating certainty:

1. **The gifts fit too well.** Over a lifetime, a town notices that the Conditions Given tend to be the ones that town will *need*, as if something is looking ahead. Easy to dismiss as hindsight and counting only the gifts that worked (and the skeptics do).
2. **The Kept are cared for, not skipped.** Many Kept report the ceremony felt like a *choice made for them*, not an absence, but not all, and the difference nags. Hard to falsify; easy to call sentiment. Both readings are *true of different Kept* (some chosen, some past her edge), which is exactly why the testimony never resolves cleanly.
3. **The reach has an edge.** The quiet, best evidence of the constraint: remote hamlets far from any mature Tree run higher on the Kept and higher on the Struck; a Tree strains and a child goes ungifted where a central town's would not; the giving visibly *thins* where the Trees are thin. Reads mundanely as distance-and-biology (the skeptics' whole case), but it is the shape of a *bounded hand*, not an absent one. That the reach has *grown* with the grafts is itself the quiet argument that a hand, not a climate, is behind it.
4. **A Tree does something a phenomenon shouldn't.** Rare, quiet moments where a scion acts with apparent *intent* (withholds a colour that would have doomed a child; a scion "reaches," and sometimes visibly *strains*, for a specific person). Never flashy. Always deniable.
5. **The Struck are met, barely.** Testimony from the Struck that the threshold felt *received*, as if someone reached for them from the far side of the door, but late, or thin, or at the very limit of arriving at all. The strongest experiential evidence *and* the clearest felt-sense of the edge; still only testimony.
6. **The confirming beat.** If the campaign ever truly confirms her, it should land as *warmth and relief with an ache under it*, not horror. The answer to "is anyone there?" is *yes, she meant it kindly, and*

*she is doing what she can against a limit.* Reserve this; the setting works better with it withheld.

## What players will think first

- **“It’s just what the Trees do.”** The skeptic’s reading: biology/phenomenon, no mind behind it. Sincere, common, and *wrong about the mind*, but they have genuinely *seen the edge* and mislabelled a limit as an absence. Safe to hold, and half-right, which is what makes it durable.
- **“If she’s real and kind, why the Tithes / why the Struck / why anyone Kept?”** The schism’s engine. These now have *true* answers with an ache in them (a gift has honest weight; she reaches the thresholds but only at the edge of her arm; some Kept are chosen for wholeness and some are simply past her reach), but the answers aren’t *provable*, so the questions stay live.
- **“A kind god would save everyone.”** The misreading the constraint invites: that a *bounded* mother isn’t really benevolent. In-world this is a real theological wound. She is kind *and* finite, and the gap between them is where the grief lives. It does not solve into either omnipotence or indifference.
- **The dark reading:** that a benevolent front hides a harvest/betrayal. This setting **rejects** that. The floor is *sound*: bounded, costly, and grieving, but sound.

## Her kindness does not launder society

The floor being sound at the *divine* layer does **not** make the *social* layer kind. People build genuinely unjust things *on top of* true gifts that she never authored and her kindness does not excuse: Struck stigma and legal suspicion, Tithe-infrastructure that becomes economic leverage over the Conditioned, guild conscription of the Given, communities that treat their Kept as spare labour or their feared Conditions (the Stilled, Bound) as things to be managed.

The keystone answers *is anyone there and do they mean well* (yes); it pointedly does **not** answer *is the society people built around her just* (often no). The moral tension of the setting lives in that gap.

Fifteen injustices, not one with hats. Maiethvael is not the “good” foil to Threnmaieth (piety as a social tax; the Kept pitied in *plenty*). Trenledd is not Threnmaieth without hymns made kinder (it is colder: no duty to keep you hale). Ornled is not freedom (no congregation-net). Confirming the Mother is kind launders none of them.

Vaethorn’s guilt-theology of unworthiness, Lestrاند’s let-the-poor-fade market, Threnmaieth’s sanctified census: three completely different injustices, all built by *people* on top of the same true gifts. If the campaign ever confirms she is real and kind, that must **not** make *any* of these three fair. They don’t share a mechanism of injustice. They share only that people built them.

The Tithes are honest costs, not divine leverage. A Tithe never seizes the PC.

The schism stays a *good-faith* disagreement, and the constraint makes it *two-sided*: believers hold the hand, skeptics hold the edge, neither holds the whole.

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## The Other Hands

**The Leaf-Mother Gives. She does not Strike. The Struck are still hers, because the hands that catch at those doors are of her household, working under her allowance.**

She is **not** exclusive. She is the first and greatest of a household. She **Gives**. She does **not** Strike. The Struck are the work of **the Other Hands**: lesser gods of her household, each with a restricted door and her allowance to reach through it.

The world still holds her as belief. The other faiths already describe these powers as *they* understand them. Confirmation is a late beat, and it should land as *the household was always there*, not as a gotcha pantheon dump.

### The division of labour

| Path          | Who                                | Where                                                     | What                                                                                                                               |
|---------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Given</b>  | the Leaf-Mother alone              | a healthy Turning Tree at Leaf-Fall                       | she looks, she chooses, she Gives. Long-Lived, Two-Bodied, Answered, Phoenix are <b>hers only</b> . No Other Hand may grant them.  |
| <b>Struck</b> | one Other Hand, by her allowance   | that Hand's own door (death, oath, drowning, stone, wild) | they may grant <b>only</b> their Condition, <b>only</b> at that door, <b>only</b> within her allowance                             |
| <b>Both</b>   | Mother <i>or</i> the relevant Hand | Tree <i>or</i> door                                       | Far-Voiced / Stilled / Taken-In can be Given at ten or Struck later. Same Condition; different hand; different person at the table |

She cannot (or will not) Give a death or a contract to a ten-year-old. Those doors do not open at Leaf-Fall. That is why Returned and Bound are Struck-only.

### The household

Five Hands, five doors, five Conditions that can arrive without a leaf. Each is **restricted**: one door, one grant, her allowance. They are not a dark court and not a rival pantheon. They are *family labour*, the

work she cannot do at the Tree without breaking what a gift is.

| Door                            | Condition                                  | Everyday name            | Liturgical (Maiethren, the Old Tongue)                 | The fresh angle                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| died with work unfinished       | Returned                                   | <b>the Quiet Tally</b>   | <i>Threnvaeth</i> (THREN-vayth): “the counted waiting” | Not Hades, not a reaper. A <b>clerk of leftover purpose</b> . Will not close the book while work remains. Warm-solemn, like the Returned themselves.                   |
| a contract sworn in extremity   | Bound (and the Unbound when the term ends) | <b>the Counterparty</b>  | <i>Orledd</i> (or-LED): “the witnessed reckoning”      | Not a devil. The one who <b>answers a sworn ask</b> and keeps the term. The Bound’s chosen face (demon / vast / unknown) is a <i>mask they gave</i> ; Orledd wears it. |
| survived drowning               | Far-Voiced (Struck path)                   | <b>the Second Breath</b> | <i>Eloren</i> (ay-LOR-en): “the deep-witness”          | Not Poseidon. The deep that <b>returns a voice</b> . The Given Far-Voiced is hers; the drowned one is Eloren’s.                                                        |
| survived being turned to stone  | the Stilled (Struck path)                  | <b>the Holding</b>       | <i>Ornhael</i> (orn-HAYL): “the whole-ground”          | Not a curse-god. The ground that <b>holds you still and lets you walk out</b> .                                                                                        |
| lost and dying in the deep wild | the Taken-In (Struck path)                 | <b>the Taking</b>        | <i>Vaelorn</i> (VAYL-orn): “the yield-land”            | Not a hungry forest. The land that <b>will not let you die unmade</b> . <i>Vael</i> in the Old Ways’ older sense.                                                      |

Collective everyday name: **the Other Hands** (she is the First Hand; they are the rest). They do not have temples of their own on the mainland as a set. The Motherfaith grew over that memory. The rival faiths kept pieces.

The names of the Other Hands may still take a final polish. The division of labour is settled.



## Allowance and purchase

- **Allowance** is hers: her permission for a Hand to Strike. An Other Hand cannot Strike a Condition outside their door, cannot Give at a Tree, cannot exceed what she has permitted. This is also *why* the Struck feel received-but-unmet-by-ceremony: a lesser hand, at the edge, by permission.
- **Purchase** is not clerical magic and not “pray for a domain spell.” It is how easily a Hand reaches where its *door is kept*: funerals and unfinished work (Threnvaeth), oaths and books (Orledd), drowning-water (Eloren), stone and stillness (Ornhael), wild and grove (Vaelorn). On the mainland those doors exist even for skeptics; the world is full of them. Belief helps; geography and practice matter more.
- **Her Giving does not need worship.** Skeptics still Turn. The Trees are her hands, not her collection plate. The Leaf-Fall is not faith-gated.

## What this does to the schism

- **Narrow-Hand** is *right*: she Gives only at the Tree; the Struck received by some other means.
- **Wide-Hand** is *right*: those means are still hers (her household, her allowance, her catch at the edge).
- **Neither holds the whole.**
- **The Watching** remembered a household before it was named Mother. Half-right.
- **The Fair Hand** is right about Bound (there *is* a Counterparty) and wrong that every becoming is a bargain. Mother’s Gifts are still gifts.
- **The Old Ways** are right that land-doors are real (Vaelorn, Ornhael, Eloren) and wrong that she is only a latecomer claiming credit. She authorized the guests.
- **The Open Table** is not of this household. Do not absorb Kumbaen’s staying-kin into Threnvaeth or anyone else. Their table is their own.

A household does not make the Leaf-Fall a committee. Giving is still love; the Tithe is still honest weight. The Other Hands are not a dark pantheon. Threnvaeth is why the Returned are respected, not why they are a plague. Narrow-Hand does not win; she authorized the catch. The stigma stays social, not cosmological abandonment.

## How the household surfaces

Keep this *behind* the keystone’s own clue-ladder. Do not lead with a pantheon.

1. **Struck testimony splits.** Some felt a mother. Some felt a clerk, a term, a deep, a holding, a green. The Motherfaith files all of it as “she caught them.” The Old Ways and the Fair Hand file it as their own doors. Both filings are half-true.

2. **A Returned who settles** sometimes speaks of a book closing, not a lap. Threnvaeth, if you are listening.
  3. **Bound faces disagree and the terms do not.** Demon, vast, unknown: the *clause* is the same shape. Orledd wearing masks.
  4. **The Watching's lintel** ("we kept the watch before the name") is about a *household*, not only a nameless Tree.
  5. **Kumbaan as control.** Almost no Struck; no Given. If the household needed only doors, the isle would be full of them. Purchase matters. The storm-wall is a reach-edge *and* a name-edge.
  6. **The confirming beat (late).** If the campaign ever names the Other Hands, it should feel like *the family was always in the next room*: warmth with an ache, not a lore dump. Pair it with the keystone's own confirming beat or let it land after. Never first.
- 

## Yumboes and Kumbaan

- **No Tree** because a graft has not crossed the storm-wall, not because the good people refused one. The isle is almost impossible to reach. Their culture is centred on something else (the Open Table, the moon, the hill, hospitality). Different ideals, different sacred.
- **No Gifts on the isle.** Her reach does not get there. There is no Leaf-Fall. Yumboes do not have Given Conditions as a people.
- **They do not worship her or her household**, so the Other Hands have **little purchase**. The doors are not kept in their names, the rites are not theirs. This is not "gods starve without prayer." It is: a Hand reaches through a door that is *used*. On Kumbaan those doors are barely a concept.
- **Struck can still happen, at far smaller percentages** than the mainland's ~15% lifetime Struck. A Yumboe who dies with work unfinished, or drowns, or is taken by the deep green of the Paps, *can* be caught, rarely. Enough for a story. Not enough to be a social class. No Returned neighbourhoods; no Bound guilds.
- **A Yumboe abroad**, standing under a mainland Tree, is a live campaign beat, not a population fact. The Tree is her hand; she *could* Give. It almost never arises. There is no racial immunity.

The Isle remains the sharpest experiment: a people outside her Giving, barely inside her household's reach, with a faith that was never hers.

Yumboes are unreached, not refused. A graft that cannot travel is not a judgment.

**"Spirits of the dead" is folklore, not literal here.** The source myth calls Yumboes ghosts/ancestral spirits. They are a *living* people (a playable Kind). The ancestral flavour is their *faith's* self-image: a

people who venerate hill, moon, and lineage and speak of themselves in the old ancestral idiom. They are not literally undead (that's the Returned's lane).

**The storm-wall is a dial, not a lock.** Whether it can be crossed, and how, is a GM lever. A permanent absolute wall kills the expedition hook. A seasonal thinning, a known-but-deadly passage, or a Condition/Kind that can survive it keeps the door usable when the story wants it.

Kumbaan stays off the clerk's list on purpose. A later campaign may reach it; it is not a great power. A wrecked pot in a sailor's story is allowed. A taking is not. Road-hands do not bring the Mother across the storm-wall. Finding an old scion on the Isle would break the isolate and the Open Table.

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## The map as the edge

The reach-gradient (dense core to thin frontier to Treeless isle) is the ground-level face of the Mother's bounded reach. In-world it reads as plain distance-and-history: the ages explain today's thin edges as *Tree-poor places* (young/sick/few grafts) and as the *front of a wave still moving* on Heskoren, and the skeptics take that as the whole truth. It is most of the truth. The part that stays GM-side is *why* the grafts thin with distance from Thaeloren: that her reach itself has an edge.

Never let a player-facing region note assert the deeper cause; let it read as geography.

**Maiethorn** is the "control" end of the natural experiment: Trees healthiest, Given densest. Keep the *cause* GM-side (her reach is fullest at the source). In-world it's just "the oldest, best-tended Trees."

**Strandoren** has Trees as healthy as Maiethorn's but wears the faith lightly. The reason the Given are dense here is the same as anywhere (healthy grafts), and the reason the *faith* is thin is purely social (commerce erodes devotion). Keep those two facts separate in-world; don't let the cool faith read as thin reach or vice versa. The eroded language drift is the tell: smooth because secular, not because Tree-poor.

**Heskoren** is the sharpest in-world test of the keystone edge. The Waiting Lands are *the place a devout population most wants an explanation for the thin gift*. The true answer (her reach is bounded and thins where the Trees are thin) is exactly the answer that would land hardest and cruellest here. It would confirm the guilt-theology's worst fear. Never let a player-facing note assert it. In-world the thin reach is *young/sick/scarce grafts* (true as far as it goes) and history (**Clock 2**: where the wood has reached; the graft-wave still moving). The gap between "true as far as it goes" and the whole truth is where the play lives.

**The Sundering Isle** is the strongest keystone experiment. A near-Treeless land whose people become what they become *without* the Leaf-Fall is the cleanest natural test of whether the Mother is behind

any of it. No Gifts (no graft has crossed; her reach does not get there). Struck are rare (the household has little purchase where it is unknown and the doors are not kept). Their Kind and their table are *their own*, not a subtler Tree. Don't resolve a lone Yumboe's Struck-or-not in session one. It's still a late beat.

**East/west is not settled cosmology.** Only the relative positions matter. If a later map or campaign wants the gradient to run north to south or along a different axis, that's free. The *gradient* is the canon, not the compass.

**The heartland heresy is a keystone keeper.** The Watching sits at the sacred center precisely so an *old* faith can hold *old* memory: what was believed before the Trees were called Hers. It's the natural in-world source that could corroborate the keystone from an unexpected direction (not the skeptics, not the devout: the *heretics*).

**Three old faiths, three edges, one buried truth.** The Open Table joins the Watching and the Old Ways as the world's three keystone-adjacent religions, each grown far from (or before) the Motherfaith's account, each possibly preserving a fragment of what the Trees really are. The Isle's is the *purest* control: a cosmology with zero Motherfaith contamination. If a campaign triangulates the keystone, these three are the corners.

**The Old Ways may be half-right for the wrong reasons.** They revere the Struck and Taken-In as *the land's own, made without the Tree*, and on a near-Treeless frontier, people genuinely do become things without a healthy Tree nearby. That's a live thread: they are the frontier mirror of the Watching, two old faiths at opposite edges of the world, both remembering something the Motherfaith smooths over. Whether they're *right* about the Mother stays keystone-gated. Host-rights do not dissolve when the keystone lands.

**The Fair Hand is a rival reading of the true gifts, not a false one.** The Conditions are real gifts. The cult calls them bargains, the Motherfaith calls them blessings, and *both* are interpretations laid over the same real thing. Neither is confirmed by any reveal. The cult is wrong about *who* (no bargain was struck), but its adherents are as sincere as the Motherfaith's. Don't play it as villain-theology. Leddvael is that reading made civic.

**The solstice-timing is a two-reading fact.** Believers: the Mother times her choosing to the year's hinge. Skeptics: the Trees colour with the length of the day, and the "choosing" is biology. She *is* real, so the believers are right about *who*, the skeptics right about the *mechanism* (she works through the Trees' real nature, not against it). Don't resolve it in player text; the calendar works identically either way.

**Kumbaan's lunar calendar is the sharpest small tell in the world.** The Yumboes keep the *moon*, not the *solstice*, because the Trees never reached them: a whole people whose reckoning of time has no Leaf-Fall in it at all. It reads in-world as mere cultural difference. It *is* also the keystone experiment:

the one calendar the Mother's Trees demonstrably never shaped. Reserve the significance; let it look like colour.

**Whoever keeps the dates holds power.** No printing press, so calendars are hand-kept by clergy and clerks. The tree-wardens set Turning-Week; the Tallied Crown's clerks record it. A campaign lever: a disputed date, a miscounted cohort, a child Turned a year "late" because someone kept the calendar wrong (or made them). Cut-years vs house-years vs "the year the graft took" is the same lever aimed at *history*.

**The sky from the ground is enough to play.** One sun. One moon on the mainland. Kumbaan keeps twelve named moons of that same sky and does not owe the mainland round a translation. Two solstices run the rite. This world does not have other planes. The storm-wall is weather, current, and reef. Whether a ship can cross it stays open. A second mainland moon is not available. Eclipses and comets are not written. A later story that needs one names it in play. It does not add a moon, a plane, or a door.

Every scion is continuous tissue of the one Tree, so the **First Cut** (the first living graft that took; who cut it stays unpicked) really did move a Hand. Player-facing, that is doctrine. The growth of reach with grafts is the quiet argument for a mind; it is not a licence to narrate her standing over the first knife. Skeptics still win the mundane reading (horticulture, ships, soil). Both readings share the same wave.

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## The ages, GM-side

**The two clocks protect the keystone without confirming it.** Clock 2 (the wave) is the player-facing face of "reach grew with the grafts," the quiet argument that a *hand*, not a climate, is behind the thinning. Skeptics still win the mundane reading (young/sick/few grafts, distance, history). Both readings share the same map. Do not let a player-facing era note assert the mind.

**Clock 1** is how you Turned: walk to a Tree, or stand under a town graft.

**The present is not post-history.** Especially on Heskoren. Narrating Ornthael (the Years of Hands) as "the modern age after the Grafting" re-creates stacked ages. Two clocks. The wave is live. A sick Tree in the core puts a Hands-town back on the neighbour's week; that is Clock 1 flipping, not an age ending.

**Heskoren is not "living in the past."** A hamlet sending this year's ten-year-olds to a neighbour is doing Clock 2, present tense. A hamlet sending them all the way to Thaeloren is doing Clock 1, present tense. Do not narrate either as re-enactment.

**The Grafting is not a redemption arc for society.** Local Trees did not abolish Struck stigma, Tithe-leverage, guild conscription, or the pitied Kept. They *relocated* who gets a local witness and who waits on a queue. The scion-queue is the Hands-era injustice grown from a Walking-era mercy. Confirming she is kind does not make the queue fair. The Seat's narration ("her will travelling") is a claim, not a solvent.

**Do not run the colonial version.** "We brought Trees to the benighted far" is the Seat's after-the-fact sermon and Lestrang's supply-chain story. The thing that happened is shorter and worse: children died on the road, someone cut a branch, it took, people copied it, the Seat claimed the copy-right. Heskoren still experiences the wave as *waiting*, not as having been given civilization. The Old Ways experience it as guests arriving late. Keep all three.

**The Walking did not make far people spiritually deficient.** Distance did. Vaethorn's guilt-theology is a Hands-era reading of a Walking-era fact. Old Ways refusal is not "missing the gift"; it is a different door. Do not let history agree with the guilt.

**The one-week door is the engine's teeth.** If eleven-year-olds Turn Given "because they tried," the split household and the held-over year lose their bite. Struck remains the later door. That is enough mercy.

**Protect the two-sided memory.** Devout Hands-era storytellers will want Brenvaeth (the Walking Years) as holy traffic: every child a pilgrim, every summer a hymn. Skeptics will want it as biology plus bad roads. Both are using the era. The graves make the hymn expensive; the hymn makes the graves a meaning. Play both. The fables refuse to pick.

**The gap (C.Y. 160 to 200)** is load-bearing. Not empty time and not a punishment. Dead wood on the Long Mile, a chain that had to mature, a queue that preferred a paying next. Filling the gap with a crusade or a miracle-crossing launders the list.

**Who made the First Cut is unpicked.** A named first Road-hand, a named parent, a named saint, is a taste call if play needs a tomb. A face makes a great-man history; the engine is wood and waiting. The five attributions are the play. Collapsing them in GM voice is how you accidentally write a gospel.

**Rithnali says *Tree*, the later Cutting-leave says *Mother*.** The early paper has not finished the overlay. Dual-practice, an old Speaker, or the college still arguing the name: playable, not a gotcha. Do not "correct" the minute.

**Before the Walk stays unfilled.** People will not give it a start, and this book does not. The Watching and the Old Ways already hold the two usable memories (seeing without a mother; doors without a graft). A third "true prehistory" would flatten both. The Tree standing before it was called Hers is compatible with she is real *and* with "the Mother-name is later." This era does not decide what she is. The *maternal intent* is settled; her metaphysical species is not.

**Long-Lived memory is the era-marker the calendar refused to be.** At **C.Y. 387** (Cut-year 387: the 387th summer since the First Cut), plenty of deathless people remember the late Walking as biography. They are walking archives, and they do not agree. Memory is perfect; *meaning* is not. A Long-Lived who walked as a child and a Seat chronicle that starts at the Cut will fight about the same summer. That fight is play. Do not have “the” Long-Lived account.

**Historical fate-shifts (already happened).** (1) road-houses became deathless banks (reformation); (2) unsanctioned cutting became Cutting-leave and the queue (absorption of a heresy by an institution); (3) required pilgrimage became optional pilgrimage (the institution survives by changing function). Present-day fate-pressure is noted, not rolled: First Seat peak and heavy; Road-hands overextended at the Heskoren front; waiting towns precarious; deathless houses peak-and-reformed.

**Two fates of the road-house is the leftover’s contradiction.** The White Note House collected. The Third Hearth kept making the bed. Both are honest. Lestrang will only count the first as success. Play both. Do not have “the” deathless account of the road. Mataero’s blindness is the document: junior who must believe the house is a bank that happens to have rooms. House custom is the credit.

**Colonial trap, present tense.** Maiethorn visitors on Heskoren will read necessity as devotion (*they still walk, how faithful*). Prestige-walkers will read necessity as poverty-theatre. Vaethorn will read delay as unworthiness. The thing that is happening is shorter: a child needs a canopy this week. Keep all three misreadings available. Do not let GM voice agree with any of them.

**The fables’ paradox is the point.** You cannot know the distance without the graves, and you cannot honour the graves without using them as a map. You cannot share a Hand without wounding a Hand, and you cannot name a First without inventing a Second that waits. You cannot honour the leftover without using it, and you cannot use it without pretending, a little, that the road is still the road, or that it is over. Removing the paradox leaves a hymn or a logistics manual. Keep both counts.

Do not add “and then the Mother walked with them,” “and then she told them to cut,” or “and then she moved the stone.” That closes the keystone in a children’s story. The confirming warmth, if it comes, is not these stories. The branch *is* her tissue; the stories must not say so. Do not pick a last line in GM voice. Which mouth an NPC offers is a faster read than a speech.

There is no official ribbon-colour. A copper-green rag is not a Taken-In. If a warden “reads” mile-shrine ribbons as leaf-colours, they are doing Hands-era overlay on Walking-era rag. Useful as a wrong NPC; do not make it doctrine.

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## Places, GM-side

A **leftover job** is the one present-tense work a square still does from the road years: devotion, prestige, or necessity. One per street.

**Harrow's Green is not the "good town" that waited faithfully.** They were a paying-enough, soil-enough, chain-enough next on a list written in the Motherwood. Luck is horticulture plus the queue. Vaethorn will preach otherwise. The **Harrow-sentence** is a tell: when an NPC says it as nostalgia, they are Maiethorn; when they say it as this year, they are the front; when they say it as a slight (*they Turned at Harrow's because they had no Hand*), they are a hamlet. One leftover job: necessity. A ribbon on the stone is texture, not a second theme. A First-Hand-year household here is lost, rich, or lying. Keep the hamlets visible from the square in at least one sightline. "The soil was right here" is horticulture; Haelin does not assert the mind.

**The Three Hamlets are not living in the past.** A hamlet sending this year's ten-year-olds to Harrow's is doing the present. They wait because the wood is slow, the road is long, and the list was written in the Motherwood. Not because they were unworthy. Confirming she is kind does not plant the scion. Fate-pressure: precarious, a single dependency on Harrow's week or a pot. Do not wipe the cluster to make the queue feel real. The pressure is the play. Seam, not a **planet-of-hats** (a place where every NPC recites one theme): all four voices (Saelvaeth luck / Vaelhesk refusal / Vaethorn guilt / Ornled slate) can sit in one week. Brenod leans sending, Vaelun leans refusal, Ornath leans the other road: leans, not flags. Which green has the sick stick waits on a session.

**The Third Hearth is not a failure.** The White Note collected. The Third Hearth kept making the bed. Do not have Thilim "lose" because the paper went to the coast. One leftover job on the street: devotion / extra mile. Necessity in the loft is Thilim's eye, not a second town-theme. Prestige that lands here is the household that missed the White Note. Orenbren is many hearths. Brenthael is a neighbour square, not a capital. Thilim's four jobs stay disagreed. Do not pick which sermon they are. Do not kill Thilim to close the Held bed (the leftover pilgrim bed). The stone is a day's water and a name; it does not assert the mind.

**Ornsael is not a Kitsune nation.** Sands-Fox densest. Mixed Kinds. A fox-market is a neighbourhood, not a quarter-with-a-gate. Pair with Saelvaeth / Harrow's Green: same sowing-root, two continents, both present tense. A party that has only seen Heskoren waiting should meet this well and have to recalibrate. A party that has only seen the Sacred Core should meet the west-road and lose the stacked-age. One leftover job: necessity. **The crisis is the drink, not a maybe-Tree.** Eolvaeth keeps the maybe-Tree, the spring, the warden who will not invent a colour, the wet leaf. Ornsael does not. Physical problem = the well. Institutional response = a share (Theisva, Lesna, Bovaer). Mystery = a wet knot below the water. Do not slide back into "warden won't call a false fall." Thin take in dry soil stays horticulture in player text. Plenty next door does not make the leftover kind. Confirming she is kind does not retire the west-road. Larbril is Saelthael's city, where the west road meets the Well-wash,



short of the pass. Ornsael is the smaller well-town farther into the dry. It is not the next roof, not the coast, and not a west bank. Ornsael is not the capital.

**Eolvaeth is not the “good town” that waited faithfully.** They were an early pot that stayed thin. Congregation did the rest. Luck is horticulture plus the queue. Not Saelvaeth’s march. Harrow’s is luck you can see from a ford. Eolvaeth is a gospel you walk to. Pair them in a campaign week if you want both leftover jobs of Heskoren visible; do not collapse them into one frontier flavour. One leftover job: devotion / the wait as destination. A cohort sent toward Saelvaeth is friction, not a second theme. The spring is the water. The wet leaf is not a ribbon. The absence of a mile-shrine is the leftover. A pretty pilgrim-town whose leftover is only picturesque agrees with Vaethorn guilt. Keep a thin year visible. Confirming she is kind does not make the wait a virtue. “The soil was never quite right here” is horticulture.

**Orentel: the White Note is not the crown.** The desk is one house on the third quay. The council is many tickets. A party that only meets Ledan has not met Orentel. One leftover job: prestige / First-Hand year as product. Necessity in the loft is texture, not a second theme. Empty berths and earth-holds are this street’s leftover. Salt on the roots is not a ribbon. Hallowquay stays a lesser quay: a neighbourhood byname, not a retcon of the capital. Dense Given stay horticulture-and-trade in player text. Confirming she is kind does not make the hold kind. A rich city stepping around a fade is the Coast’s injustice at eye level.

**Maiethlir does not capture the First Seat.** Proximity is pressure. A First Seat that is the Threnhael is a different (darker) setting. Keep the college able to refuse the roll, and keep Rithim as the local version of that refusal, incomplete. This is a Hand beside a thaw-river. The grove is a dark on the horizon. Orenbren lodges the other road. Brenthael is a neighbour of an inn, not this capital. One leftover job: devotion / extra mile, layered. The census is the layer, not the postcard. Tablets, a loud thaw, clerk-dorms in old lofts. The unfiled Held bed is a rumour the roll has not found: a different leftover, not Seine’s lintel moved to the counted city. Maiethvael is the argument next door. Same *maieth*, opposite paper. Do not make them the kind foil (piety as a social tax in plenty). Dense Given stay horticulture in player text. The loud river is not her voice unless a later reveal earns it, and even then the social-injustice guard holds. Confirming she is kind does not make the counted channel kind. Devotion sanctifies the surveillance; the surveillance enforces the devotion. No clean villain.

**Name-pairs as tells.** Maiethvael / Threnmaieth is the Motherland’s argument in two names: Mother’s *gift* vs Mother’s *reckoning*. Same *maieth*, opposite paper. Saelthael / Saelvaeth share *sael* (sowing) on two continents. Clock 2 still moving at the origin *and* the front. Do not narrate one as history and the other as frontier flavour. Trenledd’s etymology: *Thren* worn to *Tren* is the sacred count with the sacred worn off, the same machinery Threnmaieth sanctifies, named as what it does. A scholar-PC may notice; do not gloss it in player text as a clever pun. The *vael/vaeth* pair: Yield vs waiting. Same continent, opposite first syllable. Vaethorn and Vaelhesk already *feel* it.

**Theology and reach stay independent.** High reach, cooled faith on the Hinge Shore is the same pairing Strandoren proves, on the *conservative* shore. Do not let mid-hymns read as thin Trees.

**Netstrand's *neth*.** Why *night* sits on this west shore is not fully explained: night-watches, storm-wall dark, a Watching-flavoured eve-custom that does not belong this far west. Pick in play, or never.

**Ornled is not freedom.** Light state plus thin Trees plus no faith-net is exposure. Do not agree with Vaethorn that Ornled is unworthy. Distance and a choice of gospel. Horticulture plus culture.

**Hearths, not nations, everywhere.** Tengu densest in Lirorn; Snows-Fox densest there; Sands-Fox densest in Saelthael; Selkie common on the Hinge Shore and Netstrand; Taken-In honoured in Vaelhesk. Mixed Kinds. The interesting PC is a human or Selkie of Lirorn, or a Tengu of the Hinge Shore. A wing-post is a job. The moment the government is *for* a Kind, the two-layer model has started to rot.

**Threnmaieth's tell lives on Maiethorn.** The Tallied Crown distrusts the three pillars and keeps a ledger instead, and its Long-Lived crown-archivists may quietly remember what the Threnhael was made to overwrite. On Maiethorn, that archivist is near the sacred center *and* near the old heresy.

**Strandoren is the natural staging ground for Isle expeditions.** If a campaign ever reaches for the Sundering Isle, the ships, the money, and the tall tales all originate here. Netstrand is the natural berth. The merchant who “crossed the storm-wall” is a Strandor archetype. Hold whether the claim is true as a live question tied to the Isle's reveal.

**The twelve seats are named, or refused.** Seinbrun, Rothallo, Larbril, Votaer, Tasain, Raitin, Naenor, Lunbra, Braetu, Sanbreo. Vaelhesk names no city. Natai is the march. Rothallo is Orenbren's walled capital, one day's walk from the wood. People still say the Inner Close. It is the same city, not a second town and not a sixteenth flag. The First Seat stays in the wood, unnamed. Vaelhesk is the land. There is no settlement dot. The First Bowl is the guest-grove, not the seat. Natai sits west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and the square. It is not the ford and not the square. Harrow's Green stays in orbit. The six charter-towns around Raitin stay unnamed. Trenledd's governing throat stays unnamed. No capital is marked with a star.

A pretty road-end town whose leftover is only picturesque launders the graves. A waiting cluster whose only note is “poor and faithful” agrees with Vaethorn guilt. Write the job, not the postcard. Thin/sick/few grafts stay the player-facing cause. Do not let a seed-note assert the mind.

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## What is settled and what is open

**Settled.**

- The Leaf-Mother is real, benevolent, bounded, and costly. The Trees are her hands. The Conditions are real gifts. The Tithe is honest weight.
- She Gives; she does not Strike. The Other Hands Strike under her allowance. The Struck are still hers.
- Yumboes: no Gifts; Struck rare. Unreached, not refused. The Open Table is not of her household.
- The map is a reach-gradient. Four continents. Maiethorn first, Strandoren by sea, Heskoren last and live, Kumbaan never.
- Present: Cut-year 387. Two clocks. No universal year-zero. Dating reveals stance.
- The Tree is undated. Before the Walk has no start.
- High-Solstice Turning-Week. Twelve Maiethren months. Three new-year days by stance. Kumbaan keeps twelve moons.
- Fifteen powers (three corners + twelve). Kumbaan is not on the list. Rothallo is Orenbren's walled capital, one day's walk from the wood. People still say the Inner Close. It is the same city, not a second town and not a sixteenth flag. *Eolstrand* is retired; the slot is the Hinge Shore. *Aeloren* is retired.
- The twelve seats are named or refused: Seinbrun, Rothallo, Larbril, Votaer, Tasain, Raitin, Naenor, Lunbra, Braetu, Sanbreo, Vaelhesk (the land; no city), Natai. Six charter-towns and Trenledd's throat stay unnamed. The First Seat is a college in the wood beside Maiethlir, unnamed, not a throne and not captured. The White Note is placed on Orentel, not crowned. Harrow's Green and Ornsael are not capitals. Larbril is the city at the wash. Ornsael is the well farther into the dry. Natai is the march, west of Harrow's, not the ford and not the square. No capital star. Vaelhesk has no settlement dot. No graft on Kumbaan.
- The Other Count sits beside the two clocks: Closing 19–38, Two Papers 67, Grey Summer 171, Thaw-Break 233, Hinge Hush 299–304. Cutter unpicked. Present C.Y. 387.
- Fate-pressure on the First Seat, Road-hands, waiting towns, and deathless houses is visible. It has not been rolled.
- Opening kit: Isolated Fall sits at Harrow's Green, Hale-month C.Y. 387. One Gift. Apparent two is leftover fire next to a new leaf. Harvest engine stays behind this chapter.

## Open.

- **The nature of her limit.** That her reach has an edge and giving costs her is settled. *Why* (is she finite by nature, spent from some old wound, rationing a power that could run out, holding something back to hold something else up?) is unwritten. That carrying wood *moved the edge* is already evidence of a hand. It is not an explanation of the wound, the finitude, or the rationing. The ache is settled. The cause is not. A wound-in-the-deep-past is *one* available cause among several; Before the Walk does not pick it.

- **Who made the First Cut.** Contested on purpose. Folk / clergy / devout / Watching / Old Ways each have a lived story. History does not pick a face. Pick only if play needs a tomb.
- **What she is** (a goddess? the Trees' shared soul? something older wearing a mother's face for our comfort?) is undecided. The *maternal, benevolent intent* is settled, not her metaphysical species.
- **What she wants**, beyond giving good gifts, is undecided. She is kind; her larger purpose (if any) is unwritten.
- **Where she is / whether she can be reached** is undecided. Revelation is deliberately quiet; there is no throne to visit.
- **Whether the storm-wall can be crossed, and how** is a GM lever, not a settled fact.
- **Why *neth* sits on Netstrand's shore** is not fully explained.
- **Which of the three hamlets' greens has the sick stick** waits on a session.
- **Household names** (Quiet Tally / Counterparty / Second Breath / Holding / Taking, and their Maiethren forms) are polishable; the structure is settled.
- **Eclipses and comets** are not written. A later story may name one in play. A second mainland moon is not open. Other planes are not open. Whether the storm-wall can be crossed stays its own question.

## Secrets and reveals

What the table learns, and in what order. The keystone and the household are already in this chapter. This is not a second cosmology.

Keep the Phoenix engine behind the keystone. Do not lead with a second bird. Do not confirm her in session one.

## When the fire is caught

There is never a second Gift. The Tree Gives white-fire to one living person. While that person can still Rise From Ash, no second leaf falls. What can *look* like two Phoenixes is leftover fire standing next to a new Gift.

The original self ends at the death they **cannot Rise from** — the death that would cross out their last Hope slot. That death ends the Gift. A new white-fire leaf may fall at the next High Solstice any living Tree can reach. Two Gifts never overlap.

Each Rise burns a body to nothing and remakes it. The fire of that burn can be **caught** if the death is prepared. Banked fire has two jobs, and only two:

1. **While the Gift lasts.** Spend a measure to force a Rise the Phoenix did not choose, and take the memory of that death with it. The Hope slot still scars. The named piece of the old life still does not come back. The player of a PC Phoenix is never forced to Rise; this is what is done to a captive.
2. **After the Gift ends.** Spend the bank to keep the *last risen body* assembled. That is not a Rise. No Hope is crossed, because none remain. The body walks, burns, and can still take the air. It is fire's memory of a person, not a Phoenix. If the store runs out, the remnant goes to cold ash and stays there.

The remnant cannot Rise, cannot be Given, and cannot Give. Immunity and wings can linger because those are properties of the *fire*, not of the Gift. Kindle and the Dwindling do not. A remnant that still thinks it is the Phoenix is a tragedy, not a second Condition.

The slot is empty from the true death. The leaf may fall. The wider world does not see it because the remnant is still *called* the Phoenix and kept out of sight. Doctrine says there cannot be two, so a Spoken white-fire while a sanctuary still “holds the Phoenix” is filed as a mis-Speaking or a hush. The new child is real. The stories are still about the old name.

**The Protectors** catch the fire. They use this engine; they do not rewrite it. Player text knows the Care as a hospice that will not produce the one. The harvest stays here.

Clues, in order: Hope scars without memories; a sanctuary that will not produce the Phoenix; a white-fire fall that was never Spoken; fire that answers a child and an old name at once; late, the remnant goes to ash when the store is spent, or the new Gift stands in a room with the old name and the Tree does not argue. Warmth with a theft under it. Not a harvest-god reveal.

Misreadings to refuse: there were always two; the Tree made a mistake; the remnant is the real Phoenix and the child is a fraud (the useful lie; it is backwards); she stopped Giving white-fire (incomplete — she Gave; the record was kept from seeing it).

## A hidden Phoenix (player agency)

The open-card Phoenix is a fishbowl. This is the other seat. Whole-table consent, same as the public card. The Transformation card does not change.

Two legal shapes. Pick one. They are not two Phoenixes.

| Shape                  | What you are                                                                         | Typical start                                                                                                  |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The walker</b>      | The Gift that left a prepared room.<br>You can still Rise. You are the one.          | Hope scars you cannot account for. Missing deaths. A world that says the one is safe indoors.                  |
| <b>The unseen leaf</b> | A new Gift that fell where no Speaker wrote it. You can still Rise. You are the one. | Few or no scars yet. The stories are still about an older name. Something in a far house still burns like you. |

If you cannot Rise (last Hope slot already gone), you are not a Phoenix PC. That leftover is not this card.

Agree a **count** of Hope scars before play, not a biography. Walker: 1–3 scars is the working band. Unseen leaf: 0, or 1. You and the GM name **that they are missing**, not what they were.

When play offers a fragment, **the player chooses**: take it; leave it; or rewrite the meaning, not the fact. A prepared room existed. What it *means* that they walked out is theirs. The GM offers fragments. The GM does not assign their moral. One fragment a session is plenty. Zero is legal.

Stored fire can show facts (a count, a layout, a name the fire still answers, that a death was arranged). It cannot assign a self, a forgiveness, a Gift's purpose, a second Gift, or her.

## Isolated Fall — the opening

The first campaign. Play starts at an existing square. Session one is a kit, not a novel. Mystery first. One 5% beat. Wonder at an isolated fall. The Leaf-Mother is not this session's reveal.

|                  |                                                                                                                           |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Sits</b>      | Harrow's Green, Hale-month, C.Y. 387. Next week is Eolthael.                                                              |
| <b>On-screen</b> | The walker · Rosire · the new Gift (Taeren <i>or</i> a PC in that seat) · Haelin · Tora of Brenod                         |
| <b>Offstage</b>  | Reimaethe · Hithaen · Vimein · Tesara's week · the Care as a place you can walk into                                      |
| <b>Do not</b>    | Invent a Protector fortress. Lead with a second bird. Confirm her. Name the cutter. Date the Tree. Add a sixteenth power. |

There is **one Gift**. This opening needs an apparent two, so: the new Gift is an unseen leaf (can still Rise); the walker is leftover fire (Gift already ended, cannot Rise, not a Phoenix for Leaf-Fall, law, or the roster); Rosire opened a door that was not on the slate.

If the table wants a **walker-PC who can still Rise**, that PC is the Gift and there is no new leaf. That is a legal other opening. It is **not this kit**. Do not put Taeren on-screen as a second Gift to keep both shapes.

The isolated fall is last Eolthael's neighbour's week, not a new Tree. Taeren is of Brenod, not of Harrow's. Haelin did not Speak white-fire. The witness never walked home. That is why the child is still in the square when Hale-month extra mouths arrive.

What the table can see: a live-front square doing a necessity-day; civic talk that the Phoenix *should* exist and is in care; a Brenod child (or the PC in that seat) whose hands hold heat; Haelin will not name last Eolthael's colour; an upper-room guest who burns like a story and cannot account for their scars; Rosire's flinch at a room that has been cleared and laid with sand; a closed lamp that leans toward the new Gift and still knows an old name; the public sentence *the one is in care*. Not the harvest. Not the house's name as harvesters.

**Five key moments** (play in any order the table reaches; recommended order below). Do not skip. Do not open on the lamp or on two burning people in one shot.

1. **Two tenses in the square.** Mystery. Someone asks whether the one is coming for Leaf-Fall. A neighbour says the Phoenix is in care. Another says they have never seen one. Haelin: they have a Tree. They do not have a legend. Curiosity, not dread.
2. **White that nobody Spoke.** Wonder. Last Eolthael, a Brenod child stood at Harrow's Tree. Something white. Haelin did not Speak it. Heat in the hands they do not show. If a PC occupies this seat, this moment is theirs. Do not run Taeren as an NPC beside them. Do not confirm the Leaf-Mother. Linger. Then stop.
3. **Scars that do not match the lives.** Mystery. The walker is in the upper room. More crossed lives than they can put in a row. They cannot Rise. Do not stage that death this session to prove the engine. Rosire brings water and does not explain.
4. **The lamp that knows two mouths.** Wrongness glimpse (~5%). Rosire kept a closed travelling-lamp. The coal should be cold. It is not. When the new Gift is on the stair, the lamp leans. When the walker speaks an old name, the lamp answers that name too. Narrate the lamp, the lean, the two names. Do **not** narrate harvest, bank, remnant, Protectors, or "this is not a real Phoenix." One linger, then let someone pour tea.
5. **The door that was not on the slate.** Mystery. Rosire on-screen as a person, not a confession. A cleared room. Sand. They flinch. They will say: someone walked; I walked the other way. What the party does with the person who opened the door is theirs. Session one can end with the lamp still lit, the stone still unmoved, the witness still unwalked, and no one named as the one. Do not fire the remnant-to-ash beat. Do not have Vimein arrive.

**Stop lines.** No Leaf-Mother reveal. No Care-fortress. No hunt in hour one. No second Gift. After the lamp, decompress — water, bread, the stone still there.

Later sessions, memory-fragment continuation, and any ending wait. Do not write them here to tidy session one.